A COMPLETE COMPENDIUM

The Complex Codex

Everything known about Kane Parsons' Backrooms, the Complex and Async



The web series 2022 to 2026
The film Backrooms (2026) and the Everything Must Go Edition
Interviews, production, theories, mathematics
Compiled October 2026

Contents

How to Read This Codex . . . 10

Quotations . . . 10

Dates . . . 10

Names . . . 11

Images . . . 11

The Short Version . . . 12

Scope and Sources . . . 14

What was read . . . 14

PART I: Before Kane . . . 15

The Photograph and the Post . . . 16

The thread of 12 May 2019 . . . 16

Where the photograph came from . . . 16

The meme becomes a mythology . . . 18

The Poolrooms and other famous images . . . 18

How Kane's Backrooms Differs . . . 20

One place, not levels . . . 20

What Kane thinks other versions miss . . . 20

Names inside the story . . . 20

Imitators . . . 20

PART II: The Creator . . . 22

Kane Parsons . . . 23

Life . . . 23

Valve, the pandemic and Blender . . . 23

The Attack on Titan videos . . . 23

The first short . . . 24

The rest of his work . . . 24

How he works . . . 25

Influences Kane has named . . . 25

Experiences that feed the work . . . 26

Views that shape the story . . . 26

Public life after the film . . . 27

What comes next . . . 27

PART III: The Web Series . . . 28

The Series at a Glance . . . 29

What the series is . . . 29

Release order . . . 29
In-universe order . . . 30
How it was made . . . 31
Reception . . . 32
Episodes 1 to 6: The Opening Month . . . 33
1. The Backrooms (Found Footage) . . . 33
2. Mar11_90_ARCHIVE.tar . . . 35
3. Backrooms - The Third Test . . . 36
4. Backrooms - First Contact . . . 37
5. faultline.mov . . . 38
6. Backrooms - Missing Persons . . . 38
Episodes 7 to 13: Tench, the Lifeform and the Pits . . . 40
7. Backrooms - Informational Video . . . 40
8. Backrooms - Autopsy Report . . . 41
9. Backrooms - Motion Detected . . . 42
10. Backrooms - Prototype . . . 43
11. Backrooms - Pitfalls . . . 44
12. Backrooms - Report . . . 47
13. 9780415263573 . . . 48
Episodes 14 to 21: A-Space, Found Footage #2 and the Reunion . . . 49
14. Backrooms - Presentation . . . 49
15. Simpsons . . . 50
16. Backrooms - Found Footage #2 . . . 51
17. home_27647.mov . . . 53
18. I Remember . . . 54
19. Backrooms - Reunion . . . 55
20. _recording014 . . . 57
21. Backrooms - Overflow . . . 58
Episodes 22 to 26: Damage Control to Everything Must Go . . . 60
22. Backrooms - Damage Control . . . 60
23. Backrooms - Found Footage #3 . . . 62
24. Backrooms - Lighting and Tile Survey . . . 68
25. Backrooms - Static Dead End . . . 70
26. Backrooms - Everything Must Go . . . 72
PART IV: The Film . . . 75
Making Backrooms . . . 76
From YouTube to A24 . . . 76
Keeping it in continuity . . . 76
Casting . . . 77
The test shoot . . . 77

Building the Backrooms . . . 78
Shooting . . . 79
Post-production and music . . . 79
Marketing and the puzzle . . . 79
Release . . . 81
Box office . . . 81
Reception . . . 81
Awards . . . 82
Controversies . . . 82
What's next . . . 83
The Story of Backrooms, Scene by Scene . . . 84
Logos . . . 84
The cold open, 19 June 1990 . . . 84
Mary's handprint . . . 84
The first session . . . 85
The commercial . . . 85
The breaker box . . . 85
Nights in the store . . . 85
First time in . . . 86
The second session . . . 86
The expedition . . . 87
Alone . . . 87
The window . . . 87
Phil . . . 88
Mary goes in . . . 88
The dinner . . . 88
Pirate Clark . . . 89
The chase . . . 89
Async . . . 89
The ending . . . 90
The Everything Must Go Edition . . . 91
Details, Symbols and Easter Eggs in the Film . . . 92
Where it sits in the timeline . . . 92
Things carried over from the series . . . 92
Things carried over from The Oldest View . . . 93
Nods to the original Backrooms . . . 93
The store and the commercial . . . 93
Mary . . . 94
Clark . . . 94
Pirate Clark . . . 94
Phil . . . 95

Sound and music in the frame . . . 95
Text written in the Backrooms . . . 95
Mistakes and oddities . . . 95
What the film confirms about the Complex . . . 96

PART V: The Complex . . . 97

What the Complex Is . . . 98
Names . . . 98
The main idea, in the film's words . . . 98
Evidence that it copies real things . . . 98
What goes wrong when it copies . . . 99
What it's built from . . . 100
Power and light . . . 100
Scale . . . 100
It isn't fixed . . . 101
Sound . . . 101
Air, food, water and bodies . . . 101
Does it think? . . . 101
Safety rules and what Async learned . . . 102
The Threshold and the Null Zones . . . 103
The machine . . . 103
The Threshold and the Outpost . . . 103
Null zones . . . 104
Every null zone on record . . . 104
How they behave . . . 105
Falling . . . 105
Three fan sheets on null zones . . . 105
Why null zones appeared . . . 109
A Gazetteer of the Complex . . . 110
On the real side . . . 110
The Threshold side . . . 110
Division 14 . . . 111
Tench's route (Informational Video) . . . 112
Found Footage (1991) . . . 112
Found Footage #2 (1995) . . . 112
Found Footage #3 . . . 113
The Kelowna Branch (the film and Everything Must Go) . . . 115
Fan maps of the whole . . . 116
The Red City . . . 117
What Lives There . . . 120
The common thread . . . 120

The Lifeform . . . 120
The tentacled thing . . . 121
The knocker in Found Footage #3 . . . 121
Still Lifes . . . 121
Other strange things . . . 123
What the creatures have in common . . . 123
Time Slips and the Green Glow . . . 124
Every time anomaly on record . . . 124
Patterns . . . 125
Tench's jump, in numbers . . . 125
The green glow . . . 125
The Sun . . . 126
Wind chimes . . . 127

PART VI: Async and the People . . . 128
The Async Research Institute . . . 129
What it is . . . 129
The people at the top . . . 129
The money . . . 130
Equipment and methods . . . 130
Rules . . . 130
Cover-ups . . . 131
Culture . . . 131
Async after 1990 . . . 131
Everyone, in Order of Appearance in the Story . . . 133
Before the Threshold . . . 133
The Async staff, 1989 to 1990 . . . 133
The people who fell in . . . 135
The film's people outside the Complex . . . 135
The Still Lifes and creatures . . . 136

PART VII: Timelines, Words and Music . . . 137
The Master Timeline . . . 138
Inside the story . . . 138
The real history the story uses . . . 140
Making it . . . 140
In Kane's Words . . . 142
Canon and continuity . . . 142
The first video . . . 142
What the Backrooms means to him . . . 142
The Complex . . . 143

Async . . . 143
Ivan Beck . . . 144
The creatures . . . 144
The film . . . 144
Theories . . . 144
What's next . . . 144
Cast and crew . . . 145
Music and Sound . . . 146
Kane as composer . . . 146
The Backrooms OST . . . 146
Out of Sync . . . 147
Music and sound inside the series . . . 148
Music and sound in the film . . . 149
The sounds of the place . . . 149

PART VIII: Theories, Hypotheses and the Mathematics . . . 150

A Catalogue of Fan Theories . . . 151
What the Complex is . . . 151
Null zones and time . . . 152
The Lifeform . . . 152
Still Lifes . . . 153
Async and the people . . . 153
Readings of the film . . . 154
What Kane has said about theories . . . 154
Our Own Hypotheses . . . 155
Ground rules we held ourselves to . . . 155
Your hypothesis, that the Complex is steadier where people are . . . 155
The theory you brought in . . . 156
Copying as lossy compression . . . 156
The teaser, panel by panel . . . 156
Drifting toward the common, with glitches as mutations . . . 158
Real places as fresh islands . . . 158
Depth means generations, not distance . . . 158
Where the seams go . . . 159
Overlapping rooms . . . 159
Why it copies what it copies . . . 159
Your floodlights . . . 159
The fourth sign . . . 159
Where this leads . . . 159
A Working Theory of the Complex . . . 160
What Kane has said, and what he hasn't . . . 160

Law 1. Capture . . . 161
Law 2. Two fidelities . . . 163
Law 3. Matter, not light . . . 165
Law 4. The open space is the centre . . . 171
Law 5. Interpretation . . . 174
Law 6. Every remembering is a worse copy . . . 175
Law 7. The snowball . . . 178
Law 8. Continuation . . . 180
Law 9. Structure before function . . . 181
Law 10. Reaching back . . . 182
Why Kane's Complex is never huge . . . 185
The whole theory in one paragraph . . . 185
What the theory leaves open . . . 185
How sure we are, law by law . . . 186
Testing the Theory . . . 187
How the testing was done . . . 187
Ideas that didn't survive . . . 187
Every outdoor copy against the laws . . . 189
Three skies, three generations . . . 190
Clark's store, three copies from one doorway . . . 191
Every Still Life against the laws . . . 191
Pirate Clark, frame by frame . . . 193
The time problem . . . 194
Does the film show intent? . . . 194
Predictions that could break the theory . . . 195
Questions and Answers . . . 196
The basics . . . 196
How it copies . . . 196
Inside, outside and the sky . . . 199
Fronts, views and connections . . . 202
Why it goes wrong . . . 203
Plants, water and bodies . . . 204
People and Still Lifes . . . 206
Power and reaching back . . . 207
Time . . . 208
The Sun and the green glow . . . 209
Origins and the future . . . 209
The Mathematics and the Science . . . 211
The signs in Everything Must Go . . . 211
The ceiling tile and the lights . . . 212
Dates and days of the week . . . 212

Time jumps . . . 213
The fan time-jump curve . . . 213
How big is it? . . . 213
Lossy copying, in equations . . . 213
Why weak copies look like dioramas . . . 214
Drift and mutation . . . 214
The snowball, in equations . . . 214
Why near things stay right and far things go wrong . . . 215
A capture that fades with depth . . . 215
Bounces and the sky, in equations . . . 216
Simplicity survives . . . 216
Joins and microtiles . . . 216
Overlap and relocation . . . 217
Can it all be connected? . . . 217
Measuring a layout . . . 217
The psychology of misremembered places . . . 217
The real science in the series . . . 218

PART IX: Loose Ends and Reference . . . 219

Open Questions and Contradictions . . . 220
Questions canon hasn't answered . . . 220
Where the sources contradict each other . . . 221
Glossary . . . 222
Sources . . . 224
Primary, by Kane Parsons . . . 224
The film and its marketing . . . 224
Video interviews . . . 224
Print and web interviews and features . . . 224
Reference works . . . 225
Commentary and analysis . . . 225
Science and scholarship . . . 226

How to Read This Codex

This book tries to hold everything that can be found about Kane Parsons' version of the Backrooms. That means the web series he started uploading to YouTube on 7 January 2022 and the hidden videos around it, the A24 film **Backrooms** that opened on 29 May 2026 and its extended **Everything Must Go Edition**, the marketing puzzle that ran alongside the film, every interview with Kane and his collaborators that could be reached, the production history, the music, the fan theories, our own hypotheses, and the mathematics and science that help explain how the place called the Complex behaves.

You can read it front to back or dip into it. Each claim carries a small label saying where it comes from. The most common mistake in Backrooms discussion is treating something a wiki, a theorist or a marketing blurb added as if it had been shown on screen, so the labels are there to keep those apart.

Label	Meaning
[CANON]	Shown or said on screen in the web series or one of its official hidden videos
[FILM]	Shown or said on screen in the 2026 film or the Everything Must Go footage
[OFFICIAL]	Official supplementary material such as video descriptions, release dates, soundtrack titles, marketing and the fax and bulletin board puzzle
[KANE]	Something Kane Parsons said in an interview, on a stream, or as reported from his Discord or commentary
[CREW]	Something said by another member of the production, such as the production designer, producers or cast
[REAL WORLD]	A real-world fact about history, places, release data, box office or science
[FAN]	Fan documentation or fan theory from wikis, TV Tropes, video essayists, blogs and fan-made maps
[OURS]	A hypothesis we worked out ourselves
[YOURS]	A hypothesis raised by the person who commissioned this book
[SCIENCE]	Mathematics or science used as a model, a comparison or a measurement
[CONFLICT]	The sources disagree, and every version is given
[UNVERIFIED]	Reported second hand and not confirmed by another source

Some paragraphs carry two labels. [CANON] [FAN] means the thing is on screen but the reading of it comes from fans.

Quotations

The series, the film and the interviews are all copyrighted, so scenes and dialogue are retold here in our own words. Short phrases are quoted where the exact wording matters, and always with the speaker and source. A few lines have become famous in their own right, like Clark saying the place "remembers" its rooms, and those are given briefly. None of this replaces watching the material, and every video is listed with a link in the Sources part at the back.

Dates

Two kinds of date run through the book. Release dates are when a video or the film came out in the real world. In-universe dates are when the events on screen are supposed to happen, taken from video descriptions, on-screen text, dialogue and props. Kane puts the in-universe date of most episodes in the YouTube description (Pitfalls just says "5/6/1990", for example). Those descriptions were read directly for this book and are treated as official.

Names

Names follow the official material. Where fans spell something differently (Tench and Tinch, Heymann and Haymon, Kline and Klein) the official form is used and the variant is mentioned once. The company is written **Async** in running text. It turns up as ASYNC, A-sync and Async in different places, and the film's credits and Kane himself use Async.

Images

The pictures come from three places. Some are frames, stills, fan maps and fan infographics supplied by the person who commissioned this book, and the fan work is labelled as such. Others are the official thumbnails of Kane's videos and of A24's promotional videos. Two are the original photographs from 2002 that the whole Backrooms idea grew out of, which are on Wikimedia Commons. Every caption says which is which.

The Short Version

This is the whole story on two pages. Everything here is expanded, sourced and labelled later in the book.

[REAL WORLD] On 12 May 2019 someone on 4chan's paranormal board asked for unsettling pictures, and an anonymous reply posted a photograph of an empty, yellowed, carpeted room under fluorescent lights with a short caption. If you "noclip" out of reality in the wrong place, it said, you end up in the Backrooms, an endless maze of damp carpet, mono-yellow walls and buzzing lights. The photo was later traced to the upstairs of a former furniture store in Oshkosh, Wisconsin, taken during a renovation in 2002. Over the next two years an open community built a sprawling mythology of numbered "levels" and monsters on top of it.

[REAL WORLD] In January 2022 Kane Parsons, then sixteen and living in Northern California, uploaded a nine minute found-footage short he'd made in Blender and After Effects. It went viral. Within days he tied it to a story he had already been working on, about a small California company called **Async** that used to make MRI machines. Async builds a magnetic device that opens a stable doorway, **the Threshold**, into an endless interior it calls **the Complex**. Kane dropped the community's levels completely. His Backrooms is one place, handled with the sober logic of hard science fiction.

[CANON] The web series is told out of order through found footage, corporate videos and hidden files. Async's first brush with something came in a 1972 experiment signed off by a scientist named **Ivan Beck**. A prototype was tested at Oak Ridge in 1982. The sixth test of the **Low-Proximity Magnetic Distortion System**, on 17 October 1989, opened the Threshold at the same moment as the Loma Prieta earthquake. After that, missing persons cases climbed as random **null zones** started dropping people into the Complex. Async's explorers find a corpse overgrown with a mutated hay bacillus. They lose a researcher named **Peter Tench**, who turns up two months later having lived through only half an hour. They meet a stalking creature that imitates human voices (**the Lifeform**), and they learn that the Complex holds copies of real places, red-lit streets under fake night skies, rooms that stretch, and objects sinking into floors. They pitch the space to the Department of Energy as **A-Space**, hide the fact that Tench survived, and get ambushed by him. Woven through all this is footage of ordinary people who fall in by accident. There's a teenager in 1991, a woman in 1995, and **Ravi**, whose 45 minute ordeal introduces humanoid copies of people.

[FILM] The film is set in June and July 1990. It follows **Clark**, a failed architect running a failing pirate-themed furniture store in San Jose, and his therapist **Dr. Mary Kline**. A doorway opens in Clark's basement. Clark comes to believe the place "remembers" what it builds and that every remembering is a little worse than the last. He finds **Still Lifes**, misremembered copies of people, among them a giant copy of himself in his pirate costume. He decides to stay, and it eats him. Mary survives and is taken in by Async, where a researcher named **Phil** tells her that doors into the Complex are now opening everywhere. The last shot is a Still Life of Mary herself.

[KANE] Kane says the story has had a fixed arc and ending since 2022, written down in a private document of about seventy pages. He never sets up a mystery he can't answer, he hates retcons, and he sees the film as one branch of a bigger tree. What he'd really like is a limited series that reaches the main ending. He describes the Complex as something that recognises, interprets and stores the physical structure of our world, closer to a force of nature than a hell or a punishment.

[FAN] [OURS] [SCIENCE] The last parts of the book collect the fan theories and the open questions, along with some mathematical models (lossy copying, genetic drift, reconstruction toward a prior, forgetting the smallest details first) that describe how the Complex behaves surprisingly well. They end in a working theory of ten laws, tested against every case in the book, which says that the Complex keeps what things

are far better than where they belong, can copy matter but never light or sky, and fills whatever it lacks from what it already holds.

Scope and Sources

What was read

Every video in the series was read at the source. That covers the metadata, the descriptions and the transcripts, pulled from Kane's channel and from the channels hosting the unlisted videos, together with detailed notes from secondary sources.

For the film there was the full published dialogue transcript, Wikipedia's article, TV Tropes' film pages and several detailed plot write-ups.

The interviews read were Vice (2022), ABC News (2022), Anthony Padilla (2023), Dazed (2024), Smosh (2024 and 2026), Wendigoon (before release, and on set), the A24 Podcast with James Wan (2026), BAFTA (2026), Fangoria (two pieces, 2026), Interview Magazine (2026), Complex (2026), Cultured (2026), The Playlist (three pieces, 2026), The AU Review (2026), a Japanese interview digest on note.com (2026), Infobae (2026), Deadline's Zurich interview (2026), and the production designer Danny Vermette in W Magazine, the Motion Picture Association's site The Credits, and Yahoo.

On the fan side there was TV Tropes (the series and film pages with their character, timeline, theory, trivia and analysis subpages), the Kane Pixels Backrooms Fandom wiki, Wendigoon's three hour theory video, Taylor Holmes' episode guides and essays, and the fan maps and infographics supplied with this commission. For the music, the "Backrooms OST" and "Out of Sync" playlists on Kane's music channel and the film score's track titles.

PART I

Before Kane

The Backrooms had already been around for two and a half years when Kane Parsons picked it up. It was a photograph nobody could place, a single paragraph of text, and then a sprawling collective mythology. Kane's series grew out of that and then deliberately left most of it behind.

The Photograph and the Post

The thread of 12 May 2019

[REAL WORLD] On 12 May 2019 someone on 4chan's paranormal board, /x/, started a thread asking for "disquieting images that just feel off". One of the replies was a photograph of an empty interior. The walls are a dull, greyish yellow with a faint repeating pattern, the carpet is stained beige, and a drop ceiling holds rows of rectangular fluorescent panels. Partition walls break the room into odd bays, and the frame is slightly tilted. There's nothing in it at all. No furniture, no people, no signs, no windows.

[REAL WORLD] Attached to the picture was a short paragraph that more or less invented the idea. It warned that if you aren't careful and you "noclip" out of reality in the wrong areas, you'll end up in the Backrooms, where there's nothing but the smell of old damp carpet, a single maddening shade of yellow, the endless hum of fluorescent lights turned all the way up, and something like six hundred million square miles of randomly divided empty rooms to be lost in. It ends by saying that if you hear something wandering nearby, it has definitely heard you. The two phrases people quote most are "the stink of old moist carpet" and "the madness of mono-yellow".

[KANE] Kane describes the origin as two posts meeting rather than one. An image had been floating around the board, and a different anonymous user paired it with the caption. 4chan is anonymous and its threads expire, so nobody can say who posted either, and Kane has called that untraceable authorship "a big defining part" of what the Backrooms is (A24 Podcast, 2026; Smosh, 2024).

[REAL WORLD] "Noclip" comes from video games. It's a debug mode that turns off collision so the player can pass through walls and floors, so the caption is really a game glitch applied to real life. Kane has said the language is "gamey" but the idea doesn't have to stay inside games. You just fall out of the world and land somewhere monotonous that goes on forever (Smosh Asks, 2026).

[REAL WORLD] Within days the screenshot of the image and caption was everywhere as a meme. Kane remembers seeing it on Instagram in 2019 while he was in middle school. He found it "weirdly intriguing" but had no thought of making anything from it (A24 Podcast, 2026; Anthony Padilla, 2023).

Where the photograph came from

[REAL WORLD] For five years nobody knew where the picture had been taken. In May 2024 members of a Discord community devoted to the Backrooms traced it through the Wayback Machine to an archived web page from March 2003. Wikipedia summarises what they found.

Item	Detail
Building	807 Oregon Street, Oshkosh, Wisconsin
Earlier tenant	Rohner's Home Furnishings, a furniture store, from the twentieth century into the early 2000s
New tenant	A HobbyTown USA franchise, which took over the building in 2003
When the photo was taken	12 June 2002, while the second storey was being renovated
Camera	A Sony Cyber-shot
Published	2 March 2003, on the HobbyTown Oshkosh store's web page
File name	Dsc00161.jpg
Original caption	It called the space the "East (Oval) room" and mentioned water damage that meant the area had to be cleared
What happened to the room	It was later turned into a radio-controlled car track and no longer exists

Item	Detail
Afterwards	The owner ran a crowdfunding campaign against an estimated $78,000 renovation and raised more than $24,000. The building was sold in 2025 and carries on under a new name



The original photograph, taken on 12 June 2002 in the upstairs of the former Rohner's furniture store at 807 Oregon Street, Oshkosh, Wisconsin, while it was being turned into a HobbyTown USA store. (Wikimedia Commons)



A second photograph from the same 2002 set (Dsc00159), showing the same renovation with its arches and ceiling grid. (Wikimedia Commons)

[CREW] Danny Vermette, the film's production designer, pointed out that the famous yellow is partly a photographic accident. The white balance in the original picture is off, and the real room was probably closer to beige (The Credits, 2026).

[KANE] Kane said something similar about liminal photographs in 2022. He remembers the late 1990s and early 2000s through little glimpses and family photos where "the flash is always on", the lighting looks gross, the walls are yellow and the white balance is off (Vice, 2022). The yellow of the Backrooms is basically the colour of a cheap camera getting it wrong.

[FILM] Kane put the photograph's origin into his film. The way in turns up in the basement of a struggling furniture store, and when Clark first steps through, the view to his right copies the arches and layout of the real Oshkosh store. The original photograph is restaged in one of the camcorder shots (TV Tropes, film page).

The meme becomes a mythology

[REAL WORLD] Within days of the first post people were writing Backrooms stories on Reddit's r/creepypasta and r/backrooms, and the idea quickly grew. It picked up numbered **levels**, each with its own rules and look, with Level 0 as the original yellow rooms, Level 1 as a concrete warehouse, the Poolrooms, and eventually hundreds more including joke ones. It picked up **entities**, monsters like the "smilers" (a grin of glowing teeth in the dark), hounds, partygoers and skin stealers. It even picked up survival lore, like "almond water", a drink that supposedly keeps wanderers alive. All of it was collected on collaborative wikis on Wikidot and Fandom that anyone could edit, much like the SCP Foundation wiki.

[REAL WORLD] The community split over this. A Reddit user called _LitheBeep_ started r/TrueBackrooms for purists who only wanted the original empty single-image idea. By March 2022 r/backrooms had more than 157,000 members, and Backrooms content had spread across YouTube, Twitter and TikTok. In 2022 there was even a TikTok trend of using Google Earth to "find" Backrooms entrances in real buildings.

[REAL WORLD] The liminal space aesthetic grew up alongside it. The word comes from the Latin limen, a threshold, and a liminal space is somewhere you pass through, like a corridor, a stairwell, a waiting room or an empty mall, usually photographed out of context with nobody in it. The tag #liminalspaces passed nearly 100 million views on TikTok, and people linked the Backrooms yellow with caution, decay and dread. PC Gamer compared the levels to Lovecraft's R'lyeh and to the endless City in the manga Blame!, and called the Backrooms an "uncanny valley of place". ABC News and Le Monde put it in a new genre of collaborative online horror with the SCP Foundation. Kotaku thought its lack of an obvious threat made it stand out among creepypastas, and Professor Tama Leaver of Curtin University put its pull down to an "eerie feeling of familiarity" (all via Wikipedia).

[REAL WORLD] Games came fast. The first Backrooms game, from Pie on a Plate Productions, was out about two months after the post, in July 2019. Later ones include Enter the Backrooms, Noclipped, The Backrooms Project, Escape the Backrooms (by Fancy Games, praised for how much of the wiki lore it shows), The Backrooms 1998 (Steelkrill Studio, 2022, with found-footage visuals and a limited save system), Dreamcore (Montraluz, Argentina, 2025) and a Backrooms map in Meccha Chameleon (2026).

[REAL WORLD] It spread into other work too. Dan Erickson, who created Severance, has named the Backrooms as one of his influences. It got an xkcd reference. Juice WRLD's posthumous song "Party By Myself" got a Backrooms-style music video in 2024. The third season of American Horror Stories had a Backrooms episode with Michael Imperioli as a grieving screenwriter lost in mundane spaces and haunted by his missing son.

The Poolrooms and other famous images

[REAL WORLD] [FAN] A few other liminal photographs had already become Backrooms "levels" before Kane arrived. The best known are the **Poolrooms**, an endless white-tiled indoor swimming pool made popular by renders from the artist Jared Pike, and **"Level: The End"**, which comes from a photograph of a closing-down Borders bookstore with its wooden shelves stacked in stepped pyramids.

[KANE] [FAN] Kane says his own pool areas, in Found Footage #2 and the film, come mostly from his own dreams of underground pools rather than from Pike's renders (TV Tropes trivia, citing a livestream). He also told Dazed that one of his recurring nightmares was of underground swimming pools full of figures made of metal wire, which sounds a lot like both his Poolrooms and his Lifeform (Dazed, 2024).

[FILM] The film nods to both. A grimy, drained version of the pool rooms shows up during the chase, and the closing montage includes a bookstore whose pyramid shelving recalls the Borders photo (TV Tropes, film page).

How Kane's Backrooms Differs

One place, not levels

[KANE] [FAN] Kane's series ignores the community's levels, monsters and items altogether. TV Tropes sums up the result well. There are no warp passages between levels. Everything fans would call "Level 0" simply contains every kind of space, from offices and houses to pools and red-lit streets. The drops called pitfalls lead to very different areas but they aren't level changes, and the only "exits" lead back to Earth. There's no almond water, and none of the old assumption that a wanderer can never meet another person.

[KANE] Kane says he had "no idea" there was a community behind the image when he posted his first short. Wiki fans told him he was "doing the Backrooms wrong" and that there were "supposed to be smilers on level one". That went on until, in his words, people "almost forgot about the old one" and his version was "sort of adopted" (Anthony Padilla, 2023). He's relaxed about canon. He thinks "everything is canon to itself" and that people worry too much about what counts.

[KANE] He's also clear that he didn't create the Backrooms. In 2026 he told Smosh he has never claimed to be its creator and doesn't want to be, and that he just made a web series that "somehow spiraled into a movie". He told Deadline the same year that he "synthesized it into a specific version" but "can't take credit for the source".

What Kane thinks other versions miss

[KANE] Kane thinks a lot of Backrooms projects "miss the mark" by making the space dark and green, like a haunted house. The original photo is bright, washed out and low in contrast, and its horror comes from context rather than from anything in the frame. It's an everyday, mediocre place that just keeps going forever (A24 Podcast, 2026). He likes that the 4chan caption treats the place like a natural phenomenon with no morality in it. It isn't hell or a judgment, and it isn't even purgatory, because you don't do anything to end up there. It just happens to you, like getting stuck in a glitch in a game, and there's nothing fair about it.

Names inside the story

[CANON] [FAN] Inside the series nobody uses "Backrooms" as an official name. Async calls the place **the Complex**, and its sales pitch calls it **A-SPACE**, complete with a trademark sign. "Backrooms" is treated as staff slang. Accidental ways in are called **null zones** and never "noclipping", a word that didn't exist in its modern sense in 1990. In the film Clark just says "this place", and Phil, sworn to secrecy, only ever says "in there" (TV Tropes).

[REAL WORLD] The film is called just **Backrooms**, without "The". Kane pitched it with that title and nobody tried to change it. He prefers the YouTube habit of "Backrooms - Episode Name" and thinks the bare title is more elegant (Smosh Asks, 2026). Several foreign releases added a subtitle meaning "No Exit", and the Brazilian one was subtitled "A Non-Place", after the anthropologist Marc Augé's term for transit places like airports and hotel rooms.

Imitators

[KANE] [FAN] Kane's success brought a wave of imitators borrowing his look, with Async, hazmat suits and wire-thin monsters. Some became big channels themselves, including one first called "ASync Research" and later renamed "Complex Research", the "Outpost" series by Andy R Animations, and the work of a creator called Kauffman. Kane told Anthony Padilla in 2023 that some channels were using the Async

name and his characters. He doesn't mind remixing in principle, he said, but he felt the Backrooms had been "trashed pretty badly" by children's content farms, right down to joke levels like "Level Burger King". Fans of his series are quick to point out that none of these imitators are canon to it.

PART II

The Creator

Kane Parsons, known online as Kane Pixels, was sixteen when he posted the first video and twenty when his film opened at number one. A lot of what makes his Backrooms what it is comes straight from how he works.

Kane Parsons

Life

[REAL WORLD] Kane Parsons was born on 18 June 2005 in Petaluma, California (Wikipedia). He grew up in Sonoma and Marin counties in Northern California, where he and his family still live (A24 Podcast, 2026). His father, Michael Parsons, is a visual effects artist on the games side of the industry, and his mother is a therapist. He has a younger brother. His parents divorced when he was seven. He went to the Marin School of the Arts at Novato High School and didn't go on to college or film school.

[KANE] He has joked that it was "a great divorce", and his parents still get on well, but he says it changed how he saw things. Watching something that had seemed permanent simply stop existing taught him that nothing has an inherent direction and that "anything can turn into anything", so there was no reason not to throw himself into what he wanted to do. It also brought on existential crises about death at seven, which he says still come out in his films (Anthony Padilla, 2023). He talks about a "big fear of death", not of accidents but of not existing forever, and calls his projects a way of exploring the existential thinking that "bores holes" in him (Smosh, 2024).

[KANE] His parents kept him off the internet until he was eight or nine. He drew constantly and made Lego stop-motion films on an old digital camera, and by about nine the words "filmmaker" and "director" were already in his head. Creative sandbox games on a PlayStation 3 (he mentions LittleBigPlanet among others) taught him what it feels like to build a space and then watch other people walk into it. He watched effects-heavy YouTube channels like Corridor Crew, taught himself to edit from tutorials, "pirated way too much software and got a bunch of viruses", and worked his way from Windows Movie Maker through Filmora and iMovie to Premiere, After Effects and Blender. In middle school he entered a few small local film festivals and assumed he'd go to film school (A24 Podcast, 2026; Anthony Padilla, 2023).

[KANE] He says he thinks almost entirely in pictures. Words show up as images and he can't "do written language" in his head (A24 Podcast, 2026). He also says he needs to know "every single thing" about a project before anyone else touches it, and doesn't cope well with variables he can't control.

Valve, the pandemic and Blender

[KANE] Kane keeps coming back to Valve's games, Portal and Half-Life, as the biggest influence on his taste. Doug Rattmann, the unseen scientist whose scribbled messages cover the hidden rooms of Portal, was his "childhood boogeyman", and he says he could hear Rattmann's rambling in his head at night (Anthony Padilla, 2023). He told Dazed that Portal 2 "got me thinking about the feelings that spaces can evoke in a person" and "took over my life".

[KANE] He started teaching himself Blender at fourteen, at the beginning of the 2020 pandemic, because he wanted to make fan art for Half-Life Alyx. He says he could use it within a couple of weeks (A24 Podcast, 2026).

The Attack on Titan videos

[REAL WORLD] [KANE] Through 2021 he made a run of videos that showed scenes from Attack on Titan as if they were real black-and-white war footage from the 1930s and 40s, built in Blender with heavy compositing. The first got around ten million views and so did the second, and the channel picked up about 200,000 subscribers. By the end of 2021 he felt he'd used up every scene he could adapt (A24 Podcast, 2026). Treating fiction as if it were authentic old footage is exactly what he then did with the Backrooms. Wikipedia also lists an earlier web series of his, Project 209, from 2020 and 2021.

The first short

[REAL WORLD] On 27 November 2021 Kane posted "Backrooms test footage 1" on Instagram (Wikipedia). It was one shot, of a figure rounding a corner and a chair being thrown into a wall, and he built the whole first short backwards from it. The shot is near the end of the finished video (Anthony Padilla, 2023).

[KANE] He made the short in about a month in Blender and After Effects, as something relaxing to do after he came across the original Backrooms image on his computer again, along with some liminal space compilations. The opening, where a student film crew is interrupted when the camera operator falls through the ground, was the last thing he shot. He filmed it on his phone with school friends who had no idea what it was for, then ran the footage through a VCR so it wouldn't look like phone video (A24 Podcast, 2026).

[KANE] It went up on 7 January 2022 and sat at around half a million views for the first two days. Then reaction channels picked it up, and within about two weeks it had ten million. He kept a daily journal through it all. He has said he expected a modest result and thought it might flop next to his Attack on Titan work (Anthony Padilla, 2023; Smosh Asks, 2026).

[KANE] Within about a day of the short taking off, he started tying it to a different story that had been forming in his head for a while. He realised "these two things could melt together" into a specific plot and structure he could start on right away, and that other story became **the Async Research Institute** (A24 Podcast, 2026). He has also said that most of the series' ideas came before the Backrooms idea did, and that the Backrooms is "more of just a texture to wrap over everything" (Anthony Padilla, 2023).

The rest of his work

[REAL WORLD] **The Oldest View** started on 18 March 2023. It follows a young man, Wyatt, who finds a staircase in the woods that goes a mile down into an abandoned shopping mall. The mall is the demolished Valley View Mall in Dallas, rebuilt in detail from Facebook groups and city hall blueprints, and the series features the Rolling Giant, a huge papier-mache figure of the botanist Julien Reverchon. Kane calls it his favourite and most rewarding project, because it dramatises real places, real shops and real companies instead of an invented world (Cultured, 2026; Smosh, 2024). Its episodes include "Renewal", "Beneath The Earth", "The Rolling Giant (The Oldest View Part 3)", "Dispersal", "Life of a Giant" and "The Remains of Valley View Mall (Post-Demolition)".

[REAL WORLD] **People Still Live Here** (2025) is presented as gameplay footage of a game from 2005, with uploads such as "People Still Live Here V8.3 (2005 Gameplay)", "Day 2 Gameplay", "Graveyard" and "Sunshine". Kane thinks it has "a much stronger chance of having legs" than his other side projects (Complex, 2026). His main channel also has "SAYWELL" and "Sandwich".

[REAL WORLD] His second channel, **Not Kane Pixels**, describes itself as "definitely not Kane Pixels' second channel" and holds around four hundred music uploads. Its playlists include the Backrooms OST, Out of Sync, The Oldest View OST, Daemon, Highway 101, Ambient Collection, Depattern, Q2, Drear, Secure State, Siege, Inevitable, Months and It's All Happening. He told Smosh he makes roughly a song a day to unwind.

[REAL WORLD] As of October 2026 the Kane Pixels channel has about 3.67 million subscribers and 52 public videos, and the first Backrooms short has passed 95 million views.

How he works

[KANE] Kane says the same things about his method in interview after interview. He builds stories backwards from a moment or an ending he wants to reach (Anthony Padilla, 2023; Smosh Asks, 2026). He has had "a very specific timeline that this whole story abides by" from the very beginning, and the film fits into it, and he says "every bit of Backrooms related media I put out is going to fit into that timeline somewhere" (Smosh, 2024). He "can't stand retcons" and has never been "okay retconning or breaking continuity" (Smosh, 2024; Wendigoon on set, 2026). And he "would never set up a mystery not knowing the answers myself".

[KANE] He keeps a private document he calls a "big personal Wikipedia for the story". It was about 71 pages in 2024 and about 72 by 2026, and he has since tried to trim it. It isn't meant to be handed to anyone else (Smosh, 2024; Smosh Asks, 2026). He told BAFTA he has "a very firm understanding and rulebook" for the systems underneath the story and that it has been "consistent through and through", though he doesn't think audiences want "too much of a bow" on the mystery.

[KANE] He tries "very hard to not make any arbitrary decisions". If a plug socket moves an inch between episodes, he wants the viewer to assume it moved for a reason, because the building shifted (Smosh, 2024; A24 Podcast, 2026). He builds his work to be "paused and analyzed" and to hold up when someone recaps it in a video. He likes the audience to sense there's a great deal more there than they're shown (Smosh, 2024).

[KANE] His conscious influence isn't found-footage cinema. It's real footage, bodycam video and urban exploration. "The best version of what I do," he said, is "actually trying to fool people into thinking this is real" (Smosh, 2024). An edited clip from The Oldest View did end up circulating on Facebook as supposed real footage of secret tunnels. He spends a long time on small peripheral details so that the main story feels solid and could go "in any direction" (Anthony Padilla, 2023). Even thumbnails were simple. He scrubbed through the footage and grabbed a frame with the snipping tool, and he noticed that videos with the yellow rooms in the thumbnail did far better (Smosh Asks, 2026).

[KANE] He doesn't follow theories closely but checks in now and then. In 2024 he said Film Theory's reading was "fairly off" and that nobody could know where things are going because parts of the story haven't been shown yet. Only a few barely-liked comments had come close, and "one person got it, and it got two likes" (Smosh, 2024). In 2023 he said no fan theory has ever changed his outline (Anthony Padilla, 2023).

Influences Kane has named

Work or artist	Where he mentioned it	What he took from it
Portal, Portal 2, Half-Life (Valve)	Many interviews	Spaces that make you feel something, sterile institutions, sound and texture, Doug Rattmann
Mr. Robot (2015 to 2019)	Complex, Letterboxd, Smosh Asks	His favourite show, watched about eight times. Mac Quayle's score shaped his early music
Utopia (British series, 2013)	Complex, Smosh Asks	Cristobal Tapia de Veer's warped synthesiser score
One Hour Photo (2002)	Letterboxd, Complex, Smosh Asks	The main visual reference for the film, and one of his favourite films
Punishment Park (1971)	Letterboxd	The fake documentary form
Paranoia Agent (2004)	Letterboxd	Satoshi Kon's psychological unease
Silent Hill	Smosh Asks, Dazed	Early 2000s synth pads
2001: A Space Odyssey	A24 Podcast	Screened for the crew during prep
Breaking Bad, Better Call Saul, Platonic	note.com digest	How the real world outside the Backrooms should look

Work or artist	Where he mentioned it	What he took from it
The Windows XP wallpaper "Bliss"	note.com digest	Photographed near where he grew up in California
Vaporwave	note.com digest	Nostalgia stripped of context
The Blair Witch Project	Smosh 2024, Dazed	Seen once at about ten, a subconscious influence at most
Chris Cunningham's Rubber Johnny, Terry Gilliam's Brazil	Dazed	Unsettling institutional imagery
Bodycam and urban exploration footage	Smosh 2024	The rhythm of a camera worn by a person

[KANE] He told Interview Magazine he "wasn't someone who fell in love with film as a kid". His influences are "more ambient from being online over the years", and he hardly watches horror. He told Dazed that "the internet has filled the space in my life where Hollywood would be". He has never read House of Leaves, even though people compare his work to it all the time, and Wendigoon and Kane's own father keep telling him to (Wendigoon, 2026).

Experiences that feed the work

[KANE] At thirteen, exploring the Millennium Biltmore Hotel in Los Angeles with friends, he found a deserted upper hallway and a stairwell that went down more than thirteen floors and got more run-down the further it went (Dazed, 2024). The places that fascinate him most are "the ones that see little (or ideally) no active foot traffic". He describes liminal spaces as "spaces that are just there to conjoin other spaces", like a petrol station on a long drive.

[KANE] His dreams are "architecturally centered, or fixated on spatial memory". He describes dreaming of a childhood home where "the semantic information of that place all got shuffled", and yet in the dream "you believed it" (Interview Magazine, 2026). He gave Anthony Padilla a funnier version, where in the dream it feels like your actual house and then you wake up and realise it was a Walmart. For him the Backrooms "has never been scary". He has "always just wanted to run around in there" (Anthony Padilla, 2023).

[KANE] He thinks liminal photographs work because they touch "uncurated little fragments of memories that are lacking context", the way a child half-remembers a place a parent left them in for a while. Those fragments blow up some details and drop others, until you're left with "an empty world that no one else lives in anymore" (Smosh Asks, 2026; The Playlist, 2026).

Views that shape the story

[KANE] He struggles with work that promotes "an overly human view of existence". He prefers stories in which people are incidental and the laws of the universe do the driving, and he needs his supernatural "to feel like hard sci-fi" (A24 Podcast, 2026).

[KANE] He "deeply hesitates" to condemn the urge to look around the next corner. The idea that humans should live in harmony and leave everything alone strikes him as "a little phony", since any sufficiently evolved species would end up roughly where we are. Crossing an ocean, looking around a corner and going too far are, in his view, all the same trait, whether it looks noble or reckless (Wendigoon on set, 2026).

[KANE] Inside the series he thinks of the Backrooms as "a neutral technology that's not inherently anything", like any field of engineering. It could do great good or great harm, or just be nature if everyone agreed to leave it alone, which he says would never happen. He wonders aloud whether it would really be evil to ask where the power comes from and whether it could be tapped, "free power, maybe?" (Wendigoon on set, 2026).

[KANE] What the series is really about, he says, is how fast people "trip over themselves" to get somewhere first, because if it isn't them it will be someone else. He compares it to the race toward artificial intelligence, everyone teetering at the edge of "an impossible singularity" that's both magnificent and destructive. The specialists who know how things work are rarely the people steering, and when shareholders and distant managers are in charge, things tend to tip into carelessness (Wendigoon on set, 2026).

[KANE] He has "a strong aversion" to artists who lean on generative AI. If he finds out something was generated he loses interest in it completely. He calls cognitive outsourcing "a nightmare" and says leaning on language models for your own creative work does "genuine harm to your brain" (Deadline, 2026). In June 2026 he said that if he could snap his fingers and make generative AI disappear for good, he probably would (Wikipedia). He insisted the film's sets be physical, because "anytime a character is physically walking on the floor, it's a real floor" (Interview Magazine, 2026).

[KANE] "I didn't direct like a horror film. I don't view it as a horror project." He thinks the horror label was marketing's "path of least resistance" (The Playlist, September 2026). He told Infobae the aim "is not so much to frighten as to provoke introspection", and he calls the series a "sci-fi techno thriller thing" and a "hard sci-fi human drama" (Smosh Asks, 2026).

[KANE] He sees the film as a way in for newcomers that "fits perfectly with where the YouTube series was heading" and "sets up a number of things" he wants to come back to. He has called it "a large episode of the YouTube series that's told in a slightly different way" (Anthony Padilla, 2023), and says most of the "global story" was never meant to be told through solo found footage (Wendigoon on set, 2026).

Public life after the film

[KANE] He keeps "a barrier" between himself and his audience. He doesn't run the official Discord server, though it has been his main point of contact with fans since he was sixteen, and he'd rather "go off, be a secretive hermit" and make something (Deadline, 2026).

[FAN] [REAL WORLD] After the film's success a rumour went round that he hadn't really directed it. Kane turned it into a running joke about "the Older Gentleman", a reclusive figure who supposedly directs nearly every North American and European film in exchange for the creator's IP, "life rights" and genetic information. When the New York Post published where he lived and his parents' names, he joked that this was the price of exposing the Older Gentleman (TV Tropes). A24's official account marked his 21st birthday on 18 June 2026 by playing on the viral "He is only 20 years old" meme.

[REAL WORLD] He received a Creator Honor from The Game Theorists at the 12th Streamy Awards in December 2022. With Backrooms he became A24's youngest director and the youngest filmmaker ever to open a film at number one in both the United States and worldwide, beating Josh Trank's Chronicle (2012).

What comes next

[KANE] Since 2023 he has said he wants a limited series to finish the story, telling Deadline in 2026 that "the dream scenario would be a limited series for Backrooms to get to the main ending". In 2024 he put it at nine episodes if the first film did well (Smosh, 2024). In September 2026 he said there are "a few things" he'll "love to talk about" soon, and that he "never stop[s] making things" (Deadline, 2026).

[REAL WORLD] [UNVERIFIED] In September 2026 trade reports said Kane had signed with A24 to direct a sequel and that an announcement was close. Back in June 2026 Deadline had reported he was looking for a co-writer for a sequel, which Kane denied, talking instead about a television series. The Playlist has also reported that he's interested in adapting Valve's Portal as a film.

PART III

The Web Series

Twenty-six videos released between January 2022 and August 2026, six of them hidden, and told almost entirely out of order. This part goes through them one at a time in the order they came out, pulling out everything the picture, the sound, the description and the date can tell us.

The Series at a Glance

What the series is

[REAL WORLD] Wikipedia calls **Backrooms** an American science fiction analog horror web series, made mostly as found footage, about a fictional organisation called the Async Research Institute whose scientists explore an extradimensional space of huge, mostly empty, connected interiors. Kane wrote, directed, animated and scored every episode. The main episodes are in the official "Backrooms" playlist on the Kane Pixels channel. Six more are unlisted or sit on other channels, and you reach them through links tucked into episode descriptions.

[KANE] In 2022 he told ABC News it was "a slow burn story", split between the politics of Async and the United States government and the "otherworldly, confusing functions" of the Complex. In 2026 he guessed the whole thing ran to about three hours, with an Async arc and a few videos from ordinary people's point of view like the first short (A24 Podcast).

[OFFICIAL] Almost every YouTube description is just an in-universe date and a Ko-fi link, sometimes with a credit or a link to a hidden video. Those dates are the backbone of the timeline in this book.

Release order

No.	Title	Released	Length	In-universe date	Views, Oct 2026
1	The Backrooms (Found Footage)	7 Jan 2022	9:14	Filmed 4 Jul 1991, description says 23 Sep 1996	95.7 million
2	Mar11_90_ARCHIVE.tar (unlisted)	8 Jan 2022	2:48	Archive from March 1990, "Compiled on Jun 1991"	5.3 million
3	Backrooms - The Third Test	13 Jan 2022	1:46	2 Jul 1988	8.8 million
4	Backrooms - First Contact	17 Jan 2022	1:57	17 Oct 1989	13.1 million
5	faultline.mov (unlisted)	17 Jan 2022	2:59	17 Oct 1989 (real news footage)	0.46 million
6	Backrooms - Missing Persons	28 Jan 2022	2:36	3 Feb 1990	20.0 million
7	Backrooms - Informational Video	12 Feb 2022	8:01	"29 Feb 1990", a date that never existed	17.1 million
8	Backrooms - Autopsy Report	23 Feb 2022	2:36	5 Feb 1990	7.8 million
9	Backrooms - Motion Detected	11 Mar 2022	4:07	5 Mar 1990	12.9 million
10	Backrooms - Prototype	28 Mar 2022	1:32	10 May 1982	5.8 million
11	Backrooms - Pitfalls	1 May 2022	14:04	6 May 1990	13.4 million
12	Backrooms - Report	20 May 2022	6:20	6 May 1990	7.6 million
13	9780415263573 (unlisted)	20 May 2022	0:33	Undated, before Aug 1995	1.7 million
14	Backrooms - Presentation	25 Jun 2022	8:26	8 May 1990	12.1 million

No.	Title	Released	Length	In-universe date	Views, Oct 2026
15	Simpsons (another channel)	25 Jun 2022	1:08	Undated, a 1991 broadcast cut into by an ad from 2000	0.28 million
16	Backrooms - Found Footage #2	21 Aug 2022	13:23	19 Aug 1995	17.8 million
17	home_27647.mov (unlisted)	21 Aug 2022	3:26	An undated home video	1.4 million
18	I Remember	30 Aug 2022	1:29	Undated, and not in the playlist	3.5 million
19	Backrooms - Reunion	8 Dec 2022	13:11	25 May 1990	7.7 million
20	_recording014 (unlisted)	8 Dec 2022	2:32	8 May 1990	1.2 million
21	Backrooms - Overflow	24 Dec 2022	1:38	2 Aug 1972, from the document on screen	3.0 million
22	Backrooms - Damage Control	30 Jan 2023	14:03	26 May 1990	4.5 million
23	Backrooms - Found Footage #3	13 Sep 2024	45:01	Late April 1995, from a radio report	9.5 million
24	Backrooms - Lighting and Tile Survey	2 Oct 2024	8:44	14 Nov 1989	3.9 million
25	Backrooms - Static Dead End	12 Feb 2025	4:02	29 May 1990	4.1 million
26	Backrooms - Everything Must Go	3 Jul 2026 in cinemas, 17 Aug 2026 (Pacific time) on YouTube	16:04	18 and 19 Jun 1990	4.9 million

[CONFLICT] Wikipedia counts 25 episodes, including the unlisted videos but leaving out "I Remember". The fan wikis number the main episodes separately, which makes Everything Must Go the nineteenth main episode and the twenty-fifth overall. Wikipedia also puts its YouTube release on 18 August 2026. The upload timestamp is the evening of 17 August in California, which was already the 18th in most of the world.

[OFFICIAL] A few descriptions carry credits. Autopsy Report has "VA - Arthur Langlie", Found Footage #2 has "VA - Madison", and Found Footage #3 has "Ravi - Aakash Valdivia". Pitfalls, Presentation, Reunion and Damage Control credit the Rokoko Smartsuit Pro II for motion capture, Presentation credits "Trendwatch" for additional motion graphics, and Everything Must Go thanks Ensoyu, Syrz05 and Stodja for CG asset assistance.

In-universe order

[CANON] [OFFICIAL] Sorted by when things happen rather than when they were released, the series goes like this.

In-universe date	Video	What happens
2 Aug 1972	Overflow	A lab report signed by Ivan Beck, a green glow filling a room, and the night sky folding
10 May 1982	Prototype	An early magnetic device is tested at Oak Ridge National Laboratory
Apr 1988	(mentioned in The Third Test)	Ivan Beck's press conference promising a fix for storage and housing
2 Jul 1988	The Third Test	The third test of the Low-Proximity Magnetic Distortion System

In-universe date	Video	What happens
17 Oct 1989	First Contact and faultline.mov	The sixth test opens the Threshold during the Loma Prieta earthquake
14 and 15 Nov 1989	Lighting and Tile Survey	A ceiling tile and a light fitting are taken out and analysed
3 Feb 1990	Missing Persons	Missing persons posters, and an overgrown corpse found in the Complex
5 Feb 1990	Autopsy Report	The corpse is examined and a mutated hay bacillus found
1 Mar 1990 ("29 Feb")	Informational Video	Peter Tench loses his team and jumps forward to 8 May
5 and 6 Mar 1990	Motion Detected	Motion cameras catch something near the Threshold
Mar 1990, compiled Jun 1991	Mar11_90_ARCHIVE.tar	Stills from Async's archive
6 May 1990	Pitfalls and Report	Marvin falls into the pits of Room 14D, and Async reviews the tape and seals the area
8 May 1990	Presentation and _recording014	The Department of Energy tour, Tench reappearing at 5:30 pm, Clyde phoning Ivan Beck
25 May 1990	Reunion	Tench ambushes a survey team in Room 14C and shoots Mark Blume
26 May 1990	Damage Control	Async briefs its staff and says Tench is dead
29 May 1990	Static Dead End	Marvin and George talk, and the room behind 14D's door is surveyed
18 and 19 Jun 1990	Everything Must Go and the film's opening	The signs in the Kelowna Branch, and Naren Warne's death
late Jun to Jul 1990	The film	Clark, Mary and Pirate Clark
4 Jul 1991	The Backrooms (Found Footage)	A student camera operator falls in
late Apr 1995	Found Footage #3	Ravi falls in from his basement
19 Aug 1995	Found Footage #2	A woman falls through a null zone in her garage
23 Sep 1996	The Backrooms (Found Footage)	The date in the description, when the camera drops out of the sky
undated	9780415263573, Simpsons, home_27647.mov, I Remember	Hidden files that sit outside the timeline

[KANE] On set, Kane told Wendigoon that the film takes place in June and July 1990, that the series' Async story stops at the end of May 1990, and that the Async material overall runs from "fall 1989 to the spring 1990".

How it was made

[REAL WORLD] [KANE] The videos are built in Blender and composited in Adobe After Effects, then pushed through a VHS-style degradation that hides the computer graphics and makes everything look like late 80s and early 90s tape. From Pitfalls on, Kane animated people with a Rokoko Smartsuit Pro II motion-capture suit, and from Report on some episodes include live action. He voices most of the characters himself. His father plays the Async researcher Clyde in the live-action scenes (Wendigoon, relaying Kane). Kane writes and records all the music in FL Studio with software instruments.

[KANE] There are two wallpapers you'll keep seeing. Kane told Wendigoon the **chevron** pattern is "the classic Backrooms" one from the original photograph, and the **floral** pattern is what he used all through the first short.

[KANE] He has said the first short leaned "firmly too hard" into the video game language of the original caption. As a nod to glitches he had the creature glide in a T-pose and clip through pillars, and he now calls that an animation error that shouldn't be taken seriously (Smosh Asks, 2026).

[REAL WORLD] [KANE] After the film was announced in February 2023, no new Backrooms episodes came out until September 2024. Kane says that was mostly his own choice plus some "legal minutiae" in the contract, and that the studio never objected to new episodes (Smosh, 2024). Found Footage #3 was meant to come out on 6 September 2024 and slipped a week because of legal complications (TV Tropes trivia).

Reception

[REAL WORLD] The first video was a viral hit. Kotaku praised how restrained the series is with its horror and its mystery. Luiz H. C. at Bloody Disgusting tied it to Mark Z. Danielewski's novel House of Leaves and said the videos capture the book's liminal atmosphere. Dread Central, Nerdist and the radio station WPST covered it too, and WPST called it "the scariest video on the internet". Across the series the videos passed 197 million views (Wikipedia). Film Theory made several videos about it, and Kane noticed some of them were getting more views than his own episodes (Anthony Padilla, 2023).

[REAL WORLD] A24 announced a feature adaptation in February 2023, when Kane was seventeen.

Episodes 1 to 6: The Opening Month

1. The Backrooms (Found Footage)

Released	Length	Description	Views (Oct 2026)	Link
7 January 2022	9:14	"September 23, 1996", plus a link to Mar11_90_ARCHIVE.tar	95.7 million	youtu.be/H4dGpz6cnHo



Official thumbnail of The Backrooms (Found Footage), with the Lifeform standing in the floral-papered yellow rooms. Kane credits this "very clickable" image with much of the video's early spread.

The tape

[CANON] The video is presented as a recovered VHS tape. It opens outdoors on a student film shoot, at what a fan infographic identifies as a schoolyard. A clapperboard at the start gives the camera operator's name as **Kane** and dates the shoot to 4 July 1991. The director asks him to step back for a wider shot. He backs up and the camera drops straight through the ground.

[CANON] He lands in the yellow rooms, with the floral wallpaper, the damp beige carpet, the drop ceiling and the fluorescent panels of the classic Backrooms. He wanders and films, not sure what's happened. Twice, if you look closely, a tall thin figure can be glimpsed around a distant corner before he notices anything (TV Tropes). At one point he opens what looks like a fire exit and finds more of the same yellow rooms behind it, and he's audibly fed up.

[CANON] He comes to a big room with clothes piled on the floor and then to a wall covered in graffiti. There's a drawing of closed eyes next to a window with a sun over a sea seen through it, tally marks, and scrawled lines. Viewers read "DON'T MOVE STAY STILL" and "God closed his eyes" among them, along with lines repeating that "it hears" the writer and that the sound never stops (Wendigoon, TV Tropes). One blog also reads "I'M STILL ME" and "IT'S HERE IT HEARS" [UNVERIFIED] (Taylor Holmes).

[CANON] While he's filming the wall he hears something behind him. He turns, and it's the **Lifeform**, a very tall, thin, dark figure with long wiry limbs. It chases him through the rooms, roaring. For a moment during the chase it glides along in a stiff T-pose and passes straight through pillars.

[CANON] He gets away by dropping down a hole into a lower area that looks completely different. It's a dim home interior copied from a well-known liminal photograph, with a kitchen to the right, an odd staircase, and a closet door opening onto a dark hall. While he gets his breath back you can hear quiet ambience

from the Ravenholm level of Half-Life 2 (TV Tropes). Further on, a window looks out onto a courtyard copied from the atrium of the **Holiday Inn Express at London Heathrow Airport**, and two people can briefly be seen looking through one of its windows. Somewhere along the way the ambient track "13" by the composer C418 is playing.

[CANON] Eventually he's led back up into the yellow rooms. A long dark hallway with patchy lighting and bays opening off only one side becomes the scene of a second chase, and a square tunnel with a ladder leads off into one wall. In the end he hides in a narrow gap that opens onto a steep slope or chute. A Lifeform appears behind him, quieter than the first and a different shape (TV Tropes thinks it may be a second one), and it grabs him. The camera falls down the chute, drops out of the Complex, and tumbles from the open sky over a suburban neighbourhood. The tape ends as it falls.

Details and readings

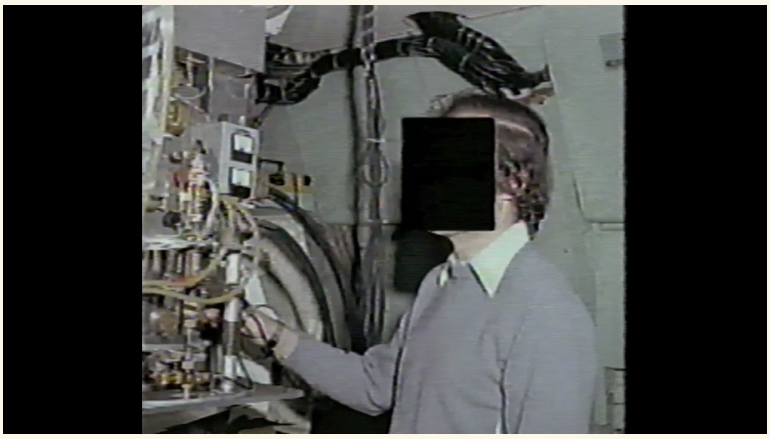
- [CANON] The last Lifeform pulls the operator away from the chute. Since the camera comes out high in the air, fans point out that following it might have killed him anyway (TV Tropes).
- [OFFICIAL] The description date, 23 September 1996, is five years and about eleven weeks after the clapperboard date. Nothing says whether the operator jumped forward in time when he fell in or the camera did when it fell out. Wendigoon raises both.
- [REAL WORLD] The Heathrow Holiday Inn Express opened in **2018**. A copy of it inside the Complex in 1991 is the series' first temporal anomaly, though nobody spotted it at the time.
- [FAN] A fan infographic supplied with this commission works out that the camera came back out about 300 metres up, from a fall time of roughly 2.25 seconds, and lands a few kilometres from the school. It guesses the camera was a VHS-C camcorder. These are fan reconstructions.
- [KANE] Kane calls the video "a pilot" and "a little tech demo" that he made "for fun to decompress", and says it's "largely disconnected from the others in the way that a pilot might be" (Wendigoon on set, 2026; Smosh Asks, 2026). He calls the creature "the Lifeform", and joked with Anthony Padilla that its official title is "life form fellow".
- [KANE] He describes the T-pose and the clipping as an animation error, a game-glitch joke he'd rather people didn't take as canon (Smosh Asks, 2026).
- [FAN] Wendigoon links the sun over the sea in the wall drawing to the sun and ocean imagery that keeps turning up across the series and in Kane's music. That's covered in the chapter on Ivan Beck theories.
- [FAN] Nobody knows who wrote on the wall. The usual guesses are Peter Tench, some later lost explorer, or someone from the early 1990s.



Fan infographic on the first video (supplied with this commission, author unknown). It sets out the schoolyard opening of 4 July 1991, the recovery date of 23 September 1996, a computed fall time, a guessed camcorder model, and a theory that null zones are wormhole-like "metric defects". Everything on it beyond the dates is fan theory.

2. Mar11_90_ARCHIVE.tar

Released	Length	Description	Views	Link
8 January 2022 (unlisted, linked from episode 1)	2:48	"Mar_90_ARCHIVE.tar / Compiled on Jun 1991"	5.3 million	youtu.be/k0L8SM32ENI



Thumbnail of Mar11_90_ARCHIVE.tar, showing a researcher with a censored face working at an equipment panel.

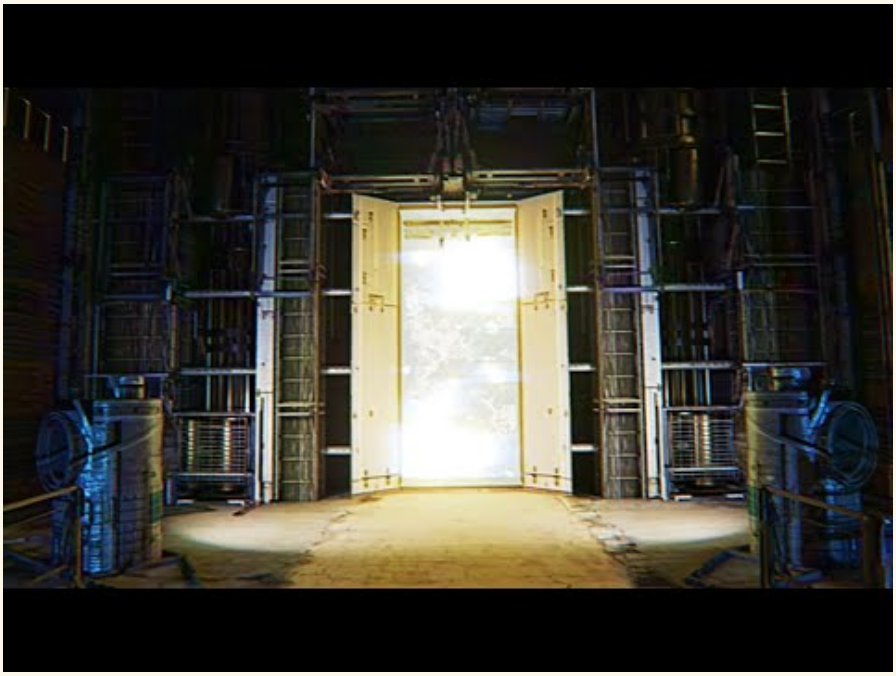
[CANON] A silent run of still images, presented as the contents of an archive file. The Fandom wiki counts nine main items. There are photographs of Complex areas with grey walls and pillars, a blueprint or circuit diagram of Async machinery, a flooded room, researchers at desks and workstations, and industrial equipment in the Async Research Facility. The faces are blacked out. One person sits by a printer writing, and another, possibly an electrician, works on some equipment (Fandom wiki, via search).

[OFFICIAL] The file name dates the archive to 11 March 1990, but the description says it was compiled in June 1991, more than a year later. It went up the day after the first video and was the first hint that an organisation sat behind the Backrooms footage, before the word Async had appeared anywhere.

[FAN] Some read that June 1991 compile date as a sign that Async's records were being gathered up or purged around then. That fits a question fans keep asking, which is where Async went after the middle of 1990.

3. Backrooms - The Third Test

Released	Length	Description	Views	Link
13 January 2022	1:46	"07/02/1988"	8.8 million	youtu.be/tvmEc7JhRoE



Thumbnail of The Third Test, showing the Threshold chamber's opening lit from inside.

[CANON] Over footage of a machine chamber, a synthesised voice says that on 2 July 1988 the **Async research facility** tested its **low-proximity magnetic distortion system** for the third time, and that the results haven't been released. It adds that at a press conference in April 1988, **Ivan Beck**, vice director of the Async foundation, explained what the tests were for. With enough backing from the United States government, he said, the program would solve all current and future storage and residential needs and save billions of dollars on building and managing property.

[CANON] The test doesn't open anything lasting. This is the first time Async, the device and Ivan Beck are named.

- [CANON] The narration says "Async research facility" and "the Async foundation". That's why TV Tropes calls it the Async Foundation, while the film and later material say Async Research Institute.
- [CONFLICT] Some fan summaries put the third test on 2 July 1982. The description and the narration both say 1988. The 1982 date belongs to Prototype, which is 10 May 1982.
- [FAN] Wendigoon points out that Beck was pitching storage and housing in 1988, more than a year before anyone actually got into the Complex. So Beck seems to have known there was a space worth exploiting before Async ever entered it, and a lot of Ivan Beck theories start from that.

4. Backrooms - First Contact

Released	Length	Description	Views	Link
17 January 2022	1:57	"10/17/1989", plus a link to faultline.mov	13.1 million	youtu.be/eXdIDjzy6KY



Thumbnail of First Contact, the first view through the opened Threshold into the yellow rooms.

[CANON] Footage of the **sixth** test of the Low-Proximity Magnetic Distortion System, on 17 October 1989. The machine runs, the doorway settles into a steady view of yellow rooms, and the voices in the room sound alarmed and amazed. Near the end someone says something like "turn that off", then "wait, there's something there", and someone else tells them to keep going (YouTube's automatic captions, so approximate). The doorway that opens here is what the series calls **the Threshold** from then on.

[CANON] [REAL WORLD] The test happens at the same moment as the **Loma Prieta earthquake**, which hit Northern California at 5:04 pm local time on 17 October 1989, just before Game 3 of the World Series at Candlestick Park. Linking this episode to faultline.mov tells you, without anyone saying it, that opening the Threshold caused the quake or came with it. TV Tropes files it under "Real Event, Fictional Cause".

- [REAL WORLD] The real earthquake was magnitude 6.9, centred in the Santa Cruz Mountains on the San Andreas fault system, and killed 63 people. A stretch of the Cypress Street Viaduct (Interstate 880) in Oakland collapsed, and part of the Bay Bridge's upper deck fell.
- [FAN] One theory notes that 1989 was a year of huge solar storms, in March and again in October, and suggests the sixth test worked because the Sun supplied energy the earlier tests didn't have. There's more on this in the chapters on the green glow and on science.

5. faultline.mov

Released	Length	Description	Views	Link
17 January 2022 (unlisted, linked from First Contact)	2:59	None	0.46 million	youtu.be/mWFMDnMDI2o



Thumbnail of faultline.mov, real ABC News coverage of the Loma Prieta earthquake.

[REAL WORLD] [CANON] Genuine ABC News coverage from the evening of 17 October 1989, with unsettling music added by Kane. Ted Koppel reports a strong earthquake in Northern California that has knocked out much of the power at Candlestick Park, where Game 3 of the World Series was about to start, and a live shot shakes as an aftershock rolls through. ABC switches to its San Francisco station KGO, which shows big fires. Leslie Brinkley reports from Oakland that a six or seven block stretch of the Nimitz Freeway, from Cypress Street up toward the Bay Bridge, has collapsed, with many dead on the lower deck. The epicentre is put about 100 miles south in the Santa Cruz Mountains. Tony Russomano reports from Santa Cruz that downtown is "basically gone", that old brick buildings have come down, that Ford's department store has collapsed, and that at least three people have died on the mall.

- [CANON] The ".mov" in the title suggests a saved computer file, kept by someone who understood what the earthquake had to do with the Threshold.

6. Backrooms - Missing Persons

Released	Length	Description	Views	Link
28 January 2022	2:36	"02/03/1990"	20.0 million	youtu.be/py6c5NaHeB8



Thumbnail of Missing Persons, with an Async hazmat team walking three abreast through the Complex.

[CANON] The video cuts between missing persons posters and footage of an Async team in yellow Level A hazmat suits exploring the Complex. Since the Threshold opened, reports of missing people have shot up, the implication being that unstable connections between the Complex and the world have started forming at random. On a routine expedition the team finds the body of a young man slumped against a wall. He and the wall around him are covered in a dark, mouldy growth.

[CANON] The Fandom wiki lists these posters.

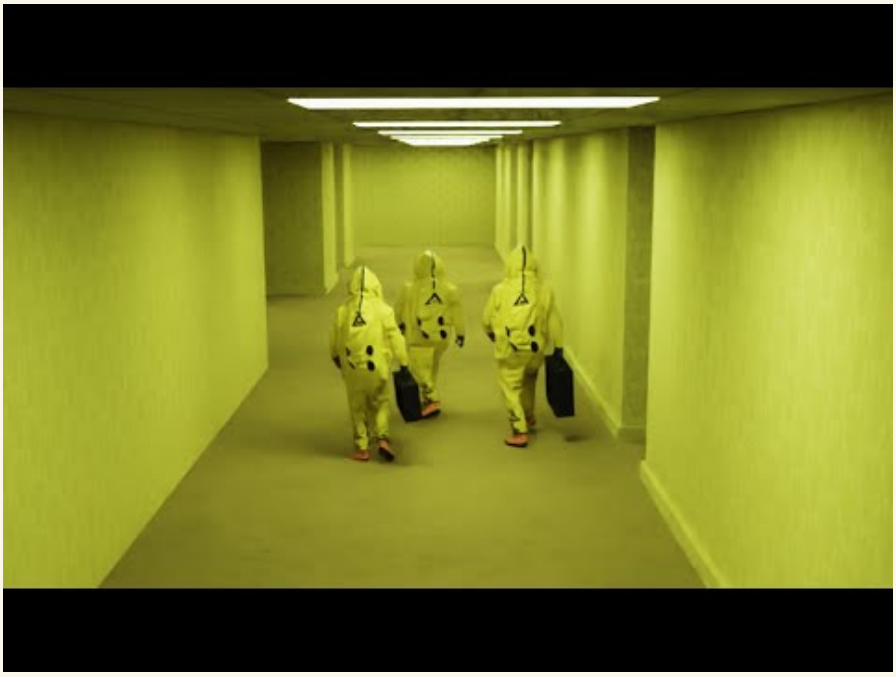
Name	What the poster says
Nicolas Bolton	A young man from northwest California, missing after 17 October 1989. Contact number 707 340-3036
Margaret Watson	Age 28, last seen 2 December 1989
Janice Scott	Details not legible in the sources
Ellis White	Age 2, male, 2 feet 7 inches tall, green eyes, curly blond hair
James Esmail	Details not legible in the sources
An unnamed man	No name visible

- [REAL WORLD] The photo on Nicolas Bolton's poster is of Nathan Barnatt, the comedian behind the "Dad" web series, who Kane has worked with before (TV Tropes).
- [CANON] At the very end a line of text appears, quoted by TV Tropes and Wendigoon as "if anybody, blame him". It never says who "him" is. TV Tropes also mentions brief mirrored text fragments flashing over some early videos, about whether the Complex could be lived in and about an unnamed man who can be held responsible.
- [FAN] Most people read "him" as Ivan Beck. Others suggest Lawrence Altman, who the fan wiki names as Async's founder, or Peter Tench.
- [CANON] The body is examined in Autopsy Report (episode 8). The date, 3 February 1990, makes this the earliest Complex expedition we see after the Threshold opened.
- [FAN] Wendigoon notes that the earliest date on any poster is December 1989, so the disappearances were noticeable within two months of the opening.

Episodes 7 to 13: Tench, the Lifeform and the Pits

7. Backrooms - Informational Video

Released	Length	Description	Views	Link
12 February 2022	8:01	"02/29/1990"	17.1 million	youtu.be/ZIFhglHn3Wo



Thumbnail of Informational Video, with hazmat-suited researchers moving through the Complex along a guideline.

[CANON] Helmet camera footage from an Async researcher on a routine layout survey. Past the Threshold the team has already set things up, with a manned operating station and guidelines, cables laid along the floor so explorers can find their way back. The camera operator, who we later learn is **Peter Tench**, hears what sounds like a crowd talking somewhere down a branch to the right. He wanders over to look and finds nothing but an empty room. There's a flash. When he turns round his team has gone, and so has the guideline they were following.

[CANON] He searches, getting more and more frightened. He passes black scraps on the floor that might be burnt material, a hallway papered in a green leafy pattern that looks stretched, a couple of wheelbarrows (one apparently a bigger copy of the other), a sledgehammer, and the flat front of a house or barn standing in a room like stage scenery. He goes through a small dark room with a house front at the far end and a big room with railings and a deep recessed shelf in one wall. At last he finds his way back to where the Threshold should be, except that there's now an **observation room** there that didn't exist when he left. It's dark and empty. When he walks in and says something, the lights turn red and an alarm goes off.

[CANON] About a minute in, a message flashes on screen for an instant. It reads something like "Not that it would do any good, but be..." and then cuts off (TV Tropes, and Taylor Holmes reads it a little differently) [UNVERIFIED].

What it turns out to mean

[CANON] The explanation comes in later episodes. Presentation shows the alarm going off on 8 May 1990 during a government tour. Damage Control confirms that the expedition was on 1 March 1990, that the team was George Levy, Marvin Leigh, Ronald McCarthy and Peter Tench, that Tench went missing at about 12:25 pm, and that after the jump he spent only about thirty minutes on tape, a few hours at most in all, before walking back into a Threshold area that had been rebuilt in the two months he skipped.

- [REAL WORLD] [CONFLICT] There was no 29 February in 1990, which wasn't a leap year. Damage Control later gives the date as 1 March, and TV Tropes and Wendigoon both flag the mismatch. It could just be a mistake, but given everything else the series does with time, plenty of fans think the impossible date is deliberate, a date that only exists on the Complex's clock.
- [CANON] The observation room he walks into is the **Threshold Outpost**, the first building Async put up inside the Complex. The fan wiki says construction started between 1 and 5 March 1990, which means they began building it right after he vanished. He walks into a building that wasn't there when he left.
- [CANON] TV Tropes notes that Marvin Leigh can be seen at the start of this video, months before he stars in Pitfalls.
- [FAN] People read the crowd voices a few ways. They might be Lifeforms imitating speech, or sound leaking through a null zone from a real place, the way Ravi later hears a man through a wall, or the barrier thinning just before a jump in time (Wendigoon).
- [FAN] The stretched wallpaper is the first sign of the stretching that Async later measures with tape in Static Dead End.

8. Backrooms - Autopsy Report

Released	Length	Description	Views	Link
23 February 2022	2:36	"02/05/1990" and "VA - Arthur Langlie"	7.8 million	youtu.be/2AN6j7JYc1g



Thumbnail of Autopsy Report, the corpse from Missing Persons partly overtaken by growth.

[CANON] A medical examiner, voiced by Arthur Langlie, records his findings on the body found two days earlier. He says the subject is male, somewhere between 18 and 21. He'd put death at about five days ago, though the tissue damage makes that hard to pin down, and the likely cause is malnutrition. He recovered most of the digestive tract. Then things stop being normal. Decomposition seems to have been "stunted",

as though parts of the body stopped decaying and were somehow kept going, while other parts were "completely overtaken by culture". He took samples. At first he thought he was looking at a clump of *Pseudomonas fluorescens*, but it looks more like a **mutated strain of plain hay bacillus**, which ought to be completely harmless. He admits he doesn't know what to make of it, and finishes by asking "Mr. Beck" where the body came from.

[CANON] The video then cuts to a television flicking through a run of images before it settles on a picture of the Threshold with the sun laid over it (Wikipedia).

Notes

- [REAL WORLD] "Hay bacillus" is the everyday name for *Bacillus subtilis*, a harmless soil and gut bacterium used in food fermentation (it's what makes the Japanese dish natto) and famous for its very tough spores. *Pseudomonas fluorescens* is another common soil bacterium, named for the green fluorescent pigment some strains make. Neither one harms healthy people.
- [CANON] The examiner is speaking to Ivan Beck, so Beck brought the body in himself. Nobody answers the question of where it came from.
- [FAN] [KANE] For a long time fans assumed the bacterium turns people into Lifeforms. Kane has said several times on Discord that the Lifeform is **not** a zombified or transformed human, though its life cycle does seem to involve human remains (TV Tropes). He did title his first published picture of the creature "Bacteria" on Ko-fi, which is where that fan name comes from.
- [FAN] Some fans tie the stalled decay to the Complex's general habit of preserving things instead of letting them change.

9. Backrooms - Motion Detected

Released	Length	Description	Views	Link
11 March 2022	4:07	"03/05/1990"	12.9 million	youtu.be/4FDotUHfpWk



Thumbnail of Motion Detected, a camera-height view of the area near the Threshold.

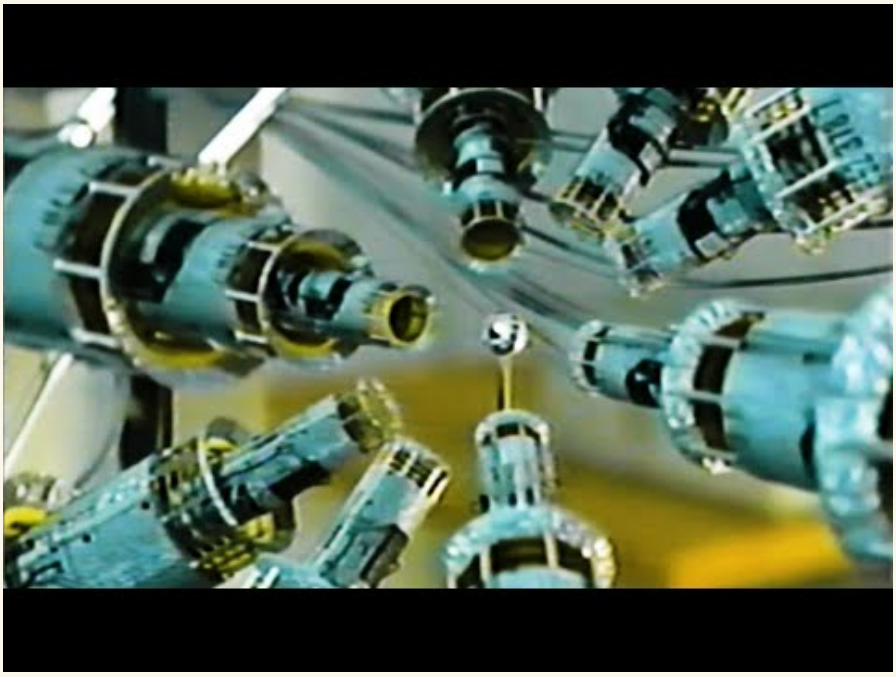
[CANON] After Tench disappears, Async puts in **seven cameras** rigged to start recording and send an alert whenever they pick up movement or loud noise, "optimally positioned along lateral division A", which the fan wiki explains is the row of cells nearest the Threshold. The video strings together everything they

caught. Most of it is dull. Employees walk between pillars, the Threshold barrier closes, a microphone fails, and one camera is said to be missing. The last clip, from camera 5 at 03:53:42 in the small hours, shows a dark shape with waving, tentacle-like limbs peering round a far wall. A Lifeform's roar can also be heard briefly at another point.

- [CONFLICT] The description says 5 March 1990. The last clip's time stamp is in the early hours, so TV Tropes' timeline puts it on 6 March, while the fan wiki keeps 5 March.
- [FAN] The obvious reason for the cameras is to catch Tench if he comes back (TV Tropes).
- [FAN] Whether the tentacled shape is a Lifeform or something else is argued about. Both wikis put it on the Lifeform page, and one theory says the earliest Lifeforms had tentacles and only later built themselves more human-shaped frames.
- [FAN] Async doesn't seem to react to this footage at all. Fans note that staff only get guns after Pitfalls two months later, and suspect the camera footage was kept from ordinary employees, the way Damage Control admits other things were.

10. Backrooms - Prototype

Released	Length	Description	Views	Link
28 March 2022	1:32	"5/10/1982"	5.8 million	youtu.be/9_UN1dsZ9Vg

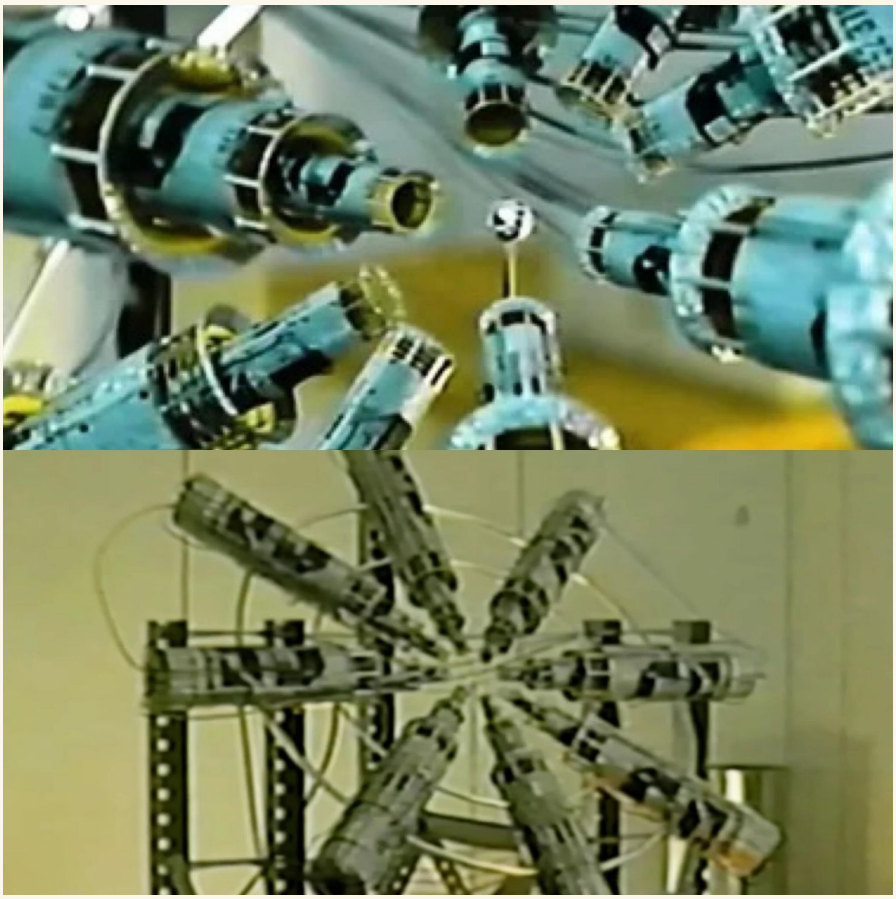


Thumbnail of Prototype, with the teal emitter rods of the 1982 device converging on a small sphere.

[CANON] Footage of a test at **Oak Ridge National Laboratory** on 10 May 1982, supervised by **Philip R. Heymann**. A frame holds eight emitter rods in a ring, all pointed inward at a small sphere that the fan wiki calls a marble. The machine hits it with electromagnetic energy and there's a yellowish glow. When it's over, the sphere is still sitting in the middle.

- [REAL WORLD] Oak Ridge, in Tennessee, is a United States Department of Energy research laboratory. That puts Async's technology inside government research seven years before the Threshold opened, and ties it to the department that later funds Async.
- [FAN] It isn't known whether Heymann worked for Async or Async inherited his work. Wendigoon suggests the 1982 team might have thought they were just teleporting objects somewhere in our own world. The Fandom wiki spells the name Heymann, and Wendigoon heard it as Haymon.

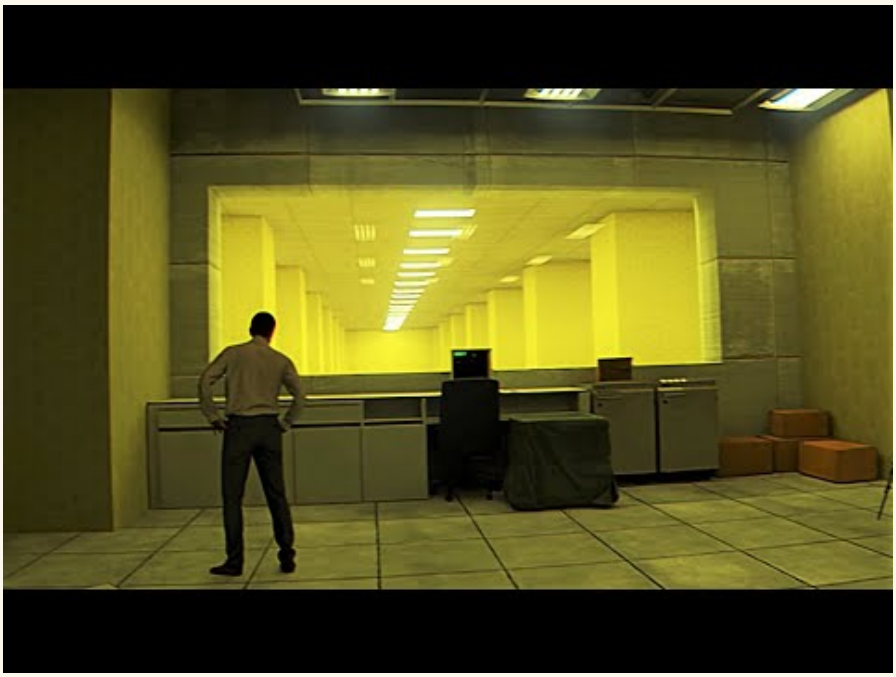
- **[FAN]** The ring of eight keeps coming back. Fans point to the eight-spoked ship's wheel in Everything Must Go and on Cap'n Clark's merchandise, and to a ring of rods behind a censored figure on the cover art of Kane's music, as deliberate echoes of this machine.



Comparison supplied with this commission. At the top is the 1982 prototype from Prototype, its emitters converging on the sphere. Below is a physical rig with the same eight-emitter layout on a perforated frame. The supplied image doesn't say where this second frame comes from.

11. Backrooms - Pitfalls

Released	Length	Description	Views	Link
1 May 2022	14:04	"5/6/1990", plus a motion capture credit	13.4 million	youtu.be/oXwlWXtpaCM



Thumbnail of Pitfalls, with a man in business clothes looking into the Threshold area from the control side.

Before the expedition

[CANON] It starts outside the Complex with radio checks and chatter, much of it muffled. Someone mentions a call coming down from Oak Ridge. The team checks microphones one by one, "Mark", "Marv", "George". Someone asks whether "the vertical expansion" has been approved yet, and someone else asks what day "the tour" will be over. A figure in business-casual clothes watches from a balcony with his hands behind his back as the hazmat team goes in, and fans compare him to the G-Man from Half-Life. Inside, a couple of blue chairs sit in the Complex, one tipped over.

- **[CANON]** Two bits of that chatter point ahead. A "tour" is coming, which is the Department of Energy visit two days later on 8 May, and Async is already talking about a "vertical expansion".

Room 14D

[CANON] The team is Mark Blume, Marvin E. Leigh on camera, George Levy, and according to the fan wiki a fourth member named Kim. They come to a room nobody has seen before ("oh wow, this is new"). Its floor is cut through with deep rectangular pits, so what's left is a set of narrow walkways between them, and you can't see far down into the pits. **Mark Blume** picks his way across to a door on the far side and opens it. A green glow comes through. Mark sounds alarmed and urgent. He wants a camera right now, and when he's told it'll have to wait he insists this "takes precedence".

[CANON] Marvin starts across with the camera, trips, and falls into one of the pits.

The fall

[CANON] Marvin lands hard (TV Tropes says he dislocates a shoulder) in a room he describes over the radio as just like the one above, "the architecture is the same but the wallpaper is different, it's a bit greener". The tunnel he fell through comes out of the wall too high to reach. They lower a guideline with a weight on it, but it's too short, and George is sent back to Standard, Async's name for its base, to bring more gear.

[CANON] Marvin starts hearing someone shouting from further in. The team says they can't hear it and asks if he's just hearing them. Someone wonders whether "Miller" is right "about the null zones", and someone else says that even if he is, they agree with Mark it isn't worth the risk. Marvin says he knows how to get back and goes to look.

The red street

[CANON] He comes out through a tunnel onto what looks like a residential street at night. There are houses, trees and street lights along a road, everything soaked in red light under a dark sky. "It's like a neighborhood." He calls out and goes into the house at the end of the street. Inside is a blue room with **upside-down traffic turn signs** sticking out of the carpet at different heights, and when he reports that they're inverted, someone on the radio asks what he means and whether he's oriented properly. His signal starts breaking up ("I think I'm losing you").

[CANON] Down a hallway he finds a room where "someone's been living". There's a chair, a sleeping bag, a backpack, rotting walls, and a heap of house numbers that seem to have been taken off the other houses on the street.

[CANON] The voice calls again, asking if anyone can hear. Marvin finds where it's coming from, standing in the dark at the back of the house. It's a **Lifeform**. He mutters that it isn't a person. The thing stops imitating, screams, pounds the wall and comes at him, and Marvin yells that it "is not a fucking person". He runs, trips, drops the camera, grabs it again, and sprints back up the street and through the tunnel to the room under the hole, where his team gets him out by lowering something down to him.

Details

- [CANON] [FAN] At one point Marvin's radio briefly picks up audio from the future, a 2015 ABC News interview with the Cuban foreign minister Bruno Rodriguez Parrilla and a snatch of MGMT's song "Kids" from 2007 to 2008. The MGMT bit was cut after a copyright claim, though you can still faintly hear it (TV Tropes, Fandom wiki via search).
- [CANON] This is the first time anyone says "null zones" out loud, the in-universe name for accidental connections between the Complex and reality. Nobody knows who "Miller" is.
- [FAN] Whose camp was in the house (the sleeping bag, the backpack) is still open. Guesses include Peter Tench during his missing months, a lost civilian, or the victim whose last words the Lifeform is repeating.
- [CANON] [OFFICIAL] A whiteboard in Static Dead End labels the red street **"14D + 228"**.
- [CONFLICT] TV Tropes' timeline calls this room "Room 14B". Reunion's dialogue and the fan wiki both say **Room 14D**.
- [FAN] Pitfalls is the series' big turning point. It's Async's first encounter with a creature, the first place that looks like the outdoors, and the first sign that the Lifeform can lure people with a human voice.



Frame supplied with this commission, showing a red-lit street with houses, trees, street lights and a tunnel ahead under a starry sky. The big red arc at the left edge is the lit rim of a tunnel mouth right next to the camera. The red light, the fake night sky and the tunnels are shared by the street in Pitfalls and the Red City in Found Footage #3.

12. Backrooms - Report

Released	Length	Description	Views	Link
20 May 2022	6:20	"5/6/1990", plus a link to 9780415263573	7.6 million	youtu.be/ywVxpZ4XUBM



Thumbnail of Report, with the Pitfalls team coming back through the Threshold area in yellow suits.

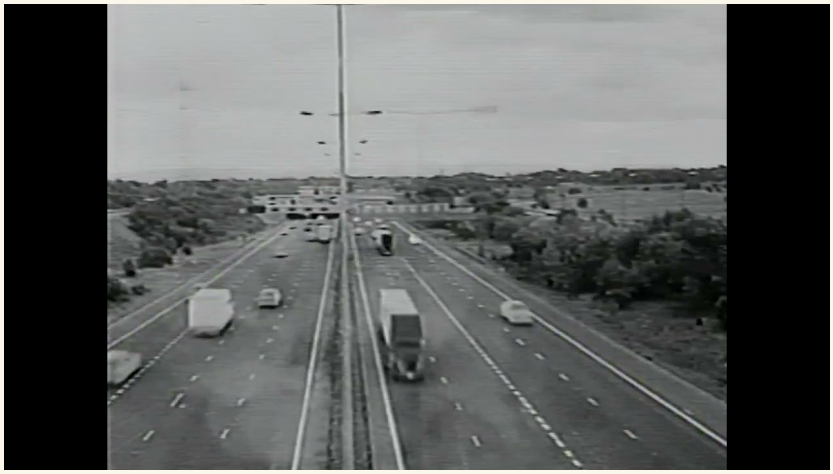
[CANON] The second video to use live action and the first to show Async staff's faces. Audio from Pitfalls plays over archive footage. The door of the Threshold Outpost opens and the Pitfalls team comes through. Inside the Async Research Facility, **Clyde** and another researcher watch Marvin's tape and are visibly shaken. **Dr. Kirk Maxwell**, in a white lab coat with an Async badge on a lanyard, walks through the halls, takes an elevator and makes a phone call. Then a series of stills shows the area where the Pitfalls

expedition began, followed by a time-lapse of its entrance being **boarded up**.

- [CANON] Async's first answer to finding something hostile is to contain it. The corridor to Room 14D is walled off, the Threshold area is fortified, and as later episodes show, expedition leaders start carrying shotguns.
- [KANE] [FAN] Clyde, the researcher with long hair, is played in the live-action scenes by Kane's father (relayed by Wendigoon, 2026).
- [FAN] It isn't known who Maxwell is phoning. Since it's the same day as Pitfalls, the guess is someone in charge, possibly Ivan Beck.

13. 9780415263573

Released	Length	Description	Views	Link
20 May 2022 (unlisted, linked from Report)	0:33	None	1.7 million	youtu.be/a7ckzgIgx_0



Thumbnail of 9780415263573, black-and-white traffic camera footage of a highway.

[CANON] Thirty-three seconds of black-and-white traffic camera footage of a busy highway. A car going at speed sinks into the road surface and is gone.

- [REAL WORLD] The title is an ISBN. Wikipedia identifies it as an edition of **"The Yellow Wallpaper"**, Charlotte Perkins Gilman's 1892 short story about a woman shut in a room with yellow wallpaper. She starts to see a trapped woman moving behind the pattern, and in the end she tears the paper down and becomes that woman. (The 978-0-415 prefix belongs to the publisher Routledge.)
- [CANON] The car turns up again in Found Footage #2, set in 1995, as a burnt-out wreck crashed into a wall inside the Complex. The fan wiki says it's a Chevrolet.
- [FAN] Wendigoon points out that a null zone on a busy highway can't have stayed open long, or hundreds of cars would have gone through, so null zones must be able to appear and close again quickly. He also reads "The Yellow Wallpaper" as an allegory for Ivan Beck, someone so set on freeing what's behind the wall that he ends up becoming it.
- [FAN] The footage isn't dated, but it has to be before 19 August 1995, when the wreck is already old.

Episodes 14 to 21: A-Space, Found Footage #2 and the Reunion

14. Backrooms - Presentation

Released	Length	Description	Views	Link
25 June 2022	8:26	"05/08/90", credits for Rokoko and Trendwatch, plus a link to Simpsons	12.1 million	youtu.be/ITuGdHxHioA



Thumbnail of Presentation, with visitors studying a table-top layout of the Complex near the Threshold Outpost.

The sales film

[CANON] The episode cuts between two things, a corporate promotional film that Async has made, and the day it's shown to the government. The promo opens with the kind of narration you'd hear in a 1980s corporate video. The world keeps changing, it says, and the last century brought innovations that reshaped life as we know it, but growth brings unwanted byproducts that could scar the modern world for good if left unchecked. Human expansion is expected to grow exponentially in the coming decades, and these unprecedented problems need unprecedented answers. Then comes the pitch, that "here at Async, we believe we have found the solution", which is the low-proximity magnetic distortion system. Part of the next line is garbled in the captions, but it describes something distributed "across all points" so that cargo and staff can pass smoothly through "their designated threshold". The current threshold is limited in size, the narrator admits, but future models will be able to "span entire rooms" and carry bigger vehicles and equipment.

[CANON] The film shows models and concepts for using the Complex as housing, transport and commercial space, and brands it **A-SPACE**, with a trademark symbol (TV Tropes).

[UNVERIFIED] One blog says the tape opens with a warning that it is for restricted use only and that the pitch talks about a trillion square miles of usable real estate (Taylor Holmes).

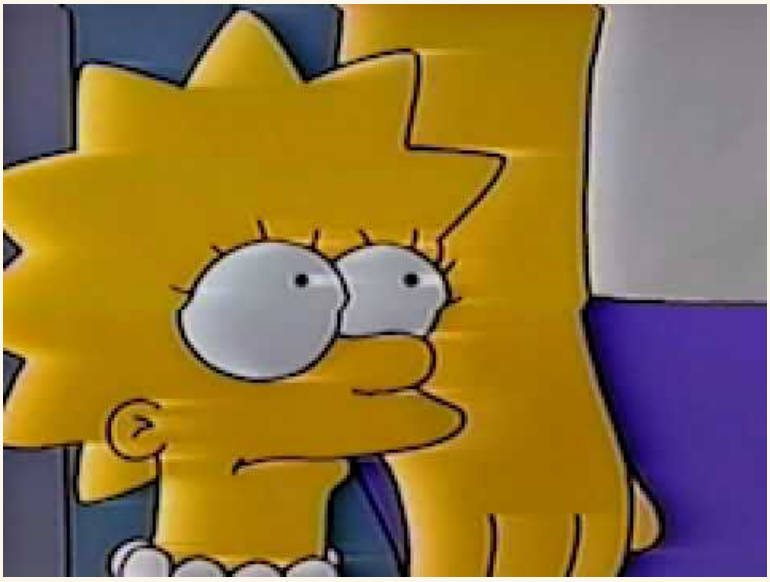
The tour

[CANON] The fan wiki describes the tour itself, and the footage matches. **James D. Watkins**, then the United States Secretary of Energy, and another Department of Energy representative are shown round the Project KV31 division by one of Async's senior engineers. They see the KV31 control room and look into the Threshold Chamber, then go through into the Complex, to an area outside the Threshold Outpost set up with concept pictures, stanchions, furniture and a table carrying a layout model of that part of the Complex. Back in the control room, with the Threshold sealed, the engineer goes through the contract with the visitors. Then an alarm goes off. A fully suited Async researcher has set off the motion sensors inside the Complex. It's Peter Tench, at 5:30 pm on 8 May 1990, sixty-eight days after he disappeared.

- [REAL WORLD] James D. Watkins really was Secretary of Energy, from 1989 to 1993, so Kane has put a real cabinet member into his fiction. Fan write-ups identify the visiting official as Watkins himself, and Wikipedia's episode summary calls him the head of the Department of Energy.
- [CANON] So the government is told, or shown, a version of the Complex in which nothing has ever gone wrong. Report has just walled off Room 14D two days earlier.
- [KANE] Kane has said the presentation's housing and waste ideas are mainly a framework to get the Department of Energy to take the project seriously. The real interest is investigation, and actually living in there would be "a pretty tedious, difficult task" (Wendigoon on set, 2026). TV Tropes adds that Kane described the pitch as Async appealing to what the government wanted to hear in order to get funding.
- [KANE] He told Smosh in 2024 that we're watching Async "upscaling and merging with an actual government agency", and that a main focus he's looking forward to is how it slowly "dissolve[s] into the Department of Energy over a period of time", with new people coming in, old ones leaving and protocols changing.

15. Simpsons

Released	Length	Description	Views	Link
25 June 2022 (on a separate channel, linked from Presentation)	1:08	None	0.28 million	youtu.be/5akGUmdjxv4



Thumbnail of Simpsons, a frame from the Simpsons episode on the recorded tape.

[CANON] A recording off television of The Simpsons episode **"Bart Gets Hit by a Car"**, the one where the shady lawyer Lionel Hutz introduces himself to Homer after Bart's accident. Partway through, the broadcast is interrupted by a **Spanish-language commercial for Dimacol**, a cough medicine sold in Mexico, before it goes back to the episode.

- [REAL WORLD] "Bart Gets Hit by a Car" first aired on 10 January 1991. The Dimacol ad dates from around 2000 (Fandom wiki, via search). The video is linked from Presentation, set on 8 May 1990, so the tape holds an episode from eight months later, cut into by an ad from ten years later.
- [FAN] Wendigoon says it was uploaded to a channel called "Laura Harris". He reads it as proof that the time distortion has leaked out into the real world and is affecting ordinary people's TV signals.
- [FAN] The ad is for cough medicine. Coughing turns up all through the series (Marvin in Pitfalls, the people in the found footage videos), and some fans take the ad as a hint that the Complex's mutated bacteria attack the lungs (TV Tropes theories page).

16. Backrooms - Found Footage #2

Released	Length	Description	Views	Link
21 August 2022	13:23	"08/19/1995", "VA - Madison", plus a link to home_27647.mov	17.8 million	youtu.be/sA5PxGHqpTo



Thumbnail of Found Footage #2, the wreck of the car from 9780415263573, crashed into a wall inside the Complex.

The garage

[CANON] A young woman (voiced by Madison, which is the name fans use for her) is filming a strange patch of her garage floor that she's marked out with a square of blue painter's tape. She pours wood chips onto it and they vanish through the concrete. She drops a baseball in, and that goes too. Then she feeds a tape measure down into the floor to see how deep it goes. The tape starts to vibrate (one write-up says at about 28 inches), the patch grows unstable, and it pulls her in along with her camera, her tripod and the bits and pieces she'd been testing with.

The rooms

[CANON] She lands in the Complex among the objects she dropped, with no idea where she is. The rooms here are oddly domestic. One is plain beige with round light fittings instead of the usual rectangular panels, a power socket on the wall, and a kitchen counter with an extractor hood but no cooker under it. The next has a dining table and chairs that are far too tall. Then a big space with one large column, a couch and a sunken middle section of floor. Then a room with a door and a big hole broken through the floor, steel supports sticking out of its edges. Through the door's keyhole she sees something completely different, white walls and wooden floors leading to a staircase lined with doors.

[CANON] She keeps going. A hallway climbs upward like a staircase with no steps. She comes into a huge hall, the scale of a hospital or a shopping centre, where ceiling tiles have fallen and black mould grows along every edge. The light above one area is green. Round the next corner there's a car crashed head-on into a wall. It's an old wreck, burnt out, the floor around it scorched. Handprints and a trail of blood lead away from it.

The house

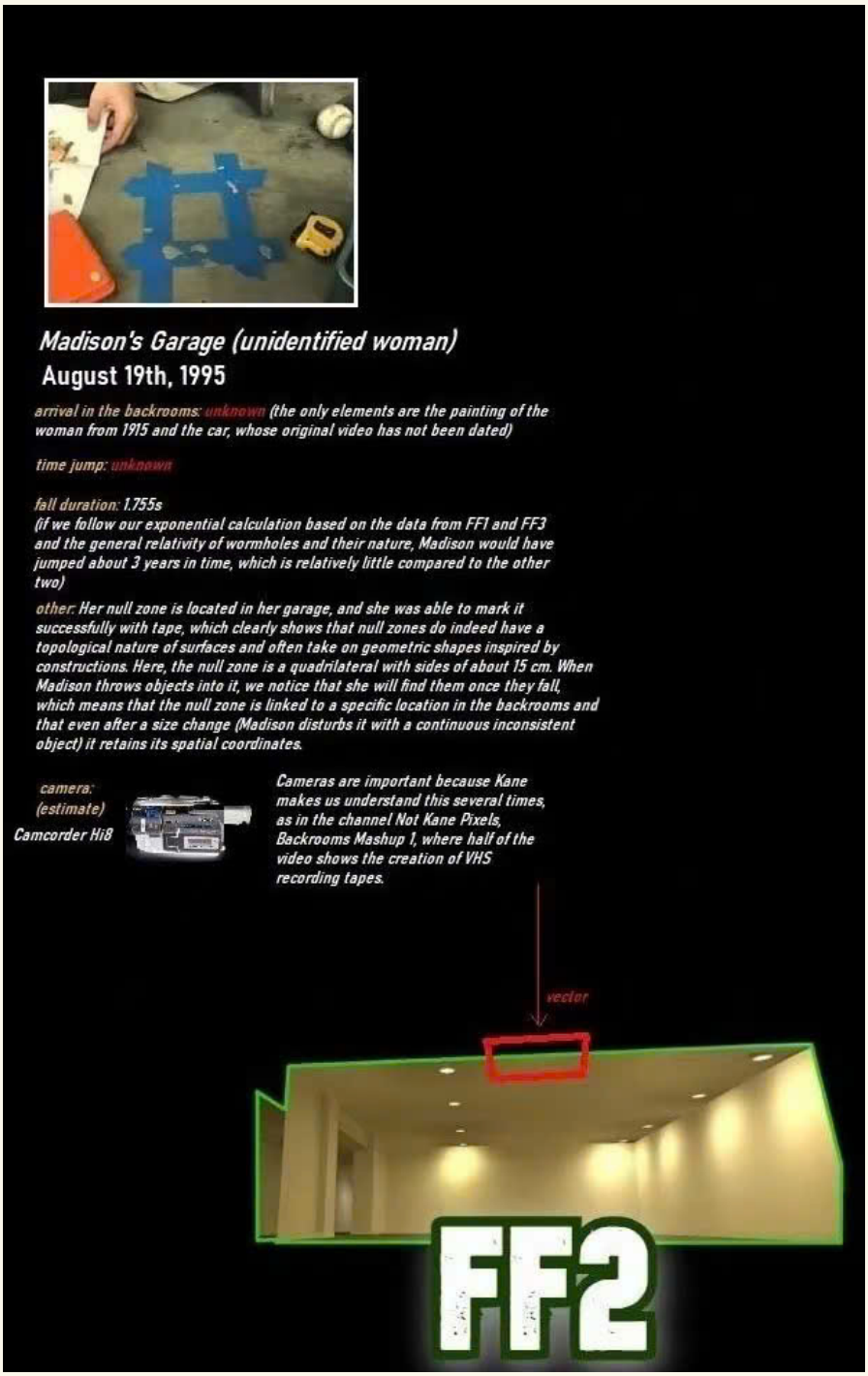
[CANON] She follows the trail into rooms that look like the inside of a house, with blue walls, wooden floors and a banister dividing a raised level from the one below. The trail ends in a dark room choked with thick black vines hanging from the ceiling. On the wall is a painting of a girl. She turns on her camera light, which bathes the room green, and the vines start to move. A **Lifeform** pulls itself out of the growth.

[CANON] It chases her through the house and back out into the Complex, screaming in what sounds like a distorted human voice, and seems to echo her own cries. At one point she hides, then can't help peeking round a corner, and it's standing right there. She runs for the hole in the floor and drops through it, falling more slowly than she should, into tiled rooms lit by a lamp on the floor. A broken wall leads into more tiled areas glowing green. There's an indoor pool that's all wrong, with misshapen basins and handrails that lead nowhere. She climbs a ladder, passes holes in the floor glowing green, and jumps a gap in the floor.

[CANON] She ends up in a dead end. The Lifeform is somewhere outside, and she cries and prays. Then the room starts to change. The doorway gets bigger and the wall beside her slides back, and cracks of glowing green light spread across every surface like breaking glass. The picture cuts out. The last shot pulls back to show the tape playing on a television in an ordinary living room, with wind chimes sounding softly.

Details

- [KANE] [FAN] The house is laid out exactly like the house Kane grew up in. He said so on a stream with Wendigoon, pointing out which corner was his own room.
- [FAN] The painting is a magazine cover by the illustrator George Brehm, made for Woman's Home Companion in September 1916 and widely reproduced as classic Americana (Wendigoon). The same picture shows up in home_27647.mov and on the cover of Kane's track "A Long Time Ago".
- [CANON] [FAN] The wrecked car is the one from 9780415263573. The fan wiki says it's a Chevrolet that met a null zone sometime between 17 October 1989 and 19 August 1995.
- [CANON] This is the strongest evidence that Lifeforms grow out of the places where people died. The driver crawled into the room, and that's where the Lifeform's nest is. Kane still insists it isn't a transformed human.
- [FAN] Who is watching the tape at the end is unknown. Wendigoon links the wind chimes to Ivan Beck, who is associated with them in Overflow and I Remember. Others think it's Async.
- [CANON] This is the Poolrooms' first appearance in Kane's series. TV Tropes notes it seems to sit below the yellow halls, as if it were some kind of waterworks.
- [CANON] The tape at the start is like the album cover for the sixth stage of The Caretaker's Everywhere at the End of Time, a turned-around picture with blue tape on its back (TV Tropes, Wendigoon).
- [FAN] A fan infographic supplied with this commission measures the null zone as a square about 15 centimetres across and works out a fall time of about 1.76 seconds. It suggests that the Complex sends anything dropped through the same zone to the same spot, and that a long continuous object poked through (the tape measure) destabilises the zone and drags things in.



Fan infographic on Found Footage #2, supplied with this commission. It shows the taped-off null zone in the garage, the date of 19 August 1995, a computed fall time and an estimated camcorder model, with a diagram of the zone's position in the ceiling of the room below. These are fan reconstructions.

17. home_27647.mov

Released	Length	Description	Views	Link
21 August 2022 (unlisted, linked from Found Footage #2)	3:26	None	1.4 million	youtu.be/Kq6l9yCO9rI



Thumbnail of home_27647.mov, a family home video frame by the sea with "NO FISHING" painted on a wall.

[CANON] A collection of ordinary home video clips and photographs. A street, a walk by the sea, a seawall painted with "NO FISHING", views from the top of tall buildings. At one point an old geocentric chart of the heavens (the kind drawn before Copernicus, with Latin lettering and Earth in the middle) is laid over the footage. A small boy sits at a table with a parent whose face is blurred, in a room laid out exactly like the house in Found Footage #2. There's a sunset over the ocean, a strange shot of dusty cobwebs, and finally a family gathered round a piano. The camera pushes past them to the painting on the wall, the same one that hangs in the nest in Found Footage #2.

- [CANON] Inside the story, these are the home videos of the people who lived in the real house the Complex copied, and the painting was copied along with it.
- [KANE] [FAN] Since the floor plan is Kane's childhood home, Wendigoon suspects the blurred faces are Kane's own family and the little boy is Kane.
- [FAN] Some read it as proof that Lifeforms are made from the people who die in the Complex, but nothing in the clip says that directly.
- [FAN] The title might be a file number, or code for an address or a date. Nobody has cracked it.

18. I Remember

Released	Length	Description	Views	Link
30 August 2022	1:29	A Ko-fi link only	3.5 million	youtu.be/c-H59GkA-I4



Thumbnail of I Remember, Async server cabinets under a white ceiling grid.

[CANON] The only video in the series without "Backrooms" in its title, and the only one left out of the official playlist. It opens on wind chimes moving in sunlight at a window, then the click of a cassette. A man's voice tells a short poem over distorted images. In our own words, he says he once had a home, a manor overlooking the sea, something left over in the world that called out to ears that couldn't hear it. When the sky darkened, the sea took the house. A pillar was cut short and thrown down to the seabed with all the other forgotten things. But he remembers. He describes fragile shells sinking slowly and folding down into themselves, tearing along the seams of the sky until nothing is left but an eternal ghost. And he asks whether anything could ever be greater than this.

[CANON] The pictures run alongside. A missing persons poster on the floor, the sea and the sun splitting apart, Async hallways and meeting rooms bending and warping, a whiteboard saying that clusters of cell images lead to individual cell classification, old computers and server racks, the facility itself buckling, the prototype machine. A researcher in a gas mask and hood stands in front of a great light that shifts from yellow to green. The last frame is a room of old computer cabinets, with the label "CRN-S8R3" on the picture.

- [OFFICIAL] Two tracks on Kane's music playlist "Out of Sync" are called "Overlooking The Sea" and "You Have Always Been Here" (the second in a piano version too). Wendigoon hears that second phrase spoken at the end of the video, and TV Tropes describes the narrator ending by saying "it" had been there all along. The automatic transcript stops at the question about something greater.
- [FAN] The most popular theory is that the narrator is Ivan Beck. The wind chimes link this video to Overflow, which has Beck's signature, and to the end of Found Footage #2. Others suggest Peter Tench losing his grip.
- [FAN] TV Tropes reads the manor taken by the sea as Async's project being swallowed by the Complex. Wendigoon reads it as Beck losing something to the Complex, whether a person, his memory or part of himself, and spending decades trying to get it back. That's his Captain Ahab theory.
- [FAN] "CRN-S8R3" hasn't been decoded. Wendigoon wonders if it's a room, slot and rack number.
- [FAN] The question "could there ever be anything greater than this?" lines up with what Phil says at the end of the film, that nothing in recorded history means more than the Complex.

19. Backrooms - Reunion

Released	Length	Description	Views	Link
8 December 2022	13:11	"05/25/90", a motion capture credit, plus a link to _recording014	7.7 million	youtu.be/ye6YpxFE9jk



Thumbnail of Reunion, with Mark Blume, without his suit's outer layer, aiming a shotgun in the dark of Room 14C.

Reopening 14D

[CANON] It opens on the California hills outside the facility, where a researcher (Clyde, per Wendigoon) is taking notes outdoors. Inside, a coffee mug carries the logo and map coordinates of the **Moss Landing Marine Laboratories**. The team takes down the wooden barricade from Report and sends a remote rover ahead. Over the radio people talk about having enough room to unpack and how many trips it'll take. The rover reaches the pit room, and someone reports to Standard that they've reached Room 14D. An air test came back fine, someone says, but they'd rather keep masks on just in case. Mark radios the base that there's "no visible signs of Marvin's friend", and someone answers that this is definitely not the name they're going to use.

[CANON] Zooming in, Marvin notices that the spot where he fell through has no proper floor under it, just a gap, so what he walked on was really a shelf. Team A starts laying plywood and metal plates to make a walkway across the pits.

Room 14C

[CANON] On-screen text explains that while Team A builds the walkway, **Mark Blume**, **Randall Tachi** and **Marvin Leigh** are doing an initial layout survey of **Room 14C**. Mark opens a case and takes out a shotgun. Marvin asks if it's the same one they trained with, and Mark says it's pretty similar, the training one was rented. Marvin says he wouldn't want to be on the other end of it, and Mark replies that you wouldn't want to be on the other end of any gun. "Standard, this is Mark. We're now beginning our progression into room 14C."

[CANON] Room 14C is dark, with no working lights. The team describes it as they go. The floor is concrete with a glossy epoxy coat. The walls are ordinary white drywall with black vinyl skirting. The ceiling is the usual kind but with smaller, tighter tiles. There's a narrow gap where one type of floor meets another, and they slip a tape measure into it. Some ceiling tiles have been moved. One of them has only seen displaced tiles four times before, and they wonder whether this is how the room always was or something new. Then Randall finds a hand-drawn map that seems to show the area around them, with 14C and the neighbouring rooms marked.

The ambush

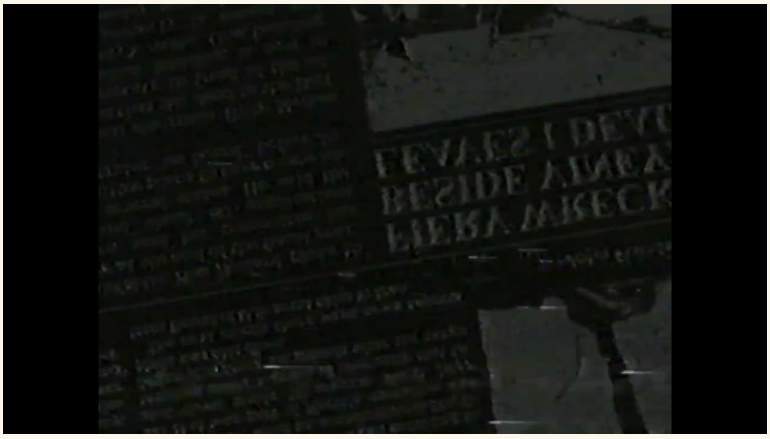
[CANON] The radio has gone dead, so they've gone too far, and they head back to report the map. In the dark someone tackles Mark and takes his shotgun. A man with the gun says he doesn't want trouble, he just wants answers and then he'll go, and asks how many people are out there. Marvin recognises him. It's **Peter Tench**. Marvin can't believe it, it's been months and they thought he was dead. Peter says that's exactly what "they" did. They took his life from him, everyone thinks he's dead, his wife and children think he's dead. He asks Marvin to tell him whether they held a funeral, and Marvin says yes.

[CANON] Team A comes over the radio. Mark answers and reports that his team is being held at gunpoint by a hostile. Peter panics, shouts that he's sorry, and shoots Mark in the side. The blast echoes on and on through the endless repeating walls. Mark lies coughing as Marvin goes to him. The video ends there.

- [CANON] [FAN] According to TV Tropes, Peter asks Marvin to let his family know he's alive. Taylor Holmes says he's wearing a black jumpsuit and that the rover found him first [UNVERIFIED].
- [REAL WORLD] [FAN] Moss Landing Marine Laboratories, on Monterey Bay south of San Jose, was badly damaged in the Loma Prieta earthquake, the same quake the Threshold's opening set off. Wendigoon found that the coordinates on the mug land on a vineyard south of San Jose, and the cover story for Peter's death was a fiery wreck beside a vineyard.
- [FAN] The shotgun is identified by Wendigoon as a Remington 870 with Magpul furniture. Damage Control confirms the Remington 870.
- [FAN] The map in 14C matches the drawing style of Peter's sketches, and fans take it as his work while he was hiding there.
- [FAN] Fans think Peter wrote the warnings in the first Found Footage video, because his situation and theirs match, though the dates make that hard to square.

20. _recording014

Released	Length	Description	Views	Link
8 December 2022 (unlisted, linked from Reunion)	2:32	"05-08-90"	1.2 million	youtu.be/cjUqCsDmx-I



Thumbnail of _recording014, a mirrored newspaper headline over dark grain.

[CANON] A recorded phone call from 8 May 1990, the day Peter came back, and we only hear one side of it. The caller, who gives his name as **Clyde**, is phoning **Ivan Beck** at wherever Beck is staying, from Async in San Jose. Clyde talks about the Department of Energy visit and whether the contracts are in order. Then he explains that the motion sensors went off and that a researcher in full gear was found in the Complex, confused. When he says the man gave his name as Peter Tench, Beck's reaction (which we can only guess from Clyde's answers) is clearly alarmed. Clyde says that as far as he knows he's the only one who knows about it, and at one point asks "this isn't him, is it?"

[CANON] Over the audio there's a mirror-image newspaper clipping. Flipped the right way round, the headline reads "Fiery wreck beside vineyard leaves one dead". That was the cover story for Peter's death.

- [CANON] This video is the first place Peter's full name appears (TV Tropes).
- [KANE] [FAN] Kane has confirmed that this Clyde is the long-haired researcher seen in Report, the one who watched Marvin's footage and took notes outside in Reunion (Wendigoon).
- [FAN] Clyde's line "this isn't him, is it?" suggests he and Beck both knew about the fake death. Wendigoon thinks only Clyde, Beck and perhaps a few others in charge knew Peter was alive between 8 May and the ambush, which is why Marvin is so shocked.

21. Backrooms - Overflow

Released	Length	Description	Views	Link
24 December 2022	1:38	A Ko-fi link only	3.0 million	youtu.be/8TYopkSmKyA



Thumbnail of Overflow, a period magazine advertisement for cassette tapes headlined "FREE SPEECH!".

[CANON] It opens on a night sky over a quiet park, with wind chimes and a radio playing. The radio is a presidential news conference about trade between "market and non-market economies". Negotiations with the Soviets are just beginning, the speaker says, and Commerce Secretary Peterson has just come back from two weeks in Moscow and Warsaw, where they're close to settling the Lend-Lease debt that has been outstanding for twenty-five years, which would open the way for Export-Import Bank credits for sales to the Soviets. A magazine ad for cassette tapes flashes up. In a laboratory a warning light marked "overload" starts flashing. On a bulletin board is a lab document. The camera moves in on it as a green glow fills the room, brighter and brighter, until there's nothing but light. Then the night sky again, folding and spiralling in on itself.

[CANON] [FAN] The fan wiki describes the document. It's a lab report on a set of glass samples, measuring their dielectric properties in the 0.5 to 0.767 GHz range, with trace amounts of **tellurium** added to change their dielectric constants and loss tangents. **Ivan Beck** signed off on it on **2 August 1972**.

- [REAL WORLD] The radio audio is real. Peter G. Peterson was US Secretary of Commerce in 1972 and led trade talks in Moscow that summer, and the Lend-Lease debt from the Second World War was settled in a US-Soviet agreement in October 1972.

- **[REAL WORLD]** A huge solar storm hit Earth in early August 1972, peaking on 4 August, one of the most intense of the century. Fans put Overflow's experiment right on top of it.
- **[CANON]** This is the earliest event in the whole timeline, seventeen years before the Threshold opened. Ivan Beck was already there, signing off on a radio-frequency materials experiment that ended in green light.
- **[FAN]** Some think the place is a radio station or a lab connected to one. The fan wiki calls it a probable radio station.
- **[FAN]** The green glow here is the same one that cracks the walls at the end of Found Footage #2 and shines through the door in Pitfalls. See the chapter on the green glow.

Episodes 22 to 26: Damage Control to Everything Must Go

22. Backrooms - Damage Control

Released	Length	Description	Views	Link
30 January 2023	14:03	"05/26/90" and a motion capture credit	4.5 million	youtu.be/j6klSI8GlXI



Thumbnail of Damage Control, a security camera frame of Peter Tench running through an Async corridor.

The escape on camera

[CANON] It opens with the radio panic from the end of Reunion, the other team hearing the gunshot. Then security footage shows Tench, shotgun in hand, coming back through the Threshold area and into Async's building, pointing the gun at staff as he goes. He runs through the halls with people chasing him and reaches a freight elevator before anyone can stop him.

The briefing

[CANON] Most of the episode is a staff meeting the next day, 26 May 1990, run by an Async representative. Async has kept people in the building overnight, and he thanks them for their patience after "a stressful 15 hours". He passes on apologies from "Dr. Beck", who can't be there. He admits there was "severe information mismanagement" and that information was deliberately kept from many people on the project. That approach, he says, has been proven not to work, and he's here to give them the real sequence of events. In our own words, this is what he tells them.

[CANON] On the morning of 1 March a team of four went into the Complex for a routine layout analysis. They were George Levy, Marvin Leigh, Ronald McCarthy and Peter Tench. At about 12:25 pm, crossing a branch of hallways they'd already explored, they realised Tench was gone. They pulled back to Standard at once, and several days of searching turned up nothing. About two weeks after he vanished, the security team made up "a more acceptable cause of death" that would keep attention away from the institute and give his family closure.

[CANON] Then, at about 5:30 pm on 8 May, a motion alert went off in the Complex, which was sealed at the time. A senior engineer went down and found a man in hazard gear, who turned out to be Peter Tench. He was moved to a secure room on that floor, where doctors spent several days running tests. By every measure he was in excellent health. His camera was still with him and had recorded everything, and the full tape would be shown later that day. The representative plays the key moment, Tench approaching the

branch on the right, and asks them to listen closely. What they just saw, he says, is "what we believe to be the moment that Peter was instantaneously transported two months forward in time". After the flash Tench spent about thirty minutes on tape trying to find his way back, and when he did, the Threshold looked the way it looked on 8 May. From his side he'd been inside for a few hours at most.

[CANON] Tench was legally dead because of the cover story, and undoing that would be hard. He understood, the representative says, and agreed to wait while they worked out how to bring him back into society without raising suspicion. It took longer than expected. Stuck underground with little to do, his mental state slipped. Around the end of the second week he began showing behaviour typical of paranoid schizophrenia, though the representative adds they don't believe he actually had that condition. He seemed to have convinced himself that he was still inside an illusion made by the Complex and that the staff meant him harm. On the night of the 22nd, just as he was about to be moved to a temporary home above ground, he broke away, used stolen credentials to force his way back into the Complex, and stayed hidden until he ambushed Team B in Room 14C the night before. Dr. Blume is in critical condition.

[CANON] The representative goes on. Tench probably gave up on finding another threshold during his two days inside but still believed they were all trying to trap him. After firing one shot from the Remington 870 into Dr. Blume's side, he ran to the Threshold Outpost, turned the gun on several more staff on his way through Standard and the lower offices, and passed through an empty lab beside storage, where Dr. Maxwell managed to disarm him and the gun went off into the ceiling. Tench still got away through the maintenance wing and up the freight elevator to the surface. As far as they can tell nobody outside saw him leave. About five minutes later security reached the ground floor and swept the hillside where the cameras last saw him. There, the representative says, there's "no easy way to say this", Tench was found dead halfway down the hill. Running through brush, he hadn't seen a sudden dip in the ground and had fallen forward onto a large rock.

[CANON] He finishes by calling Tench a brilliant man who gave everything to the project and wouldn't want it held up in his name. The work is bigger than any one person, he says, and they need to hold on to the existing understanding that Peter is and has been deceased. "That is done. And there is nothing more to be extracted."

The images at the end

[CANON] After the speech a run of brief images flashes past. A used syringe on the ground. A man in a button-up shirt standing in front of a huge ball of green energy. Three people grieving around a table. A desk covered in monitors, papers and objects. The green energy image again, tinted purple. Drawings from Tench's room, crowds gathered around doors with faces crossed out and the date 17 May 1990, and a man by the sea with the words "If the wind is right, you can sail away". A security camera on an empty city street, zooming in on one man standing alone. The Threshold fading into a sunset. Then an empty house with music playing, and a phone on the wall that starts to ring as the camera moves toward it.

Reading it

- [CANON] [CONFLICT] Damage Control and Reunion tell different stories. In Reunion Peter says Async took his life and left him for dead. In Damage Control Async says it was trying to help him and that he ran back into the Complex in a delusion. TV Tropes treats it as a Rashomon situation, with no proof either way.
- [KANE] [FAN] Kane has said he doesn't see Async as evil, more as out of its depth. TV Tropes also notes he's said the people in charge are normal people who mostly try to be careful. Fans point out that a company covering itself would say exactly what this representative says, and that the meeting is literally called Damage Control.
- [CANON] The representative's account that Tench jumped "two months" forward is the precise figure. From 1 March to 8 May is 68 days. Several fan sources say three months, which is wrong.

- [REAL WORLD] "If the wind is right, you can sail away" is a line from Christopher Cross's 1979 song "Sailing". Kane recorded a cover of it on his music channel, in the "Out of Sync" playlist.
- [FAN] Most fans think the man on the street camera is Peter, alive, and that the phone ringing in the empty house is him calling home or someone calling about him. Wendigoon thinks Async may simply have killed him. The syringe is an unexplained detail that both camps use.
- [FAN] The date on Peter's drawings, 17 May 1990, turns up again on the first fax from Cap'n Clark's in the film's marketing puzzle. Nobody has explained the coincidence.
- [CANON] Peter's belief in an "alternate threshold" hasn't been answered. Every later video confirms there are many other ways in.

23. Backrooms - Found Footage #3

Released	Length	Description	Views	Link
13 September 2024 (delayed a week for legal reasons)	45:01	"Ravi - Aakash Valdivia"	9.5 million	youtu.be/acdYs9tPLko



Thumbnail of Found Footage #3, the house built inside a blue box with a painted sky, clothes strewn across the floor in front of it.

[REAL WORLD] At forty-five minutes this is by far the longest episode, and the first to star a live-action actor, Aakash Valdivia as Ravi. This account is put together from the footage together with Wikipedia, TV Tropes, Wendigoon's detailed recap, the fan wiki and a fan-made route map supplied with this commission.

Before

[CANON] It opens with bits of Ravi's own video diary. He talks to the camera, disgusted, about overhearing two people from upper management mocking a sick child and then more or less admitting their company was at fault, joking that if they accidentally pushed out the whole county someone might finally get that ranch he always wanted. The fan wiki describes them as a Monsanto executive and a "DPR manager" (most likely meaning California's Department of Pesticide Regulation), and says Ravi realised he'd caught them on tape while reviewing footage at a hotel. A radio in the background is talking about the aftermath of the Oklahoma City bombing, which puts the video in late April 1995, after the bombing on 19 April.

[CANON] At home in his apartment Ravi hears a noise downstairs. He phones his landlord, who says nobody is due to do any maintenance. He goes down and finds his sliding glass door smashed, mutters "fuck me",

and assumes he's been burgled. He has a drum kit set up in the middle of the room. There's a brief strange distortion near a closet. In the basement, or the unit below, he finds a large hole broken through a cinder block wall with a passage behind it. The lights flicker, the ground shakes, there's a glowing green hole, and he's knocked through.

- [FAN] The broken glass lies outside the door, so something broke out of his home rather than into it (TV Tropes, Wendigoon).

Into the Complex

[CANON] He slides down a chute and tumbles out of a cabinet into something like a classroom or office, and he can't climb back up. The rooms are almost right. A stool sits on a desk that's too low, one chair has an absurdly tall back, a long conference table cuts across a doorway, and a window looks onto a brick wall. Through a door he hears strange music. He crawls through a small passage into a room with a microwave, a sunken wall and a couch, and behind the couch, where a picture should hang, the wall opens into another room. That one has a single lamp on, a kitchen table, and a clock stopped at 7:16. There's a bright room with six chairs facing each other under a fake skylight showing a painted sky, a ledge with two recliners facing a wall, and a passage hidden behind a dresser.

[CANON] One room has a child's play rug printed with roads and buildings, and Ravi laughs at it. Another is crowded with sofas, and he wonders out loud whether this is a furniture store now. A darker room has a traffic cone in the corner and chairs piled against a door as a barricade.

[CANON] Following the music he finds a run-down room with a speaker on the wall playing it (the track is Kane's "Still Life"). There's black growth under the speaker, the carpet and wallpaper are peeling, books and papers are laid out on the floor around a single point, and the drawers have been pulled out and searched. Something in a dark alcove makes him gasp "oh my god", but the camera never shows it clearly before a noise startles him. As he backs out the room's lights switch off. He runs to the sofa room and shuts the door behind him. Someone knocks on it, politely, like a person would. He tells them to go away, and whatever it is starts smashing the door down.

The Red City

[CANON] He runs through an office scattered with empty water jugs and out onto an enclosed walkway between two buildings, and stops. Outside the windows is a city at night, office towers with lit windows, trees and a road, everything flooded with red light under a starry sky. He laughs, wheezing, and then mutters "fuck me". This is what fans call **the Red City**, and the fan wiki files it under a wider area called the Red Outdoors.



Frame from Found Footage #3 supplied with this commission. The Red City seen through the walkway windows, with lit office windows under red light.

[CANON] Past the walkway he climbs over a balcony ledge and finds a stage-set version of the outdoors. There's a tiled path, green carpet standing in for grass, a street lamp, a slide, and the shell of a building that's nothing but a front with windows. While he's on the far side, the lights come on. He runs up a staircase into a stretch of normal yellow Backrooms with a black stain on the floor and growth on the walls, and then into what looks like an apartment, with power sockets, a radiator and a kitchen, except the windows are bricked up and there's no ceiling, just the brick walls rising to a big light. He climbs a ladder and sees a seated Buddhist statue with its back to him.

[CANON] Through narrow corridors he reaches a dance studio with a wall of mirrors, where speakers are playing a Chinese song called "煤气灶" ("Gas Stove"). On the wall is a health screening flyer from USC Arcadia Hospital, printed in Chinese and dated **2022**. An "exit" sign leads him into a big room with a tower that rises up out of sight and drops below him too. Every level of it carries the same painting of a smiling sun in splendour. Mixing desks, electronic keyboards and a microphone stand are scattered around it, and the fan wiki calls the place the Recording Studio. He finds a radio set, records a call for help and gets it transmitting.

The Still Life

[CANON] Heading back through the dance studio, he finds a room with green carpet holding a drum kit, a pot plant and a remote control car. A door from there loops him back to the playground stage set. Radio chatter is getting louder somewhere, and he goes toward it. Then something gets up off the floor in the dark and charges at him, and the picture freezes for a moment as it does. It's human-shaped but wrong. It looks like a man in a dark jacket over a white shirt, with a pale face whose left side is dark, but its movements and proportions are off, its arm too thin and its head swinging too much, and part of the time it runs on all fours. The music changes to Kane's "Do You Like Air Conditioning". Ravi dives through a crawl space, shoves a couch in behind him and topples a shelf onto it to wedge it shut. The thing doesn't follow.

- [KANE] [FAN] Kane later called this creature a **Still Life**. The film is in effect an explanation of what it is.

The deep rooms

[CANON] He's in something like an old attic now. A quick cut shows something small and black growing up from under a skirting board. He passes along a dark hall into a room full of stop signs and wet floor signs, with a picture of **Mao Zedong** surrounded by candles like a shrine. Then come industrial concrete corridors, closet doors that open into an office, and big skyscraper windows that show the Red City again, with a giant road sign standing on its end among the trees, pointing straight up. Another walkway takes him back into yellow wallpaper. Through a gap in a wall he looks down into the six-chair skylight room he passed earlier, with an upright book or brick balanced beside the gap. A hallway has a crack running across the floor where two kinds of room meet. In the middle of a long hallway stands a **cardboard cutout of a caveman**, all on its own.

The house

[CANON] Past a white office he comes into a room with a whole house in it. The room is a blue box with white blotches painted to look like sky. The ground is covered in discarded clothes, with burn marks and smears of what might be blood running off toward a dark tunnel. Half sunk into the floor is a human figure, solid and grey like a statue, holding a phone to its ear.

[CANON] Inside, the house is far more complete than anything else he's seen. There are cooking utensils on the counters, a bottle of whiskey on the table, a chair knocked over, black footprints across the floor, and a single shoe half stuck in the floor with black marks around it. There's a lamp, a bookshelf, a mounted fish on the wall and paintings. He opens the front door and finds brick and concrete.

[CANON] Then he hears a man's voice, close, as if just on the other side of the wall. The man thinks Ravi is an intruder, tells him he's on private property, and thinks he might be the guy who keeps coming round trying to talk to his boys. His family is trying to sleep, he says, and Ravi should leave or he'll call the police, and anyway the station is a quarter of a mile down the road. Ravi says he's been walking for something like nine hours, tells him to go ahead and call the cops, and begs for help. Neither of them can see the other. When the man looks outside there's nobody there. Ravi describes where he is, a living room with a fish on the wall, and the man realises he's describing his own living room. Convinced Ravi is stuck inside his wall, he agrees to help and starts breaking through it. Something startles him. There's a rushing roar, the room shakes, the man yells, and then nothing. Ravi calls out and gets no answer.

- [FAN] In the background on the man's side a television commercial can be heard. Wendigoon identifies it as a freecreditreport.com ad that ran from 2007 to 2009, which would put the man twelve or more years in Ravi's future.
- [FAN] TV Tropes notes the whiskey bottle (probably Jack Daniel's) and wonders whether the father has a drinking problem.
- [FAN] Fans call the man "Wall Dad". Those who think the Speaker Room creature is a copy of him call it "Still Dad".

The end

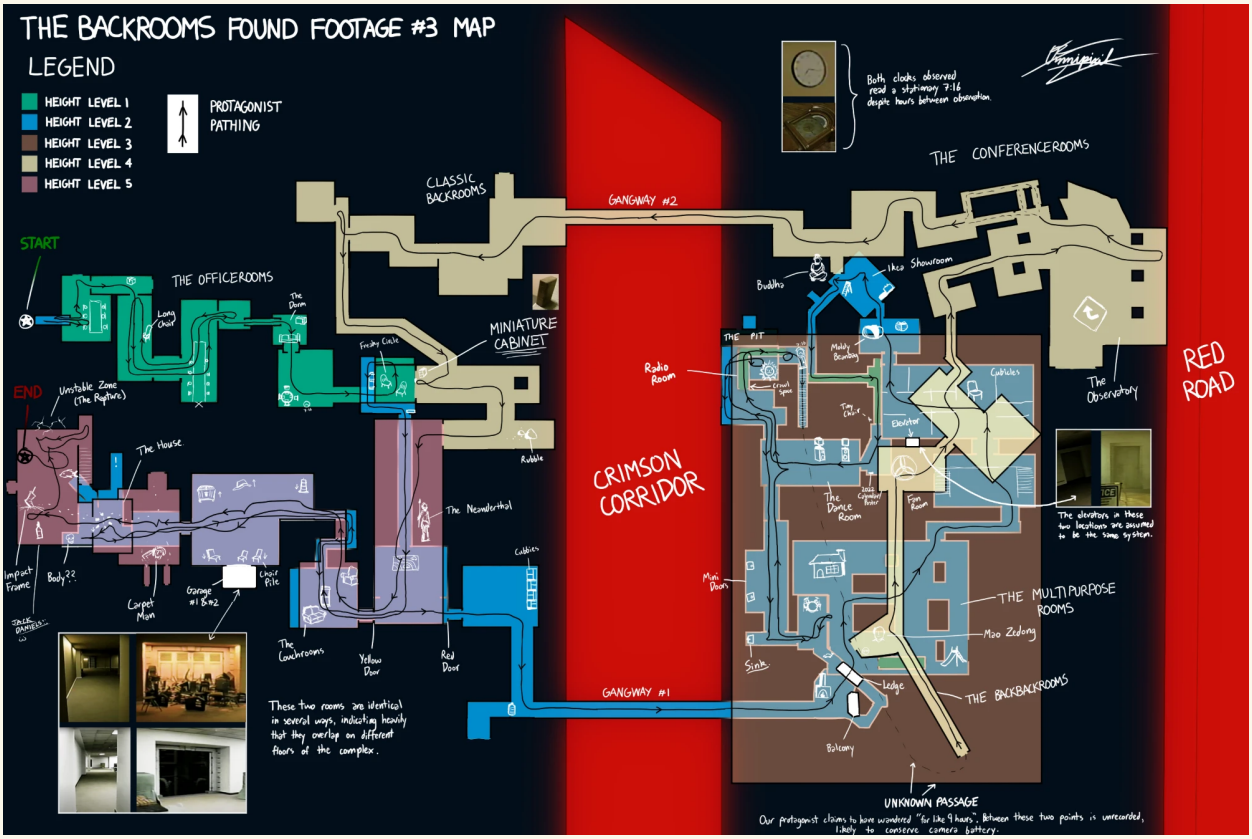
[CANON] Some time later, possibly days, Ravi turns the camera on himself in red light, exhausted and weak. He tells a story from his childhood about a day at a park with friends and a scary face he saw, says he can't remember what the sky looked like that day, says he just wants to go home, and starts apologising for all the things he said that didn't need saying. He says he was going to fix something, and the battery dies mid-sentence.

Details and readings

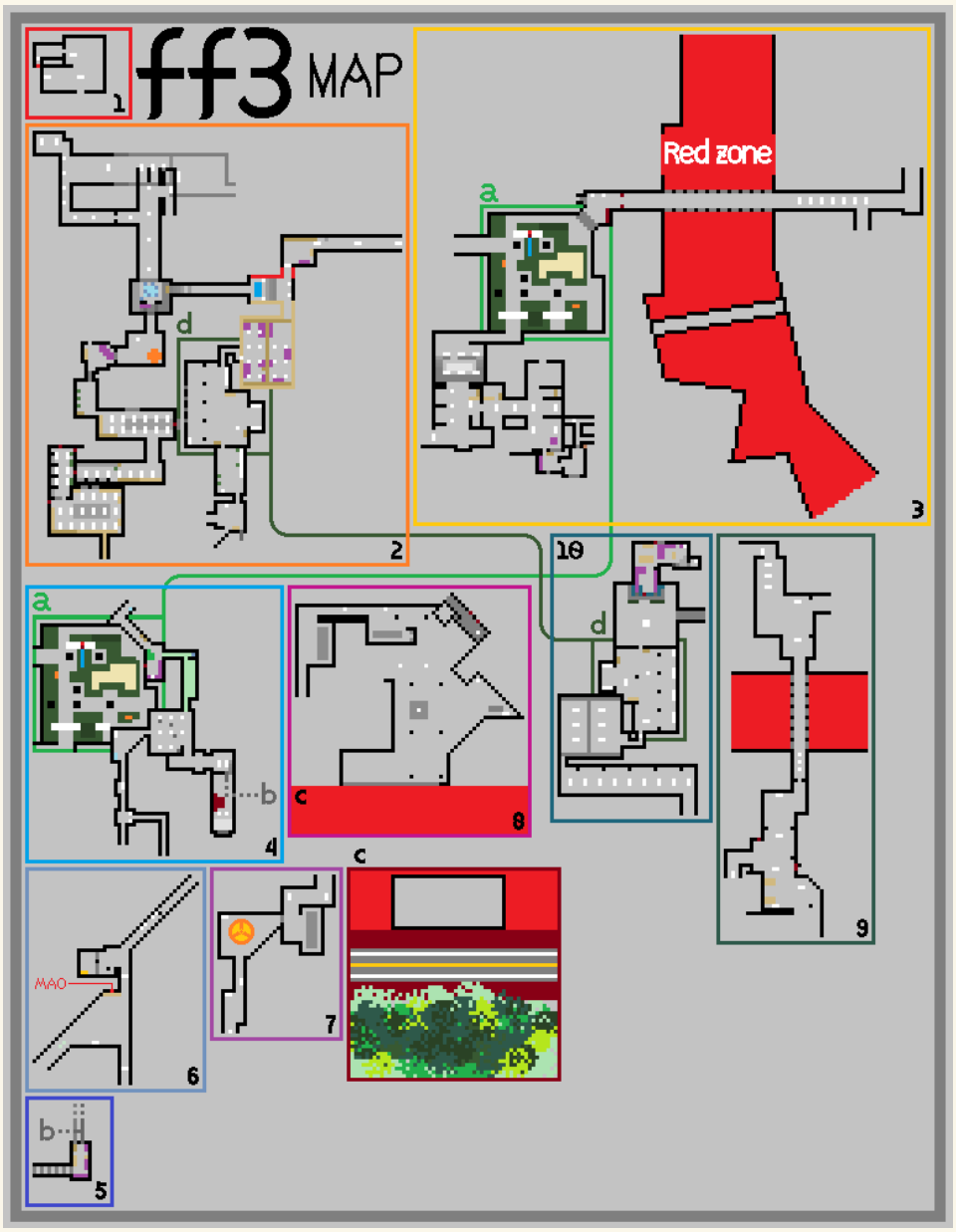
- [FAN] TV Tropes points out that one small residence Ravi passes through matches the layout of Elliot's apartment in Mr. Robot, Kane's favourite show.
- [FAN] The drum kit in the Complex echoes the one in Ravi's apartment. Wendigoon takes this as the strongest sign yet that the Complex copies what's near its null zones or what's in the minds of the

people inside it.

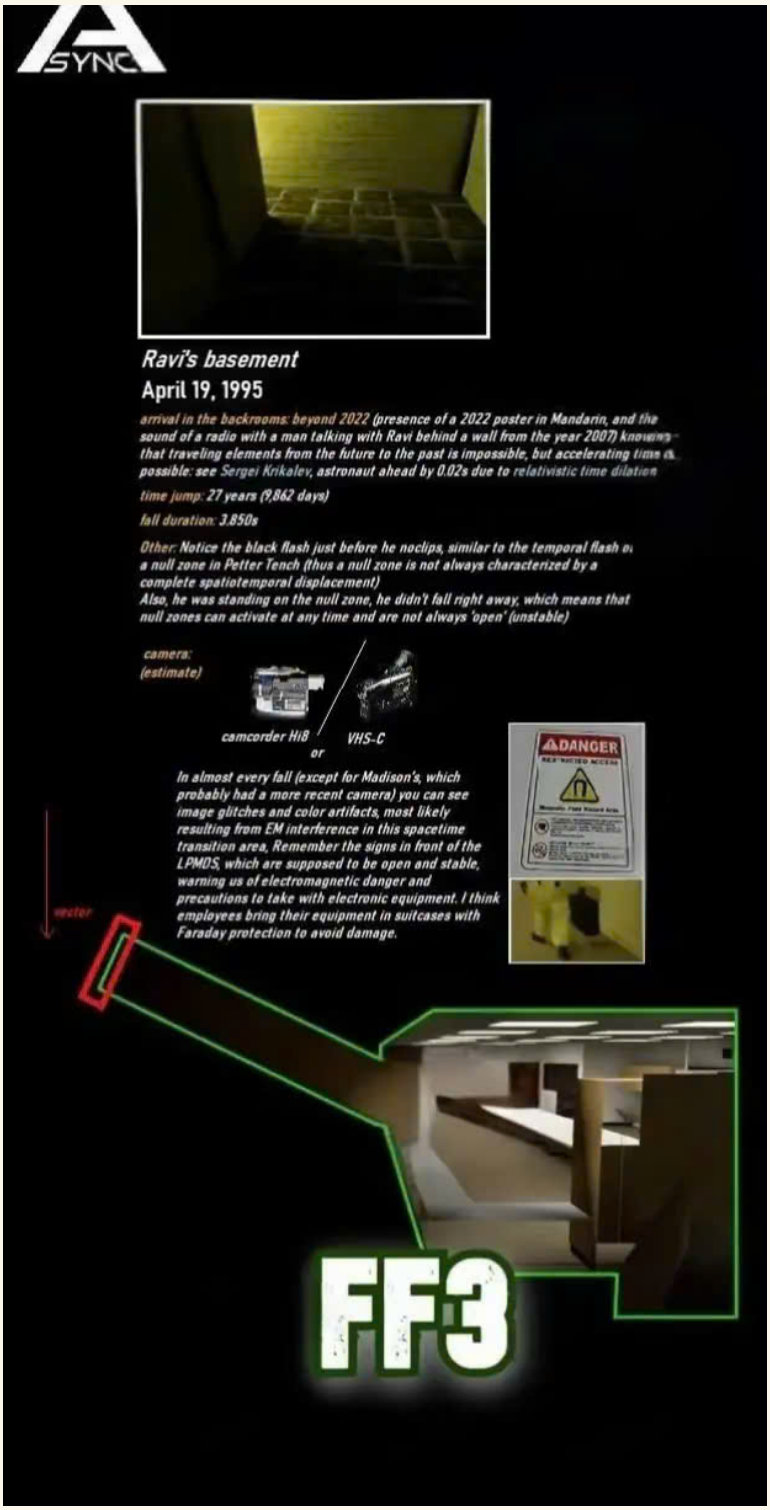
- **[FAN]** Fridge theories on TV Tropes read the Red City as a copy of a Chinese city, pointing to the Mao shrine, the Chinese flyer and the Chinese song. They also suggest the Mao picture comes from the Complex seeing his portrait everywhere and mistaking respect for worship.
- **[FAN]** The half-sunken grey figure holding a phone is read by Wendigoon as a Still Life still being formed out of the floor, a copy of someone frozen mid-phone call.
- **[FAN]** The sun painting is the "Sun in Splendour" symbol, which is also the profile picture of Kane's music channel. Wendigoon thinks it may belong to another of Kane's projects (People Still Live Here has an upload called "Sunshine").
- **[FAN]** Some think the edits at the start, and the freeze when the creature appears, mean someone has cut this tape together and is showing it to an audience, perhaps Async (TV Tropes theories).
- **[FAN]** The fan-made route map below traces Ravi's path through five height levels. It suggests that two of the rooms he passed through are the same room seen on different floors, that the clocks he saw hours apart both read 7:16, and that the walkways cross a single long red street.



Fan route map of Found Footage #3, supplied with this commission (signed by its maker). Colours mark five height levels. It names areas such as the Officerooms, Classic Backrooms, the Couchrooms, the Multipurpose Rooms, the Backbackrooms, the Pit, the Radio Room, the Dance Room, the Observatory, two gangways over a Crimson Corridor and Red Road, and the House, and marks objects like the Neanderthal cutout, the Buddha, Mao Zedong and the 2022 calendar poster.



A second fan map of Found Footage #3, drawn on a pixel grid and supplied with this commission. Numbered panels follow the route, with lettered links where areas connect and the red zone marked across the middle.



Fan infographic on Found Footage #3, supplied with this commission. It dates Ravi's fall to 19 April 1995, estimates a time jump of 27 years from the 2022 poster, computes a fall time, and argues that null zones open and close at random. These are fan inferences.

24. Backrooms - Lighting and Tile Survey

Released	Length	Description	Views	Link
2 October 2024	8:44	"11/14/1989"	3.9 million	youtu.be/DSWUEmJDglw



Thumbnail of Lighting and Tile Survey, with hazmat-suited researchers on a ladder lifting out a ceiling tile.

Taking the ceiling apart

[CANON] Set less than a month after the Threshold opened, this is Async doing basic science on the building itself. It starts with a researcher talking to the camera. Today is 14 November, a Tuesday, and it's incredibly cold, and she hopes that by the time anyone watches this they'll have proper heating down there. The team in hazmat suits works from a ladder with pulleys and straps (take the red one, someone says, because the green won't reach). Someone tells a colleague to always check the handle, because people get too comfortable. They lift out a ceiling tile and look up into the space above. There's no insulation on top of the tiles, but there's insulation on the floor above, and ventilation ducts running round the back. There's no rust. There's "more than one floor", someone says, "and I use that term loosely".

The report

[CANON] The rest is the formal report (Wikipedia names the presenter as Dr. Julia Meisner, delivering it the next day). Her findings, in plain language, go like this.

[CANON] They tried to cut the power to the nearest light, an ordinary fluorescent troffer, but couldn't find where it came from. The conduit was still live even though there was no visible power supply anywhere, and the source of the current is still unknown. They isolated the fitting with insulated tools, took the troffer out of the ceiling and carried it back to Standard, along with half a metre of conduit, making the exposed wiring safe afterwards.

[CANON] The ceiling tile measures **1.27 by 1.14 metres**, which is "certainly not standard". Otherwise it's normal. It's mostly mineral fibre with a fissured surface and slightly recessed (tegular) edges. By their first estimate it's about 60 per cent mineral wool, which is amorphous silicate fibre usually made from basalt or slag, about 20 per cent expanded perlite (mainly silicon dioxide and aluminium oxide), and the rest a mix of silicate material, starch, latex polymers and plant fibres, which is to say recycled cellulose.

[CANON] The troffer's housing is galvanised steel with a thin zinc coating. Its four bulbs are "non-standard in proportion" but closest to **T12** tubes, each **1.2 metres long and 38.1 millimetres across**. Assuming the rest match the one they tested, they hold a calcium halophosphate phosphor coating to turn ultraviolet into visible light, a little mercury vapour to make the ultraviolet, and argon gas to help start the tube and regulate the current, all standard for fluorescent bulbs. They connect through a **G13** two-pin base with 13 millimetre spacing. The wiring is PVC-insulated copper. The prismatic diffuser over the bulbs is polymethyl methacrylate, the same as in Async's own building.

[CANON] The ballast is the electromagnetic kind, a laminated steel core with copper windings built for 60 Hz power. It gives off a strong **120 Hz hum**, which seems to be true of most if not all the lights they've

checked in the Complex, mostly just by ear. The hum comes from magnetostriction and the core vibrating, and it can get worse if the laminations loosen or the potting material inside breaks down over time, so this one has clearly been running a while. Even so it works fine. Its large size suggests it was built for a non-standard space.

[CANON] Then come the labels. The ballast is marked as a **UNIVERSAL Type A, made in 1975, serial number A75234X**. The troffer is stamped **3X432**, **made in 1973 in Reading, Pennsylvania**, and UL listed. The bulbs are **Sylvania F40SW** (soft white), made in the USA, with the date left blank.

[CANON] She sums up. The fittings are outdated in design but fully working. The fact that every light in the area keeps running steadily points to a continuous, maybe self-sustaining, power source that nobody has found yet. The materials are tough and hardly worn, as if they were built to last a very long time, "possibly indefinite use". Everything they've tested so far is about what you'd expect from a troffer pulled out of the ceiling of their own building. Nothing strange, she says, which somehow makes it stranger. Her voice fades out as she starts on further investigation.

Notes

- [KANE] This is Kane's favourite episode (Wendigoon, 2026). Chiwetel Ejiofor spent about half of his first conversation with Kane talking about it, which Kane took as a sign he understood what the Backrooms needed (Smosh Asks, 2026).
- [REAL WORLD] 14 November 1989 really was a Tuesday.
- [REAL WORLD] [SCIENCE] The real-world details are right. A T12 tube is twelve eighths of an inch across, which is 38.1 millimetres. The F40 is a 40 watt, four foot (about 1.22 metre) tube. G13 is the standard bi-pin base for T12 and T8 tubes. A magnetic ballast on 60 Hz mains hums at 120 Hz because magnetostriction stretches the core twice in every cycle. Standard drop-ceiling tiles in the US are two by two feet (0.61 metres square) or two by four feet (0.61 by 1.22 metres). The Complex's 1.27 by 1.14 metre tile matches neither.
- [FAN] Wendigoon makes the key point. If the Complex were only copying human memory, it wouldn't bother with ductwork, insulation and manufacturer serial numbers, because nobody remembers those. Where it does copy, it copies better than memory does.
- [FAN] The idea that the space above the ceiling is "more than one floor" hints that you could keep climbing up through ceiling after ceiling.

25. Backrooms - Static Dead End

Released	Length	Description	Views	Link
12 February 2025	4:02	"05/29/1990"	4.1 million	youtu.be/ZbPaWvqAEq4



Thumbnail of Static Dead End, showing the finished walkway and steel frame over the pits of Room 14D, with researchers at the far end.

The phone call

[CANON] Over shots of nature, Marvin is on the phone with George Levy and he's angry. He doesn't like any of this, and he says flatly that they killed Peter. Peter was alive and well, and the United States Department of Energy had the resources to sort it out. George pushes back. Neither of them knows exactly what happened, he says, it isn't their business, they're lucky to be on the project, and it isn't worth dying on this hill. Marvin asks what happens if next time it's one of them, put down like an animal over a minor hiccup with a speech at the memorial because anything else isn't cost effective. George says they won't let that happen. He's had this same conversation with three other people already, he says, and nobody wants a repeat. He tells Marvin to take a couple of weeks off, and that doing so will show the people upstairs they can handle this kind of thing. Marvin calms down and apologises, saying he just had to get it out of his system.

[CANON] During the call there's a whiteboard with a drawing of the red street from Pitfalls, tunnel and trees included, labelled **"14D + 228"**, and a closet holding props from the A-Space presentation, a model of the original Threshold and pictures of houses that could be built in the Complex.

Behind the door

[CANON] In Room 14D the walkway over the pits is finished, and a steel frame with a winch stands over one pit, apparently for lowering people to the street below. George has the camera now. The door that Mark opened in Pitfalls is open, and he walks through it. A colleague says they want to show him what they found down the hall, and says Mark had described the effect as horizontal and running off around a corner. Squares of tape have been stuck along one wall to monitor it, and they've been pulled into rectangles, because the **wallpaper is stretching** sideways and the pattern lines up with what Mark drew. The colleague says this room has been cleared already. It's a dead end, and there are dips in the floor that George should avoid because nobody has checked them yet, though everything suggests they're safe.

[CANON] George goes in and is surprised. The room has carpet and tiled walls, and its objects are half melted into the floor. There's a football, a chair, a table and a couch, all sunk partway in, and sections of floor have slumped as if the floor itself had sagged inward. At the end, a hump of carpet rises with a single plastic lawn chair sitting on top of it.

- [CANON] This finally answers the cliffhanger from Pitfalls, three years later. What Mark saw through the green-lit door was the stretching, and this half-formed room.
- [FAN] Wendigoon connects the green glow Mark saw to the green light at the end of Found Footage #2, where walls move as the glow appears. He suggests the green is the Complex changing in real time, and

that this room is one that "hadn't finished" being made. He offers a cell that didn't finish dividing as an image for it, and even floats the idea that the Complex only generates as people approach its edges.

- [FAN] TV Tropes calls it the cliffhanger that sets up the film, whose central idea is the Complex's flawed attempt to "remember" objects that end up fused into surfaces.
- [FAN] Taylor Holmes says a distant screech can be heard [UNVERIFIED].

26. Backrooms - Everything Must Go

Released	Length	Description	Views	Link
3 July 2026 in cinemas after the film's credits. 17 August 2026 (Pacific time) on YouTube	16:04	"6/18/1990" and CG asset credits	4.9 million	youtu.be/ewZxobnBb30



Thumbnail of Everything Must Go, with the sale signs hanging and sinking into the floor of the sign room.

[REAL WORLD] This first played as fifteen minutes of footage after the credits of the Everything Must Go Edition of the film, then came to YouTube in August. Avan Jogia reprises his film role as Naren Warne, and Kane voices the other characters (Fandom wiki, via search). Kane said on Discord that it isn't behind-the-scenes material or a re-edit, and that fans of the YouTube series would probably like it.

Day one, 18 June 1990

[CANON] Three researchers, **Naren Warne**, **Aaron Ng** and **Bill**, are exploring an area the fan wiki calls the **Kelowna Branch**. They're trying to work out where they are, since the hallways are roughly the same shape, and someone notes it's been ten minutes since they saw any electrical fittings. One of them calls the others over to see something. Naren asks whether it's "that purple table again", which he hates, and the other corrects him that it was a desk, not a table. It's neither. It's a set of signs reading "EVERYTHING MUST GO! ENTIRE STORE ON SALE". They agree it's new, a new structure, and someone is thrilled by the way the signs pass right through the floor.

Day two, 19 June 1990

[CANON] A narrator, one of the team speaking after the fact, takes over. He says the signs were the highlight of the day before, and that Dr. McCarthy (Ronald McCarthy, from the Tench expedition) was keen to see them himself and came along the next morning in place of a Dr. Ring. At about 11:00 on 19 June they packed a mobile toolkit and went in. They planned to go on to "the new outpost" after the sign room, and Naren was carrying start-up materials for some machines. Nothing in the room had changed. Their main concern was what he calls "the instancing question", whether the three structures were meaningfully related to one another.

[CANON] The signs cut through the carpet and into the concrete underneath and won't budge when pulled, and the smaller ones are thinner. There's a clear sequence across the room, with the signs getting smaller and lower toward the back wall. They measure everything they can.

Measurement	Value
Sign 1	1.44 by 1.44 metres, hanging clear of the floor, lowest corner about 0.3 metres up
Sign 2	1.13 by 1.13 metres above the floor, measured along the edge that stays clear of the floor, so the true height is unknown
Sign 3	0.66 metres wide, a little under half of it buried, height unknown
Gap from sign 1 to sign 2	3.47 metres
Gap from sign 2 to sign 3	3.26 metres
Ratio of widths, 2 to 1 and 3 to 2	0.785 and 0.584, so not a constant multiple
Differences in width	0.31 and 0.47 metres, growing rather than shrinking, so not a constant step
Ratio of the gaps	3.26 over 3.47, about 0.94, close enough to hint at regularity but impossible to judge from so few samples

[CANON] Ronald works on the numbers while the narrator and Naren run a materials survey. Every sign is corrugated polypropylene, with screen-printed ink and steel hanging wire, all consistent with ordinary shop signage. They cut sign 2 off flush with the floor, which leaves a silhouette of sign material showing in the carpet and concrete. Probing it, the material blends into the concrete within about a centimetre, and they can't tell what happens below that without tools they don't have.

[CANON] Then the narrator explains how they settled the instancing question. Shared design alone, the print and layout and colour, could come from a template and wouldn't mean much. What they looked for were things no template could explain, the tiny flaws every real object picks up, like scratches, tooling marks and unevenness in the extruded plastic. They found **the same micro-imperfections on all three signs, in proportional positions**. The signs weren't printed from one design. They were **instances of the same physical object**.

Behind the wall

[CANON] As they're packing up, McCarthy fetches a power saw from the cart. Given the trend in the sizes and the average spacing, he reasons, a fourth sign might be sitting just inside or just beyond the back wall. They cut into it, and there it is, a fourth sign, much smaller and barely clear of the carpet. They argue. They're running about twenty minutes late, and someone wants to come back with five or ten or twenty people. McCarthy wants five more minutes and thinks this is worth being late for. Then someone sees something through the hole and realises it's a hand.

[CANON] They cut through. On the other side, in the dark, is a **mannequin** holding a **ship's steering wheel**. It "feels different here", someone says. There are more signs at about the same scale, maybe slightly smaller, along with coat hangers, boxes or clothing, lawn furniture and "a whole bunch of new rooms". Naren thinks they should go back now. There's a sound and a light somewhere above them. Naren doesn't want to check it out, but McCarthy, called Ron here, does. They find a **television** switched on, playing strange video and music, and someone says it just keeps getting better and better. Then something heavy is moving, and the sound seems to come from above. A tall figure in a pirate costume lunges out of a doorway at them, and Naren runs.

What it adds

- [FILM] [CANON] This is the prologue to the film. The thing that attacks them is **Pirate Clark**, the Still Life copy of the furniture store owner Clark in his commercial costume, and the store they've broken into is a Complex copy of **Cap'n Clark's Ottoman Empire**. The film opens with Naren alone and lost after this attack, and he's killed on the same day.

- [FAN] TV Tropes points out what this means. Three Async researchers literally cut open the wall that had kept Pirate Clark sealed off from the area near the Threshold, and Naren's frightened flight led it toward the part of the Complex Clark would later explore.
- [CANON] The signs, the ship's wheel, the coat racks, the lawn furniture and the television are all things from Clark's store. They were appearing in the Complex **before** the film's events, before Clark had even found his doorway.
- [CANON] The narrator's method, identical flaws in proportional positions, is real forensic thinking. It shows the Complex isn't drawing the same sign three times. It's placing one object three times at different scales, the way a computer renders instances of a single model.
- [FAN] The fan wiki says the Kelowna Branch, KLWNA for short, can be reached through a doorway-type null zone in the basement of Cap'n Clark's store, and that it holds three copies of the store. Kelowna is a city in British Columbia, the province where the film was shot, though no source connects the two.
- [FAN] The "purple table" is a running joke and a hint at earlier expeditions we haven't seen (TV Tropes).
- [OURS] The narrator's name isn't stated, but it can be worked out. The fan wiki says Aaron Ng was replaced by Ronald McCarthy on the second day, and the "Dr. Ring" McCarthy replaced is almost certainly "Dr. Ng" misheard in the transcript. With Naren and McCarthy both named in the third person, the narrator should be **Bill**. Naren is still alive at the end of the footage.
- [SCIENCE] The sign measurements can be tested properly, and the chapter on mathematics does that, working out what a fourth sign would measure under different rules.

PART IV

The Film

Backrooms (2026) took a nine minute YouTube short to the top of the worldwide box office. This part covers how it was made, what happens in it scene by scene, and everything hidden in its frames.

Making Backrooms

From YouTube to A24

[KANE] Less than a month after the first short went up, Kane started getting emails from the film industry, which he'd never dealt with before. He was wary, having grown up watching studios hand beloved properties to writers who didn't understand them. By February 2022 he had three general meetings a day. Atomic Monster (James Wan's company) was one of the first, within about the second week, and he also met 21 Laps (Shawn Levy's company). He was torn between them until the two companies decided to work on it together, which settled it for him (A24 Podcast, 2026). He first met James Wan over Zoom while Wan was in post-production on Aquaman 2, and remembers Wan walking in eating a salad. They met in person in 2023 on the set of Night Swim, when Kane was seventeen.

[REAL WORLD] On 6 February 2023 A24 announced the adaptation, a co-production with Chernin Entertainment, Atomic Monster and 21 Laps Entertainment, with Kane directing his first feature. Roberto Patino was hired to write the screenplay. The budget was set at under $10 million, co-financed by Chernin and A24. Reports at the time called Kane seventeen and the youngest director A24 had ever hired (Deadline, Polygon, IGN, TheWrap, February 2023).

[KANE] Kane says he gave up some leverage to make the deal, deliberately, and that talk of him losing the Backrooms IP is baseless. He sees his specific version of the Backrooms as "running through A24 as a conduit", and says A24 has shown "nothing but restraint" about what it wants to do with it. Marketing is the one area where he has to keep checking things (Deadline, 2026).

[REAL WORLD] Patino was later replaced by Will Soodik, whose credits include Ash vs Evil Dead. Patino stayed on as a producer. Soodik has the screenplay credit, with the story based on Kane's series.

Keeping it in continuity

[KANE] Kane says the script was where he "consistently had the least creative control", and that his authority grew as production went on (Interview Magazine, 2026). People new to his work kept asking why the film couldn't be set in the present day, or be a loose adaptation of the creepypasta rather than part of his timeline. He fought that, describing it as "fighting a force of nature" against people who didn't know the existing story, and made "swaps and decisions to ensure that it stays consistent" so the film wouldn't become "a costume worn by a different film" (Cultured, 2026; Wendigoon on set). There were early versions that leaned too hard on knowing the series and versions too far from what the Backrooms needed to be, and it took about two years to land on the final form (BAFTA, 2026). He says the hardest thing was cutting the lore down to "the most fundamental elements" and avoiding "lore bloat" (The Playlist, 2026).

[KANE] He credits the producer and director Osgood Perkins (Longlegs, The Monkey) with modelling "productive stubbornness", which helped him resist "creative distillation or alterations from the original source material" and stop the film turning into "a tropey horror film" (Interview Magazine, 2026). Perkins was writing his own next film during prep and hung around "like a big brother". Every Friday the team rented a cinema to watch something relevant, beginning with 2001: A Space Odyssey on the big screen (A24 Podcast, 2026).

[CREW] Mark Duplass publicly defended Kane's control of the set, saying he was "100% in control. More so than many directors 3x his age" (Cultured, Complex).

Casting

[REAL WORLD] In May 2025 Chiwetel Ejiofor and Cristin Milioti entered negotiations to star. In June Ejiofor was confirmed, Renate Reinsve was cast after Milioti's deal fell through, and Will Soodik was announced as writer of the latest draft. In July Mark Duplass, Finn Bennett, Lukita Maxwell and Avan Jogia joined.

[KANE] Ejiofor was "the first and only person" they approached for Clark. Kane spoke to him early one morning, the same day as the test shoot, because Ejiofor was in the UK, and they talked for an hour or two. Kane liked that he was curious and enjoyed engaging with the scientific method through film. Half their conversation was about Lighting and Tile Survey, the episode where Async takes apart a ceiling light. Reinsve, he says, had an almost spiritual connection to what the Backrooms touches on. He wanted actors who had a personal curiosity they were trying to satisfy, not people whose agent had set up "a horror film" (Smosh Asks, 2026; A24 Podcast, 2026). The casting director was Wittney Horton.

Actor	Role
Chiwetel Ejiofor	Clark, a failed architect running a failing furniture store
Renate Reinsve	Dr. Mary Kline, Clark's therapist
Ember Ambrose	Young Mary, in flashbacks
Mark Duplass	Phil, an Async researcher
Finn Bennett	Robert "Bobby" Franklin, Kat's boyfriend
Lukita Maxwell	Kathrine "Kat" Taylor, Clark's assistant manager
Avan Jogia	Naren Warne, the Async explorer in the opening
Robert Bobroczkyi	Pirate Clark, the Still Life copy of Clark
Krista Kosonen	Nora Kline, Mary's mother, in flashbacks
Patrick Baynham	The bearded Still Life
Dana Mahmood	Archibald Leland Sutter, the Still Life in the wheelchair
Rhiannon Roberts	The red-haired Still Life
Philip Granger	The meter man
Katharine Isabelle	An uncredited guest at Mary's house party

[REAL WORLD] Behind the camera were Jeremy Cox (cinematography), Greg Ng (editing), Danny Vermette (production design), and Edo van Breemen with Kane (music). The producers credited by Wikipedia are James Wan, Michael Clear, Roberto Patino, Shawn Levy, Dan Cohen, Dan Levine, Osgood Perkins, Chris Ferguson, Peter Chernin, Jenno Topping and Kori Adelson. The production companies are A24, North Road Films, 21 Laps Entertainment, Atomic Monster, Phobos and Oddfellows Pictures, with Chernin Entertainment co-financing, and TV Tropes also lists Kane's own company, Async Pictures Inc. Amazing Ape Productions and Werner Pretorius did the creature effects. Quincy, the first assistant director, handled the extras.

[FAN] TV Tropes notes that most of the American characters are played by non-Americans, with British Ejiofor and Bennett, Norwegian Reinsve and Finnish Kosonen, and that Reinsve's mother's pill bottles carry the name Nora, the same name as the character Reinsve played in Sentimental Value.

The test shoot

[KANE] In April 2025, before the film was greenlit, Kane went to Vancouver for a two-day test shoot with a skeleton crew. They tried shooting inside an abandoned Sears department store that indie productions had left old sets inside, which felt very Backrooms, with its big open floor and little kitchen sets. In hindsight it would have been "horribly, horribly inefficient" and cramped, and the real studio space turned out to be far better (Wendigoon on set). He had worried beforehand about all the customs of directing a crew he didn't know, and found once he was there that they were "just a bunch of people" he got along

with. You say what you want and why, and you do it (Smosh Asks, 2026; A24 Podcast, 2026).

Building the Backrooms

[KANE] Before prep was even approved, Kane had modelled and lit every set in Blender in decent detail and made concept art, to "strong-arm" the project along. By the time they talked about designing sets, he says, "it was already designed". What was built is "pretty much a one-for-one physical construction" of his Blender files (Wendigoon on set; Fangoria, 2026). He taught the cinematographer Jeremy Cox enough Blender that they could pass files back and forth, and the shot list was largely made in Blender too. Locations were scanned so Kane could remodel them and control the lighting in previsualisation. On the stages they laid out tape and walked distances, nudging a wall here and there for fire lanes, and if a hallway didn't feel long enough on camera they shortened it to get the right look (Smosh Asks, 2026; A24 Podcast, 2026).

[CREW] The original Blender map Kane sent Danny Vermette covered about 100,000 square feet, and the file was so big it crashed Vermette's computer. They built roughly 30,000 square feet across four sound stages. Vermette called fitting it all in "Tetris". All four stages had to be partly ready at once, and sets were still being built until the last day of shooting (Yahoo, The Credits, 2026).

[CONFLICT] Wikipedia says 37,000 square feet of wallpaper and 29,000 square feet of carpet were used. W Magazine says 30,000 square feet of wallpaper and 27,000 square feet of carpet. Wikipedia and Kane both place the shoot in Vancouver, and one Yahoo article says Toronto soundstages.

[REAL WORLD] [CREW] The materials were sourced locally in Canada to avoid tariffs. Vermette wanted the design to be vertical and awkward rather than "flat, endless rooms", with ramps, crawl spaces, slopes and raised platforms that made the actors physically uncomfortable and sold the idea of several levels (Yahoo; The Credits). He took inspiration for the furniture from clipping in video games, the way objects pushed through solid barriers look spliced at odd angles, which grew into "ceiling-sweeping piles of Frankensteined ottomans and chairs" (Yahoo UK). His rule for the space was that "the more we sink into this world, the more things are less remembered", and pulling real-world elements into it gave them an anchor (The Credits).

[KANE] There are two carpets and two wallpapers on set, the chevron print that's "the classic Backrooms one" from the original photo and the floral print from the first short. They argued over the tone of the wallpaper and carpet for several weeks (Wendigoon on set). One section, the area around the furniture store's basement and the entrance, was built as a single continuous set, a "hub" they kept coming back to. The furniture pile there originally reached the ceiling with twice as much stuff (Wendigoon on set).

[CREW] [KANE] The way in was done practically. Vermette built two portals, one for the camera and one for the actor, and they dollied through together. Once the actor was through, a wallpaper plug went back up with a seam, and post-production rotoscoped out the seams where hands passed through (Yahoo; The Credits). Kane jokes that the plugs were operated by someone else, not him.

[CREW] Vermette kept everything strictly period-accurate, putting in nothing that didn't exist by the time of the story, and he called the Async facility "100 percent era-correct". Clark's store upstairs is painted in "sad greys and blues" that reflect him, and the basement is a neutral beige that shades into yellow. A 1990s couch that Mary watches television on was his favourite piece. Mary's childhood home was designed to decay and disappear (W Magazine; The Credits).

[KANE] Kane cared about details nobody would ever see clearly. The night before the first day of shooting he stayed up until three writing out period-accurate legal paperwork for a desk scene, because the prop paperwork was recycled and would "break an illusion" if anyone zoomed in, and in the end it barely showed (Wendigoon on set). They couldn't win every battle. There wasn't the money to paint out every

cable, and the fire sprinklers aren't quite the right 1990 models, which he expects online viewers to spot (A24 Podcast, 2026).

[REAL WORLD] [KANE] The crew really did get lost. Sets were duplicated so the same place could be filmed in two spots, the stages were packed to the walls, and you often had to cut through sets to get anywhere, past moving doors and flats, in the dim set lighting (Smosh Asks, 2026). Alex Hirsch and Wendigoon both admitted getting lost on set when they visited (TV Tropes memes). Kane calls the film "90% practical" (Discord, via TV Tropes).

[KANE] He found standing in the finished set strange. It was like being "familiar with a place that doesn't exist and then it does", and there was "no barrier of disassociation" between it and the place he'd spent years building on a computer (Fangoria, 2026). He told BAFTA that this deep into production it still felt like being "inside a weird, artificial blender file".

Shooting

[REAL WORLD] Principal photography ran in Vancouver from 7 July to 14 August 2025 under the working title **Effigy**. The outside-world scenes were shot first, and the production then moved onto the stages for the second half. Roughly half the film is outside the Backrooms (Smosh Asks, 2026).

[KANE] Inside the Backrooms they shot mostly on 12 to 15 millimetre lenses, getting very close to the actors' faces against huge spaces to exaggerate the scale. The low-resolution camcorder footage in the film was made digitally in post rather than shot on old cameras (TV Tropes). The teaser trailer was mostly made in Blender (Discord, via TV Tropes).

[KANE] A real fly kept showing up on set during Mary's scenes and wouldn't leave. There had been a fly idea in an early version that was later scrapped, so the crew worked the real fly back into the story, and a CG version of it is what Mary sees pass through the wall before she follows (BAFTA, 2026).

Post-production and music

[KANE] In post he worked about twenty-hour days, got "way too hands on" with the visual effects, and co-scored the film (Smosh Asks, 2026). The score uses no orchestra beyond a few single instruments, mainly bass clarinet, plus some fiddle and tambourine, built with software instruments in FL Studio. He wanted "very gentle but massive drones and wails" with an aged 1990s to 2000s feel, like "something echoing down a corridor", always evolving rather than repeating a melody (Interview Magazine, 2026). He lists the ambient tracks from Portal, early 2000s Silent Hill synth pads, Cristobal Tapia de Veer's Utopia score, early software synths like Absynth and Reaktor, Mac Quayle's Mr. Robot music and One Hour Photo as influences (Smosh Asks, 2026). The Music part of this book covers the score and the songs in detail.

[KANE] He says the film is "built to be paused and analyzed" just like the YouTube work, and since you can't pause a cinema, people will need to see it more than once to catch everything (A24 Podcast, 2026).

Marketing and the puzzle

[REAL WORLD] On 18 August 2025 A24 posted a single word, "2026". The teaser poster, just the Backrooms wallpaper with the title and date barely visible at the bottom, came out on 23 February 2026, and the teaser trailer on 24 February. The full trailer followed on 31 March, with Instupendo's "Six Forty Seven" reworked into a ticking loop. Two character posters of Clark and Mary, small against huge Backrooms spaces in a style compared to Mr. Robot, were captioned on Instagram "If you're not careful...", the first words of the original 4chan post (TV Tropes).

[OFFICIAL] The taglines were "You are not supposed to be here", "Everything must go", "See how far it goes" and "The more you look, the more you find". A24 also released promos called "Hello" and "Step Through", an official promo on 13 May, a second promo, an "Everything Must Go" promo, an official clip on 2 June, a behind-the-scenes clip of Robert Bobroczkyi being made up as Pirate Clark (from a making-of documentary only on the Blu-ray), a one hour Backrooms ambience video, a short of the cast mapping the set, a live stream called "Instupendo, Live From The Backrooms", and the A24 Podcast episode with Kane and James Wan on 6 May.



A24's behind-the-scenes thumbnail, with Robert Bobroczkyi in the Pirate Clark costume and prosthetics, his peg leg rig visible.

[OFFICIAL] The most elaborate piece was a puzzle that started with a fake local television ad. A24 paid to air a commercial for **Cap'n Clark's Ottoman Empire**, with Ejiofor in character as the pirate mascot. Nothing in it mentions the film apart from a small A24 logo in the corner. A phone number flashes up during the ad, and it turns out to be a fax number. Fax it and you get back a printed flyer for the store dated **17 May 1990**, the same date Peter Tench wrote on the walls of his room in Damage Control. The flyer promises shoppers they can get lost in an endless sea of quality furniture.

[OFFICIAL] A24 also sold a Cap'n Clark's T-shirt. The back shows the eight-spoked ship's wheel and a pirate holding a sword that splits into two blades from one handle, and it carries a second fax number. Faxing that returns a page dated **18 May 1990** inviting you to "Join the South Bay Bulletin Board", decorated with a sun over a ship at sea. A phone number on that page plays a recording saying the South Bay Bulletin Board archive number has been out of service since 1991 and directing callers to an archive website, a mock-up of a dial-up bulletin board system where visitors can leave an email address and phone number (Wendigoon, 2026, who gives the address as 408bbsarchive.net [UNVERIFIED]).

[OFFICIAL] [FAN] Posts on that bulletin board foreshadow the film. A user called bekind_rewind complains that someone dumping trash in a Fremont parking lot has drawn seagulls that attack customers near a store, and in the film a seagull appears in the Backrooms. A user called nextdoor247 reports that someone has been stealing stop signs, and in the film Clark finds a mirrored stop sign inside (TV Tropes).

[OFFICIAL] [FAN] People dressed as Async staff in hazmat suits were seen around the world taping blue doorways onto walls, some of them at real places famous from liminal photographs, including the Holiday Inn Express at Heathrow (TV Tropes trivia).

[REAL WORLD] Wendigoon read the sun and ship on the fax as deliberate, since the sun and the sea are the series' recurring symbols.

Release

[REAL WORLD] The film premiered at the Aero Theatre in Santa Monica on 7 May 2026. It opened in South Korea and Italy on 27 May, in Australia on 28 May, and in the United States on 29 May. It reached digital platforms on 14 July, a week later than first planned, and later streamed on HBO.

[REAL WORLD] [CONFLICT] An extended version, **Backrooms: Everything Must Go Edition**, opened in cinemas on 3 July 2026 (TV Tropes says 4 July). It adds about fifteen minutes of footage after the credits, taking the running time from about 1 hour 51 minutes to about 2 hours 6 minutes. Kane said on Discord that it isn't behind-the-scenes material or a re-edit of the main film, which is unchanged, and compared the extra footage to his YouTube videos. It went up on his channel as the episode Everything Must Go in mid-August.

Box office

[REAL WORLD] Made for about $10 million, the film took $38.4 million on its first day and opened to $81.5 million in the US and Canada and $118 million worldwide, A24's biggest opening ever. Projections beforehand had been around $40 to 50 million. In its second weekend it fell 70 per cent to $26.3 million domestically and crossed $213 million worldwide, passing Marty Supreme (2025) as A24's highest-grossing film. By the fourth weekend it was at $301 million, and in September it passed $400 million. As of 20 September 2026 it had grossed about $402.5 million, with $197.5 million in the US and Canada and $204.9 million elsewhere. Its biggest foreign markets were China ($27.8 million), Mexico ($17.8 million), the UK ($17.6 million), Australia and New Zealand ($12.3 million) and France ($12.2 million).

[REAL WORLD] It's A24's highest-grossing film, the fifth highest-grossing independent film of all time, and the second highest-grossing horror film of 2026. Kane became the youngest filmmaker to open at number one in the US and worldwide, at twenty. TV Tropes reports that 41 per cent of the opening audience was under 21. It came out two weeks after Obsession, Curry Barker's YouTube-born horror film, and the two topped the US box office in successive weeks, pushing The Mandalorian and Grogu down the chart.

[FAN] The film's arrival brought jokes. The Hollywood Handle accidentally posted that it was projected to make "70 dollars", and a viral tweet calling Kane "only 20 years old" turned into an endless meme.

Reception

[REAL WORLD] Rotten Tomatoes counted 87 per cent positive reviews from 312 critics, averaging 7.4 out of 10, with a consensus calling it a startlingly assured debut that turns the internet's liminal spaces into something both mesmerising and terrifying. Metacritic gave 76 out of 100 from 47 critics, "generally favorable". CinemaScore audiences gave it a B minus, and PostTrak found 68 per cent positive and 53 per cent who would definitely recommend it.

[REAL WORLD] Amy Nicholson in the Los Angeles Times found it less a conventional horror film than a dreamlike experience, like a Dali painting that moves. Dan Bayer at Next Best Picture said Kane arrived "as a fully formed filmmaker". Sonny Bunch at The Bulwark thought it a bit too explicit about its themes but praised its emotional honesty and psychological depth. Owen Gleiberman at Variety praised the dread built from mood, sound and image rather than jump scares, comparing it to Eraserhead, The Shining and Skinamarink. Peter Bradshaw in The Guardian compared it to Japanese horror, Severance and The Rehearsal. Angie Han at The Hollywood Reporter praised its labyrinths and fluorescent disorientation. Beatrice Loayza in The New York Times noted the script's ideas about trauma, the unconscious and gentrification as a repression of the past. Lex Briscuso at IGN called it a cerebral rabbit hole, and Ryan Lattanzio at IndieWire praised Kane and Vermette for spatial uncanniness never seen on a big screen before.

[REAL WORLD] Not everyone was convinced. Nicholas Russell at Defector argued the film loses what made the shorts special, their feeling of decontextualised fragments that had been drifting round the internet for years, and swaps it for a conventional emotional journey. He found the camcorder sequences self-referential and the nostalgia a "semi-fetishistic pastiche".

[REAL WORLD] Trade writers saw the film, along with Obsession, as evidence that YouTube filmmakers were changing horror. The Hollywood Reporter reported that studios had started scouring Reddit for stories to adapt. Joseph Bernstein in The New York Times connected the film to Gen Z's unease with life online, linking the Backrooms' labyrinth to lockdowns, recommendation algorithms and generative AI.

Awards

Award	Date	Category	Nominee	Result
Astra Midseason Movie Awards	30 June 2026	Best Picture	Backrooms	Nominated
Astra Midseason Movie Awards	30 June 2026	Best Director	Kane Parsons	Nominated
Astra Midseason Movie Awards	30 June 2026	Best Actor	Chiwetel Ejiofor	Nominated
Astra Midseason Movie Awards	30 June 2026	Best Supporting Actress	Renate Reinsve	Nominated
Astra Midseason Movie Awards	30 June 2026	Best Horror	Backrooms	Runner-up
Critics' Choice Super Awards	6 August 2026	Best Horror Movie	Backrooms	Nominated
Critics' Choice Super Awards	6 August 2026	Best Actor in a Horror Movie	Chiwetel Ejiofor	Nominated
Critics' Choice Super Awards	6 August 2026	Best Actress in a Horror Movie	Renate Reinsve	Nominated
Fangoria Chainsaw Awards	25 October 2026	Best Wide Release	Backrooms	Pending
Fangoria Chainsaw Awards	25 October 2026	Best First Feature	Backrooms	Pending
Fangoria Chainsaw Awards	25 October 2026	Best Lead Performance	Chiwetel Ejiofor	Pending
Fangoria Chainsaw Awards	25 October 2026	Best Cinematography	Jeremy Cox	Pending
Fangoria Chainsaw Awards	25 October 2026	Best Score	Kane Parsons and Edo van Breemen	Pending
Fangoria Chainsaw Awards	25 October 2026	Best Creature FX	Amazing Ape Productions and Werner Pretorius	Pending

Controversies

[REAL WORLD] [FAN] Around release, copyright strikes hit several older Backrooms videos by other creators, and people accused A24 of trying to claim the whole concept. Kane promised to find out what had happened. It turned out to be a rogue automated system on YouTube, which was fixed, and A24 said it wouldn't try to take the concept away from the people who built it (TV Tropes).

[FAN] The Hong Kong poster stretched things, billing the film as a shocking creation from James Wan and "the team behind Stranger Things", without mentioning Kane. His name was added back in the local trailer. In Hong Kong the title was 嚇房, a pun on the word for guest rooms, and in Russia it was released as "Behind the Scenes of Reality".

What's next

[KANE] In May 2026 Kane said he wasn't finished with Backrooms and that things were "in the works right now", and that the YouTube series would carry on. In June, Deadline reported he was looking for a co-writer for a sequel, which he denied, talking instead about a television series. In September, reports said he'd signed with A24 to direct a sequel and that an announcement was imminent. His stated dream remains a limited series that reaches the main ending.

The Story of Backrooms, Scene by Scene

This chapter retells the whole film in order, in our own words, drawing on the published dialogue transcript, Wikipedia, TV Tropes and the detailed plot write-ups. It gives away everything.

Logos

[FILM] The film opens on production logos drawn in the style of an old computer, with A24's logo in Backrooms yellow, all under the low buzz of fluorescent lights.

The cold open, 19 June 1990

[FILM] Camcorder footage. An Async explorer in a hazmat suit, **Naren Warne**, is alone and breathing hard. He fumbles with a radio until it works and calls "Standard". He's been separated from the others, he thinks he's all right, but he's never been out this far and doesn't know where he is. He didn't get a good look at it, he says, but there's something else in here. He begs them to come and get him, and ends up sobbing. Nobody answers.

[FILM] A distant shriek. He moves on. A seagull suddenly flaps up out of nowhere, crashes to the floor and lies still, then jerks back to life and flies off. He passes furniture that has clipped into the walls. A door creaks open (with a stock squeaky-door sound the film reuses several times). Wind chimes tinkle somewhere. There's a rasping breath in the distance. He runs into a dead-end room with a sky of painted clouds and a locked door, tries to push back out through the only way in, and runs straight into the thing that's been following him. His screams distort into static.

[FILM] A television clicks off. Someone at Async has been watching the recovered tape.



Everything Must Go, the prologue added to the extended edition, shows how Naren's team broke into the copy of Clark's store and released what kills him in this opening.

Mary's handprint

[FILM] A dreamy memory. A young Mary and her mother **Nora** press their handprints into wet cement in front of their house. Then heavy machinery rumbles in and the house is demolished, by a firm called Reverchon Ventures according to fan accounts. Mary keeps a broken chunk of the concrete with her handprint in it.

The first session

[FILM] Workers clatter in the background as **Dr. Mary Kline**, a therapist, talks to her patient **Clark**. She tells him we all have loops, habits that keep us walking in circles and reaching for the same solutions over and over, because it's the path of least resistance, the one that kept us safe as children. He learned to push people away before they could hurt him, she says, and he's still stuck where he started, alone. Clark says he isn't lonely, he has employees and customers. She says she didn't say lonely, she said alone. He admits he hurts people, though he doesn't mean to, and says it's "just the way I'm wired". When she asks if he's ready to try a new path, he says yes, while shaking his head.

[FILM] She asks him to role-play the night his wife, **Barbara**, threw him out. He says it's his house and he's the one paying for it. Playing himself, with Mary as Barbara, he tells it his way. He came home late and broke a glass in the kitchen, which woke her, and things escalated. Asked how many beers, he dodges. Then it turns ugly. She's a professional student, he says, a thirty-year-old freshman at law school, while he pays for her school, her time off school and the roof over her head. When "Barbara" says that just because he didn't get to be an architect, he explodes. He is an architect, he shouts, he's just stuck selling furniture because someone won't get off her backside and help him. Then he apologises to Mary for losing his temper. She tells him that's the point of the exercise and his reaction was quite normal.

The commercial

[FILM] Clark films an advert for his store, **Cap'n Clark's Ottoman Empire**, dressed as a pirate with a parrot on his shoulder and a table leg strapped to his knee as a peg leg. In a single long take he hams it up, promising treasure-hunting shoppers deals on bedrooms, living rooms and dinettes at the "Santa Clara Valley's favorite warehouse and showrooms", at Capitol and McKee just off the 680, ending with a line about every sultan deserving a throne. Then he sits on the prop throne and it breaks under him. He tells **Bobby**, who's filming, to turn the camera off, and tells his assistant manager **Kat** to open the store. She points out they've already been open. Bobby asks whether Clark's supposed to be a pirate or a sultan. Clark tells him to shut up and calls the throne cheap particleboard.

The breaker box

[FILM] A meter man checks the store's power. The meter's fine, he says, and if the bill is high that's Clark's problem. Clark tells him the store loses power after hours, upstairs one night and downstairs the next. In the breaker box they find a red switch set crooked, at an angle, connected to nothing, as if someone had just stuck it in there. Power can't even pass through that part of the circuit, the meter man says.

Nights in the store

[FILM] Clark is sleeping in the store, on one of the display beds. At night he drinks and watches television. An infomercial advertises **The Window Within**, a self-help book by Dr. Mary Kline, with a three-part audio programme called Guided Openings, for $24.95. Its pitch is about living behind glass and opening the window within. Then an advert for data security, then the old science fiction film Santa Claus Conquers the Martians. In his car he listens to Mary's tape, which talks about consciousness as a room full of memories, about the walls an untrained mind builds, and about a window that was never locked.

[FILM] Mary, meanwhile, hosts a party at her house and drifts through it alone, as cut off from her guests as Clark is from everyone.

[FILM] Another night, Clark watches an advert for his successful rival, **Big Wayne's Furniture Barn**, whose host is a cowboy, and mutters at it. The picture dissolves into static. The lights flicker. He goes down to the breaker box in the basement, finds that the strange red switches are now the only ones that do anything, and switches them off. In the dark he hears the hum of fluorescent lights coming from a wall,

and sees a sliver of light in a crack. He reaches out and falls through.

First time in

[FILM] He's in the Backrooms. He finds a huge pile of furniture, chairs and sofas and tables jammed together, some melded into each other, with a television on top. Around a bend there's a mirror-image stop sign. There's a copy of his broken throne, bigger than the real one. Down a long hall he sees a silhouette that turns out to be a cardboard cutout of a caveman, with a speaker attached that plays the greetings in dozens of languages from the Voyager Golden Record. He finds a security camera. Hidden behind a loose wooden panel is a duffel bag of tapes and floppy disks with an Async ID badge belonging to Naren Warne. There are shoes half sunk into the floor, and a hole stuffed full of chairs.

[FILM] Heavy footsteps. Something out of sight flings the caveman cutout across a hallway. Clark runs back to where he came in and finds the wall solid. He pats along it in panic until he finds the soft spot a few steps over and tumbles back into the basement. Then, inexplicably, he goes back in to grab a stool to take with him. An Async researcher, Phil, sees all of this on a surveillance monitor.



Still from the film supplied with this commission, showing the furniture pile in the yellow rooms near Clark's entrance. Chairs, sofas, cabinets and a television are stacked and fused under the drop ceiling. On set the pile first reached the ceiling with twice as much furniture.

The second session

[FILM] Clark turns up late to therapy looking terrible. When Mary gently asks if he's intoxicated, he says he hasn't had a drink since Friday, and that's probably why he looks like this. He asks whether she's ever had someone committed. Then he tells her he found a place in the store. It's like the store just keeps going on the other side of a wall, like a copy of itself. He thinks they must be using mirrors to hide the entrance. At first it looks like a huge office building, he says, and then you realise none of it makes sense. He reaches for an image. Imagine describing a dog to someone who has never seen one and asking them to draw it. They'd get some things right but never everything, and from a distance you'd think it was a dog until you looked closer.

[FILM] There are no people that he's seen, he says, but there are footsteps and things move when he isn't looking. It's massive, as big as New York's subway system, and sometimes he's scared he'll get lost. The entrance is on the subfloor, so it's probably all underground and not on any city map. Mary, careful, notes

that he hasn't had a drink since Friday. Clark understands what she's implying (withdrawal, not discovery), slaps down a hand-drawn map, and says he'll come back with proof and she'll owe him a serious apology.

The expedition

[FILM] Clark knocks at Kat and Bobby's apartment at night. Bobby opens the door shirtless. Clark offers them two hours of overtime to help with "research", and asks if Bobby can borrow the camera again. Bobby got it through his student ID.

[FILM] The rest is Bobby's camcorder footage, in a squarer frame that degrades the deeper they go. Clark has supplies laid out, including stop signs and a blue rope. Kat jokes that he's going to tie them up. He says they're going to tie themselves up. He's taped the outline of the door on both sides to help find the way back. He steps into the wall and disappears. Bobby follows, laughing in disbelief, and then Kat.

[FILM] Inside, Clark shows them round. It looks like an empty office, Bobby says. Clark says it's as if it was made by construction workers on acid, and that there's even a pool, sort of. Bobby reads the mirrored stop sign out loud as "POTS". Clark says he's been in every night since he found the place and has barely scratched the surface. Kat asks whether he drugged them. Bobby says he'd know if he was high, apart from the weed, which doesn't count.

[FILM] They reach a long, steep chute, a slope going down into the dark. Bobby wants to see what's down there and they lower him on the rope, which is tied to the leg of a bed. At the bottom he finds a room full of laundry, piles of clothes everywhere, and it stinks. Then he sees something and yells to be pulled up. They haul him back up, terrified, and he says there's someone down there. While they're trying to untie his harness, the rest of the rope, still hanging down the chute, is yanked from below. They can't hold him. Bobby is dragged screaming back down into the dark. The bed slams forward into Clark and Kat and they tumble down after him. At the bottom there's a trail of blood. Kat goes after Bobby screaming his name, and she and Clark are separated.

Alone

[FILM] Clark runs. He comes into a dark room lit only by a Christmas tree, where a music box is playing "Feliz Navidad". It stops and starts again. A figure in a wheelchair switches on a lamp, and a woman in a red business suit with a strange face starts lurching stiffly toward him with a long shriek. He flees through dim, dry pool rooms full of tiles and running water. Then he hears Kat knocking and crying. She's on the other side of a wall, begging him to let her in, saying she can see him through the glass. He can only see tiles. She sobs that it's going to come back for her. As he tries to work it out, she screams at him to look behind him. The camera he set down rises off the ground, picked up by something much taller than him.

The window

[FILM] Mary dreams of being a child, peering through the newspaper taped over the windows of her mother's house. Just as she reaches for the handle her mother rushes in and scolds her for trying to go outside, because "they're all over the place". Knocking at the door, then the demolition machinery crashing through it, and she wakes.

[FILM] Her phone rings. The machine picks up with her greeting, and then Clark's voice, shaky. He's opened the window, he says, and he won't be coming back.

Phil

[FILM] At home, the Async researcher **Phil** is watching The NeverEnding Story with his family, microwave popcorn in hand, when a Cap'n Clark's commercial comes on. Clark in his pirate outfit invites viewers to get lost in an endless sea of furniture. Phil's face falls and he says nothing. He wears a T-shirt printed with Conway's Game of Life, and on his wall is a framed newspaper story about Async getting federal funding for MRI machines.

Mary goes in

[FILM] Mary drives to the store. Seagulls are crying outside. Bills and eviction notices have piled up at the door, and "RIP OFF" has been sprayed on the front. Inside, bossa nova Muzak is still playing and the lights flicker. In the basement she finds Clark's maps, a whiteboard, a door outline taped on the wall and wind chimes hanging. A fly buzzes around, then flies straight through the taped doorway into the wall and vanishes. She follows it.

[FILM] Inside she hears voices in the distance, overlapping and fading. She finds a mural Clark has painted, of a huge dark figure on a throne lifting a smaller figure toward a window, with writing around it. It says tables don't bleed, that the roof is wrong, that the floor plan has changed again, and that he doesn't know who signed the plans but the handwriting looks like his.

[FILM] Clark appears and says she found it. He was hiding because she was being too loud. When she asks where they are, he says it's "every place that ever was". Heavy, rhythmic thuds come closer. He tells her to stay calm, it's "only me", "you know me". The lights go off. He chokes her unconscious, apologising, saying it's for her own good.

The dinner

[FILM] She wakes tied to a chair in a dark dining room, with 1920s jazz crackling from somewhere. Around the table are three still, malformed people. One sits in an old wheelchair with a lamp attached, one is a bald, bearded man with too many eyes, and one is a red-haired woman with a face made of several angles at once. Clark recites Mary's own speech about loops back to her, then asks whether this place isn't a real mess, and beautiful in a way.

[FILM] When she asks who these people are, he explains. "This place builds them." Or rather, he corrects himself, "it remembers them", and the more times it remembers something, the less it does. Somewhere out there is a guy in a striped shirt, but in here he's remembered slightly wrong. Somewhere out there is a man in a wheelchair, with a lamp. That's how you get all of this, he says, places and rooms and buildings misremembering themselves. He thinks they're an improvement on the originals, because they can't feel anything. He stabs the bearded one, who doesn't react, and marvels that they have no thoughts, no pain, no ego, no fear. They just exist, like furniture. Then the best part. He tears the bearded one open and scoops out white, porridge-like stuff, and says you can eat them. He opens a fridge and shows her Kat's severed head. That's his assistant manager, he says. He tried to help her.

[FILM] Mary begs him to untie her so they can talk. He says if he did, she'd run around like a headless chicken looking for a way out and end up exactly where she is, like the paths she always talks about. What he wants is for her to tell him he didn't do anything wrong and that she was wrong about him. Not like that, too fast, he says. He wants to set the scene first. The night he was kicked out of his own house. It was darker, he says, and asks for the lights. The woman doesn't respond. He says he tried this exercise with her before and it went nowhere, so he switches off the main light himself, and the man in the wheelchair turns his lamp on. Something is still off. Clark cuts the red hair off the woman, who doesn't react, and puts it on Mary's head as a wig.

[FILM] He replays the argument, crueller this time. He had "as many as I wanted", he says, because it's his house and he pays for everything. When she starts the line about him not getting to be an architect, he explodes again. Mary breaks out of the role, saying she isn't his wife and has never even met her. He screams at her to stay in character, three times, until she screams back at him to go to hell, in stronger words.

[FILM] And then she tells him. The real reason his wife left, she says, wasn't the drinking or the rage, it was the whining. Nothing's ever his fault. He drinks too much and blames his job. He hates his job and blames the world. He gets kicked out and blames his wife. He attacks her and ties her up and blames his brain, but he is his brain. Is she saying it's his fault? Yes, she says, but it's just the way he's wired, isn't it?

[FILM] He asks quietly how he stops doing that. She says she honestly has no idea. She can't help him, she can't save anyone. He says he doesn't think he wants to change. Then don't, she says. He likes it in here, he says. For the first time in a long time he feels he's right where he's supposed to be. Then stay, she says, but let her go. He says he's sorry.

Pirate Clark

[FILM] Faint rhythmic thudding, getting closer, with a shriek. The red-haired woman panics and runs into a corner of the room, scrabbling at the walls as if for an exit that isn't there. The man in the wheelchair flicks his lamp on and off. A towering figure comes through the doorway. It's Clark again, enormous and distorted, in the full pirate costume, the peg leg now a real peg made of a chair leg, the hat grown into its head, eyes bulging. Clark speaks to it gently, asking what it's doing here, and introduces Mary as their therapist who was just leaving. It doesn't need to worry, he says, she says they don't need to change. "It's just the way we're wired." It lifts him up like a child and bites into his shoulder. He screams as it tears him apart.

The chase

[FILM] Mary runs. The thing follows, dragging what's left of Clark at first. It knocks politely on a door she's shut behind her before smashing it down. Scrambling over a hallway filled with sofas she hurts her leg badly, hearing a crack, and slows to a hobble. Somewhere a caveman cutout is reciting its greetings in dozens of languages. She runs through a copy of a suburban neighbourhood, brightly lit as if it were day, and into an enormous room built around a pit with no visible bottom, its walls lined with open, showroom-like rooms. She edges along narrow ledges and a staircase and climbs up through a hatch in the ceiling into what looks like the basement of Clark's store.

[FILM] For a moment it seems she's out. But this basement has none of Clark's maps or supplies, and upstairs the glass front doors open onto a solid yellow wall. It's a copy of the store. The peg leg clunks behind her. She swings a hat stand and breaks the peg leg. A cardboard caveman, rigged by Async, gets knocked over, an alarm blares and gas floods the room. Everything goes muffled. The gas drops Mary, but not the pirate. It pins her down. She pulls out the chunk of concrete with her childhood handprint and smashes it into its face again and again until the concrete shatters and its jaw cracks. She squeezes through a gap too narrow for it to follow. On the other side, men in hazmat suits blast her with gas from a blue canister before one of them stops the others, realising she's a person. They ask who she is, what happened, whether she can still see "the pirate", and whether "the other guys" are still going out the back.

Async

[FILM] Mary is carried back through Async's Threshold, the KV31 portal. She's given a brain scan and dressed in a tank top. Being led through the facility, she glimpses a lab where Pirate Clark lies on a table with its hat removed, leaving a raw wound where the hat had grown into its scalp.

[FILM] In an interview room with a two-way mirror, a researcher introduces himself as Phil. He wants to clarify a few things. How did she get in? She walked through a wall in the basement of a furniture store. He shows her a photo to confirm the location, then a photo of a man, Clark, and asks whether he's who she was looking for. She asks where she is. He fumbles. His company makes MRI machines, or used to, before they found it. She realises he's been inside. Yes, he says, and now it's his job. Every day he goes in and tries to find out a little more, mapping what he can, and he's more and more convinced that nothing in their lifetime, maybe nothing in recorded history, means more than this. But he doesn't understand it. He can't even describe it.

[FILM] Mary finishes the thought for him with Clark's line about describing a dog to someone who's never seen one. Then she asks what happens next. He'll write down what she tells him, and then what, will he let her go? They all want the same thing, Phil says, just to find out a little more. What's going to happen to her? That decision isn't up to him. He suggests they just talk, like two regular people who've both been in there. There are doors opening everywhere, he says. They don't know why, or what's connecting them. They keep happening, and they don't know how to stop them. His voice fades out as Mary stops listening, and wind chimes sound.

The ending

[FILM] A closing montage of copies. Missing persons posters for Kat and Bobby on telephone poles, last seen on 3 July. Clark's store. A bookstore with pyramid shelving. Mary's childhood home, now a heap of rubble with an old street lamp in front of it, with the handprints restored. Last of all a loose copy of the Async interview room, and sitting in it, silent and still, a deformed copy of Mary herself in her tank top, a face split down the middle with two noses, six fingers on one hand.



Frame from the closing montage supplied with this commission. A remembered heap of demolished house, with grass, broken paving and an ornate street lamp, sits inside a yellow-walled room under fluorescent panels. Fan write-ups identify it as the Complex's copy of Mary's demolished childhood home.

[FILM] Over the credits plays "The Word Becomes Flesh" by Boards of Canada.

The Everything Must Go Edition

[FILM] From 3 July 2026, cinemas showed the extended edition, with about fifteen minutes after the credits. That footage is the episode Everything Must Go, covered in full in Part III, showing Async researchers on 18 and 19 June 1990 measuring the sale signs, cutting into the wall and finding the copy of Clark's store and the thing that lives there. Seen in that order, the film begins and ends with Naren's team.

Details, Symbols and Easter Eggs in the Film

Where it sits in the timeline

[KANE] [FILM] The film takes place in June and July 1990, right after the series' Async episodes end in late May 1990 and a year before the first Found Footage tape (Wendigoon on set). The dates on screen confirm it. Naren's tape is from 19 June 1990, Clark shows up on Async's security cameras on 29 June 1990 (a date visible in the trailer's CCTV shot), and the missing persons posters say Kat and Bobby were last seen on 3 July. The posters in the closing montage suggest at least two weeks have passed by the time Mary goes in.

[FAN] TV Tropes calls the film an interquel, a story set inside the gaps of the series rather than after it. Taylor Holmes puts it the same way. It isn't the aftermath of the series, it happens inside the series.

[FILM] [CANON] The Kelowna Branch, where Async found the sale signs, is the part of the Complex joined to Clark's basement. Project KV31's Threshold is within reach of it, which is how Async's outposts, cameras, cutouts and traps come to be in the area Clark explores (TV Tropes, "Continuity Nod").

Things carried over from the series

- [FILM] The cold open restages the start of the first Found Footage almost shot for shot, until Naren goes further in (TV Tropes).
- [FILM] Naren radioing "Standard" for help echoes Ravi using a radio in Found Footage #3, and in both cases the noise brings the thing to them.
- [FILM] The cardboard caveman first appeared, without a speaker, in Found Footage #3. In the film Async has wired cutouts with audio to lure entities, and later rigs one as a gas trap.
- [FILM] The music track "Still Life" plays from intercoms in the filthy rooms where Still Lifes nest, in Found Footage #3 and in the film. The film's soundtrack has a slowed, mournful version called "Old Home Not Yet Built".
- [FILM] Pirate Clark knocks politely before smashing a door down, exactly like the unseen pursuer in Found Footage #3, which strongly suggests that pursuer was a Still Life too.
- [FILM] Clark taping the outline of the doorway copies the woman in Found Footage #2, except he also tapes the way back, which she never got the chance to do.
- [FILM] Bobby begging to be pulled back up the chute mirrors Marvin stranded in the pit in Pitfalls.
- [FILM] Kat seeing Clark through a wall he can't see through echoes Ravi and the father hearing each other through a wall without seeing each other.
- [FILM] A cutout flung across a hall echoes the chair thrown in the first Found Footage, the shot the whole series was built from.
- [FILM] A square tunnel in a wall with a long drop behind it repeats one from the first Found Footage. The long, unevenly lit hallway with side bays (fans call it Junction 3) matches the dark hallway from the first tape.
- [FILM] [CANON] Wind chimes, which the series associates with Ivan Beck, hang in the room beside Clark's entrance, and are heard as Mary drifts off during her interview.
- [FILM] A green glow can be glimpsed very briefly just off camera during the chase (TV Tropes theories page).

Things carried over from The Oldest View

[FILM] [FAN] The firm demolishing Mary's house is **Reverchon Ventures**, named after the botanist whose papier-mache figure is the Rolling Giant in The Oldest View. The face of that puppet can be glimpsed through Bobby's camera in the pool section. The Oldest View track "Scent of Freshly Cut Grass" plays after Clark's first escape. Bobby's descent down the long diagonal shaft recalls Wyatt's endless staircase, and Mary edging along a ledge beside a chasm with a monster behind her recalls Wyatt too, though she does better than he did (TV Tropes, "Creator Cross-References").

Nods to the original Backrooms

- [FILM] The famous 2002 photograph is restaged during Clark's camcorder escape, and the view through the first doorway reproduces the arches of the real Oshkosh store (TV Tropes).
- [FILM] The hum of fluorescent lights at full buzz from the 4chan caption runs right through the soundtrack.
- [FILM] The film's way in is in the basement of a failing furniture store, just as the original photograph was taken in a former furniture store being cleared out.
- [FILM] A bookstore with pyramid shelving appears in the closing montage, recalling the Borders photograph behind "Level: The End".
- [FILM] A drained, grimy version of the Poolrooms appears in the chase.
- [FILM] Ravi wondering aloud in Found Footage #3 whether he'd wandered into a furniture store now reads as a joke in hindsight (TV Tropes).

The store and the commercial

- [FILM] Clark's commercial is deliberately terrible. It's one long take, he's out of breath and sweating through his costume, the parrot lies sideways, his real leg is plainly visible above the peg, and the chair breaks under him. The version A24 released online is shot much better (TV Tropes).
- [FILM] Clark lists "living rooms, bedrooms, dinettes", the famous lyrics of the Montgomery Flea Market advert from the 2000s. Kane confirmed in an interview that the reference is intentional (TV Tropes memes).
- [FILM] The store's sign shows a white pirate with a hook hand and two legs, in red and black, nothing like Clark's own teal and yellow mascot with a peg leg. One theory is that Clark bought an existing business and couldn't afford a new sign (TV Tropes).
- [FILM] The neon sign has two swords that would light up one after the other at night to suggest movement. During the day both show at once, which fans read as an omen of the doubled, repeated things in the Backrooms (TV Tropes).
- [FILM] The cowboy-themed rival, Big Wayne's Furniture Barn, suggests Clark simply copied a more successful competitor's gimmick, badly.
- [FILM] The store is at Capitol and McKee in San Jose, near the 680 freeway. Fans note it's not far from the Winchester Mystery House, Sarah Winchester's famous maze of stairs to nowhere and doors in floors, and that both are close to the 280 and 680 freeways (TV Tropes).
- [FILM] [FAN] The "Ottoman Empire" with a Caribbean pirate makes no sense, as Bobby says. TV Tropes points out that the Ottomans really did back pirates, the Barbary corsairs, but Clark's costume is a generic eighteenth-century Caribbean pirate.
- [FILM] [FAN] A pirate makes pirated copies. Fans read Pirate Clark as the literal incarnation of an unauthorised copy, and the wide hat as a minotaur's horns, the beast at the centre of the labyrinth (TV Tropes).

Mary

- [FILM] Mary's self-help book is called **The Window Within**, with a companion audio programme called Guided Openings, sold on late-night television.
- [FILM] Her mother Nora taped paper over the windows and forbade her to open them or go outside, because "they" were everywhere. Clark's voicemail, saying he opened the window and won't be coming back, arrives right after Mary dreams about exactly that. Fans wonder whether the Complex fed him the phrase (TV Tropes theories page).
- [FILM] The concrete chunk with Mary's childhood handprint is set up early and pays off when she smashes it into Pirate Clark's face until it breaks. The closing montage shows the handprints restored in the Complex's copy of her old home.
- [FILM] At her party she's surrounded by people and completely alone, mirroring what she said to Clark in their first session.

Clark

- [FILM] Clark wears a T-shirt from a modernist architecture festival, and his doodles favour brutalist buildings, a style long out of fashion by 1990. At one point he uses a T-square on a round table. His maps of the Backrooms are genuinely skilled (TV Tropes).
- [FILM] In the first session he says yes to being ready to change while shaking his head.
- [FILM] He tells Mary he hasn't had a drink since Friday on what's implied to be a Monday. A long-term heavy drinker can hallucinate two or three days into withdrawal, which is why Mary is careful with him (TV Tropes, "Genius Bonus").
- [FILM] [KANE] Clark kept Kat's head in the fridge in the hope that the Backrooms would "remember" her and make a Still Life of her. Kane explained this in his commentary (TV Tropes trivia).
- [FILM] In the second role-play Clark changes "a few beers" to "as many as I wanted", which fans read as the truth slipping out.
- [FILM] His last words throw Mary's diagnosis back at himself. "It's just the way we're wired."

Pirate Clark

- [FILM] It wears the costume from the commercial, but the Complex has made the costume part of its body. The peg is a real peg made of a chair leg, and the hat is part of its head, which is why Async had to scalp it to take it off (TV Tropes).
- [FILM] It's made of the same cheap material as Clark's furniture, so Mary can snap its peg leg with one swing of a hat stand, just as the particleboard throne snapped under Clark.
- [FILM] It's immune to Async's knockout gas, presumably because the Complex didn't copy whatever inner biology the gas would act on (TV Tropes).
- [FILM] Its lair under the store copy is full of discarded, foul-smelling clothes and blood but no bodies, which fits with it eating its victims. There's a huge copy of Bobby's "End Apartheid" T-shirt there, and shoes near its throne (TV Tropes).
- [FILM] Clark's mural shows the figure on the throne lifting a smaller one, the same pose Pirate Clark takes with Clark before biting him.
- [FILM] An Async photo shows Clark and Pirate Clark together in a hallway, calmly, as though they'd been spending time together (TV Tropes YMMV).
- [FAN] The pose, lifting Clark and biting, recalls Goya's painting "Saturn Devouring His Son".

Phil

- [FILM] Phil's T-shirt shows Conway's Game of Life. In that mathematical game, patterns that never change from one generation to the next are called **still lifes** (TV Tropes, "Fridge Brilliance").
- [FILM] His family is watching The NeverEnding Story, a film about a boy pulled into a world being eaten by the Nothing.
- [FILM] A framed newspaper story in his house is about Async receiving federal funding for its MRI machines.
- [FILM] [FAN] When he tells Mary he's been inside and "now it's my job", it reads as though he first found the Complex himself and was then recruited, the way Mary might be. TV Tropes reads him as a mirror of Clark. Both go in daily through a basement doorway, both recruited others, and both think it's the most important thing that ever happened to them.

Sound and music in the frame

- [FILM] The cutouts play the greetings from the Voyager Golden Record, recorded in 1977 in 55 languages, including Sumerian, Akkadian, Hittite and Ancient Greek, along with the line "Hello from the children of planet Earth" (transcript). TV Tropes lists the languages in a slightly different form. The trailer uses the same recordings over Clark's first entry.
- [FILM] "Feliz Navidad" by José Feliciano plays from a music box in the Christmas tree room.
- [FILM] 1920s jazz on a crackly record plays in the dining room, and the fan wiki says a reversed version of "You Can't Forget" can be faintly heard under it.
- [FILM] The film also uses "Ulterior Motives" (a song once famous as unidentified "lostwave", also known as "Everyone Knows That") at Mary's party, "Eyes of a Stranger" by the Payolas, and "B1 - All that follows is true" from The Caretaker's Everywhere at the End of Time, during Mary's memory of her mother in hospital.
- [FILM] The credits song, "The Word Becomes Flesh" by Boards of Canada, is from the album Inferno, the duo's first in thirteen years, released the same day as the film. Its lyrics describe an embryo developing.
- [OFFICIAL] The released promo commercial uses a tavern-style cover of "Through the Fire and Flames" by Algal the Bard.

Text written in the Backrooms

[FILM] The film shows a handful of messages. There's the mirrored "POTS" stop sign. Clark's mural says that tables don't bleed blood, that the roof is wrong (twice), that the floor plan changed again, and that he doesn't know who signed the plans but the handwriting looks like his. There are Clark's labelled maps in the basement. Fans also point to a house number half hidden by leaves showing "6 7", which Kane admitted on Smosh wasn't deliberate.

Mistakes and oddities

- [FILM] Cars from the 2000s can be seen in the background when Mary arrives at the store. Fans either call it a mistake or treat it as one more time slip (TV Tropes).
- [KANE] Kane admits some details aren't period-perfect, like fire sprinklers and cabling, because there wasn't the budget to fix everything (A24 Podcast, 2026).

What the film confirms about the Complex

[FILM] Taken together, the film nails down several things the series only hinted at. Async began as a maker of MRI machines (Phil says so outright). The Complex copies real places near its openings, Clark's store among them, and copies people as well as rooms. Those copies of people, the Still Lifes, are frozen at a particular moment, so Clark's copy is Clark in his costume on the day of the commercial. They can be eaten, they don't react to pain, and they may or may not think. The doorways are multiplying. And by the end the Complex has made a copy of Mary in Async's custody.

[KANE] [FAN] Kane has cautioned in an interview that the Complex isn't choosing particular moments out of people's minds to copy, and that how it really works is still open (TV Tropes YMMV, "Common Knowledge"). Clark's theory that it "remembers" is a character's best guess, which Kane says is how the film is meant to work. Nobody in it is an ambassador for the Backrooms with a rulebook, just people trying to describe what they've seen (BAFTA, 2026).

PART V

The Complex

What the place is, how it behaves, where its doors are, what lives in it, and what it does to time.

What the Complex Is

Names

[CANON] Async never calls it the Backrooms. To them it's **the Complex**, and in their sales pitch it becomes **A-Space**. Their own building, the Async Research Facility on a hillside in San Jose, is called **Standard** when people talk about it from the other side, as in "radio Standard" or "back to Standard". The way in that Async built is the **Threshold**, and the openings that appear on their own in the real world are **null zones**. The word "noclip" never comes up, which TV Tropes puts down to the term not really existing in 1990.

[FILM] The film's characters don't have Async's words. Clark calls it "this place" and Mary never names it. The title of the film is plain *Backrooms*, without "The", and Kane is firm that this is the right way to say it (Smosh Asks, 2026).

[KANE] Kane has said he sees the Backrooms as open source, something anyone can connect with, and that his own version needs one consistent vision even though anyone could make one (Smosh Asks, 2026). Within that version the rules are fixed. He's said that from the start he had a very specific timeline that the whole story follows, the film included, and that he would never set up a mystery without knowing the answer himself (Smosh, "The Truth About The Backrooms", 2024). He also said that exactly one fan had worked the whole thing out, in a comment that got two likes.

The main idea, in the film's words

[FILM] The clearest statement of how the Complex works comes from Clark, sitting at the dinner table with his collection of Still Lifes. Asked who these people are, he says the place builds them, then corrects himself. It's more that it **remembers** them, and "the more times it remembers something, the less it does". Somewhere outside, he says, there's a real man in a striped shirt, and in here he's been remembered slightly wrong. Elsewhere he compares it to drawing a dog without ever having seen one. The same line is in the teaser.

[KANE] Kane has been careful about how much weight to put on this. Clark's theory is a character's best guess. Nobody in the film is an ambassador for the Backrooms who knows the rules, they're just people describing what they see (BAFTA, 2026). He's also said that the Complex isn't picking out particular moments from people's minds (TV Tropes YMMV).

[FAN] Two readings of "remembers" run through the fandom. In one, the Complex reads the memories of the people near it. In the other, it has its own memory and is copying things it has encountered directly, which fits Clark's wording (it remembers, not they remember). The fan wiki's "Memory Theory" page leans toward the first and uses it to explain the house in Found Footage #2, the farmhouse in Informational Video and the red neighbourhood in Pitfalls. Wendigoon leans toward the second, for a reason covered below.

Evidence that it copies real things

The record across the series and the film is long. Taken in order, it looks like this.

- [CANON] **Light fittings and ceiling tiles.** The troffer Async pulled out of the ceiling in November 1989 carries real manufacturer labels. A Universal ballast from 1975, a troffer from 1973 made in Reading, Pennsylvania, Sylvania F40 bulbs. The chemistry of the tile is right for a real mineral fibre tile. Only the sizes are off.

- [CANON] **A courtyard at Heathrow.** In the first Found Footage (1991) a window looks onto a copy of the atrium of the Holiday Inn Express at London Heathrow, which opened in 2018.
- [CANON] **Homes.** The domestic rooms of Found Footage #2, whose real original turns up in the home videos of home_27647.mov with the same layout and the same painting on the wall (the floor plan is Kane's own childhood home, per Wendigoon), the convincing house where Ravi meets the father in Found Footage #3, and the dim house interior copied from a well-known liminal photograph at the bottom of Kane's pit.
- [CANON] **Outdoors.** The farmhouse façade and green leafy wallpaper Tench passes, the red street of Pitfalls, the Red City, the stage-set playground with green carpet for grass.
- [CANON] **Particular objects from particular places.** A Chinese health flyer from USC Arcadia Hospital dated 2022, a mirrored stop sign, a portrait of Mao Zedong, a cardboard caveman, a painting of a smiling sun on every floor of a tower.
- [FILM] **Clark's store.** At least three copies of Cap'n Clark's Ottoman Empire, made after the doorway opened in its basement. There's a maze built out of the store's own materials, an accurate interior copy, and an inside-out copy with both inside and outside. The sale signs Async found in the Kelowna Branch on 18 June 1990 are copies of the real store's closing-down banners.
- [FILM] **People.** The Still Lifes. Pirate Clark is Clark on the day he shot his commercial. Mary's copy is made of her after Async detains her.

[FAN] Wendigoon's argument against the "it reads minds" version comes from the Lighting and Tile Survey. Nobody remembers the serial number on a ballast, the date on a troffer, the ductwork above a ceiling or the insulation on the floor of the storey above. If the Complex were building from human memory, those things would be missing or vague. They're precise. So where it copies, it copies the physical thing, and does it better than any memory could. What goes wrong is scale and arrangement, not detail. That's a real constraint on any theory and comes up again in the hypotheses part.

What goes wrong when it copies

[CANON] [FILM] The errors are as consistent as the copying. Every category below has more than one example.

- **Wrong sizes.** The 1.27 by 1.14 metre ceiling tile. The bulbs that are "non-standard in proportion". The tall dining table and chairs in Found Footage #2. The ballast that's too big.
- **Repetition.** The three EMG signs, each smaller and sunk further into the floor than the last. Doors that open onto identical rooms. The same painting on every level of the tower.
- **Things merged into surfaces.** Furniture half sunk into the floor in the Static Dead End. Store furniture clipping through walls in the film. The giant road sign standing on its end among the trees outside the Red City.
- **Stretching.** The wallpaper in the corridor past Room 14D was physically stretching sideways, pulling square pieces of tape into rectangles (Static Dead End).
- **Facades.** The barn front, the building that's only a front with windows, the Red City's windows that look like glowing pictures rather than rooms.
- **Mirroring.** The stop sign that reads backwards, in Pitfalls and again in the film (POTS). The reversed song in the dining room.
- **Lost purpose.** A kitchen hood with no cooker beneath it. A door that opens onto a brick wall. A staircase with no steps. Clark's description is that the place loses the point of what it's copying. A house in Pitfalls "forgets" it's supposed to be a house as you walk through it.
- **Wrong context.** A Christmas tree with figures round it in a dark room. A church-like shrine around a portrait. A playground indoors, with green carpet for grass.

[FILM] [FAN] TV Tropes reads the film's montages as showing the drift directly, a fresh copy of a real place first and then later, vaguer versions, with the familiar blank yellow rooms as the end result ("Genius Loci" and "Clone Degeneration"). On that reading the classic Backrooms are where copying ends up, not a separate kind of place.

[FAN] The fan wiki sums up the pattern with the phrase that the Complex gradually "forgets" the details of its copies, so that the more something has been copied, the further it drifts. Clark's line says the same thing in reverse. Something remembered many times is remembered less well.

What it's built from

[CANON] Everything tested so far is ordinary matter. The ceiling tile is mineral wool, perlite and cellulose. The light housing is galvanised steel, the diffuser acrylic, the wire PVC-coated copper. The carpet is carpet. There's no rust and almost no wear, and Dr. Meisner's report says the materials look built for "possibly indefinite use".

[FILM] The film adds that the copied furniture is the same cheap particleboard as the original, so a copy of a throne that snapped in real life snaps in the Complex too. Still Lifes are filled with a white, porridge-like or stuffing-like substance instead of organs, and Clark eats it.

Power and light

[CANON] The lights never go out on their own and nobody can find what feeds them. In the Lighting and Tile Survey the conduit stays live with no supply anywhere to be found, and every light in the area runs steadily. The report concludes there must be a continuous, maybe self-sustaining source that nobody has located. The ballasts hum at 120 Hz.

[FILM] In the film the Complex takes power the other way too. It draws on the electrical supply of Clark's store, showing up as extra red switches in his breaker box, and when he flips those switches off, the store goes dark except for the fluorescent hum coming from a wall.

[CANON] Lights can also switch on in response to people. In Found Footage #3 the lights of the stage-set playground come on while Ravi is on the far side of it, and TV Tropes reads that as something turning them on to find him. In Async's Threshold Outpost the motion sensors turn the lights red and set off an alarm.

[CANON] **Coloured light** is unusual. Most of the Complex is lit with the same cool fluorescent white seen through yellow wallpaper. The exceptions are the red street in Pitfalls, the Red City, the green glow, and the red of the Outpost alarm. The Red City is covered in its own section in the gazetteer, along with your hypothesis about its source.

Scale

[CANON] Nobody knows how big it is. In the Presentation, Async pitches it as limitless space for storage and housing. The main chamber beyond the Threshold is about a hundred metres on each side, with a regular grid of cross-shaped pillars, and beyond that the layout gets much less regular. The space above the ceiling in the Lighting and Tile Survey is "more than one floor", which suggests the Complex goes up as well as along.

[FAN] The fan wiki says the Complex is at least the size of a very large city and probably much larger, possibly infinite. A figure of 600 million square miles has circulated in fan writing. For comparison, that would be about 1.55 billion square kilometres, roughly three times the surface area of the Earth (about 510 million square kilometres). There's no canon source for it.

[CANON] Whatever its size, the parts we've seen are connected. People walk, fall or climb from one area to the next through doors, gaps in walls, holes in floors, crawl spaces, chutes and ladders. Async's divisions are reachable on foot from the Threshold. Ravi walks from a classroom to a house to a furniture store to the Red City without ever leaving.

It isn't fixed

[CANON] The Complex changes. In Reunion, Room 14C isn't what Marvin remembered. The walls are white drywall with black vinyl baseboards, the proportions seem different, and ceiling tiles have been moved as if something shifted them on purpose. In Static Dead End the wallpaper is visibly stretching. At the end of Found Footage #2 the walls of a room start to move as green light cracks through them.

[CANON] It also grows toward the real world. The film's doorways are said to be multiplying. Missing persons spiked after the Threshold opened in October 1989. A copy of Clark's store appeared because the Complex had found its basement.

[FAN] Wendigoon offers two images for the half-formed Static Dead End room. Either it's like a cell that hadn't finished dividing when people walked in on it, or the Complex was absorbing that area and hadn't finished. He also floats the idea that it only generates as people approach its edges. None of this is confirmed.

Sound

[CANON] Sound behaves strangely. Inside, every light hums. Through some walls you can hear the real world. Ravi talks to a father in a real house through a wall he can't see through, and hears a television on the other side. In Informational Video the camera operator listens at a wall that seems to have voices behind it. Marvin's radio in Pitfalls picks up broadcasts from 2008 and 2015. Async's own sensors respond to noise as well as movement.

[FILM] In the film, Kat can see Clark through a wall that's opaque from his side. One-way visibility hasn't been seen anywhere else.

Air, food, water and bodies

[KANE] Asked by Smosh in 2024, Kane said there's probably food in the Backrooms but it would be very hard to find and might be rotten. Water would be easier. There are toilets, and probably working ones, and he said that wasn't him making it up on the spot, it's what makes sense. A person who noclipped in would behave normally and their body would work normally. Asked whether the toilet paper was one-ply, he said there's variety. Asked about animals, he asked what counts as an animal.

[CANON] The young man found in Missing Persons died of malnutrition, about five days before he was found, which fits a place where food is there in theory but not in practice.

[CANON] The cold is real. Dr. Meisner says on 14 November 1989 that it's incredibly cold. In the film Clark and Mary aren't dressed for cold and don't seem cold, so this may vary by area.

[FILM] [CANON] Still Lifes are edible. Clark lives on them. What a person could eat in the series is less clear. Ravi's footage shows no food at all.

Does it think?

[FAN] TV Tropes files it under "Ambiguously Sentient Object". The case for some kind of agency comes mostly from the film. It encroaches on Clark's power system, shows him footage of the Complex on his television, flickers the store lights to lead him to the basement, and makes the crack of light that opens just as he reaches it. Clark's voicemail, saying he opened the window, arrives right after Mary dreams of

opening one, and fans wonder whether the Complex gave him the phrase.

[KANE] Kane describes the Backrooms inside the story as a neutral technology, not inherently anything, which could do great good or great harm or simply be nature if everyone left it alone (Wendigoon on set, 2026). He also resists calling the film horror (see Part II). That doesn't settle whether it has a mind, but it argues against reading it as malevolent. Asked directly in his Japanese interviews, as summarised on note.com, he said "I don't know if there is intelligence or intent behind it."

[FAN] The opposite view, that it behaves like a natural system with no intent, fits most of the series. Wendigoon's suggestion is that it acts like a body. Entities are its immune response, and the Lifeform behaves like a bacterial colony with a life cycle. That's discussed in the theories part.

Safety rules and what Async learned

[CANON] Async's procedures grow out of accidents.

- After Tench vanished on 1 March 1990, expeditions had to be at least three people, and nobody walks off alone. The fan wiki records the three-person rule as mandatory.
- After Marvin's fall and the Lifeform on 6 May 1990, the hallway to Room 14B was walled off and teams were issued rifles.
- After Naren's death on 19 June 1990, Async began placing decoys with speakers to lure entities onto camera and then into gas traps.
- The Threshold has an airlock and blast doors. Motion sensors at the Outpost trigger red lights and an alarm.
- In Static Dead End, people avoid the dips in the floor because nobody has checked them yet.

[FAN] The fan wiki reads the three-person rule as a sign that groups make the Complex more stable. Nothing in canon says that outright. The stated reason is ordinary safety. It is still notable that the two worst incidents both began with someone alone, Tench in a corridor and Marvin in a pit.

The Threshold and the Null Zones

The machine

[CANON] Async's way in is a machine called the **Low-Proximity Magnetic Distortion System**, or LPMDS. It's the centrepiece of **Project KV31**, a room-sized apparatus built around a doorway known as the Threshold. Its story, pieced together from five episodes, goes like this.

Date	Event	Source
2 August 1972	Ivan Beck signs off a lab report on glass samples doped with tellurium, testing their dielectric behaviour between 0.5 and 0.767 GHz. A green glow fills the room. This happens during the great solar storms of August 1972	Overflow, fan wiki
10 May 1982	A prototype is tested at Oak Ridge National Laboratory under Philip R. Heymann. It blasts a small marble with electromagnetic energy, producing a yellowish glow, and the marble stays put	Prototype, fan wiki
around April 1988	Async begins developing Project KV31 proper, promising to solve "all current and future" storage and housing needs	fan wiki
2 July 1988	The third test fails	The Third Test
17 October 1989, 5:09 pm	The sixth test opens the Threshold. The Loma Prieta earthquake had struck at 5:04 pm	First Contact, faultline.mov
after 17 October 1989	Async repairs the damage and adds an airlock while it works out whether the far side is safe	fan wiki

[KANE] On the earthquake, Kane has implied that it didn't technically "cause" the Threshold to open (fan wiki, citing his comments around faultline.mov). The five minute gap between the earthquake and the test also argues against the test causing the quake. The two happening together is left as a deliberate mystery.

[CANON] **The name** of the project is generally read as **Karlovy Vary 1931**, the place and year of Ivan Beck's birth, a reading the fan wiki records as a theory. TV Tropes notes that KV31 also looks like a designation from the Valley of the Kings in Egypt, where tombs are numbered KV1, KV2 and so on, which casts the whole project as the opening of a tomb.

[SCIENCE] The real numbers behind Overflow are covered in the science part. Briefly, tellurite glasses are real, are studied for exactly the dielectric properties the report describes, and 0.5 to 0.767 GHz is a plausible microwave test band.

The Threshold and the Outpost

[CANON] On Async's side there's the KV31 control room, which looks down onto the Threshold Chamber. On the far side is the first structure Async built inside the Complex, the **Threshold Outpost**, sometimes called the Observation Room. The fan wiki gives the details. Building started between 1 and 5 March 1990 and was finished around 6 May. Inside are control panels and two computer desks by the observation windows. There's a blast door with a metal shutter on the right wall and a keycard door on the front wall. Motion sensors installed by the time of Presentation turn the lights red and sound an alarm.

[CANON] That alarm is what announces Peter Tench on 8 May 1990. It also marks the moment, in Damage Control, when Tench goes the other way, through the Outpost and into Standard with a shotgun.

[CANON] Beyond the Outpost is the **Main Chamber**, about a hundred metres on a side, held up by a grid of cross-shaped pillars, with the yellow wallpaper, brown carpet, drop ceiling and humming lights of the classic Backrooms. Async treats each corridor off it as a numbered division. Lateral divisions run off the left and right sides and numbered divisions off the front and back. The row of cells closest to the

Threshold is "lateral division A", where the seven cameras of Motion Detected were placed on 5 March 1990. Most divisions are dead ends. Division 14 and one unnamed division lead on into the rest of the Complex.

Null zones

[CANON] A null zone is a place in the real world where a surface stops being solid and things fall through it into the Complex. The term first appears written on a blueprint of the Threshold in Informational Video, which suggests the LPMDS itself works by making one. The first time anyone says it aloud is in Pitfalls, when one of the team on the radio wonders whether "Miller" is right "about the null zones". Nobody knows who Miller is.

[FAN] The fan wiki says null zones are also called "null kx fields", and one of the fan sheets below uses the same "kx" wording. Neither says where it appears on screen [UNVERIFIED].

[FAN] The fan wiki divides them into two kinds, **Thresholds**, which are stable, and **glitches**, which come and go. The Threshold is an artificial one. Clark's basement doorway is a natural one that behaves like a Threshold, and the wiki calls it "doorway-type".

Every null zone on record

When	Where	What happened	Source
17 Oct 1989 onward	Async, San Jose	The Threshold. Stable, guarded, two-way	First Contact onward
late 1989 onward	Northern California	Missing persons spike. Posters for Nicolas Bolton, Margaret Watson (last seen 2 December 1989, age 28), Janice Scott, Ellis White (age 2), James Esmail and an unnamed man	Missing Persons, fan wiki
before Feb 1990	unknown	A young man ends up inside and dies of malnutrition, found 3 February 1990	Missing Persons, Autopsy Report
between Oct 1989 and Aug 1995	a highway	A car vanishes from traffic camera footage at full speed and turns up years later wrecked against a wall inside	9780415263573, Found Footage #2
29 June 1990	Clark's store basement, San Jose	A crack of light in a wall that swallows Clark. Stable, two-way, used for days	the film
June 1990	in mid-air	A seagull appears in the Complex, apparently clipped in while flying	the film
4 July 1991	where Kane was shooting a student film	Kane falls in. His camera later comes back out through a different null zone and is recovered on 23 September 1996	Found Footage, TV Tropes timeline
19 August 1995	a garage floor	A square marked in blue tape that wood chips fall through. A tape measure pushed in starts to vibrate, the zone widens, and the woman filming is pulled through	Found Footage #2
undated, probably 1990s	a breached cinder block wall in a basement	Ravi climbs through and falls a long way down a tunnel, coming out of a cabinet in the Classroom Area	Found Footage #3
same day as Ravi	a house wall, somewhere else in time	A father breaks his wall open to help Ravi and is heard falling in, but doesn't arrive where Ravi is	Found Footage #3

How they behave

[CANON] Putting those together gives a set of fairly safe statements.

- **They can be any size and grow.** The garage zone is small enough for wood chips but pulls in a woman once disturbed. The highway zone took a whole car.
- **They can be anywhere.** Floors, walls, a road, the air.
- **They're dangerous to touch.** Pushing something into one seems to make it worse. The fan wiki describes unstable glitches as growing briefly when a large object gets stuck in them, letting a person or car through, then pulling back and sealing.
- **They can be one-way.** Nobody who fell through a glitch ever got back the same way. Clark's doorway, which went both ways for days, is the exception, and so is the Threshold.
- **They don't connect cleanly.** The father in Found Footage #3 is heard falling through a wall that's right next to Ravi, yet he doesn't land near Ravi. Wendigoon suggests the two ends of a zone may not even be at the same time.
- **Things come back out.** Kane's camera reached the real world through a different zone. The tapes of Found Footage #2 and #3 also got out somehow, and the fan wiki takes this to mean that "warps" inside the Complex lead back to Earth.
- **They're linked to time slips.** Kane's tape is found five years after it was shot. Ravi hears a commercial from 2007 to 2009 through a wall. See the next chapters.
- **They're linked to the green glow.** The glow appears where walls move and spaces change, and the fan wiki associates it with portals opening.

[FILM] The film shows a natural null zone forming. The store's power goes strange, the breaker box sprouts red switches, the TV shows static and Backrooms footage, the lights flicker, and a crack of fluorescent light opens in the basement wall. When Clark reaches for it, the concrete seems to swallow him. After that it's a doorway he can tape round and walk through at will.

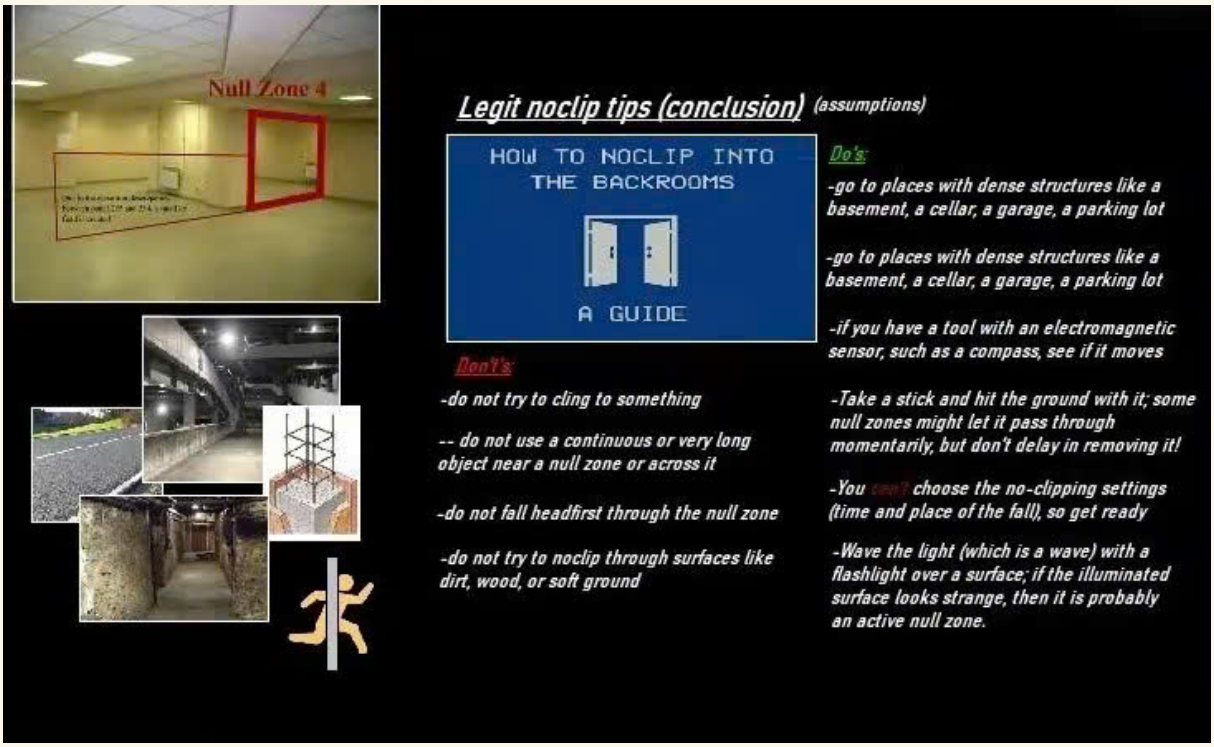
Falling

[CANON] People usually fall when they go through, and the fall is often long. Ravi drops down a tunnel and comes out of a cabinet. The woman in Found Footage #2 lands among the wood chips she'd poured in earlier. Kane falls before he lands in the Complex. In each case the camera picture and sound break up during the fall, which in the found footage could be the tape, the camera or the crossing itself.

[FAN] The fan infographics on Found Footage #1, #2 and #3 supplied with this commission each work out a fall time from the footage, about 2.25 seconds for Kane, about 1.76 seconds for the garage, and about 3.85 seconds for Ravi.

Three fan sheets on null zones

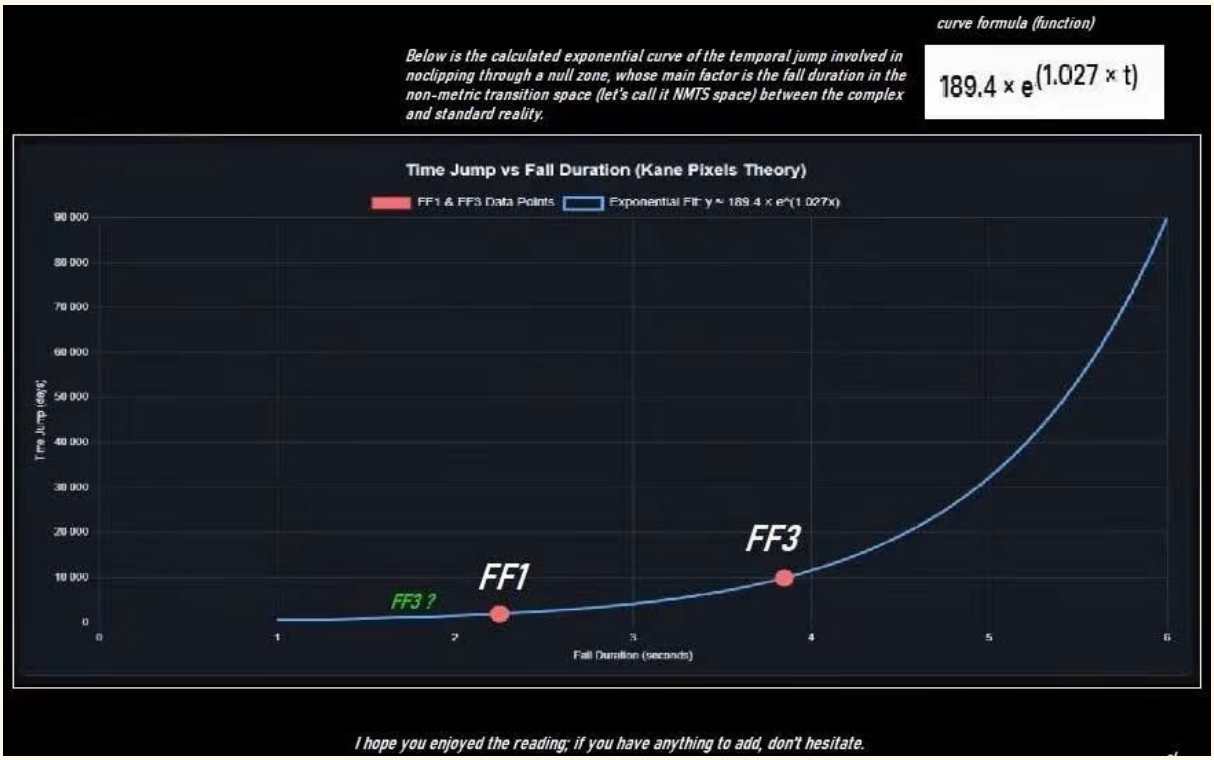
These three images came with this commission. They're unattributed fan theory, shown here as they are and then tested against what's on screen.



Fan sheet, "Legit noclip tips (conclusion)". A tongue-in-cheek guide to falling into the Backrooms, built from the found footage episodes.

[FAN] **The "noclip tips" sheet** gives dos and don'ts, which it calls assumptions. Its dos are to look for dense structures such as basements, cellars, garages and car parks, to watch a compass or other magnetic sensor for movement, to tap the ground with a stick and pull it out quickly, and to sweep a torch over a surface to see if it looks strange. It adds that you can't choose when or where you'll come out. The don'ts are to avoid clinging to anything, to keep long objects away from a zone, not to fall in head first, and not to try it through dirt, wood or soft ground.

[OURS] Checked against canon, a few points hold up well. Long objects really are dangerous, since the tape measure in Found Footage #2 is what seems to set the zone off. Basements and garages fit Ravi, the woman and Clark. You can't choose where you come out, as the father shows. The compass idea has some logic, because Async's machine is magnetic, but nothing on screen shows a null zone moving a needle. The "not wood or soft ground" rule has counterexamples. The father breaks through an ordinary house wall, and the seagull comes through thin air.



Fan graph, "Time Jump vs Fall Duration (Kane Pixels Theory)". It fits an exponential curve, y = 189.4 e^(1.027 t), through two points labelled FF1 and FF3, with fall time in seconds against time jump in days.

[FAN] **The time jump graph** proposes that the longer the fall through a null zone, the further you're thrown in time, following the curve

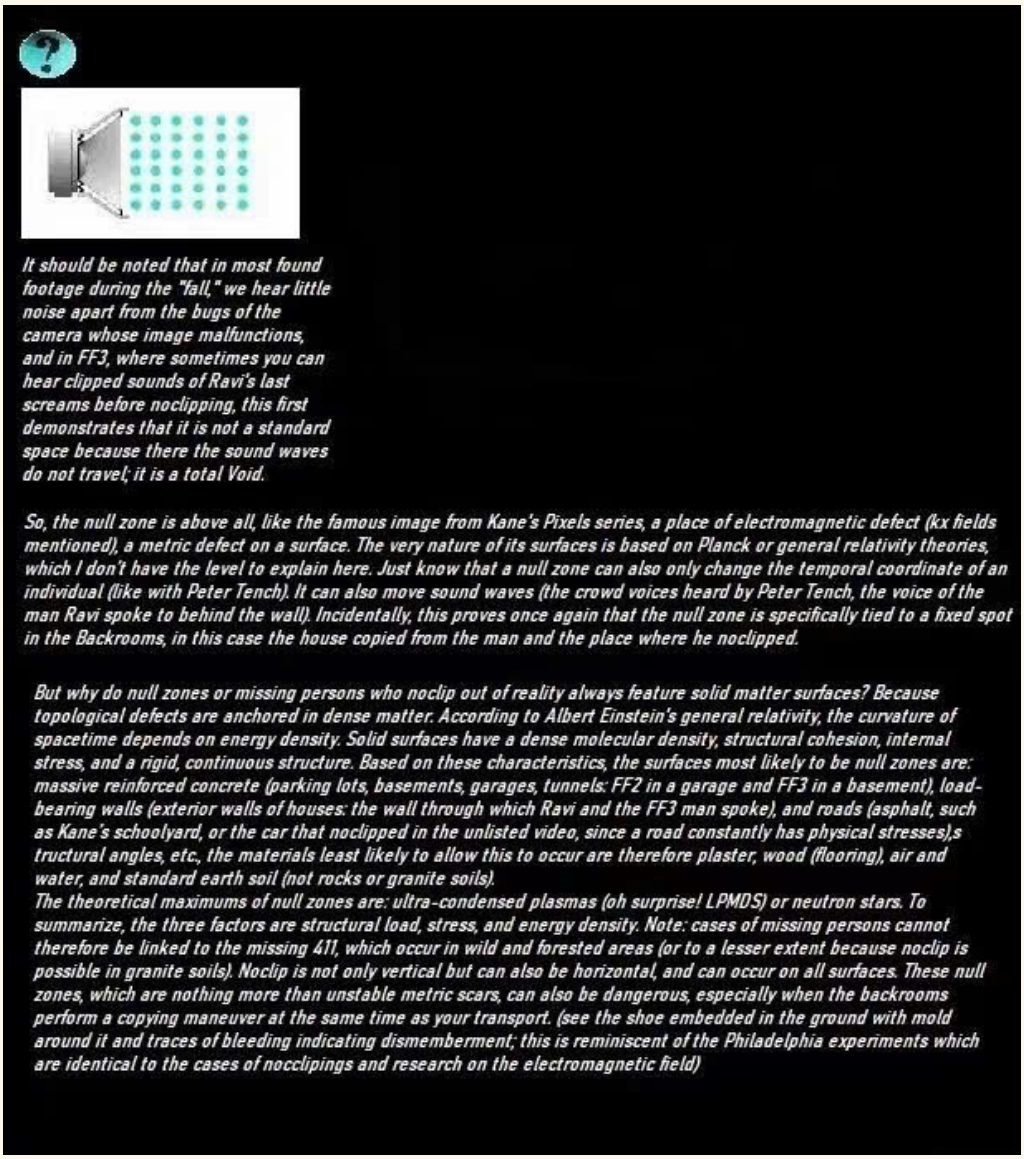
$$\text{jump (days)} = 189.4 \times e^{1.027 \times t}$$

where t is the length of the fall in seconds. The sheet names the space you fall through the "non-metric transition space" (NMTS). It plots Found Footage #1 at about 2.25 seconds and Found Footage #3 at about 3.85 seconds.

[OURS] The numbers check out as a fit. Kane's camera was lost on 4 July 1991 and recovered on 23 September 1996, which is 1,908 days, and the curve gives 1,910 at t = 2.25. The FF3 infographic estimates Ravi's jump as 27 years, about 9,862 days, and the curve gives 9,875 at t = 3.85. But a curve with two free numbers will always pass through two points, so this proves nothing about the shape. Any two points would fit an exponential, a straight line or a power law just as well. A third data point is needed, and the ones we have don't cooperate.

- **Found Footage #2.** The same author's sheet gives the garage fall as 1.76 seconds. The curve predicts a jump of about 1,154 days, a bit over three years. Nothing on screen tells us when her tape was found, and there's no sign of a jump that size.
- **Peter Tench.** He jumped 68 days without falling at all. He walked down a corridor. The curve can't give anything less than 189.4 days even for a zero second fall. To get 68 days you'd need a fall of minus one second.
- **What's being measured.** For Kane the 1,908 days isn't a jump that happened to him. It's how long his camera took to reach the real world, through a second null zone. Mixing that with Ravi's jump compares two different things.
- **Measuring the falls.** All three fall times come from edited, glitching footage. Kane cuts and breaks up the picture during falls on purpose, so screen time during a fall isn't a reliable clock.

[OURS] Our verdict is that it's a neat idea with no support yet. If Kane ever shows a fourth fall with a known date on both sides, it could be tested properly.



Fan sheet on the physics of null zones. It argues they're electromagnetic or "metric" defects tied to dense solid matter, with a reference to the Philadelphia Experiment.

[FAN] **The physics sheet** makes four claims. Sound doesn't carry during the fall, so the in-between is a total void. A null zone is an electromagnetic defect in space (it mentions "kx fields") that can shift a person's place in time, as with Tench, and can carry sound, as with the voices Tench heard and Ravi's conversation with the father. Null zones form in dense, stressed solid matter like reinforced concrete, load-bearing walls and roads, and not in plaster, wood, water or soil, because in general relativity energy density curves spacetime. And because of that, null zones shouldn't be connected to the "Missing 411" disappearances in the wilderness. It ends by comparing a shoe stuck in the ground with mould around it, which is the shoe half sunk into the floor of the house Ravi finds in Found Footage #3, to the Philadelphia Experiment.

[OURS] [SCIENCE] Some of this works as storytelling and some doesn't work as physics.

- **The silence.** In Found Footage #3 you can hear clipped fragments of Ravi's screams during the fall, which the sheet itself admits. Dropouts in a tape are a simpler explanation than a vacuum.

- **Density and relativity.** It's true that energy density curves spacetime. It's not true that concrete curves it noticeably more than wood. The dimensionless measure of how strongly a mass bends spacetime nearby is $GM/(rc^2)$. For a hundred tonnes of concrete seen from one metre away that comes to about 7×10^{-23}. For the whole Earth at its surface it's about 7×10^{-10}. A slab of concrete is four times denser than a plank, but four times almost nothing is still almost nothing.
- **A better reason for the pattern.** Null zones probably seem to favour basements and garages for a more ordinary reason. That's where people are, and where they keep cameras. And the seagull and the father's drywall are exceptions anyway.
- **The Philadelphia Experiment** is a 1943 legend about a US Navy ship made invisible and teleported. It's widely regarded as a hoax, and the Navy says it never happened. It's a good mood reference for Async, which also experimented with magnetism, but it isn't evidence.
- **Missing 411** is a series of books and films by David Paulides about people vanishing in national parks. Kane has never referred to it. The sheet's point that the Complex's openings cluster in built places rather than forests is fair as far as the episodes go.

Why null zones appeared

[CANON] [FAN] The series strongly implies that null zones are Async's fault. Missing persons climb sharply after 17 October 1989, and the fan wiki reads the Threshold's blueprint as describing the machine making a null zone of its own. TV Tropes points out that every dated video showing the Complex comes after the Threshold opened, and asks whether Async created the Backrooms in its current form or only woke it up.

[FAN] Against that, TV Tropes points to the Still Life in the wheelchair, which it describes as dressed in nineteenth-century clothes, as a sign the Complex had been copying the world for a long time. And Overflow's green glow in 1972 shows something was already there seventeen years earlier.

[KANE] Kane's own framing leaves room for both. He has described the Backrooms as something that could simply be nature if everyone agreed to leave it alone, and added that this would never happen (Wendigoon on set, 2026).

A Gazetteer of the Complex

This chapter lists every named or clearly identifiable place, inside and outside the Complex, grouped by where it sits and who found it. Area names in quotation marks are fan wiki names unless the footage gives one. Where the wiki's name and the footage disagree, both are given.

On the real side

Async Research Facility ("Standard") [CANON]. Async's headquarters on a hillside in San Jose. Damage Control mentions lower offices, empty labs next to storage, and an exit to the hillside where Tench died. Report shows corridors, an elevator and phones. Its basement level holds the KV31 control room, which looks onto the **Threshold Chamber** and the LPMDS. In the film it's where Mary is interrogated and scanned, and where Pirate Clark lies on a table.

Oak Ridge National Laboratory [CANON] [REAL]. A real Department of Energy laboratory in Tennessee, where the prototype was tested on 10 May 1982.

Cap'n Clark's Ottoman Empire [FILM]. Clark's furniture store at Capitol and McKee, San Jose, near the 680 freeway. Its basement holds the breaker box that grows red switches and the wall that becomes a doorway. Clark's maps and whiteboard end up down there too.

Mary's house [FILM]. Her modern house, where she holds the party, and her **childhood home**, being torn down by Reverchon Ventures, with her handprint in the concrete.

Phil's house [FILM]. Suburban, with a framed newspaper story about Async's MRI funding on the wall.

Ravi's apartment and the basement below [CANON]. A broken sliding glass door, a breached cinder block wall, and the hole he climbs through (Found Footage #3).

The garage [CANON]. Where the woman in Found Footage #2 tapes off the null zone.

The highway [CANON]. Seen on the traffic camera in 9780415263573.

The Threshold side

Threshold Outpost [CANON]. Covered in the previous chapter. Async's first building inside, with desks, windows, a blast door and a keycard door. Motion sensors turn the lights red.

Presentation area [CANON]. A stretch outside the Outpost dressed for the Department of Energy visit with concept art, stanchions, furniture and a table carrying a layout model of the nearby Complex (Presentation).

Main Chamber [CANON]. About a hundred metres square, a grid of cross-shaped pillars, the classic yellow look. Each corridor off it is a numbered division. "Lateral division A" is the row of cells nearest the Threshold.

The motion camera hallways [CANON]. Seven cameras along lateral division A on 5 March 1990. Camera 5 caught waving appendages at 03:53:42 on 6 March, and the last clip shows the tentacled entity (Motion Detected).

Unknown division [FAN]. The second division, besides Division 14, that the fan wiki says leads deeper in.

Division 14

[CANON] Async found Division 14 somewhere between First Contact and Pitfalls. Its rooms run in order.

Room 14A [CANON]. Named, little shown.

Room 14B [CANON]. Where Marvin's team was surveying on 6 May 1990. Afterwards the hallway leading to it was boarded up, shown in a timelapse in Report. The TV Tropes timeline says it was walled off because of the Lifeform.

Room 14C [CANON]. The site of Reunion on 25 May 1990, where Tench ambushes Mark, Marvin and Randall. Marvin finds it different from how he remembers, with white drywall walls, black vinyl skirting, changed proportions and moved ceiling tiles. The fan map below labels a second version "14C'".

Room 14D [CANON]. Classic architecture with a wooden door at the far end and a floor full of square pits in a five by seven grid. Discovered on 6 May 1990 by Marvin, Mark, George and Kim. Mark crossed it on the pit edges. Marvin slipped on a flat piece of carpet and fell. Later Async built a walkway across it, covering about half the pits, and a steel frame with a winch over one pit to lower people to the street below.

Room 14D-22A [CANON] [FAN]. Where Marvin landed, down the twenty-second pit. Near the chute it looks like the classic Backrooms, with wooden skirting along floors and walls and randomly placed lights. Further away it looks more like an office. The wallpaper is a little greener. The fan wiki notes that most of the other pits are dead ends or lead into the same room, because 14D-22A has a ceiling where the other holes should come through.

The red street, "14D-22B" or "14D + 228" [CANON] [CONFLICT]. The red-lit neighbourhood Marvin reached through a low gap under a distorted hallway, with houses that lose track of being houses, a mirrored traffic sign in a "living room", trees, street lamps and a road tunnel. The whiteboard in Static Dead End labels a drawing of it "14D + 228". The fan wiki calls it Room 14D-22B, the Red Neighbourhood. The whiteboard reading may be the same label written differently.



The red street from Pitfalls, supplied with this commission. The street lamps on the right give ordinary white light. The red comes from low on the left, lighting the trees, the house fronts and the rim of the tunnel, and throwing red pools across the road.

The door at the end of 14D [CANON]. Mark saw green light through it in Pitfalls. In Static Dead End it leads to a corridor where the wallpaper is stretching sideways, with tape squares stuck along it to measure the effect.

The Static Dead End [CANON]. The fifth and last room of Division 14 on the fan wiki's count. Half classic wallpaper, half tiles like the pool area. A football, plastic chairs, a table and a couch are sunk partway into the floor and walls. Patches of floor sag and bulge, and a hump of carpet at the end carries a single lawn chair. The fan wiki says it has one accessible pit. Kim showed it to George on 29 May 1990.

Tench's route (Informational Video)

The leafy corridor and the barn [CANON]. Where Tench wandered on 1 March 1990 before being thrown forward to 8 May. A hallway papered in green leaf print, wheelbarrows and a sledgehammer lying about, and the front of a barn. The fan map calls it the "fake farm".

The wall with voices [CANON]. Where the camera operator listens to what sounds like people talking behind a wall, just before he's separated.

Found Footage (1991)

The Corridors [CANON]. The looping yellow corridors where Kane first lands and the Lifeform chases him, gliding through pillars in a T-pose that Kane later called early weirdness rather than canon.

The Staircase Room [CANON]. The dark room Kane drops into through a hole in the carpet, with a lit staircase, a laundry room, a dark room and a closet. It's copied from a well-known liminal photograph. Ravenholm ambience from Half-Life 2 plays here. The fan wiki says the stairs lead up to the Gallery Area, and that Kane once showed a Blender map on Discord linking this room to Found Footage #2's Household Area, which isn't confirmed as canon.

The Heathrow courtyard [CANON]. A window onto the atrium of the Holiday Inn Express at London Heathrow, with two figures briefly at a window. The real hotel opened in 2018.

The dark hallway and the slope [CANON]. The long, unevenly lit hallway with bays on one side, a square tunnel with a ladder in one wall, and the narrow gap opening onto a steep slope down which the camera finally goes, coming out high in the air in the real world. Fans call the hallway's film twin Junction 3.

Found Footage #2 (1995)

Household Area [CANON]. Rooms that copy a modern home badly. A beige room with round lights and a kitchen hood over no cooker, a dining table and chairs far too tall, a room with one large column, a couch and a sunken floor, and a room with a door and a jagged hole broken through the floor with steel supports sticking out. Through the keyhole of that door the woman sees white walls and wooden floors leading to a staircase lined with doors, which the fan wiki calls the Empty Gallery Area.

The rising hallway [CANON]. A corridor that climbs like a staircase with no steps.

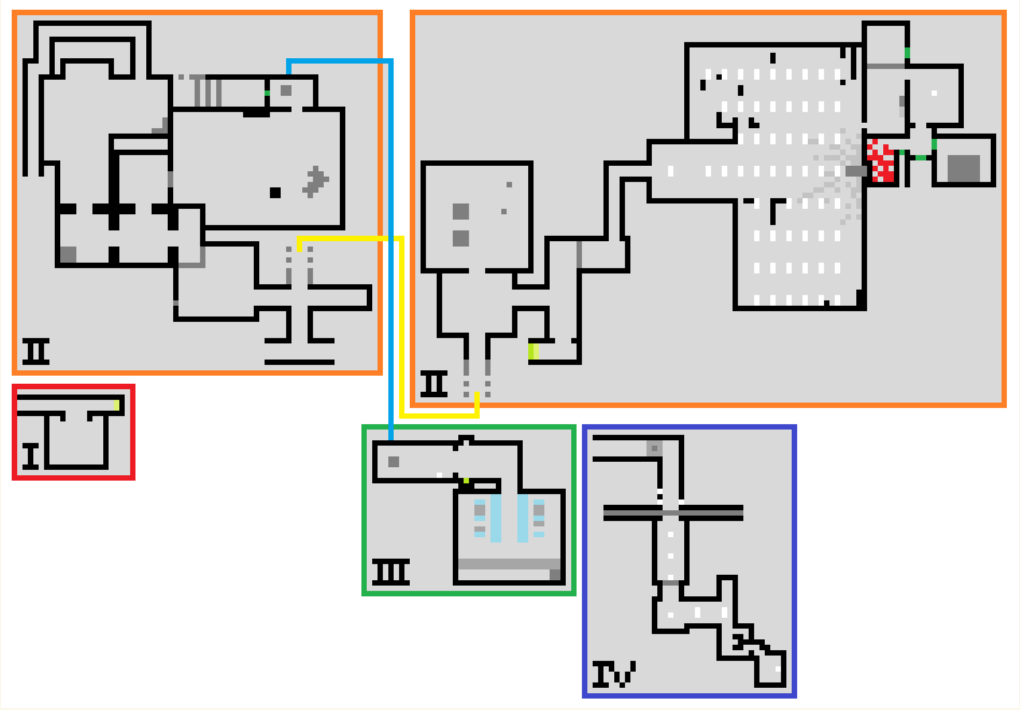
The great hall [CANON]. A space the size of a hospital or shopping centre, ceiling tiles fallen, black mould along every edge, green light over one part. Round a corner is the burnt-out car from the highway, crashed into a wall, with handprints and a trail of blood leading away.

The vine room [CANON]. Where the trail leads, a room covered in dark growth that turns out to be the Lifeform.

Tiled Pool Area [CANON]. Reached by lowering herself through the jagged hole. White tiles on every surface, pools with metal rails, lights that glow green down a hallway as the Lifeform closes in. A ladder at

the end leads back up to the classic Backrooms. According to the fan wiki, Kane has said his pool rooms come mainly from his own dreams rather than from Jared Pike's renders.

The last room [CANON]. The dead end where she's cornered while the walls move and green light breaks through the cracks.



Fan pixel map in four numbered zones, supplied with this commission. It appears to trace Found Footage #2, with zone III holding pools. The maker and the exact intent aren't known, so the reading of the zones is ours.

Found Footage #3

Classroom Area [CANON]. Where Ravi drops out of a cabinet. A stool on a desk too low for it, a chair with an absurdly tall back, a long table blocking a doorway, a door opening on a brick wall, and a hole into a household area.

Furniture Store Room [CANON]. Rooms of displayed furniture with an "exit" door into more rooms and an outpost. After the film it's hard not to connect this with the copies of Clark's store, but nothing on screen says it's his.

The office and the skywalk [CANON]. An office littered with empty water jugs, then an enclosed walkway between two buildings with windows onto the Red City.

The Red Outdoors and the Red City [CANON]. See its own section below.

The playground set [CANON]. Past a balcony, a stage-set version of outside with a tiled path, green carpet for grass, a street lamp, a slide, and the shell of a building that's only a front. Its lights come on while Ravi is there. The fan wiki calls it the Playroom Area and links it by hallway to the classic Backrooms.

The roofless apartment [CANON]. Sockets, radiator and kitchen, but bricked-up windows and no ceiling, only brick walls rising to a big light. From a ladder Ravi sees a seated Buddhist statue with its back to him.

Foreign Music Area and the dance studio [CANON]. Narrow corridors to a mirrored dance studio playing the Chinese song "煤气灶" ("Gas Stove"), with a USC Arcadia Hospital health flyer dated 2022 on the wall.

The Recording Studio [CANON]. A huge room with a tower going up and down out of sight, every level carrying a painting of a smiling sun in splendour, and mixing desks, keyboards and microphone stands scattered about. Ravi records a call for help on the radio set here.

The drum kit room [CANON]. Green carpet, a drum kit, a pot plant and a remote control car, with a door looping back to the playground.

Speaker Room [CANON] [FAN]. The filthy den where the Still Life rises off the floor and charges, with the song "Still Life" coming from speakers.

Old Attic [CANON]. An attic-like space where something small and black grows from under a skirting board.

The shrine room [CANON]. Stop signs, wet floor signs, and a picture of Mao Zedong ringed with candles.

Concrete corridors and the Conference Office Area [CANON]. Industrial corridors, closet doors opening into an office, then tall windows onto the Red City again, with a giant road sign standing on end among the trees, pointing up.

The skylight room [CANON]. Six chairs under a skylight, seen first directly and later from above through a gap, with a book or brick balanced at the gap's edge.

The caveman hallway [CANON]. A long hallway with a cardboard caveman standing alone in the middle, the same cutout Async later wires with a speaker.

The house in the blue box [CANON]. A whole house inside a room painted blue with white blotches for sky. Clothes all over the ground, burn marks and smears running toward a dark tunnel, and a grey human figure half sunk into the floor holding a phone to its ear. Inside, the house is nearly perfect, with utensils, a whiskey bottle, a knocked-over chair, black footprints, a lamp, a mounted fish, and one shoe half stuck in the floor with black marks around it. Its front door opens onto brick.



The house in the blue box from Found Footage #3, supplied with this commission. The painted sky, the scattered clothes and the porch are all visible.

The father's house [CANON]. Not in the Complex at all, or not only. Ravi talks through a wall to a man in a real house who thinks someone is in his walls. A TV advert on his side dates to 2007 to 2009. When the man breaks the wall to help, he's heard falling in.

The Kelowna Branch (the film and Everything Must Go)

[FILM] [FAN] The **Kelowna Branch**, KLWNA on Async's labels, is the region joined to Clark's basement. Async reached it from their side before Clark ever found it. Kelowna is a city in British Columbia, where the film was shot.

The Everything Must Go room [CANON]. Three identical closing-down sale signs, each smaller and sunk further into the floor than the one before. Async cut through the wall on 19 June 1990 to find the predicted fourth and broke into a maze-like copy of a furniture store.

KLWNA Outpost, or the Secluded Outpost [FILM] [FAN]. An Async base far from the Threshold in classic-looking rooms with arched doorways, Async tools, a corridor with guide cables, and a hallway full of furniture and crossing store signs. Naren dies near here.

Junction 3 [FILM] [FAN]. The long hallway with bays on one side, where the cardboard caveman stands and where Naren hid his duffel bag of Async data and his ID card. Clark finds the bag.

Piled Laundry Area [FILM] [FAN]. Reached by a "trash chute" sloping down at 24.5 degrees. Rooms heaped with clothes, rubbish, furniture and things that can't be identified, with a cast concrete crawl space where ceiling panels are missing. This is where Bobby is lowered and where "Still Life" plays from the intercom.

Christmas Tree Room [FILM]. A dark room with a decorated tree, a music box playing "Feliz Navidad", and three or more human-looking figures. It's where Clark first meets the Redheaded and ALS Still Lifes.

Tiled Pool Area [FILM]. A drained, grimy version of the pools Clark flees through, with the Rolling Giant's face briefly visible through Bobby's camera.

Household Area and the Cramped Couch Room [FILM] [FAN]. Domestic copies along Clark's routes.

CCTV-Monitored Room [FILM] [FAN]. Watched by an Async camera, which Clark later destroys. A square crawl space behind a fake wall leads to the Throne Room.

The Throne Room [FILM]. Pirate Clark's lair beneath the store copy, full of foul clothes and blood, with a giant copy of Bobby's "End Apartheid" shirt and shoes around the copied throne. Clark's mural is near it.

The three store copies [FILM] [FAN]. A maze built from the store's own materials, an accurate interior copy whose entrance has been walled off and whose caveman is wired to gas cylinders, and an inside-out copy with both inside and outside. TV Tropes adds that the copy has a huge pit directly beneath it, and a much smaller pit with a flimsy door leading up from the pit room into the copy's basement. Square pits keep marking the way to somewhere very different, in the series and in the film. [OURS] Frames supplied with this commission show the accurate interior brightly lit, and the inside-out and maze copies dark. The testing chapter of Part VIII works through all three.

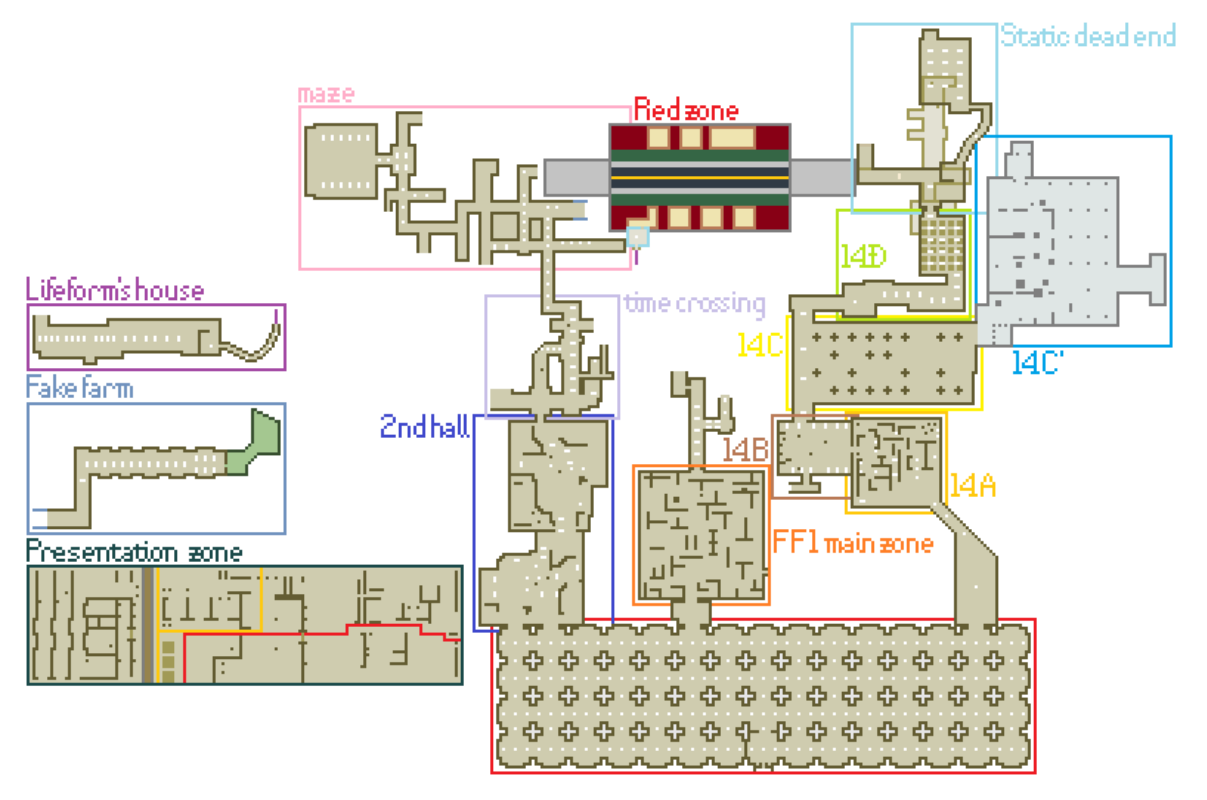
The dining room [FILM]. Where Clark holds his dinner with the Still Lifes and ties Mary to a chair. Jazz plays on a crackly record, and the fan wiki says a reversed "You Can't Forget" sits under it.

The chasm [FILM]. The ledge Mary edges along during the chase.

Recycle Bookstore [FILM]. A bookstore with pyramid shelving in the closing montage, named on the fan wiki.

Mary's old home [FILM]. In the closing montage, a copy of her childhood house with the handprints restored.

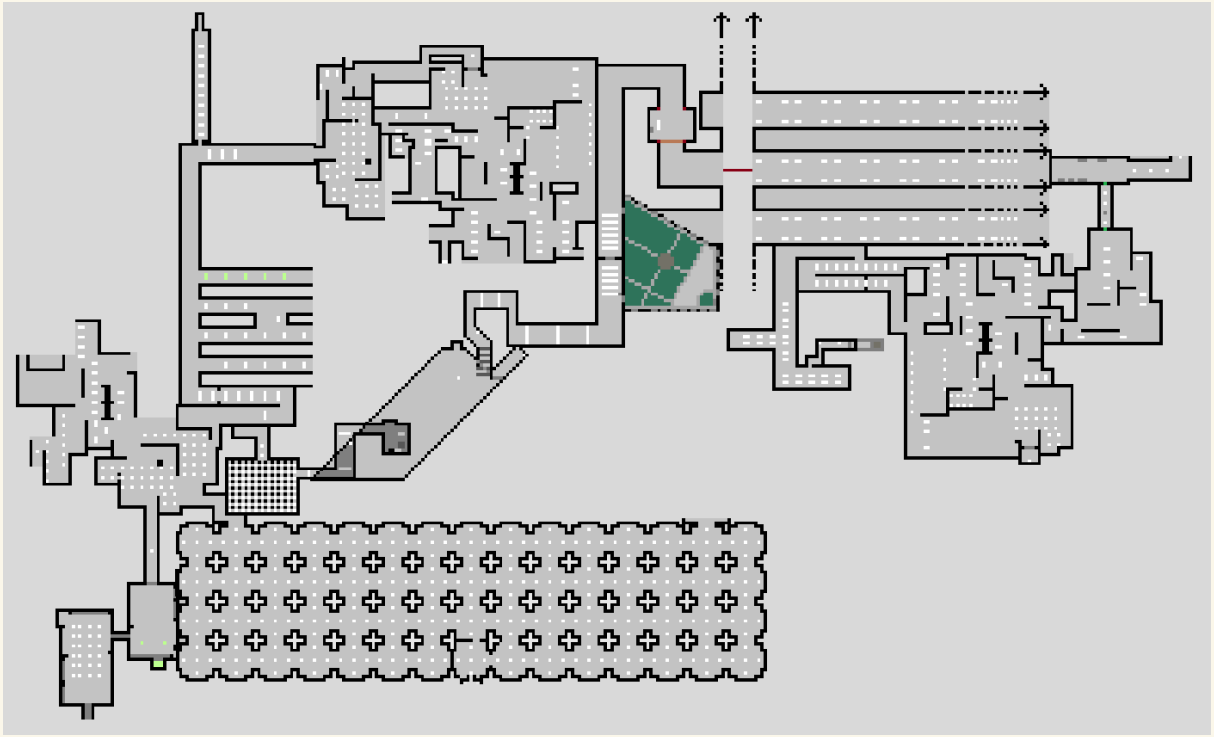
Fan maps of the whole



Fan pixel map linking many areas, supplied with this commission. Its labels are the maker's own.

[FAN] The map above tries to join Async's areas into one plan. A large hall of cross-shaped pillars at the bottom is the Main Chamber. Above it sit the "FF1 main zone" and Rooms 14A to 14D, with 14C' as a second state of 14C and the Static Dead End at the top right. A "Red zone" with a road and houses connects to a "maze" on the left, with a "time crossing" and a "2nd hall" below that. Three insets stand apart, labelled "Lifeform's house", "Fake farm" and "Presentation zone".

[OURS] Much of this is guesswork the footage can't support. Nothing on screen links Kane's 1991 rooms to Async's divisions, and the red street is reached down a pit, not across a floor. As a way of keeping track of what's been seen, though, it's useful, and its idea that 14C exists in two states matches Reunion.



A second fan pixel map, supplied with this commission, with a pillar hall at the bottom, a diagonal ramp, a green patch like the playground set, and a many-lane road running off the edge.

[FAN] This one centres on a road of many lanes running off the map, with a green park-like patch beside it, a long diagonal ramp, a tall shaft, a grid-hatched square that looks like Room 14D's pits, and the pillar hall again at the bottom. It reads as an attempt to place the Red City's road and the playground set relative to the Main Chamber.

The Red City

[CANON] Ravi sees it twice in Found Footage #3, first from the skywalk and later from the Conference Office windows. It's a city at night with lit office towers, trees and a road, under a starry sky, and everything that isn't a light source is drenched in red. He laughs until he wheezes. The second time, a giant road sign stands on its end among the trees.

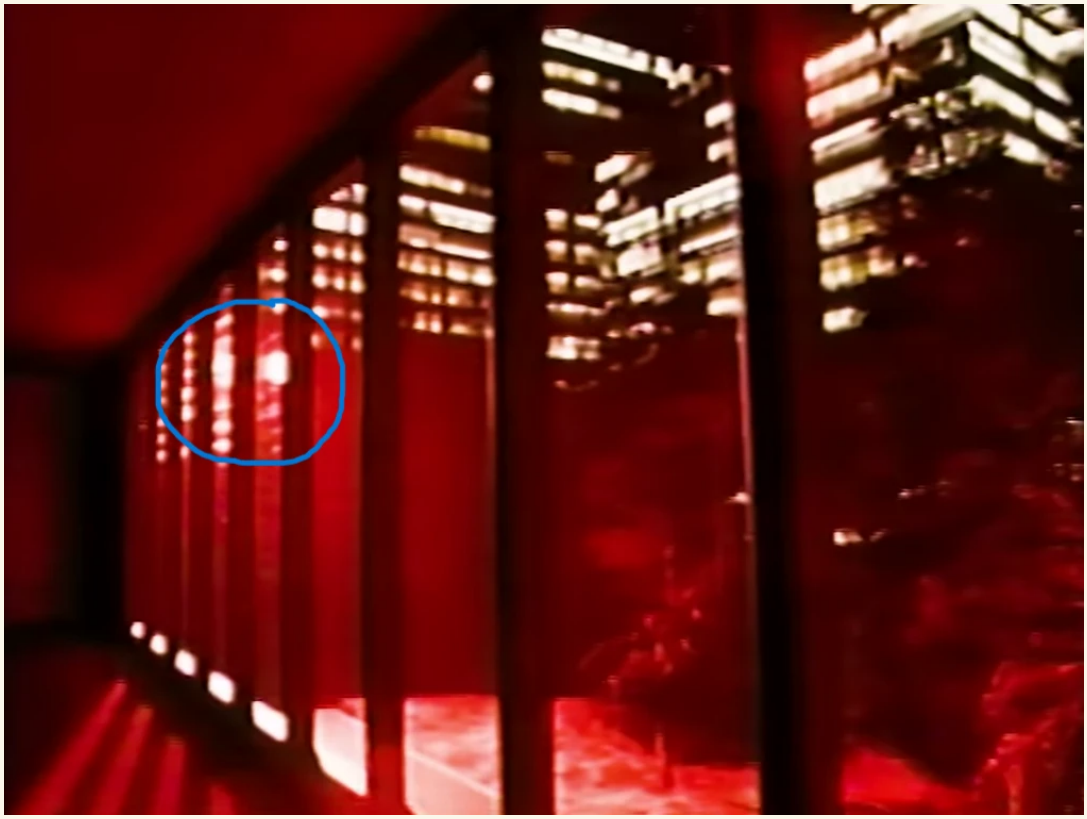
[FAN] The fan wiki files it under the "Red Outdoors", an area that tries to imitate the outdoors and gets it wrong. It notes that the skywalks pass through flat walls painted or lit as sky, that the whole city seems enclosed in a giant box like a video game skybox, that the building windows look like glowing pictures rather than rooms, and that the stars may be electric lights. TV Tropes' fridge page reads it as a copy of a Chinese city, pointing to the Mao shrine, the Chinese flyer and the Chinese song nearby.



The Red City from the skywalk in Found Footage #3, supplied with this commission.

[CANON] **Kane's own music.** One track on the Not Kane Pixels Backrooms soundtrack is called "Red Sun in the Sky". Nobody has tied it to a specific scene, but no other part of the series has a red sky.

Your hypothesis, the floodlights



The Red City frame you marked, with your blue circle around what you think are two round floodlights giving off the red light.

[YOURS] You noticed two round, bright spots in the left-hand panes of the skywalk, inside the blue circle, and proposed that they're **floodlights**, and that they're what's giving the Red City its red light.

[OURS] Looking closely at that frame, at the second Red City view, and at the red street in Pitfalls, here's what the footage shows.

- **The red isn't in the camera or the glass.** The office windows in the towers glow warm white and yellow, not red. If the camera, the tape or the skywalk glass were tinting everything, those windows would be red too. So the red belongs to the light falling on things that don't make their own light, the skywalk ceiling, the window frames, the trees and the ground.
- **The red light has a direction.** In the Pitfalls street, the ordinary street lamps on the right give white light, while the red comes in low from the left. It lights the trees and house fronts from that side, lights the rim of the tunnel, and lays separate red pools across the road. That's what a coloured lamp or floodlight off to one side does, and not what a red sky does. In the Red City frames, one edge of a window frame glows bright red as if lit from outside, and the trees on the right are lit red from in front.
- **The marked spots look like lamps.** Inside your circle are two rounded blobs, side by side at the same height, brighter and rounder than the rectangular office windows around them. Each has a near-white middle and a red rim. That's how a very bright coloured light looks on a camcorder. The centre overloads every colour channel and goes white, and only the fringe shows the true colour.
- **There has to be a lamp somewhere.** If the fan wiki is right that the city sits inside a box with walls standing in for sky, then there's no sun. The light has to come from fixtures inside the box.
- **It fits how the Complex fakes the outdoors.** Every other fake outside in the series is lit by fittings. The playground set has its own street lamp and lights that switch on while Ravi is there, and the house in the blue box sits under a painted sky in a lit room. A copied place lit by a pair of big red lamps would be in keeping.

[OURS] There are other ways to read the circled spots, and they should be ruled out before calling it settled.

- **Reflections.** The skywalk interior is red-lit as well. Lights inside the walkway reflected in the glass would show up as round bright spots at regular positions pane after pane, and there's a regular row of bright spots along the bottom of the panes in the same frame. Two spots side by side in neighbouring panes could even be one lamp reflected twice.
- **Bloom.** The footage is blurred and processed to look like tape, and a tight cluster of bright windows could smear into a round glow.
- **One frame isn't enough.** The circled spots are tiny and soft.

[OURS] The way to test it is motion. As Ravi walks, a reflection in the glass slides along with him, while a lamp far outside barely moves against the buildings. If the two spots hold still relative to the towers across several frames, they're out there in the city. Checking whether the same spots appear in the second view from the Conference Office windows would help too. On the "Red Sun in the Sky" title, one more thought. The circled spots are low, at about the height of the middle floors of the towers, not high overhead. So if Kane's red sun is meant literally, the Complex's version of a sun may be just this, a pair of lamps on poles. That's speculation on our part.

[OURS] Our verdict is that the red light almost certainly comes from coloured lamps aimed at the scene rather than from the sky, the camera or the glass, which supports the core of your hypothesis. Whether the two spots you circled are those lamps, or reflections of lamps inside the skywalk, is a coin toss on one frame and needs the motion test.

[OURS] The working theory takes this further in its dusk theory, under Law 3. The red lamps stand in for the light of a sun that had just set, which is why their red comes in low from one side under a sky already dark with stars.

What Lives There

The common thread

[FAN] TV Tropes points out what makes the Complex's creatures dangerous. They're good at seeming human. The Lifeform copies voices, the thing in Found Footage #3 knocks politely, and Still Lifes go through human motions. Anyone who falls in assumes they're in some huge hidden building that must have other people in it, so a voice calling for help or a knock on a door is exactly what they want to hear.

[CANON] Two distinct kinds of creature have been shown, the **Lifeform** and the **Still Lifes**, plus a handful of things that might be either or neither. Kane has confirmed the first two are completely separate (TV Tropes, from Discord).

The Lifeform



The Lifeform in the original thumbnail of Found Footage.

[KANE] **The name.** The episodes never name it. Kane consistently calls it "the Lifeform" in interviews and on Discord. Async's researchers nickname it "Marvin's Friend" in Reunion. Fans also call it Bacteria, after the title Kane gave his first published picture of it on Ko-fi.

[CANON] **Appearances.**

Episode	What's seen
Found Footage (1991)	A very tall, thin, dark figure with long wiry limbs chases Kane, roaring. Later a second, quieter one with a different shape and softer calls pulls him back from the chute
Motion Detected (6 March 1990)	Heard roaring on the cameras. Camera 5 records waving limbs
Pitfalls (6 May 1990)	It calls "hello?" and "can anybody hear me?" in a human voice from a hole at the end of a hallway, then deepens its voice and charges, screeching. Marvin outruns it
Found Footage #2 (1995)	A room covered in dark vine-like growth that moves. It chases the woman through the household rooms and the pools with great persistence, and green light grows as it closes in

[CANON] **Body.** Tall and stick-thin, with very long arms and legs like wire or vines, far stronger than they look. It stomps heavily despite its thin legs. The woman in Found Footage #2 mistakes one for a plant. The fan wiki says it isn't really black but a fleshy red, and only looks black because of the tape effects and heavy editing.

[CANON] **Biology.** The clues all point to bacteria. The young man found in February 1990 was partly overgrown with a mutated hay bacillus, his decay oddly halted in places. In Found Footage #2 a trail of

growth leads from the crashed car to the room where the Lifeform waits, and there's no sign of the driver. Ravi sees something small and black growing out from under a skirting board.

[KANE] Kane has said repeatedly on Discord that the Lifeform is not a human transformed or zombified by the bacteria, but its life cycle does seem to involve human remains (TV Tropes). Sketches he posted on Discord seem to show them growing in place like plants until they become mobile.

[CANON] **Behaviour.** It hides just out of sight, approaches silently, imitates human voices to draw people in, and charges with a roar once seen. If it loses its prey it keeps scanning quietly, as if to make them think they've escaped. The one in Pitfalls doesn't follow Marvin back into the room he fell into. The one in Found Footage #2 doesn't give up.

[KANE] In the first video it glides through pillars in a stiff T-pose. Kane has said that was early weirdness from a video made as a standalone tech demo and shouldn't be taken as canon (TV Tropes).

[FILM] **Absent from the film.** The Lifeform doesn't appear and isn't mentioned. TV Tropes suggests it was left out to keep the film focused on the Still Lifes rather than introduce two kinds of monster at once. Pirate Clark takes its role as the tall, slow, relentless thing in the dark.

[FAN] **Readings.** A colony organism, a "worm that walks" made of bacterial structures that may use its victims' bodies. A cordyceps-like growth from corpses. Wendigoon's version is that it behaves like a bacterial colony with a life cycle, and that it and the Still Lifes act like the Complex's immune system. A TV Tropes theory that it turned victims into more Lifeforms was ruled out by Kane.

The tentacled thing

[CANON] At the very end of Motion Detected, something with what look like two big tentacles curls round a corner on camera. Nothing else is known. Both fan wikis fold it into the Lifeform's page, and one suggests it's an earlier stage that later builds itself a more human-shaped frame. TV Tropes leaves it as a separate unknown.

The knocker in Found Footage #3

[CANON] After Ravi shuts a door behind him, something knocks on it gently, like a person. He tells it to leave him alone. It breaks the door down. The song "Still Life" had been playing in what seems to be its den just before.

[FILM] [FAN] The film all but answers who it was. Pirate Clark knocks on a door the same way before smashing it in, and "Still Life" plays in the Still Life dens in the film too. Most fans now take the knocker to be a Still Life, probably the same one Ravi meets in the Speaker Room. Whether it knocked to trick Ravi or because it knew that people knock but not how doors work is open.

Still Lifes

What they are

[FILM] Clark's explanation is the only one anyone gives. The place builds them, or rather remembers them, and the more times it remembers something, the less it does. Somewhere out there is a real man in a striped shirt, and in here he's been remembered slightly wrong. It's like drawing a dog without knowing what a dog looks like.

[FILM] Each one seems to be copied from a particular person at a particular moment. Pirate Clark is Clark on the day of the commercial, in costume. Mary's copy is Mary in custody at Async, in the tank top they gave her. The film never shows the moment of copying.

[KANE] Kane has said the Complex isn't picking moments out of people's minds (TV Tropes YMMV). And in his commentary he explained that Clark kept Kat's head in the hope the Complex would remember her and make a Still Life of her, which is Clark's theory, not necessarily the truth.

Their bodies

[FILM] Their faces are where the copying fails worst. There are extra eyes, two faces merged at an angle, a face split down the middle with two noses, or several views of one head fused together. Six fingers on a hand is common. Inside there are no bones or organs, just a white mush like porridge, rice or furniture stuffing. Clark eats it. They don't seem to feel pain. Async's gas, which knocked Mary out almost instantly, does nothing to Pirate Clark, presumably because there's no real biology inside for it to act on. They aren't invincible, though. Clark tears one open with his hands, and Pirate Clark's peg snaps with one blow.

[FAN] TV Tropes offers a reason faces suffer most. A living body has more detail packed into less space than a room does, so any copy loses more.

Their minds

[FILM] It varies a lot. The bearded one barely reacts to anything. The red-haired one attacks when startled, then goes almost catatonic, until Pirate Clark appears and she panics. The one in the wheelchair answers to being spoken to and switches his lamp on when the lights go off, apparently understanding what Clark wants. Pirate Clark hunts, patrols a territory, and lived alongside Clark for days before eating him. Clark says he tried to teach the red-haired one to turn off the lights and it went nowhere.

[CANON] [FILM] Hostile Still Lifes make filthy dens of rubbish and clothes, and "Still Life" plays from speakers or intercoms in them, in 1990 and in Ravi's time alike.

The ones we know

The Speaker Room Still Life [CANON]. Found Footage #3. It rises off the floor in the dark and charges. Something like a man in a dark jacket over a white shirt, pale face dark down one side, an arm too thin, a head that swings too much, sometimes running on all fours. Ravi escapes through a crawl space. It's quick and agile, unlike the slow ones in the film.

The Redheaded Still Life [FILM]. Played by Rhiannon Roberts and named only in the credits. A woman in a red business suit whose face looks like several angles of a portrait merged into one. She shrieks and lurches at Clark in the Christmas tree room. Later Clark scalps her to make a wig for Mary when he forces Mary to play Barbara, and she doesn't react. When Pirate Clark comes she runs screaming into a corner and keeps scrabbling at it as if there were a way out. [FAN] Many think she's a copy of Barbara, Clark's ex-wife, though the film doesn't show Barbara clearly enough to compare.

Archibald Leland Sutter (ALS) [FILM]. Played by Dana Mahmood and named only in the credits. A young man fused to an old-fashioned wheelchair, legs attached haphazardly to the front, dressed in what TV Tropes calls nineteenth-century style, with a lamp on his chair that he switches on and off. When Pirate Clark kills Clark he flicks the lamp frantically. [FAN] TV Tropes notes that his initials spell ALS, a disease that often puts people in wheelchairs, and says Archibald, Leland and Sutter are lamp companies. The Complex seems to have kept the idea of a wheelchair and lost its purpose, so he's literally in it. His old clothes have been read as a sign that the Complex was copying people long before 1989.

The Bearded Still Life [FILM]. Played by Patrick Baynham. Three pairs of eyes, two on the cheeks and two on the forehead. He sits at Clark's table and doesn't react when Clark stabs him to show that Still Lifes feel no pain, or when Clark pulls pieces off him to eat. He doesn't even react to Pirate Clark.

Pirate Clark [FILM]. Played by Robert Bobroczkyi, built on Chiwetel Ejiofor's likeness. Clark in his commercial costume, remembered as a towering, wire-thin giant with bulging eyes and a permanently miserable face. The table leg strapped to Clark's knee has become a real peg leg made of a chair leg, with

no real leg behind it, and it's as flimsy as the furniture it came from. The hat is part of its head, so Async had to scalp it to take the hat off. It's the only Still Life that bleeds like a person. It knocks before smashing doors in. It kills Naren in the cold open and Bobby on the expedition, presumably Kat as well, and finally Clark, biting into his shoulder as he tries to calm it. Its lair under the store copy has foul clothes, blood, shoes, a giant copy of Bobby's "End Apartheid" shirt, and no bodies. Mary snaps its peg with a hat stand, smashes her concrete handprint into its face until the concrete breaks, and leads it into Async's gas trap. The last we see, it's lying on a table in Async's lab with the crown of its head cut away.

Mary's Still Life [FILM]. Played by Renate Reinsve. Sitting in a copy of Async's interview room, in the tank top Async gave her, staring at its lap. A face split down the middle with two noses, six fingers on the right hand gripping the left arm. Less distorted than most.

The man in the striped shirt [FILM]. Mentioned by Clark as an example and never shown.

The figures in the Christmas tree room [FILM]. Three or more human-looking figures round the tree, which the fan wiki calls statues.

A hazmat Still Life [SUPP] [FAN]. The inner sleeve of the film's soundtrack on vinyl shows a Still Life in an Async hazmat suit. Fans who believe Still Lifes are copied at a person's most intense moment have guessed it's Mark Blume, who was shot in Room 14C (TV Tropes YMMV).

Other strange things

The grey figure by the blue-box house [CANON]. In Found Footage #3, half sunk into the floor in front of the house, a solid grey human figure like a statue holds a phone to its ear. [OURS] It may be an unfinished or failed Still Life, like the half-made Static Dead End room, or a copy of a statue.

The seagull [FILM]. In the cold open a seagull bursts out of nowhere, crashes to the floor, lies still, then suddenly comes back to life and flies off. [FAN] TV Tropes reads it as a real bird that clipped in mid-flight, and worries about what happens when a null zone opens in the path of a plane. The ARG had bulletin board posts about seagulls gathering at a store's car park after someone dumped rubbish there. [OURS] Its dead-then-alive moment could also make it a copied bird, the only non-human Still Life shown, but that's a guess. Kane's answer when asked about animals in the Backrooms was to ask what counts as an animal (Smosh, 2024).

Voices behind walls [CANON]. The voices in Informational Video, Kat's voice through the tiles, and the father's voice through the wall are all people, or at least sound like people. The first is unexplained.

The Rolling Giant [FILM]. The face of the papier-mâché figure from The Oldest View shows up briefly through Bobby's camera in the pool section. It's a cameo rather than a creature.

What the creatures have in common

[OURS] Lining up every creature shown so far, a few things hold for all of them.

- None is native in the way an animal is native to a habitat. The Lifeform seems to grow out of what falls in. Still Lifes are copies of people who were near the Complex.
- All of them get human things slightly wrong. Voices without people, knocking without understanding doors, a wheelchair grown into a body, a costume grown into a skin.
- All the hostile ones hunt by sound and approach. Async's response, from cameras that wake on noise to speakers in cardboard cutouts, uses the same weakness.
- The film's Still Lifes are slower and less hostile than the one in Found Footage #3. Whether that's a difference between individuals, or a sign that Still Lifes change over time, isn't known.

Time Slips and the Green Glow

Every time anomaly on record

[CANON] The Complex doesn't keep the same time as the world. People come out later than they went in, and things turn up inside years before they exist outside. The fan wiki keeps a list. Here's every case found for this book, in the order they happen in the story.

Story date	Episode	What's out of place	How far
1 March to 8 May 1990	Informational Video, Presentation, Damage Control	Peter Tench vanishes at about 12:25 pm on 1 March and walks back into the Threshold Outpost at 5:30 pm on 8 May. About thirty minutes of his tape come after the jump, and from his side he was gone a few hours at most	68 days and 5 hours forward
"29 February 1990"	Informational Video's description	A date that didn't exist, since 1990 wasn't a leap year. Later episodes say 1 March	none, or a date only the Complex has
6 May 1990	Pitfalls	Marvin's radio picks up MGMT's "Kids" (released 2008) and an ABC News interview with Cuba's foreign minister Bruno Rodríguez Parrilla (2015)	18 and 25 years ahead
undated, after 10 Jan 1991	Simpsons	A tape of "Bart Gets Hit by a Car", first aired 10 January 1991, broken into by a Spanish-language ad for Dimacol cough medicine that ran in Mexico around 2000	about 9 years
4 July 1991	Found Footage	A window onto the atrium of the Holiday Inn Express at London Heathrow, which opened in 2018	27 years ahead
4 July 1991 to 23 Sep 1996	Found Footage	Kane's camera comes back out through another null zone and is recovered more than five years after it was shot	5 years, 2 months
undated	Found Footage #3	A USC Arcadia Hospital health flyer dated 2022 in the dance studio	depends on Ravi's date
undated	Found Footage #3	Through the wall, the father's television plays a freecreditreport.com ad from 2007 to 2009	the father may be years ahead of Ravi
June to July 1990	the film	The ALS Still Life dresses in what looks like nineteenth-century style	backwards, if it's a copy of an old person
June to July 1990	the film	Cars from the 2000s in the background outside the store	likely a production slip, but some fans count it

[FAN] The fan infographic on Found Footage #3 supplied with this commission dates Ravi's fall to 19 April 1995 and works out a jump of 27 years from the 2022 flyer. Nothing on screen gives Ravi's date directly, so this is an estimate.

[CONFLICT] **Overflow's date.** The fan wiki says Beck signed the report on 2 August 1972. Wendigoon gives 4 August 1972, the peak of that month's solar storm. Overflow's description gives no date. The fan wiki reads its date off the signed document itself, which makes 2 August the stronger reading, though either way the experiment falls inside that storm.

Patterns

[OURS] Lining these up shows a few things.

- **Almost everything misplaced comes from the future.** The Heathrow atrium, the 2022 flyer, the 2008 song, the 2015 interview, the 2000 advert and the 2007 to 2009 commercial all appear before they exist. The only things that look older than their surroundings are the ALS Still Life's clothes and the 1970s light fittings, and old fittings aren't strange in a building.
- **People only go forward.** Tench jumped two months ahead. Kane's camera came out five years later. No one has gone back.
- **Leaks happen at thin places.** Tench was listening to voices through a wall when he was thrown forward. Marvin's radio caught the future while he was down a pit. Ravi heard a future television through a wall that turned out to be a null zone. Wendigoon draws the same link. A thinning of the barrier, then a flash or burst that throws someone in, or forward.
- **Sound and signals leak more than people do.** Radio, television and voices cross time much more often than bodies.

[FAN] Wendigoon's summary is that the Complex is a jumble of different places from different times in one place. He then admits that doesn't fully make sense either, because if it simply mixed times you'd expect more from the past than the future. Our table agrees with his doubt.

Tench's jump, in numbers

[SCIENCE] From 12:25 pm on 1 March to 5:30 pm on 8 May 1990 is 68 days, 5 hours and 5 minutes, or 98,225 minutes. Damage Control says Tench spent about thirty minutes on tape after the jump and a few hours at most inside altogether. Taking thirty minutes to three hours as his side of it, time outside ran somewhere between about **550 and 3,300 times faster** than time for him. If the Complex simply slowed time for whoever was inside, a single hour spent inside at that rate would be somewhere between 23 and 136 days outside. No other visitor seems to have lost time like that. Async's teams go in for hours at a time and come back the same day. So whatever happened to Tench was an event, not a steady rate. That's also what Wendigoon's "flash" idea implies.

The green glow

[CANON] A green light shows up again and again, nearly always where something is changing. The fan wiki says it first appeared in the original Found Footage but didn't matter until Found Footage #2. Here are the appearances.

- **Overflow (1972).** In a lab, an overload warning flashes and a glow grows from bright yellow into green over a cork board where Beck's signed report is pinned. The episode ends with the night sky from the opening folding in on itself.
- **Prototype (1982).** The marble test gives off a yellowish glow.
- **Damage Control's images.** A man in a button-up shirt stands in front of a huge ball of green energy, and the same picture appears again tinted purple.
- **Pitfalls (1990).** Green light through the door at the end of Room 14D, which Mark reports.
- **The Ladder Room.** The fan wiki describes a ladder into a hole, with an almost identical room beyond and a hallway giving off a faint green glow.
- **Found Footage #2 (1995).** Green light over part of the great hall. A hallway in the pools glows green as the Lifeform closes in. In the last room the doorway gets bigger, the wall recedes, and green light cracks through as the walls move.

- **Static Dead End (1990).** The green door finally opens on stretching wallpaper and a half-formed room.
- **The film.** A very brief glimpse just off camera during the chase. TV Tropes counts it as a semi-confirmed appearance with no further explanation.

[FAN] The fan wiki's theory is that the glow is gamma radiation driven by magnetic and electromagnetic waves, tied to null zones opening and to the layout changing. Wendigoon reads it as the Complex reshaping itself in real time. Both fit the cases above, where green light appears as walls move, rooms grow, or a door leads somewhere unfinished.

[SCIENCE] Gamma rays can't be seen, so a visible green glow can't be gamma radiation itself. It could be the visible light given off when something is hit by radiation, the way some materials glow when struck by X-rays or particles, or it could be something else entirely.

The Sun

[FAN] Wendigoon's longest thread is about the Sun. The setting sun is laid over the Threshold in Informational Video. home_27647.mov holds a long shot of sunset over the ocean. Ravi climbs past paintings of a smiling sun in splendour on every level of the tower. Out of Sync's cover art is full of suns, sea and green light.

[FAN] He then lines up the dates. Overflow falls on one of the biggest solar storms in recorded history. The sixth test, the one that worked, came in October 1989, a month with several solar storms and flares. His suggestion is that the Sun gave Async's magnetic machine the extra push it needed, both times. He adds the **green flash**, the brief green spark sometimes seen at the top of the Sun as it sets, as a natural echo of the green glow. Another thread of his theory has Ivan Beck injured in the right eye by the 1972 event, based on Out of Sync's artwork and sketches Kane posted on Discord.

[REAL WORLD] [SCIENCE] The real space weather is as dramatic as he says.

- **August 1972.** A run of large flares from 2 to 7 August produced one of the fastest solar storms ever recorded, peaking on 4 August. A 2018 study in the journal Space Weather (Knipp and others) concluded that it likely set off dozens of US Navy magnetic sea mines off the coast of North Vietnam that day. For a story about a magnetic machine, that's a striking real event.
- **March 1989.** A severe geomagnetic storm on 13 March knocked out the Hydro-Québec power grid for about nine hours.
- **October 1989.** A large flare on 19 October and a strong geomagnetic storm on 20 and 21 October, two to four days after the sixth test on 17 October.
- **The green flash** is real and comes from the atmosphere bending different colours of sunlight by slightly different amounts, so the green part of the Sun's disc is the last to drop below the horizon for an instant.
- **Aurora** is mostly green too. The strongest auroral light is the 557.7 nanometre emission of oxygen atoms, which is why solar storms paint the night sky green. Out of Sync's "Sea Ice" artwork shows green aurora.

[OURS] One timing detail cuts against the October idea. The big October 1989 flare came two days after the sixth test, not before it. If the Sun helped, it would have to have been the smaller activity earlier that month, or something else entirely. The 1972 date fits much better.

Wind chimes

[CANON] Wind chimes are heard at the start of Overflow, at the end of Found Footage #2, and at the start of I Remember. In the film they hang in the room next to Clark's doorway and sound as Mary drifts off during her interview. The fan wiki ties them to Ivan Beck, and suggests he narrated I Remember and was the person watching Found Footage #2's tape at the end. Two Out of Sync track titles, "Overlooking The Sea" and "You Have Always Been Here", are phrases from I Remember (Wendigoon).

PART VI

Async and the People

The company that opened the door, and everyone, inside and out, who went through one.

The Async Research Institute

What it is

[CANON] The **Async Research Institute**, also called the Async Foundation and, in the film, simply Async, is a private research company in San Jose, California. Its building is on a hillside, and its staff call it Standard when they're on the other side. The logo and name appear on badges, hazmat suits, tapes and paperwork throughout the series.

[FILM] Phil tells Mary the company made MRI machines, or used to, before they found the Complex. The newspaper on his wall is about Async getting federal money for its MRI machines. TV Tropes says Async began as a company known for making MRI machines before moving into particle physics.

[FAN] The fan wiki says Async was founded in **1983** by a physicist, **Lawrence Altman**, who has run it ever since. In 2024 Kane said he'd thought about changing Altman's name because it now felt too "on the nose", which fans take as a nod to Sam Altman of OpenAI.

[CONFLICT] If Async was founded in 1983, it can't have run the 1972 experiment or the 1982 Oak Ridge test. Ivan Beck signed the 1972 report, but nothing says he signed it as an Async employee, and the fan wiki says the Oak Ridge test was run by the laboratory under Philip R. Heymann, who is only "often thought" to have worked for Async. The likeliest reading is that Beck brought work begun elsewhere to Async, but that's an inference.

[REAL WORLD] [SCIENCE] MRI is a sensible starting point for a company that ends up building a "magnetic distortion system". An MRI scanner is a very strong, very even magnet with radio-frequency coils, and its makers know more than almost anyone about building large magnets and shielding them. The technique was first called NMR imaging, for nuclear magnetic resonance, and was renamed partly because patients were frightened of the word "nuclear".

The people at the top

[CANON] **Ivan Beck** is vice director of Async and head of Project KV31. He's never been seen on screen. The fan wiki gives his birth as 16 July 1931 in Karlovy Vary, Czechoslovakia, to Doris and Antonin Beck, from images Kane posted and later deleted (Wendigoon). He signed the 1972 report in Overflow, was asked by the medical examiner where the body came from, was phoned at home by Clyde the night Tench came back, and sent apologies for missing the Damage Control briefing.

[KANE] Kane has described Beck as the closest thing the series has to both a main character and a central antagonist (TV Tropes).

[FAN] Most fans think the voice of I Remember is Beck's, because of the wind chimes linking it to Overflow and Found Footage #2, and because two Out of Sync track titles quote it. Wendigoon goes further and suggests Beck lost or damaged his right eye in the 1972 event, based on Out of Sync's artwork and sketches Kane shared on Discord, and compares him to Captain Ahab, a man who can't let go of the thing that hurt him.

[FAN] **Lawrence Altman**, director and founder, per the fan wiki. Little else is known.

[FAN] **Kirk Maxwell**, described by the fan wiki as high-ranking with full access clearance. He's the man in the lab coat walking the halls and making a phone call in Report. In Damage Control a "Dr. Maxwell" disarms Tench in an empty lab, the shotgun going off into the ceiling.

The money

[CANON] On 8 May 1990 Async pitched the Complex to the Department of Energy as **A-Space**, room without limit for storage, housing, transport and commerce, a cure for pollution and overcrowding. Secretary of Energy James D. Watkins toured the Threshold. The contract was signed, and the funding came, despite the alarm that went off during the visit.

[KANE] Kane says the pitch was mainly a framework to get the government to take the work seriously, and that actually living in there would be "a pretty tedious, difficult task" (Wendigoon on set, 2026). The real interest is investigation. He has also said that what he's looking forward to exploring is Async "upscaling and merging with an actual government agency", slowly dissolving into the Department of Energy over time as new people arrive, old ones leave and protocols change (Smosh, 2024).

[FAN] TV Tropes notes that the A-Space pitch says nothing about the creature on Marvin's tape, recorded two days earlier, or about Tench. Report had just shown the hallway to Room 14B being boarded up. Whatever the researchers knew, the government was shown a Complex where nothing had gone wrong.

Equipment and methods

[CANON] Across the series and the film, Async's kit includes the following.

- **The LPMDS and the Threshold**, with an airlock, a blast door and a keycard door at the Outpost.
- **Level A hazmat suits.** Yellow for most staff. TV Tropes says supervisors wear lime green.
- **Radios**, with the distortion you'd expect from early 1990s handsets, and an alarm that sounds while the Threshold is open, as an audio guide back.
- **A tether** back to the Threshold, per TV Tropes' list of procedures.
- **Seven motion and noise cameras** in lateral division A from 5 March 1990, which start recording when triggered.
- **Motion sensors** at the Outpost that turn the lights red.
- **The Async Rover**, a tracked unmanned vehicle with a camera and sensors, driven from a workstation outside Division 14 with a keyboard and joystick (fan wiki).
- **Ladders, pulleys and straps** for the Lighting and Tile Survey, and insulated tools for isolating live wiring.
- **A walkway and a steel frame with a winch** over the pits of Room 14D by late May 1990.
- **Tape squares** stuck to walls to measure stretching.
- **Shotguns**, after Pitfalls. Mark carries a Remington 870 in Reunion.
- **Outposts** deep inside, like the KLWNA or Secluded Outpost.
- **Cardboard cutouts with speakers** playing the Voyager Golden Record greetings, to lure entities onto camera, and later **gas traps** rigged to them with a tripwire and blue canisters of knockout gas.
- **Saws** for cutting through walls, as in Everything Must Go.
- **MRI scans**, which Mary is put through at the end of the film.

[KANE] Kane says of Async's armed teams that it's filled with people who have never touched a gun in their life, and it's not a military organisation (TV Tropes).

Rules

[CANON] [FAN] Async's procedures, as far as they can be pieced together.

- Expeditions must have at least three people. The fan wiki records this as mandatory, and the researchers are almost always seen in threes.

- Nobody wanders off alone.
- Injuries have to be reported, like at any workplace.
- Areas where something dangerous was seen get walled off.
- Unchecked ground, like the dips in the Static Dead End, gets avoided until it's been cleared.
- Information is compartmentalised. Damage Control admits this went too far.

Cover-ups

[CANON] Async hides things, from the public, from the government and from its own staff.

- **Peter Tench's death, the first time.** About two weeks after he vanished on 1 March 1990, the security team invented "a more acceptable cause of death". The TV Tropes timeline describes it as a staged car accident around 15 March, followed by a funeral. Wendigoon mentions an Out of Sync cover showing the headline of a faked vineyard wreck.
- **Peter Tench's return.** After he came back on 8 May, Clyde told Beck that, as far as he knew, he was the only one who knew. Tench was kept underground for two weeks while they worked out how to "undo" his death.
- **Peter Tench's death, the second time.** Async's account is that he broke out, shot Mark, fled up the freight elevator and fell onto a rock on the hillside. Peter's own words in Reunion were that they took his life and left him for dead. Damage Control ends with images that might show him alive in a city.
- **The government.** The A-Space presentation shows none of the danger.
- **Staff.** Damage Control's representative admits information was deliberately kept from many people working on the project.
- **Mary.** In the film she's held, interrogated and scanned, and Phil can't tell her what will happen to her. The decision "isn't up to him".

[KANE] [FAN] Kane's intent is that Async is out of its depth rather than evil (TV Tropes). TV Tropes' summary is that the people on the ground are mostly careful and decent, and that the corner cutting happens above them.

Culture

[FILM] By the film, the Complex has a grip on Async's people. Phil goes in every day to learn a little more, and believes nothing in their lifetime, maybe nothing in recorded history, matters more. Naren's team in Everything Must Go is so keen on the store copy that Naren's objections are ignored, and cutting through the wall lets Pirate Clark loose.

[FAN] TV Tropes points out that Clark's own obsession suggests becoming fixated on the place might be something the Complex does to whoever finds it, not just Async.

Async after 1990

[CANON] Async's own records stop in July 1990. The Found Footage tapes of 1991 and 1995 show no Async people, equipment or signs anywhere. Either they were somewhere else in a vast space, or something happened. The film hints that Async may be the ones who collect the tapes, through its shots of them watching Clark on monitors and the end of Found Footage #2, where the tape plays on someone's TV.

[FAN] The whiteboard in I Remember reads that clustering cell images results in individual cell classification. Wendigoon takes this as Async studying the bacteria forming around bodies, and argues that between 1990 and Ravi's time Async learned the creatures follow sound, which would explain the speakers playing music in the Complex.

[KANE] Kane's statement that Async slowly merges into the Department of Energy is the only word from him on where it goes.

Everyone, in Order of Appearance in the Story

This roster runs roughly in story order. The Still Lifes and creatures have their own chapter and are only listed briefly here.

Before the Threshold

Ivan Beck [CANON]. Vice director of Async and head of Project KV31. Born 16 July 1931 in Karlovy Vary to Doris and Antonin Beck (fan wiki, from images Kane posted). Signs off the tellurium glass report on 2 August 1972. Never seen. The medical examiner reports to him, Clyde phones him, the Damage Control briefing apologises for his absence. Fans widely take him to be the voice of I Remember. Kane calls him the closest thing the series has to a protagonist and an antagonist at once.

Philip R. Heymann [CANON] [FAN]. The scientist in charge of the 1982 prototype test at Oak Ridge National Laboratory. The fan wiki notes he's often assumed to have worked for Async.

Lawrence Altman [FAN]. Physicist, founder and director of Async since 1983, according to the fan wiki. Never seen.

The Async staff, 1989 to 1990

Dr. Julia Meisner [CANON]. Presents the Lighting and Tile Survey on 15 November 1989 (Wikipedia names her). She stumbles over a few words and admits she's no lighting expert, which TV Tropes counts as a realistic touch. The researcher who opens that episode, complaining about the cold on 14 November, may or may not be her.

Peter Tench [CANON]. Doctor and researcher, camera operator in Informational Video. Vanishes on 1 March 1990 at about 12:25 pm while his team crosses a branch of hallways they'd already explored. Lives through about half an hour on tape and walks into the Threshold Outpost on 8 May 1990 at 5:30 pm, setting off the alarm during the Department of Energy visit. His full name first comes out in _recording014. Legally dead after Async's staged accident, he's kept underground, deteriorates, escapes into the Complex on 22 May with stolen credentials, ambushes Team B in Room 14C on 25 May, shoots Mark Blume, fights his way out through Standard, and according to Async falls to his death on the hillside. His drawings show crowds at doors with faces crossed out, the date 17 May 1990, and a line from "Sailing". Damage Control's last images may show him alive. Several sources wrongly say he jumped three months. It was 68 days.

Marvin E. Leigh [CANON]. "Marv". Seen at the start of Informational Video, on Tench's team on 1 March. Camera operator in Pitfalls on 6 May 1990, when he falls down pit 22 of Room 14D, dislocates his shoulder, follows a voice calling for help, finds the red street, meets the Lifeform and outruns it. Not amused when the others call it "Marvin's Friend" in Reunion. Held at gunpoint by Tench on 25 May. In Static Dead End he tells George that Async and the Department of Energy killed Peter, and is told to take a couple of weeks off. Every expedition he's on goes wrong.

Mark Blume [CANON]. The researcher in Pitfalls who crosses the pits of Room 14D on their edges and opens the door to the green light. In Reunion he carries the team's shotgun, jokes with Marvin that nobody wants to be at the wrong end of any gun, gets ambushed and disarmed by Tench, panics on the radio and is shot in the side. Left coughing on the floor. In critical condition on 26 May. His drawing of the stretching effect is what Static Dead End checks. Fans think a hazmat Still Life on the soundtrack's vinyl sleeve may be him.

George Levy [CANON]. On Tench's team on 1 March. Camera operator in parts of Pitfalls, filming what Mark found behind the door. In Static Dead End, on 29 May 1990, he talks Marvin down on the phone (he's had the same conversation with three others), then crosses the new walkway and sees the Static Dead End for the first time.

Kim [CANON]. One of the four who found Room 14D on 6 May 1990. Shows George the Static Dead End.

Randall Tachi [CANON]. The third member of Team B in Reunion, with Mark and Marvin in Room 14C.

Ronald McCarthy [CANON]. On Tench's team on 1 March. On 19 June 1990 he joins Naren and Bill to see the sale signs, works the numbers, and decides there should be a fourth sign behind the wall. He fetches the saw, cuts through, and is first to want to go and look at the strange light and the TV. Fate after the Pirate Clark attack unknown.

Clyde [CANON]. Phones Ivan Beck on 8 May 1990 in _recording014 to tell him a man calling himself Peter Tench has turned up in the Complex, and says he thinks he's the only one who knows. Also appears reviewing Marvin's footage in Report (fan wiki).

Kirk Maxwell [CANON] [FAN]. Senior figure with full clearance, walking the halls and phoning in Report. The "Dr. Maxwell" who disarms Tench in Damage Control.

The senior engineer [CANON]. Shows the Department of Energy party round on 8 May and goes through the contract. Finds Tench at the Outpost after the alarm.

The Damage Control representative [CANON]. Unnamed. Runs the 26 May briefing, admits to "severe information mismanagement", tells the story of Tench's death, and ends on there being "nothing more to be extracted".

The medical examiner [CANON]. Voiced by Arthur Langlie. Examines the young man found on 3 February 1990, notes malnutrition and the mutant hay bacillus, and asks Beck where the body came from. Async outsourced him, which TV Tropes reads as realistic.

Miller [CANON]. Mentioned only, in Pitfalls, as someone with a theory about null zones.

The man in the suit [CANON]. Watches the hazmat team cross the Threshold at the start of Pitfalls. TV Tropes compares him to Half-Life's G-Man.

Naren Warne [CANON] [FILM]. Played by Avan Jogia in the film and in Everything Must Go. On 18 June 1990 he's with Aaron Ng and Bill when they find the sale signs. On 19 June, with Bill and McCarthy, he helps survey the signs, argues they should go back, and runs when Pirate Clark attacks. In the film's cold open he's alone, lost, radioing Standard, and dies after reaching an outpost. He'd hidden a duffel bag of Async data and his ID card by the caveman in Junction 3. TV Tropes suggests he was trying to blow the whistle. Clark finds the bag.

Aaron Ng [CANON] [FAN]. Async researcher on the 18 June expedition, thrilled by the signs. Replaced by McCarthy the next day. The "Dr. Ring" in the transcript is almost certainly him.

Bill [CANON]. On both days of Everything Must Go, and by our reasoning its narrator, the one who explains the "instancing question" and the matching flaws.

Phil [FILM]. Played by Mark Duplass. Watches Clark on a monitor during Clark's first trip. At home with his family, watching The NeverEnding Story, he goes quiet when Clark's advert comes on. Wears a Game of Life T-shirt. Interviews Mary at the end, tells her Async made MRI machines, that he's been inside and now it's his job, that he goes in every day, and that doors are opening everywhere and they can't stop them. TV Tropes reads him as Clark's mirror.

James D. Watkins [CANON] [REAL]. The real United States Secretary of Energy from 1989 to 1993, who tours the Threshold in Presentation (fan wiki). An unnamed Department of Energy representative is with him.

The people who fell in

The young man in Missing Persons [CANON]. Aged 18 to 21. Found slumped against a wall in the Complex, apparently dead of malnutrition about five days earlier, part of his body overgrown with a mutant hay bacillus and strangely preserved.

The missing persons on the posters [CANON] [FAN]. Nicolas Bolton, a young man from northwest California, with a contact number of 707 340-3036. TV Tropes says his photo is Nathan Barnatt, creator of the "Dad" videos, who Kane has worked with. Margaret Watson, 28, last seen 2 December 1989. Janice Scott. Ellis White, a two-year-old boy, 2 feet 7 inches tall, with green eyes and curly blond hair. James Esmail. An unnamed man.

The driver [CANON]. Whoever was in the car on the highway in 9780415263573. The burnt-out car turns up in Found Footage #2 with handprints and blood leading away from it, toward the room where the Lifeform waits.

Kane [CANON]. The young man behind the camera in Found Footage, falling in on 4 July 1991 while making a student film. Chased by the Lifeform, he drops into the Staircase Room, sees the Heathrow courtyard, and is finally grabbed by a second Lifeform as he's about to go down the chute. His camera comes out through another null zone and is found on 23 September 1996. The TV Tropes timeline names him Kane, after his creator.

The woman in the garage [CANON] [CONFLICT]. Found Footage #2, 19 August 1995. Never named. Fans call her Madison after her voice actor. Wendigoon calls her Angie. She tapes off a null zone, drops things through it, gets pulled in by a tape measure, crosses the Household Area and the pools with the Lifeform after her, and is last seen cornered as green light breaks through the walls. Her tape is then shown playing on someone's television, with wind chimes.

Ravi [CANON]. Played by Aakash Valdivia. A young man who keeps a video diary, grumbles about two managers he overheard mocking a sick child and admitting to wrongdoing, then goes down to check a break-in in the basement under his apartment and climbs through a hole in a wall. Explores further than anyone in the found footage, from the classrooms to the Red City, the tower and the house in the blue box. He talks to a father through a wall, which only gets the father pulled in somewhere else. Chased by a Still Life, he's last seen in red light, exhausted, telling a story from his childhood and starting to apologise for things he said, until the battery dies. The fan infographic dates his fall to 19 April 1995. The TV Tropes timeline says he presumably starved.

The father [CANON]. On the other side of a wall from Ravi, in a house where a 2007 to 2009 TV advert is playing. At first he thinks Ravi is someone who's been talking to his boys. He agrees to break through the wall to help, then is heard falling in. Fate unknown.

The father's boys [CANON]. Mentioned only. Whoever was "talking to" them through the walls before Ravi isn't explained.

The film's people outside the Complex

Clark [FILM]. Played by Chiwetel Ejiofor. A failed architect who runs a failing furniture store, Cap'n Clark's Ottoman Empire, and plays its pirate mascot in his own adverts. A heavy drinker, divorced from Barbara, seeing Mary for therapy. Finds the doorway in his basement on 29 June 1990, explores, brings back furniture and maps, takes Bobby and Kat in on 3 July, loses them both, and decides to stay. He lives

with his Still Lifes, eats them, keeps Kat's head in the hope the place will remember her, paints a mural to his own copy, phones Mary to say he opened the window and won't be back, then ties her up and makes her replay their sessions. He's eaten by Pirate Clark as he tries to calm it, his last words throwing her diagnosis back at himself. Clark's surname is never given.

Dr. Mary Kline [FILM]. Played by Renate Reinsve, and by Ember Ambrose as a child. A therapist and author of a self-help book, The Window Within, with a companion audio course, Guided Openings. Raised by a mother who papered over the windows and kept her inside. Her childhood home is being demolished. Goes to the store after Clark's call, follows him in, survives Pirate Clark, sets off Async's gas trap, and ends up being interviewed by Phil. A Still Life of her appears in the last shot.

Nora Kline [FILM]. Played by Krista Kosonen. Mary's mother, seen in flashbacks, who taped paper over the windows because "they" were everywhere. Seen in hospital in one memory. Her pill bottles carry her name.

Bobby Franklin [FILM]. Robert Franklin, played by Finn Bennett. Kat's boyfriend, works at the store, owns the camcorder through his student ID, wears an "End Apartheid" shirt. Lowered down the chute into the Piled Laundry Area on 3 July, comes back up terrified, and is later killed by Pirate Clark. A giant copy of his shirt ends up in its lair.

Kat Taylor [FILM]. Kathrine Taylor, played by Lukita Maxwell. Assistant manager at the store. Gets separated, sees Clark through a wall he can't see through and begs him to let her in, and is killed. Clark keeps her head in his fridge. Posters say she and Bobby were last seen on 3 July.

Barbara [FILM]. Clark's ex-wife, who threw him out after the night he came home drunk and broke a glass. Seen only in Clark's role-plays, through Mary playing her. Fans think the Redheaded Still Life may be her copy.

The meter man [FILM]. Played by Philip Granger. Comes to check the store's electricity.

Big Wayne [FILM]. The cowboy host of the rival Big Wayne's Furniture Barn adverts.

Mary's party guests [FILM]. Including an uncredited Katharine Isabelle.

Phil's family [FILM]. Watching The NeverEnding Story with him.

The Still Lifes and creatures

Covered in full in the previous part. For reference, the Lifeform, the tentacled thing, the knocker, the Speaker Room Still Life, the Redheaded Still Life (Rhiannon Roberts), Archibald Leland Sutter (Dana Mahmood), the Bearded Still Life (Patrick Baynham), Pirate Clark (Robert Bobroczkyi), Mary's Still Life (Renate Reinsve), the man in the striped shirt, and the hazmat Still Life on the vinyl sleeve.

PART VII

Timelines, Words and Music

Everything in date order, everything Kane and his crew have said, and every piece of music tied to the series.

The Master Timeline

Three timelines follow. The first is the story as it happens inside the fiction, with every dated or datable event. The second is the real history the story borrows. The third is how the series and film were made and released. Where sources disagree, the disagreement is marked.

Inside the story

Date and time	Event	Source
16 July 1931	Ivan Beck born in Karlovy Vary, Czechoslovakia, to Doris and Antonin Beck	fan wiki, from images Kane posted
19th century or earlier	The person the ALS Still Life copies may date from here, going by his clothes	TV Tropes, a reading
2 August 1972	Beck signs off the tellurium glass report. A green glow fills the lab and the night sky folds	Overflow
10 May 1982	Prototype test at Oak Ridge under Philip R. Heymann. A marble in a yellowish glow	Prototype
1983	Async founded by Lawrence Altman	fan wiki
April 1988	Development of Project KV31 begins. Beck promises a fix for storage and housing	fan wiki, The Third Test
2 July 1988	The third test fails	The Third Test
17 October 1989, 5:04 pm	The Loma Prieta earthquake	faultline.mov
17 October 1989, 5:09 pm	The sixth test opens the Threshold	First Contact
from 17 October 1989	Missing persons climb. An airlock is added to the Threshold	Missing Persons, fan wiki
14 November 1989	Ceiling tile and light fitting removed. "Incredibly cold"	Lighting and Tile Survey
15 November 1989	Dr. Meisner's report	Lighting and Tile Survey
2 December 1989	Margaret Watson, 28, last seen	Missing Persons poster
about 29 January 1990	The young man in the Complex dies, roughly five days before he's found	Autopsy Report
3 February 1990	His body is found	Missing Persons
5 February 1990	The autopsy. A mutant hay bacillus	Autopsy Report
1 March 1990, morning	Layout analysis by George Levy, Marvin Leigh, Ronald McCarthy and Peter Tench. The description says "29 February"	Informational Video, Damage Control
1 March 1990, about 12:25 pm	Tench vanishes	Damage Control
1 to 5 March 1990	Construction of the Threshold Outpost begins	fan wiki
5 March 1990	Seven motion cameras placed along lateral division A	Motion Detected
6 March 1990, 3:53 am	Camera 5 records moving limbs. The tentacled thing at the end	Motion Detected
March 1990	Stills later compiled into an archive in June 1991	Mar11_90_ARCHIVE.tar
about 15 March 1990	Tench's death faked as an accident. A funeral is held	Damage Control, TV Tropes timeline
about 6 May 1990	Threshold Outpost finished	fan wiki
6 May 1990	Room 14D found by Marvin, Mark, George and Kim. Marvin falls down pit 22 and meets the Lifeform	Pitfalls
6 May 1990	Marvin's tape reviewed. The hallway to Room 14B boarded up. Rifles issued	Report, TV Tropes timeline

Date and time	Event	Source
8 May 1990	The A-Space presentation and Department of Energy tour. Contract agreed	Presentation
8 May 1990, 5:30 pm	Tench walks into the Threshold Outpost, 68 days after he left	Presentation, Damage Control
8 May 1990, evening	Clyde phones Beck	_recording014
17 May 1990	The date in Tench's drawings. Later used on the first Cap'n Clark's fax	Damage Control, film marketing
about 21 May 1990	Tench showing paranoid behaviour, according to Async	Damage Control
22 May 1990, night	Tench escapes back into the Complex with stolen credentials	Damage Control
25 May 1990	Tench ambushes Team B in Room 14C and shoots Mark Blume. Escapes up the freight elevator and, per Async, dies on the hillside	Reunion, Damage Control
26 May 1990	The staff briefing after "a stressful 15 hours"	Damage Control
29 May 1990	Marvin and George on the phone. The Static Dead End surveyed	Static Dead End
18 June 1990	Naren Warne, Aaron Ng and Bill find the sale signs in the Kelowna Branch	Everything Must Go
19 June 1990, about 11:00 am	Naren, Bill and Ronald McCarthy measure the signs, cut through to the fourth, find the store copy. Pirate Clark attacks	Everything Must Go
19 June 1990	Naren lost and killed near an outpost. Async starts planning decoys and gas traps	the film, TV Tropes timeline
before 29 June 1990	Clark's store losing power. Red switches appear in the breaker box	the film
29 June 1990	Clark falls through his basement wall. Async's cameras see him	the film, trailer
30 June to 2 July 1990	Clark explores and maps, brings out furniture, tries to tell Mary	the film, TV Tropes timeline
3 July 1990	The expedition with Bobby and Kat. Bobby is killed and Kat is lost	the film, posters
4 to 5 July 1990	Clark stays. Kat dies. He gathers Still Lifes, paints the mural, wrecks Async's camera, calls Mary	the film, TV Tropes timeline
about 6 July 1990	Mary goes in. Clark is eaten. Pirate Clark is gassed. Mary is taken by Async	the film, TV Tropes timeline
after that	A Still Life of Mary appears in a copy of the interview room	the film
June 1991	Async's March 1990 archive compiled	Mar11_90_ARCHIVE.tar
4 July 1991	Kane falls in while making a student film	Found Footage
between October 1989 and August 1995	A car vanishes from a highway	9780415263573
late April 1995	Ravi falls in from his basement. The fan infographic says 19 April	Found Footage #3, radio report
19 August 1995	The woman in the garage falls in	Found Footage #2
23 September 1996	Kane's camera found	Found Footage
undated	The Simpsons tape, home_27647.mov, I Remember	hidden videos

[CONFLICT] The TV Tropes timeline lists Found Footage #2 (1995) before Ravi and leaves Ravi undated. Ravi's late April 1995 date, from a radio report in his video, puts him four months before the woman in the garage.

[KANE] Kane told Wendigoon on set that the Async story in the series runs from autumn 1989 to spring 1990, and that the film is set in June and July 1990.

The real history the story uses

Date	Real event	How the story uses it
1817	Giovanni Belzoni records the tomb numbered KV31 in the Valley of the Kings	a possible source for the project's name
1943	The Philadelphia Experiment legend	cited in a fan sheet
2 to 7 August 1972	A run of big solar flares and one of the fastest solar storms ever recorded, peaking on 4 August. US Navy mines off North Vietnam detonate	Overflow's date
summer to October 1972	US-Soviet trade talks and the Lend-Lease debt settlement	Overflow's radio
1973, 1975	The troffer and ballast dates on the copied light	Lighting and Tile Survey
1977	The Voyager Golden Record launched, with greetings in 55 languages	the cutouts' audio in the film
13 March 1989	A geomagnetic storm blacks out Hydro-Québec	fan theories on the sixth test
1989 to 1993	James D. Watkins is Secretary of Energy	Presentation
17 October 1989, 5:04 pm	The Loma Prieta earthquake, magnitude 6.9	First Contact, faultline.mov
19 to 21 October 1989	A large solar flare and a strong geomagnetic storm	fan theories on the sixth test
10 January 1991	"Bart Gets Hit by a Car" first airs	Simpsons
2000	The Dimacol advert runs in Mexico	Simpsons
12 June 2002	The original Backrooms photo taken in Oshkosh, Wisconsin	the film's first doorway
2007 to 2009	The freecreditreport.com advert	Found Footage #3
2008	MGMT's "Kids"	Pitfalls
2015	The ABC News interview with Bruno Rodríguez Parrilla	Pitfalls
2018	The Holiday Inn Express at Heathrow opens	Found Footage
2022	The USC Arcadia Hospital flyer's date	Found Footage #3

Making it

Date	Event
12 June 2002	The photograph is taken
18 June 2005	Kane born in Petaluma, California
12 May 2019	The 4chan thread and the caption that start the Backrooms
July 2019	The first Backrooms game
2020	Kane, at fourteen, teaches himself Blender
2021	Kane's Attack on Titan videos
27 November 2021	"Backrooms test footage 1" on Instagram
7 January 2022	The Backrooms (Found Footage)
8 January to 24 December 2022	Episodes 2 to 21
December 2022	Creator Honor at the 12th Streamy Awards
30 January 2023	Damage Control
6 February 2023	A24 announces the film, with Kane directing at seventeen
18 March 2023	The Oldest View begins
May 2024	Discord sleuths trace the photo to Oshkosh
13 September 2024	Found Footage #3
2 October 2024	Lighting and Tile Survey

Date	Event
12 February 2025	Static Dead End
April 2025	Two-day test shoot in Vancouver
May to July 2025	Casting
7 July to 14 August 2025	Principal photography in Vancouver, as "Effigy"
18 August 2025	A24 posts "2026"
23 and 24 February 2026	Teaser poster and teaser trailer
31 March 2026	Full trailer
7 May 2026	Premiere at the Aero Theatre, Santa Monica
29 May 2026	US release. $81.5 million opening weekend
18 June 2026	Kane turns 21
30 June 2026	Astra Midseason nominations
3 July 2026	The Everything Must Go Edition in cinemas
14 July 2026	Digital release
17 August 2026	Everything Must Go on YouTube, Pacific time
September 2026	Worldwide gross passes $400 million

In Kane's Words

Part II covers Kane's life and general views. This chapter gathers everything he has said that bears on the story itself, sorted by subject, so a claim can be checked quickly. Each entry gives the source and year. Quotes are kept short and the rest is paraphrase.

The sources are Anthony Padilla's "I spent a day with" video (2023), Smosh's "The Truth About The Backrooms" (2024), Smosh Asks (2026), the A24 Podcast with James Wan (2026), Wendigoon's on-set interview (recorded 2025, released 2026), BAFTA's interview (2026), and print interviews named where used. Discord statements are as reported by TV Tropes and the fan wiki.

Canon and continuity

- [KANE] He has had a very specific timeline from the start, and the film fits into it. Every piece of Backrooms media he puts out will fit somewhere (Smosh, 2024).
- [KANE] "I would never set up a mystery not knowing the answers myself" (Smosh, 2024).
- [KANE] He can't stand retcons and has never broken continuity on purpose (Smosh, 2024. Wendigoon on set).
- [KANE] He doesn't de-canonise things, except visual effects errors. The Lifeform clipping through a wall in the first video was an animation error from a video made "half as a joke", which leaned too hard into the video game language of the original copypasta (Smosh Asks, 2026). Discord statements to the same effect are reported by TV Tropes.
- [KANE] If a plug socket moves an inch between videos, it's because the narrative needed it to (Smosh Asks, 2026).
- [KANE] His private lore document was about 71 pages in 2024 and 72 by 2026. He's tried to trim it (Smosh, 2024. Smosh Asks, 2026).
- [KANE] On Backrooms canon in general, "everything is canon to itself", and the lore runs as deep in what's unsaid as in what's shown (Padilla, 2023).
- [KANE] The material planned and written goes beyond the YouTube series and beyond the film. Both lay out a broader tree of the narrative, and he builds toward an ending he wants to reach (A24 Podcast, 2026).

The first video

- [KANE] He calls it a pilot and a tech demo, made to decompress, and largely disconnected from the rest the way a pilot can be (Wendigoon on set. Smosh Asks, 2026).
- [KANE] It was filmed on his phone with friends who didn't know what it was for, then run through a VCR (A24 Podcast, 2026).
- [KANE] Within about a day of posting it he started teasing Async, because he realised the Backrooms and another story he'd been building could melt together (A24 Podcast, 2026).

What the Backrooms means to him

- [KANE] He sees the Backrooms as reacting to a fear that, with more information than ever, it means less and less. Information is "put through a blender" and fed back, and people start to roleplay as themselves (A24 Podcast, 2026).
- [KANE] He calls the drop ceiling a symbol of uniformity and efficiency, not bad in itself, and the Backrooms "a purgatory that we built" rather than something beyond humanity. He frames this as a systemic pattern, not malice (A24 Podcast, 2026).

- [KANE] It's like walking around in a dream (Smosh, 2024).
- [KANE] The Backrooms is "more of just a texture to wrap over everything". Most of the series' ideas came first (Padilla, 2023).

The Complex

- [KANE] Inside the story it's a neutral technology, not inherently anything. It could do great good or great harm, or simply be nature if everyone agreed to leave it alone, which would never happen (Wendigoon on set).
- [KANE] There's probably food, but it would be very hard to find and might be rotten. Water would be easier. There are toilets, probably working ones. A person who fell in would function normally (Smosh, 2024).
- [KANE] The Complex isn't selecting particular moments out of people's minds (as reported by TV Tropes YMMV).
- [KANE] It "recognizes, interprets, and stores" the physical structure of our world, is "obsessed" with how that world is physically built, "synthesizes such environments internally", builds "a cache of physical spatial information" and "aggregates" what it takes in. "Sometimes, humans get caught up in that too" (Japanese interviews, as summarised in translation on note.com, 2026).
- [KANE] "I don't know if there is intelligence or intent behind it." He doesn't want to define it or treat it as having a "Backrooms spirit", and he says the audience's reading of how it works is as valid as the characters' (same source).
- [KANE] Nobody in the film is an ambassador with the rules. They're people describing what they see (BAFTA, 2026).
- [KANE] The film keeps the Complex itself "pretty much unchanged". What's new is that it comes alive through people the audience can relate to (A24 Podcast, 2026).
- [KANE] The earthquake didn't technically "cause" the Threshold to open (as reported by the fan wiki).
- [KANE] The yellow wallpaper design comes from Europe (as reported by Wendigoon).

Async

- [KANE] Async isn't evil, it's out of its depth (TV Tropes, from Discord). The people in charge are mostly normal and mostly try to be careful.
- [KANE] It's filled with people who have never touched a gun. It isn't a military organisation (TV Tropes).
- [KANE] The A-Space pitch was a framework to get government interest. The real interest is investigation, and living in there would be "a pretty tedious, difficult task" (Wendigoon on set).
- [KANE] What he looks forward to exploring is Async merging with a government agency, slowly dissolving into the Department of Energy as people come and go and protocols change (Smosh, 2024).
- [KANE] The specialists who know how things work are rarely the ones steering, and when distant managers and shareholders take over, carelessness creeps in (Wendigoon on set).
- [KANE] He thought about renaming Lawrence Altman because it felt too "on the nose" (as reported by the fan wiki, 2024).
- [KANE] Fake channels using the name Async, some of them verified, get nearly as many views as his own (Padilla, 2023).

Ivan Beck

- [KANE] Asked by Wendigoon who the protagonist of the series is, he said Ivan Beck. Asked who the antagonist is, he said Ivan Beck again (Wendigoon on set, and in an earlier conversation).
- [KANE] Beck's birthplace and year, Karlovy Vary in 1931, come from images Kane posted and later deleted (Wendigoon).

The creatures

- [KANE] He calls the creature "the Lifeform". It isn't a human turned into something by the bacteria, though its life cycle seems to involve human remains (TV Tropes, from Discord).
- [KANE] The Lifeform and the Still Lifes are completely separate (TV Tropes, from Discord).
- [KANE] In his commentary, he explained Clark kept Kat's head hoping the Complex would remember her (TV Tropes trivia).
- [KANE] Asked whether there are animals, he asked what counts as an animal (Smosh, 2024).

The film

- [KANE] It's set in June and July 1990, and the series' Async arc stops at the end of May 1990 (Wendigoon on set).
- [KANE] It was meant to be a first step that works for newcomers while keeping direct continuity with his work, as the first short was (A24 Podcast, 2026).
- [KANE] The danger was putting too much lore into one film. They focused on the most fundamental elements (A24 Podcast, 2026. The Playlist, 2026).
- [KANE] The script was where he had least control, and his authority grew through production. He made swaps to keep it consistent so it wouldn't become "a costume worn by a different" story (Interview Magazine, 2026).
- [KANE] It's built to be paused and analysed (A24 Podcast, 2026).
- [KANE] He doesn't see it as a horror film (The Playlist, 2026).
- [KANE] The "living rooms, bedrooms, dinettes" line is a deliberate Montgomery Flea Market reference (as reported by TV Tropes).
- [KANE] The "6 7" house number wasn't deliberate (Smosh Asks, 2026).
- [KANE] Some period details, like sprinklers and cabling, aren't right because the budget couldn't fix everything (A24 Podcast, 2026).
- [KANE] Everything Must Go isn't behind-the-scenes material or a re-edit, and fans of the YouTube series will probably like it (Discord, as reported).

Theories

- [KANE] One person worked it all out, in a comment with two likes (Smosh, 2024).
- [KANE] Film Theory's reading was "fairly off" (Smosh, 2024).
- [KANE] No fan theory has ever changed his outline (Padilla, 2023).

What's next

- [KANE] His goal is a limited series to finish the story. In 2024 he put it at nine episodes if the film did well. In 2026 he called a limited series "the dream scenario" for reaching the main ending (Padilla, 2023. Smosh, 2024. Deadline, 2026).
- [KANE] He'd love a single season (Smosh Asks, 2026).

- [KANE] In September 2026 he said there were "a few things" he'd love to talk about soon (Deadline, 2026).

Cast and crew

[CREW] Statements from the cast and crew are collected in Part IV with the making of the film. The ones that matter most for the story come from Danny Vermette. Kane's Blender map covered about 100,000 square feet and crashed Vermette's computer, about 30,000 square feet were built across four Vancouver stages, Vermette wanted the spaces vertical and awkward rather than flat and endless, and he kept every detail period-correct for 1990. Mark Duplass vouched for Kane's command of the set.

Music and Sound

Kane as composer

[KANE] Kane scores all his own videos and co-scored the film with Edo van Breemen. He works in FL Studio with software instruments. For the film he used no orchestra, only a few single instruments, mostly bass clarinet with some fiddle and tambourine. He wanted "very gentle but massive drones and wails" with an aged 1990s to 2000s feel, like something echoing down a corridor, always shifting instead of repeating a tune (Interview Magazine, 2026; see Part IV).

[REAL WORLD] His music lives on a second YouTube channel, **Not Kane Pixels**, in two main playlists. The Backrooms OST collects the series' score. Out of Sync is a looser set of pieces, covers and demos that Wendigoon and others read as a portrait of Ivan Beck.

The Backrooms OST

[REAL WORLD] Forty-five tracks on the Not Kane Pixels playlist as of October 2026, with about six million total plays. In playlist order, with the play counts shown when it was read, they are listed below. Where a track is known to play in a particular episode or scene, that's noted.

No.	Track	Length	Plays	Where it's heard
1	Government Funding	4:10	1.5M	Async's motif and the series' unofficial theme. Returns in the film inside "Humble MRI Company" and "Cold Floor"
2	Pipes	3:04	714K	
3	You're Done (Daisy Bell)	2:35	592K	Built on "Daisy Bell", the 1892 song a computer first sang in 1961
4	Glacier	3:32	553K	A second version is on Out of Sync
5	Missing Persons	3:28	625K	Missing Persons
6	Auditory Guidepost	3:42	324K	Part of it returns in the film's "Cold Floor"
7	The Complex	7:04	914K	
8	KV31	4:55	381K	
9	Deeper Than The Walls	4:38	287K	
10	Sealed Away	2:20	352K	
11	Post-Traumatic Amnesia	3:44	273K	A second version is on Out of Sync
12	Person	3:34	265K	
13	Not Your Decision	2:19	329K	
14	The Only Thing That Matters (Demo)	2:35	192K	
15	Async Research Institute	2:54	263K	
16	Hazmat	2:20	202K	
17	Malignant	2:30	263K	
18	Instances	4:53	260K	
19	Compromises	5:16	391K	
20	Please do not Speak	3:25	316K	
21	Non-Disclosure Agreement	5:17	157K	
22	Hanging Frame (Time Passages)	6:15	209K	
23	Remember	3:11	159K	

No.	Track	Length	Plays	Where it's heard
24	Turn on the TV (Demo)	6:15	168K	An orchestral demo is on Out of Sync
25	data not accessible	2:34	125K	
26	Old Objects in Quiet Rooms	6:50	149K	
27	A Passage	3:42	130K	
28	Distant	4:55	93K	
29	Ghost	3:56	91K	
30	Department of Energy	3:51	106K	Named for Presentation's visitors
31	Congratulations, Ivan	3:18	163K	
32	The Reason	2:46	210K	
33	Tunnel Vision	4:24	159K	
34	For the Sake of Mankind, There Is Nothing More to Be Extracted	10:51	246K	Echoes the last line of Damage Control
35	MidwesternTraumaLight	7:39	113K	
36	Survey	2:18	80K	
37	Threshold	5:47	147K	
38	Off the Deep End	2:47	101K	
39	Boxed In (DEMO)	3:19	111K	
40	Rest Forever in This Dead End	6:51	291K	
41	Still Life	4:39	1.8M	The clarinet loop from the Still Life dens in Found Footage #3. In the film it plays from intercoms, and the soundtrack version is "Old Home Not Yet Built"
42	Do You Like Air Conditioning	2:47	2M	Ravi's chase in Found Footage #3. The most played track
43	Red Sun in the Sky	4:47	150K	No scene confirmed. See the Red City section
44	UL Listed	7:53	168K	Shares its name with the UL mark on the copied troffer in Lighting and Tile Survey
45	Kane Parsons - Instruments of Measurement	7:09	76K	Posted about three months before October 2026

[FAN] TV Tropes says "Still Life" appears on Volume 3 of the series soundtrack, which suggests the playlist is grouped into volumes in other releases.

Out of Sync

[REAL WORLD] Forty-one tracks, listed here in playlist order.

A Long Time Ago. Who was that again? In Sight In Mind. whatthefuckareyoutalkingabout. Glacier (Version 2). 1980. Post-Traumatic Amnesia (V2). A Job in Silicon Valley 198X. You Have Always Been Here (Piano Version). Alive. Loman Commutes. OctoberDoor1989. Christopher Cross, "Sailing" (cover). Document Purge. A Life (Entropy Part 1). Seizure. Asynchronous Suppression (Demo). Tidal Pools. You Have Always Been Here. Contractors. Alphaville, "Forever Young" (cover). Steady Machine. You Cannot Make It Go Away. The Same Material (Demo). Government Funding (Orchestral Version). Sundown Entry Wound. Don't Leave. Sea Ice. A Glimpse (Demo). OMD, "Souvenir" (cover). None of Them Trust You. Neuron Home. Ivan Visits the Light + Defy. Turn on the TV (Orchestral Version) (Demo). Overlooking The Sea. Watching The Clock (Demo). IVN (V2). remains. Government Funding V2. Visible Light. Oldsong.

[FAN] **What the covers show**, according to Wendigoon's reading.

- **A Long Time Ago** opens with art by the American illustrator George Brehm, and Wendigoon reads it as Beck's childhood.
- **In Sight In Mind** shows an American community, perhaps Beck after emigrating.
- **Post-Traumatic Amnesia** shows an eye with rooms of the facility bending into each other, read as Beck after the 1972 event.
- **A Life (Entropy Part 1)** uses the Flammarion engraving, the famous image of a traveller poking his head through the edge of the sky to see the workings of the heavens beyond. Wendigoon reads it as Beck reaching past the edge of reality.
- **The Same Material** starts on a California evening and fades into the Threshold, then the Threshold drenched in green.
- **Sea Ice** shows floating ice, a green aurora and the sun rising over the ocean.
- **Ivan Visits the Light + Defy** shows the sun rising over a suburban house.
- **IVN (V2)** follows an earlier "IVN" that showed someone floating in green light with the whole face visible. The second version shows only a single eye.
- **Visible Light** shows a sketch of Beck among people and the prototype, shifting through the spectrum from blue to red and ending on green.
- **Oldsong** returns to Brehm, perhaps an older Beck.
- **Sundown Entry Wound** shows the sun with a green flash. It plays over the opening phone call of Static Dead End.
- A cover with a man in a suit, face censored, test charts behind him and the headline of the faked vineyard wreck that covered up Tench's disappearance. Eight rods point inward, the prototype, and the man's face is replaced by a picture of the Sun during the August 1972 storm, with the sunspot over his right eye.
- **Overlooking The Sea** and **You Have Always Been Here** take their titles from lines in I Remember.
- **OctoberDoor1989** points at the Threshold opening. **A Job in Silicon Valley 198X** and **Loman Commutes** sound like ordinary working life at Async, Loman being the doomed salesman of Death of a Salesman. **Document Purge** and **None of Them Trust You** fit the cover-ups.

[REAL WORLD] **The covers.** Christopher Cross's "Sailing" (1979), whose line about sailing away if the wind is right is written in Peter Tench's drawings in Damage Control. Alphaville's "Forever Young" (1984). OMD's "Souvenir" (1981).

Music and sound inside the series

- [CANON] **Found Footage.** Ravenholm ambience from Half-Life 2 in the Staircase Room, and the ambient track "13" by C418 somewhere along the way (TV Tropes).
- [CANON] **Pitfalls.** MGMT's "Kids" (2008) and a 2015 ABC News interview cut into Marvin's radio.
- [CANON] **Simpsons.** A 2000 Dimacol advert in a 1991 broadcast.
- [CANON] **Found Footage #2.** Wind chimes as the tape ends on someone's television.
- [CANON] **I Remember.** Wind chimes and cassette noise under the narration.
- [CANON] **Overflow.** Wind chimes, and a radio playing a 1972 press conference about trade with the Soviets.
- [CANON] **Damage Control.** The line from "Sailing" in Tench's drawings. Music in the empty house at the end.
- [CANON] **Found Footage #3.** The Chinese song "煤气灶" ("Gas Stove") in the dance studio. "Still Life" from speakers in the dens. "Do You Like Air Conditioning" in the chase. A freecreditreport.com jingle

through the father's wall.

- [CANON] **Static Dead End.** "Sundown Entry Wound" under the phone call.
- [CANON] **Everything Must Go.** A television in the store copy playing strange video and music.

Music and sound in the film

- [FILM] **Score.** Kane and Edo van Breemen. Named cues include "Cold Floor" (with pieces of "Auditory Guidepost" and "Government Funding", as Async pulls Mary through the Threshold), "Humble MRI Company" (under Phil's MRI line, with "Government Funding" again), and "Old Home Not Yet Built" (the film's version of "Still Life").
- [FILM] **From The Oldest View.** "Scent of Freshly Cut Grass" after Clark's first escape.
- [FILM] **Needle drops.** "Ulterior Motives" (the once-unidentified "lostwave" song also known as "Everyone Knows That") at Mary's party. The Payolas' "Eyes of a Stranger". The Caretaker's "B1 - All that follows is true" during Mary's memory of her mother in hospital. José Feliciano's "Feliz Navidad" from a music box in the Christmas tree room. 1920s jazz on a record in the dining room, with a reversed "You Can't Forget" under it according to the fan wiki.
- [FILM] **Credits.** Boards of Canada's "The Word Becomes Flesh" from Inferno, their first album in thirteen years, released the same day as the film. Its words follow an embryo growing.
- [FILM] **The cutouts.** Greetings from the 1977 Voyager Golden Record, in 55 languages including Sumerian, Akkadian, Hittite and Ancient Greek, with the line "Hello from the children of planet Earth".
- [FILM] **The store.** Bossa nova muzak still playing in the empty store when Mary arrives.
- [OFFICIAL] **The trailer** reworks Instupendo's "Six Forty Seven" into a ticking loop and uses the Voyager greetings over Clark's first entry.
- [OFFICIAL] **The promo commercial** uses a tavern-style cover of DragonForce's "Through the Fire and Flames" by Algal the Bard.
- [KANE] Asked on Smosh Asks about needle drops, Kane confirmed there are some (2026).

The sounds of the place

- [CANON] **The hum.** Every light hums at 120 Hz, twice the 60 Hz mains frequency, because the steel core of the ballast stretches and shrinks twice per cycle. The original 4chan caption's "fluorescent lights at maximum hum-buzz" turns out to be right about the physics.
- [CANON] **Silence.** Long stretches of nothing but hum and footsteps, which the Lifeform and the Still Lifes use to hide.
- [CANON] **Voices that aren't people.** The Lifeform copying cries for help. The knocker's polite knock.
- [CANON] **The alarm** at the Threshold, which TV Tropes says doubles as an audio guide home while the Threshold is open.
- [CANON] **The screech** heard faintly in Static Dead End, according to Taylor Holmes [UNVERIFIED].
- [FILM] **Distant shrieks and thuds.** Pirate Clark's footsteps, his peg on the floor, the knocking before the smash.

PART VIII

Theories, Hypotheses and the Mathematics

What fans have argued, what we've worked out ourselves, and the numbers behind both.

A Catalogue of Fan Theories

Every theory here is fan work, not canon. Each one gets a status. **Confirmed** means a later video, the film or Kane has said it's so. **Jossed** means the same sources have ruled it out. **Open** means nothing settles it yet. **Weak** means it's still open but the evidence on screen leans against it. Where we've added our own assessment it's marked as ours.

The main collections drawn on are the TV Tropes theory pages for the series and the film, Wendigoon's three hour analysis (April 2026), Taylor Holmes's film explainer (2026), the fan wiki's theory pages, and the fan sheets supplied with this commission.

What the Complex is

Theory	Who	Status
The Complex copies real places, and gets worse the more it copies	many, the fan wiki's "copy of a copy"	**Confirmed** in spirit by Clark's line and the film's montages
It builds from the memories of the people inside it ("Memory Theory")	fan wiki	**Weak**. Kane says it doesn't pick moments from minds, and the Lighting and Tile Survey's serial numbers are beyond anyone's memory
It has its own memory, independent of visitors	fan wiki, Clark's wording	**Open**, and the reading that best fits the evidence
It copies more accurately near a null zone, so places get vaguer the further you are from an opening	Wendigoon	**Weak**. The first rooms in Found Footage #1 and #2 are already abstract
It copies more accurately the longer it "holds" someone, which is why Ravi saw a drum kit like his own	Wendigoon	**Open**
It's a simulation, a computer, or Ivan Beck's dream	various, reported by Wendigoon	**Weak**. Too much physical interaction with the real world, as Wendigoon himself argues
It's an MRI scan made into a place, since Async made MRI machines and Mary is scanned at the end	fan wiki theory	**Open** as metaphor. Nothing literal supports it
Before 1972 it was a void, and Ivan Beck was the first thing it touched. The yellow wallpaper is from his past, and Kane said the wallpaper design comes from Europe	Wendigoon	**Open**. Elegant, unprovable so far
It acts like an immune system, with Still Lifes as antibodies repelling intruders	Wendigoon	**Open**. Several Still Lifes in the film are harmless, which weakens it
It didn't exist, or not in its current form, until Async opened the Threshold	TV Tropes	**Weak**. Overflow (1972) and the ALS Still Life's old clothes suggest it's older
The real world in the film is itself a fresher memory that hasn't degraded yet. The crooked switch is a sign	TV Tropes film theories	**Open**, and impossible to test
It can be destroyed if everyone who knows about it forgets or dies	TV Tropes film theories	**Open**
Its output converges on the yellow rooms like an evolving algorithm, and the credits song about an embryo hints it's growing into something	TV Tropes film theories	**Open**
As it merges with reality, its creations will appear in the world, like in Satoshi Kon's Paprika	TV Tropes film theories	**Open**

Theory	Who	Status
It deliberately lured Clark, and used him to lure Mary through her trauma about opening the window	TV Tropes film theories	**Open**. The timing of the voicemail is suggestive

Null zones and time

Theory	Who	Status
Null zones appeared because of the Threshold	widely held	**Open**, heavily implied by the missing persons spike
The sixth test worked because of the October 1989 solar storms, and Overflow happened during the August 1972 storm	Wendigoon	**Open**. The 1972 match is exact. The big October 1989 flare came two days after the test
The green glow is gamma radiation linked to layout changes	fan wiki	**Weak** as stated, since gamma rays aren't visible. **Open** that the glow marks layout changes
The green glow is the Complex reshaping itself in real time	Wendigoon	**Open**
A thinning of the barrier followed by a flash throws people in or forward in time	Wendigoon	**Open**
The time jump grows exponentially with the length of the fall, jump = 189.4 e^1.027t days	fan sheet supplied with this commission	**Weak**. Two points fit any two-parameter curve, and Tench's jump without a fall doesn't fit. See the null zones chapter
Null zones form in dense, stressed solid matter because energy density curves spacetime	fan sheet supplied with this commission	**Weak**. Concrete doesn't curve spacetime noticeably more than wood, and the seagull came through air
"Noclip tips" (basements and garages, keep long objects away, you can't pick where you land)	fan sheet supplied with this commission	Partly supported. See the null zones chapter
The "29 February 1990" date is deliberate, a date only the Complex has	many fans	**Open**. Later episodes simply say 1 March
The 2000s cars in the film are a time slip	TV Tropes film theories	**Weak**. Most likely a production slip, like the sprinklers Kane admits to

The Lifeform

Theory	Who	Status
The bacteria turn people into Lifeforms	many	**Jossed** by Kane on Discord
Marvin was infected in Pitfalls and will turn	TV Tropes	**Jossed**
The thing in Ravi's studio is the Found Footage #1 cameraman, transformed	TV Tropes	**Jossed**
The Lifeform grows from human remains like a fungus or colony	many, Wendigoon	**Open**, and Kane says its life cycle does involve human remains
The Lifeform kills, keeps what it needs, and leaves the clothes and a black stain, which explains the clothes piles	Wendigoon	**Open**
It's a droid or synthetic being	TV Tropes	**Jossed** by its bacterial nature
It's a motion camera from Motion Detected taken over by a Lifeform, which is why it records and plays back voices	TV Tropes	**Weak**
It's blind and screams for echolocation	TV Tropes	**Open**
It isn't malicious, just lonely and bad at communicating, and the last one in Found Footage saved Kane from falling	TV Tropes	**Open**. Its behaviour in Pitfalls and Found Footage #2 argues against

Theory	Who	Status
Individual Lifeforms have different temperaments	TV Tropes	**Open**
The voices in Missing Persons are Kane's take on the wiki's Partygoers	TV Tropes	**Jossed** in effect, since the Lifeform mimics voices
Lifeforms are fearful of Still Lifes, which is why one wouldn't follow Kane down	TV Tropes film theories	**Open**
Lifeforms are very old, very degraded copies of people, scribbles of a human	TV Tropes film theories	**Weak**. Kane says they're unrelated to Still Lifes
Lifeforms are traumatic memories of people trapped inside, their microbe nature a literal "dis-ease"	TV Tropes film theories	**Open** as metaphor

Still Lifes

Theory	Who	Status
The Found Footage #3 knocker was a Still Life	many	**Confirmed** in effect by the film's callback
Still Lifes are snapshots of a person at a particular moment	Wendigoon, TV Tropes	**Confirmed** by Pirate Clark and Mary's copy
Still Lifes are made at a person's lowest or most intense moment. Pirate Clark is Clark when the chair broke under him	TV Tropes film theories	**Open**. Kane says it doesn't pick moments from minds
The Redheaded Still Life is Barbara	TV Tropes film theories, many	**Open**
The bearded one is Clark's stepfather and ALS is Barbara's brother	TV Tropes film theories	**Open**, with no evidence
The hazmat Still Life on the vinyl sleeve is Mark Blume	TV Tropes YMMV	**Open**
The grey figure with a phone outside the blue-box house is a Still Life	Wendigoon	**Open**
Eating Still Lifes protected Clark from the bacteria	TV Tropes film theories	**Open**
The wiki's Partygoers, Hounds and Skin Stealers could return as Still Lifes of hazmat staff, lost pets and Clark's scalping	TV Tropes film theories	**Open**, speculation about a sequel

Async and the people

Theory	Who	Status
Async plans to trap people inside as slave labour	TV Tropes	**Jossed** by the film and Kane
Async faked Tench's death a second time, and he's alive	many	**Open**. Damage Control's last images keep it alive
Async forced Tench back into the Complex	Reunion's implication	**Open**. Damage Control tells it differently
Tench narrated I Remember	TV Tropes	**Weak**. The wind chimes point to Beck
Beck narrated I Remember and watched Found Footage #2's tape	fan wiki	**Open**, widely held
Beck lost his right eye to the 1972 event, and he's Ahab chasing his whale	Wendigoon	**Open**
Kane named Altman after Sam Altman	fans	**Weak**. Kane said he considered renaming him because the name had become too pointed, which implies the name came first
Async collects and presents the found footage	TV Tropes, the film's hints	**Open**

Theory	Who	Status
Ravi's footage was edited and paused by someone presenting it	TV Tropes	**Open**
A leak from inside or across a null zone will expose Async	TV Tropes	**Open**
Clark caused some of the strange things Async found later	TV Tropes film theories	**Weak**. The film's timeline puts Async's finds first
Mary was Clark's therapist for years	TV Tropes, before release	**Jossed**. He came to her after his divorce
Clark will stay in the Backrooms	TV Tropes, before release	**Confirmed**
The Lifeform will appear in the film	TV Tropes, before release	**Jossed**
The green glow will appear in the film	TV Tropes, before release	**Confirmed**, barely

Readings of the film

[FAN] Taylor Holmes lays out five ways to read the film. The literal reading, where the Complex is just a strange physical place. Async as the real villain. A hybrid, where the Complex is a real place that's shaped by the minds near it, which is the one he favours. A trauma allegory, where the whole thing is about Clark's and Mary's damage. And a reading where it's all Mary's story, the Complex standing for her mother's house and her own fear.

[FAN] Wendigoon reads the series through The Yellow Wallpaper, Charlotte Perkins Gilman's 1892 story about a woman confined to a room whose wallpaper seems to hold a trapped woman. The hidden video 9780415263573 is titled with the ISBN of an edition of that story, and Wendigoon reads it as an allegory for Ivan Beck, someone so set on freeing what's behind the wall that he becomes it. He also compares the series to House of Leaves, which Kane says he has never read.

[FAN] Other connections fans make include Richard Matheson's "Little Girl Lost", filmed for The Twilight Zone in 1962, in which a girl named Tina rolls through a wall into another dimension, her parents hear her but can't find her, and a physicist friend outlines the opening in chalk the way Clark tapes his (TV Tropes lists the parallels). Also the Winchester Mystery House near Clark's store, Goya's Saturn for Pirate Clark, and Conway's Game of Life for the name Still Life.

What Kane has said about theories

[KANE] One person got it all right, in a comment with two likes. Film Theory's reading was "fairly off". No theory has ever changed his outline (Smosh, 2024. Padilla, 2023).

Our Own Hypotheses

This chapter collects the ideas we've worked out ourselves while putting this book together, along with your own hypotheses and the theory you brought in from elsewhere. Your ideas are tagged as yours, ours are tagged as ours, and each is checked against canon as hard as the fan theories were. The mathematics behind several of them is set out in full in the next chapter.

Ground rules we held ourselves to

[OURS] We started from three facts that any theory of the Complex has to explain.

1. **It copies the physical world, not people's impressions of it.** Ballast serial numbers, the factory and year on a troffer, ductwork above the ceiling. Nobody remembers those, yet they're there. Kane's own words, from a Japanese interview as summarised in translation on note.com, describe the Complex as synthesising environments internally and building "a cache of physical spatial information", and as "obsessed" with how our world is physically structured.
2. **Its copies degrade.** Clark's line says each remembering is worse than the last. Danny Vermette described the film's design the same way, that the deeper you sink into this world, the less things are remembered and the further they drift from their original state (motionpictures.org, 2026).
3. **It isn't random.** The three sale signs are one physical object placed three times at shrinking sizes, with identical flaws. The yellow rooms repeat. Errors fall into a handful of recurring kinds.

Your hypothesis, that the Complex is steadier where people are

[YOURS] You proposed that the Complex is more stable where beings are present, and less stable where nobody is.

[OURS] Canon never says this outright, but it points that way more than it points against.

- **The three-person rule.** The fan wiki records that Async requires at least three people per expedition "due to its unstable nature". No episode states the reason in those words, so we treat it as likely rather than confirmed.
- **Lone people suffer most.** Tench vanished and lost two months the moment he was alone. Marvin's worst minutes were alone at the bottom of a pit. Ravi and the woman in the garage were alone throughout.
- **Room 14C changed between visits.** Nobody watched it change. It was simply different when Marvin came back.
- **Nothing rebuilds casually in front of someone.** The exceptions are dramatic and come with the green glow, as in the last room of Found Footage #2. The stretching in the Static Dead End is slow enough that Async had to tape squares to the wall to see it.

[OURS] If we read Clark's line literally, your idea follows almost by itself. "The more times it remembers something, the less it does." Suppose a space is held steady for as long as someone can perceive it, and that each time someone comes back to a space nobody has been perceiving, the Complex has to remember it again. Every return is one more remembering, and each remembering is a little worse. A place watched continuously is remembered once and kept. A place visited, abandoned and revisited is remembered again and again. A larger group spread out holds more of the Complex steady at once, so fewer places get remembered afresh, and the place as a whole is steadier. That's the three-person rule as a consequence rather than a precaution.

[OURS] It makes predictions that could be checked against future episodes. Busy places like the Main Chamber should be the most regular, and they are. Remote places, rarely seen, should be the most changed. Places seen once and never again should be most likely to differ when someone does come back. The obvious counterexample would be a room changing dramatically in front of a group without any green glow. None has been shown yet.

The theory you brought in

[YOURS] You came across a theory, source unknown, with three parts. The Complex's first capture of a place keeps its original look. Every copy is a copy of a copy and loses something, like a JPEG saved over and over. And the yellow office rooms are the default it falls back to once enough has been lost.

[OURS] It doesn't come from any Kane source, so we treat it as a fan theory. Its three parts hold up differently.

- **First capture keeps the look. Supported.** Clark's store, Mary's childhood house and the house in the blue box are all recognisable. The house Ravi finds is the most complete thing in the series.
- **Copy of a copy. Supported in spirit.** Vermette's description, Clark's line, and the three signs in a row, each worse than the last.
- **Yellow as the default. Partly contradicted.** The Threshold opened straight into the yellow rooms in 1989. Yellow isn't found only far away from real places. It's the most common state everywhere, with real places sitting inside it like islands. A better wording is that the yellow rooms are whatever the Complex has repeated most, and real places are fresh rememberings set into it.

Copying as lossy compression

[OURS] The JPEG comparison is better than it looks, because it points to real mathematics. Information theory proves that a copy made from a copy can't hold more information about the original than the copy it was made from. That's the data-processing inequality. Each generation can only stay level or lose.

[OURS] And lossy compression doesn't lose things at random. It drops the finest detail first and keeps the large shapes longest, then fills the gaps with whatever is most typical. Image compression throws away high frequencies. Human memory does the same. People recalling a story drift toward the version their culture expects, which Frederic Bartlett showed in 1932. A system remembering a room badly should forget the clutter, then the shape of the furniture, then the windows, and keep the walls, the floor and the ceiling. Where it's lost something it should fill in the most typical thing it knows. Clark's dog-drawing line is this exactly. Someone who has never seen a dog and is drawing from a description will get the overall shape and fill the rest with guesses.

The teaser, panel by panel



The teaser's sequence of eight stages, supplied with this commission. A sunlit basement room is remembered again and again until it becomes the yellow rooms.

[OURS] The teaser is the best evidence we have for how the remembering works, because it shows one room passing through eight stages.

Stage	What changes
1, the original	A sunlit basement with a strip window, an armchair, a shelf, clutter, a door and a ceiling lamp
2	The clutter is gone. The window, chair and shelf survive. The light goes prismatic
3	The window slips lower. The shelf flattens into the wall. The armchair melts, its arms sinking into the floor

Stage	What changes
4	The window is now only a frame on the wall. Trim lines appear. The chair is a stub fused into the corner. The room is bigger
5	An empty box with only the lamp and a dark doorway. No window
6	Bigger again. The walls bend. A raised step appears in the floor
7	The walls yellow. A dark arched passage appears that wasn't there before
8	The yellow office Backrooms, with partitions and fluorescent panels

[OURS] Six things come out of it.

1. **Fine detail goes first.** Clutter, then the shape of the furniture, then the window. The walls, floor and ceiling last longest.
2. **Objects don't wander off. They sink and fuse** into floors and walls, as in the Static Dead End and the film.
3. **Light simplifies.** The sunlight from outside goes first, the lamp stays, and generic fluorescent panels take over at the end.
4. **Proportions drift.** Rooms grow, walls bend, floors step.
5. **It converges on one type,** the Complex's most common memory, the yellow office.
6. **Deeper means further down.** The camera sinks through the floor into each worse copy.

[OURS] Every one of these fits lossy compression with a typical room as the fallback. Point 3 also fits the Red City. A copied outdoor scene with no real sun would have to keep its lamps, which is the core of your floodlight hypothesis.

Drifting toward the common, with glitches as mutations

[OURS] If each copy is put together from pieces of the copy before it, picked in proportion to how often each piece appears, then rare pieces vanish first and common ones take over. Population genetics has exactly this model, genetic drift, worked out by Wright and Fisher. On its own, drift ends with every piece the same. But if the copying also makes occasional mistakes, mutations in the genetic version, variety settles at a steady level instead of disappearing. That's a good description of the deep Complex. The yellow rooms go on and on, but every so often there's a pool, a Christmas tree, a playground, a mirrored stop sign.

[OURS] On this reading the visible glitches, furniture through walls, sagging floors, signs half sunk in carpet, are the mutations. They aren't failures of the system. They're what keeps it from collapsing into a single room repeated forever.

Real places as fresh islands

[OURS] Real places turn up inside the Complex in near-perfect condition, Clark's store and Ravi's house among them. On our reading these are fresh rememberings, first-generation copies, set down in the middle of much older material. Their freshness depends on how recently and how directly the Complex has met the original. Clark's store was copied while its basement was joined to the Complex. The house Ravi finds is right next to a null zone, the father's wall. Wendigoon has the same intuition about proximity.

Depth means generations, not distance

[OURS] "Deeper" in the Complex shouldn't be measured in metres from the Threshold. It should be measured in how many times a thing has been copied. The yellow rooms right outside the Threshold are old and repeated, which is why they're so generic. Clark's store, much further away, is young. That explains how the most degraded material in the series sits at the front door.

Where the seams go

[OURS] A useful result from computer graphics bears on how the Complex might join its pieces. Researchers studying how to build new shapes that look locally just like an example (Kalojanov, Bokeloh, Wand and others, 2012) proved that any such shape can only be made of particular pieces of the example, which they called microtiles, joined only along boundaries that actually occur in the example. If the Complex builds new layouts that look locally like real buildings, its seams should fall where real buildings join, at doorways, corridor ends and junctions. Mostly they do. Rooms in the Complex usually connect through openings. The exceptions are revealing. The crack running across a hallway floor in Found Footage #3, where two kinds of room meet, and the Static Dead End, half wallpaper and half tile, are places where two pieces were forced together without a natural join between them. They look exactly like what you'd expect when no clean join was available.

Overlapping rooms

[OURS] Virtual reality research shows people don't notice when rooms overlap. In Evan Suma's "Impossible Spaces" studies (2012), people walked through rooms that overlapped by up to about 56 per cent without noticing. Khrystyna Vasylevska's "Flexible Spaces" (2013) rearranged parts of a layout while they were out of sight, and people didn't notice that either. Three things in canon look like this. Room 14C rearranged itself while nobody was there. Kat could see Clark through a wall he couldn't see through, which is what you'd get if two copies shared the same space and only one was solid from one side. And mapping keeps failing. Clark's mural complains that the floor plan "changed again".

Why it copies what it copies

[OURS] The Complex copies places near its openings and people near its openings. Clark's store, the basement copies, the father's house next to the null zone in his wall. In the film it copies Mary at Async, right beside the Threshold. Everything copied was near a connection when it was copied, or was something that had gone through one, like the car, the seagull, and the clothes and shoes of the dead. That suggests a simple rule. The Complex copies what touches it. The Heathrow atrium and the Arcadia flyer are the hard cases, since we don't know of any connection in London or Arcadia, but a world full of brief, unseen null zones would explain them as easily as it explains the car on the highway.

Your floodlights

[YOURS] [OURS] Covered in full in the gazetteer under the Red City. Our verdict is that the red light almost certainly comes from coloured lamps rather than the sky, the camera or the glass, and that the two spots you circled are good candidates for those lamps but need a motion test to rule out reflections.

The fourth sign

[OURS] Everything Must Go gives three sign widths and two gaps, and Async correctly predicted a fourth sign behind the wall. The next chapter works out what that fourth sign should measure under each rule that fits the first three. The footage shows it "much smaller and barely clear of the carpet", which fits some rules better than others.

Where this leads

[OURS] The next three chapters pull all of these ideas, and the ones you brought in from your own discussions, into a single working theory of ten laws, test it against everything in this book, and use it to answer every question about the Complex it can reach.

A Working Theory of the Complex

This chapter gathers everything in the last two chapters, together with the questions you kept asking and the hypotheses you brought in from your own long discussions, into a single theory of how the Complex behaves. It's set out as ten laws. Each law says what it claims, what in canon supports it, what it explains, what it doesn't claim, what would break it, and how sure we are.

Every law was checked against every relevant case in this book, from the troffer labels to the last shot of Mary's Still Life. Ideas that failed those checks were thrown out or rewritten, and the next chapter records which ones and why. The chapter after that answers, one by one, every question about the Complex that this theory can reach.

None of this is canon. Kane has said plainly that the audience's reading of what the place is and how it works is as valid as the characters' reading, and that he doesn't want to pin it down. A working theory is the right thing to aim for. It should explain as much as possible with as little as possible, and say clearly where it could be wrong.

What Kane has said, and what he hasn't

Any theory has to start from Kane's own words, and some popular claims about them turned out to be wrong when we went looking.

[KANE] In his Japanese interviews, as summarised in translation on note.com, Kane describes the Complex as a domain that "recognizes, interprets, and stores" the physical structure of the world we live in. He calls it a massive system that is "obsessed" with information about how our world is physically built. He says it "synthesizes such environments internally" and builds "a cache of physical spatial information", that it takes structures in and "aggregates" them, and that "sometimes, humans get caught up in that too". Asked about a mind behind it, he says "I don't know if there is intelligence or intent behind it."

[KANE] Elsewhere he has called it a neutral technology, not inherently anything, which could do great good or great harm or simply be nature if everyone left it alone (Wendigoon on set). He has described it as closer to a force of nature than a hell or a punishment. And he has said it isn't picking out particular moments from people's minds (as reported by TV Tropes).

[OURS] Three claims that circulate as Kane quotes couldn't be found anywhere.

- **That the Complex "is getting better at learning".** No interview, commentary or Discord report we could find says this. The nearest line in canon belongs to someone in Everything Must Go who says the television "just keeps getting better and better". The idea of a Complex that improves can still be argued from the laws below, but it shouldn't be attributed to Kane.
- **That the Complex isn't sentient.** Kane says he doesn't know. "Neutral" is a word about good and evil, not about whether something has a mind. This theory needs no mind to work, but it can't rule one out, and neither can anyone else yet.
- **That the Complex isn't human-centric.** Nothing in this exact form was found. What Kane has said, that humans "get caught up" in it, does point the same way. People are incidental to what it does, not its target.

The ten laws in brief

- **1. Capture.** The Complex takes in the physical structure of whatever touches it. It takes a whole scene at one moment, and the people in that scene are caught up with it.
- **2. Two fidelities.** What a thing is comes through almost perfectly. Where it belongs comes through badly.
- **3. Matter, not light.** Sky, sun, stars, horizon and distance aren't objects, so they can't be captured. Every outdoor copy arrives without them.
- **4. The open space is the centre.** A copy keeps the open space at its heart and the faces that border it, to a depth that fades. The Complex then closes that open space with its own material, so the faces always look inward.
- **5. Interpretation.** Whatever is missing, whether it was never captured, lost through repetition or damaged, is filled from what the Complex already holds, matched by look and by role.
- **6. Every remembering is a worse copy.** Each copy is made from the last. Detail drains away and the filling grows.
- **7. The snowball.** The default is whatever the Complex has repeated most, and because it copies its own copies, its earliest material snowballed into the yellow rooms.
- **8. Continuation.** It extends itself through openings, joins pieces at natural seams, forces joins where there are none, and fills the gaps with its default rooms.
- **9. Structure before function.** Forms come through well. Working insides and behaviour come through roughly, and best in the freshest copies.
- **10. Reaching back.** Once joined to a place, the Complex begins to change our side too.

Law 1. Capture

Law 1

The Complex takes in the physical structure of whatever touches it, places next to its openings and things that pass through them. It takes a whole scene at one moment, and anyone in that scene comes along as a passenger, wearing what they wore and holding what they held.

What canon shows

[CANON] [FILM] Every copy whose origin we know was made near an opening, or of something that went through one.

- **Clark's store.** At least three copies, made while a doorway stood open in its basement. The closing-down banners that Async found in the Kelowna Branch on 18 June 1990, before Clark ever went in, are copies of the banners hanging in the real store. They can be seen in the commercial itself.
- **The father's house.** The house in the blue box is almost certainly a copy of the house of the man Ravi talks to through a wall. Ravi describes the room he's in, a living room with a mounted fish, and the man recognises his own living room. The real house and the copy sit on either side of a null zone in that wall.
- **Mary.** Her Still Life sits in a copy of Async's interview room, a few corridors from the KV31 Threshold, the largest opening there is. She's wearing the tank top Async gave her.
- **Ravi's drum kit.** Ravi has a drum kit in the middle of his apartment, and his basement had a hole broken through a cinder block wall just before he fell in. Inside the Complex he later finds a room with a drum kit in it.
- **Things that fell through.** The car on the highway, the seagull, the clothes and shoes of the dead, and a giant copy of Bobby's "End Apartheid" shirt in Pirate Clark's lair.



Clark's commercial, frame supplied with this commission. The real store, with "MUST GO!" and "ON SALE" banners hanging from the ceiling, and Clark in the costume of his teal and yellow mascot. Both of his white sneakers are visible. The chair leg serving as a peg is strapped alongside his real lower leg.

A scene at a moment

[FILM] The copies are snapshots. Pirate Clark is Clark on the day of the commercial, in costume. Mary's copy is Mary at Async, in custody. Neither is the version of the person who spent the most time anywhere. Clark slept in his store and drank in front of the television for weeks, and Mary spent years in her therapy office, yet the copies are of a costume day and an interrogation room.

[OURS] That rules out two tempting ideas at once. The Complex isn't choosing the most typical version of a person, and it isn't choosing the most memorable one, which Kane has ruled out in any case. What decides it is physical presence at the place and moment of capture. Clothing is part of a person's physical state, so it comes along. So does anything strapped to them.

People are passengers

[KANE] Kane's own phrase is that "sometimes, humans get caught up in that too". The thing the Complex is taking is the structure of places. People are inside those places, so sometimes they come along.

[OURS] This explains why Still Lifes are rare. A person is only copied if they happen to be standing in a place at the moment the Complex takes it. Most people never stand next to an opening at all.

Capture comes in events

[FILM] Clark spent weeks in and around his doorway, going in and out, sleeping a few metres from it. The film shows exactly one copy of him. So capture isn't a continuous recording of everything near an opening. It happens in events.

[OURS] What triggers an event isn't shown. The best candidate is growth. The Complex seems to capture when it extends itself, and canon often marks its active changes with green light (see the time and green glow chapter). That would make capture rare even at a busy opening, which is what the film shows.

The hard cases, and time

[CANON] Two copies have no known opening near their originals. The courtyard of the Holiday Inn Express at Heathrow, which opened in 2018, appears in a tape from 1991. A health flyer from USC Arcadia Hospital, printed in Chinese and dated 2022, hangs in a dance studio Ravi passes in 1995.

[OURS] Both are explained if openings are brief, unseen, and scattered through time as well as space. The car on the highway proves that openings can appear and vanish where nobody is watching, and Tench's jump of 68 days proves that the Complex and our world don't share one clock. Clark's own description of the place, "every place that ever was", fits the same picture.

[OURS] There's a second half to the time problem. Almost every misplaced thing in the Complex comes from the future, which at first looks like it needs its own explanation. But old things inside the Complex don't look misplaced. A ballast made in 1975 in a ceiling looks perfectly normal, and so does a 1973 troffer. ALS's nineteenth-century clothes only stand out because a person is wearing them. The only things that look wrong are the ones from after the date of the scene. So contacts can be spread across time in both directions, and we only notice the ones from the future. The next chapter sets this out in a table.

What this law doesn't claim

[OURS] It doesn't say why openings form where they do. Async's machine makes one on purpose. Natural ones turn up in basements, garages and walls, inside solid structures, as the null zones chapter describes. Nor does it say how the capture physically works, which canon keeps hidden. The questions chapter goes as far as the evidence allows.

What would break it

- A fresh copy of a place that could never have been near any opening, at any time.
- A Still Life of a person who was never near an opening and never went through one.
- Several copies of one person made at a place they visited only once and briefly, with no opening there.

How sure we are. Strong. Every case with a known origin fits, and the two that lack one are explained by something canon already shows, openings that appear briefly and unseen.

Law 2. Two fidelities

> **Law 2**
>
> What a thing is comes through almost perfectly, down to its chemistry and the printing on its labels. Where it belongs comes through badly. Its size, its position, its orientation, how many of it there are, what it's next to and what it's for can all go wrong.

What canon shows

[CANON] The Lighting and Tile Survey is the cleanest proof. The troffer carries a real manufacturer's label, the ballast is a Universal Type A from 1975 with a serial number, the bulbs are Sylvania F40s, and the ceiling tile has the right chemistry for a real mineral fibre tile. But the tile is 1.27 by 1.14 metres, a size no manufacturer makes, and the ballast is too big. Within a single fitting, every material is right and some of the proportions are wrong.

[CANON] Everything Must Go gives the second proof. Three closing-down signs, each smaller and sunk further into the floor than the last, carry the same tiny flaws in proportional positions. One object, copied three times, perfect each time, at the wrong sizes and the wrong depths. The mathematics chapter works through the numbers.

[FILM] The film adds more. The copy of Clark's throne is bigger than the real one. Bobby's shirt is copied at giant size. Store furniture clips through walls. The mirrored stop sign is the right sign facing the wrong

way.

Why the split exists

[OURS] What a thing is lives inside the thing. The chemistry of a tile, the ink on a label, the grain of particleboard are all contained in the object itself. Where a thing belongs is a relationship between that object and others, often across a distance. Any copying process that makes small errors keeps the first kind of information far better than the second.

[SCIENCE] A simple model shows why. Suppose each remembering keeps every object intact but nudges its position by a small random amount. After n rememberings, an object has drifted by an amount that grows like the square root of n. Two objects that sit side by side drift together if they're remembered as one piece, so their relationship survives. Two objects far apart, joined by a long chain of pieces, each with its own error, drift apart by an amount that grows with the square root of the length of the chain as well. So near relationships survive and far ones decay, while the objects themselves stay perfect. The mathematics chapter sets this out in a formula.

[OURS] A photocopier that kept every letter crisp but let the margins and paragraphs drift would do the same thing on paper. The Complex does it in three dimensions.

Every error kind is a relationship failing

Error kind in canon	Which relationship failed	The thing itself
Wrong sizes, like the tile, the ballast, the throne, the tall dining table	Size relative to everything else	Correct in material and form
Repetition, like the three signs and the painting on every level of the tower	How many there should be	Identical, flaws included
Things merged into surfaces, like furniture sunk into floors	Position relative to the floor or wall	Intact apart from where it overlaps
Stretching, like the wallpaper in the Static Dead End	Proportion along one direction	The pattern is the right pattern
Facades, like the barn front	Depth behind the face	The face is correct
Mirroring, like the POTS stop sign	Orientation	Every letter correct, reversed
Lost purpose, like a hood with no cooker	What it's for and what it serves	The hood is a real hood
Wrong context, like a Christmas tree in a dark room	What surrounds it	The tree and its figures are intact

[OURS] All eight error kinds in canon are failures of relationship, not of identity. That's the strongest evidence for this law.

Lights keep the state they were captured in

[FILM] [CANON] Of the three copies of Clark's store, the accurate interior is brightly lit, while the inside-out copy and the maze are dark. The Lighting and Tile Survey says the Complex's lights never go out on their own.

[OURS] Both fit one rule. Whether a lamp is on or off is part of what it is at the moment it's taken, its physical state, so it's copied like any other identity (Law 2). A lamp captured on stays on forever, which is canon's "never go out on their own". A lamp captured off stays off forever. Copies of a place taken at night, with its lights off, are dark copies. Most of the Complex is lit because most of what it has copied was lit when it was taken, and because the default rooms are made of lit things.

What would break it

- A copy with a perfect layout but the wrong materials, such as a correctly proportioned ceiling of tiles with the wrong chemistry.
- A light that was off when captured coming on by itself, or one that was on going out by itself.

- A sign or label copied with wrong or garbled text while its placement was perfect.

How sure we are. Very strong. It's the shape of every observation in canon, and Wendigoon reached the same distinction from the light fittings alone.

Law 3. Matter, not light

> **Law 3**
>
> The Complex copies matter. It cannot copy the things that aren't matter, the sky, the sun, the stars, the horizon and distance itself. So every copy of an outdoor scene arrives with its ground, plants, objects and buildings, and without its sky. Whatever the sky did has to be done instead by something the Complex does have. And the sky doesn't only go uncopied, it drains the copying. Whatever faced the open sky comes through streamlined, like a stage set, and whatever was enclosed comes through faithful.

Why the sky can't be copied

[SCIENCE] The blue of the sky isn't a surface. It's sunlight scattered by the air, which is why the same air is black at night and orange at sunset. A star is a sun light years away, and a horizon is an effect of distance. There's nothing in any of them that a local copy of matter could contain. A capture that takes in what is physically present in a volume around an opening gets the grass and the lamp post, and gets the air in between, but it can't get the light that was falling on them from ninety-three million miles away.

Every outdoor-looking place in canon

Place	Matter that came through	What stands in for the sky and the sun
Mary's childhood home, in the film's closing montage	Rubble, grass, broken paving, an ornate street lamp	Yellow walls and fluorescent panels
The Red City	Office towers, trees, a road, a giant road sign	Lamps for stars, coloured lamps for the red light, a dark surface for the night sky
The red street in Pitfalls	Houses, trees, street lamps, a road tunnel	A dark overhead, and red light coming low from one side like a floodlight
The playground set	A tiled path, a slide, a street lamp, a building front	Lights that switch on, and an enclosed room
The house in the blue box	A whole house, porch, hedges, back fences	A box painted blue with clouds
The six-chair room	Six chairs	A skylight with a painted sky in it
The roofless apartment	Sockets, a radiator, a kitchen	Brick walls rising to "a big light"
The farm corridor	Wheelbarrows, a sledgehammer, a barn front	Leaf-print wallpaper for the foliage
The film's suburban street	Houses, fences, mailboxes, plants, a road	A drop ceiling of fluorescent panels and warehouse fans, brightly lit "as if it were day"



Frame from the film supplied with this commission. A copied suburban street inside a vast yellow room. The houses are cut off a few metres behind their fronts where they meet the walls, and the sky is a drop ceiling of fluorescent panels with big ceiling fans. Pirate Clark stands at the far end.

[OURS] Nowhere in the series or the film is there a real sky or real sunlight. Every outdoor copy is lit by fittings, which the gazetteer had already noticed while studying the Red City. This law explains why. It also explains why the playground's lights switch on, why the Red City needs lamps, and why the lights of the Complex never go out on their own. There's no other source of light in there. There's no day or night to copy.

[CANON] Ravi's last tape, in red light, has him trying to recall a day at a park as a child and saying he can't remember what the sky looked like. It isn't evidence for anything. It's still a striking line to put at the end of a walk through a place with no sky.

What this law settles

[OURS] It settles the question of plants. Grass and trees are matter, so where they were present at capture, they come through, which is why Mary's yard has real-looking grass under fluorescent panels. Substitution only fills gaps, and the biggest gap in any outdoor scene is always the sky. Earlier ideas, that the Complex replaces anything hard to reproduce with something cheap, or that it doesn't know what grass is, fail on Mary's yard. This one doesn't.

[OURS] It also settles why the Complex is always enclosed. It isn't that the Complex refuses to make an outside. It has nothing to make an outside from.

Everything that faced the sky is streamlined

[YOURS] You noticed it first, in the house in the blue box. Its front looks like a diorama. The siding is one flat blue, the hedges along the porch are green boxes, nothing is worn or out of place, and it feels like a stage set or a model even though it looks like a normal suburban house. The same feeling hangs over the film's street. Your theory is that exteriors look wrong because they were exposed to the sky.



The house in the blue box from Found Footage #3, a sharper frame supplied with this commission. Flat single-colour siding, hedges like green boxes, no wear, no clutter. Its interior is near perfect.

[CANON] **[FILM]** Every copy in canon that faced the open sky looks streamlined, and every fresh interior looks faithful.

Copy	What faced the sky	What was enclosed
The house in the blue box	Flat single-colour siding, hedges reduced to boxes, no wear, a stage-set front	A near-perfect interior, utensils, a whiskey bottle, a mounted fish, a shoe stuck in the floor
Clark's store	A plain box with a gable front, the sign and the mascot	An accurate sales floor, signs, furniture, trusses, long fluorescent tubes
The film's suburban street	Toy-clean garages, spotless fences, nothing incidental anywhere	Not shown
The red street	Boxy, simplified houses	The one house entered dissolves inward, which is Law 4's fade, a different effect
The Red City	Towers whose windows look like glowing pictures	Not shown
The playground set	Grass reduced to flat green carpet, a building that's only a front	None
The farm corridor	Foliage reduced to leaf-print wallpaper, a barn that's only a front	None



The copy of the outside of Clark's store, a frame from the film supplied with this commission. A plain box with a gable front, the sign and mascot, cars half sunk in the car park, real trees, and plain unlit ceiling tiles where the sky should be.

[OURS] Seven for seven. The film's street settles it. It was the open space at the centre of its own capture, so if fidelity only fell with distance from the opening, its fronts should be sharp and detailed. They're toy-clean instead. Distance can't explain that. Exposure to the sky can. And it isn't only a matter of budget. The film built both the store's inside and its outside copy as sets, with the same crew, and made one detailed and the other streamlined. That's a choice.

Why it feels fake

[OURS] Real outsides are covered in incidental things. Weathering, stains, uneven paint, moss, bins, hoses, toys, a bike against a wall, footprints in the grass. Streamlining removes exactly those first, because they're the smallest details (Law 6). What's left is perfect geometry, one flat colour per surface and nothing that happened to it. People read that as a model, a stage set or a diorama, a house nobody has ever lived in.

[REAL WORLD] Your comparison to a bomb test site is apt. For Operation Cue in 1955, houses were built on the Nevada Test Site, furnished inside and posted with mannequins, with plain, clean outsides, so their effects on homes could be measured. The house in the blue box has a grey, statue-like figure half sunk in front of it holding a phone. That resemblance isn't evidence of anything. It's the same feeling.

The sky drains the capture

[YOURS] You also asked whether the Complex might work something like light bouncing off surfaces, with exteriors streamlined because outside there isn't much for it to bounce off. You worried the idea was absurd. It isn't. It's real physics, and it's the clearest mechanism this theory has.

[OURS] **[SCIENCE]** Inside a room, light bounces between the surfaces again and again, so every corner is lit from many directions. Outside, light that heads for the sky never comes back, so an outside wall is lit essentially once, from one side, and most of the energy is lost. Rendering calls this radiosity, and it's why shadowed corners look the way they do. If the Complex's copying behaves the same way, then inside it keeps circulating and samples every surface many times, so detail survives, and outside it drains into the sky and samples each surface once, weakly, so only large shapes and main colours survive. The mathematics chapter works it through. With ordinary surfaces, an enclosed surface is sampled about three times as often as one that sees nothing but sky, and keeps about three quarters of what makes it distinctive, against about half.

[OURS] That single idea explains seven things at once.

1. Detailed interiors and streamlined exteriors from one capture, the store and the house in the blue box.
2. Toy-clean fronts even at the centre of a capture, the film's street.
3. Facades, since a face that sees the sky is sampled weakly and what's behind it isn't reached at all.
4. Why outdoor copies are rare, since the capture leaks away outdoors and rarely gathers enough to bring much back.
5. Why the sky itself is never copied. It's where the capture goes, not something it meets.
6. Flat substitutes like green carpet for grass and leaf wallpaper for trees, where only "flat and green" survived.
7. Why distant towers are faces only, one weak touch and nothing behind.

Darkness doesn't matter, only the sky

[OURS] The capture isn't visible light. It only behaves like light in two ways. It moves freely through enclosed space, and the open sky swallows it. Being dark doesn't weaken it at all.

[CANON] That's why the Lighting and Tile Survey found its most precise detail in the darkest places, the ductwork above the tiles, the insulation on the floor above, the serial number on a ballast inside a sealed fitting. Those are the most enclosed spaces in a building, so under this model they're the best copied, and canon agrees. A pitch-black cellar would be copied faithfully. A sunlit lawn and a moonlit lawn would both be streamlined.

Why the red copies are red, the dusk theory

[YOURS] You asked how the Complex knows to colour the lights of an outdoor copy, and suggested the Red City might be red because of a sunset. Your earlier floodlight hypothesis, covered in the gazetteer, already showed the red comes from lamps rather than the sky. This takes both a step further.

[CANON] Look at what the two red copies actually show, as the gazetteer's frame study found.

- The sky is dark, with stars in it.
- The red light comes in low, from one side, lighting the trees and house fronts from that side and throwing red pools across the road, the way a floodlight would.
- The ordinary street lamps on the other side give white light.
- The Red City's office windows glow warm white, not red.
- Kane has a track called "Red Sun in the Sky".

[OURS] A red sky at sunset would be bright orange, with no stars. But at dusk, after the sun has set, the sky overhead is already dark with the first stars, while the last red light still comes in low and flat from one side, the side where the sun went down. That's both red copies exactly. The rule that follows is this.

> **The light of the moment**
>
> The sun isn't matter, so the Complex can't copy it (Law 3). It replaces it with fittings matched by look (Law 5), and they keep the colour and the direction of the light the sun was giving at the moment of capture. The sky's appearance becomes surfaces. The sky's light becomes lamps. Everything that was a lamp already, a street light, a lit window, is matter and keeps its own colour.

Captured at	The sun's light	What the Complex puts in its place
Midday	White, from high above	Bright panels overhead. The film's street, "brightly lit as if it were day"
Late afternoon	Warm, low	Warm floodlights low on one side

Captured at	The sun's light	What the Complex puts in its place
Dusk or dawn	Red, very low, with the first stars out	Red floodlights low on one side, a dark surface overhead with point lights for stars. The red street and the Red City
Deep night	None	A dark surface with point lights for stars, and nothing but the scene's own lamps

[OURS] That explains why the red copies are red, why their red has a direction, why their own street lamps and windows aren't red, and why red is rare. Dusk lasts minutes, and only an outdoor capture taken in that window comes out red. It also explains why a day capture like the house in the blue box gets a blue surface rather than blue light. Its sky's appearance became paint, and its sunlight, white and from above, became the room's ordinary lighting.

[OURS] It's our theory, not canon. What would break it is a red copy lit evenly from above, a red copy with no stars, or a red copy whose own street lamps are red too.

The outdoor system, in full

[OURS] Canon has never explained why the Complex's outdoor places exist or why they're rare, and the open questions chapter lists it as unanswered. Every observation canon does give fits one system, which follows from Laws 1, 3, 4, 6 and 7.

The outdoor system

- **What.** An outdoor copy is a capture whose open space at the centre was outdoor air, a street, a yard, a car park, instead of rooms.
- **Why it's rare.** Openings form inside solid structures, basements, walls and garages, so a capture fills an interior first and reaches outdoor air only through a door, a window or a gap. Once it's outside, the sky drains it, so it gathers little. And remembering eats rare material first, so outdoor copies fade fastest.
- **How it looks.** Never open to a sky. Closed by paint, a dark surface with lamps, or plain ceiling tiles. Lit by fittings. Every building in it is a streamlined front facing the open space, with nothing behind.
- **When.** Only at a capture event whose flood reached outdoor air. The moment decides its light. Captured at midday it gets bright panels, at dusk a dark surface with stars and red floodlights low on one side, as the red street and the Red City did, in deep night only its own lamps. Lights that were already lamps keep whatever state and colour they had.
- **Where.** Only near the opening that made it, among fresh copies, and in the first few copies of copies around them. Never in the deep default rooms, which are old material whose sky was lost long ago. None of canon's seven is near a way in.

What would break it

- A real sky anywhere in the Complex, or real sunlight, or shadows cast by a sun.
- A fresh copy whose sky-facing outside is as detailed, cluttered and weathered as its inside.
- A fresh, enclosed interior copied as a stage set.
- Outdoor-looking places turning up commonly among the old default rooms, or right beside a way in.
- A copied outdoor scene lit by nothing at all, with no fittings and no source.

How sure we are. Strong. It's the only law that's purely about physics, and it has no exception in canon.

Law 4. The open space is the centre

> **Law 4**
> A copy keeps the open space at its heart and the faces of the things that border it, to a depth that fades the further it reaches behind them. The Complex then closes that open space with its own walls and ceilings. So the faces of a copy always look inward into the room, and their backs end at walls, fences or nothing. Which open space is at the centre depends on the capture. Outdoors it's the street or the yard. Indoors it's the rooms themselves.

[YOURS] This law comes from your question about the house in the blue box. How does the Complex know to keep the front of a place unobstructed and visible inside a room, and why does the same thing happen to the film's street?

What the pictures show



The house in the blue box from Found Footage #3, frame supplied with this commission. The house stands flat against the back wall of a box painted dark blue with clouds. Its porch, railings and hedges face the open floor. The brown backyard fences show at both rear corners.

[CANON] The house in the blue box stands against the back of its room. Everything in front of it is open floor, with clothes scattered across it. The brown backyard fences show at both rear corners, and the back wall of the box rises directly behind them. The painted sky covers the walls.

[FILM] In the film's suburban street, the houses on both sides face the road, with garage doors, mailboxes, picket fences and plants along their fronts. Each one is cut off a few metres behind its front, where it meets the yellow wall of the room. Above the road there's a drop ceiling of fluorescent panels.

Why the fronts face you

[OURS] In the real world, "front" means the side that faces open space. Houses are built to face their street. Their backs face fences and the next lot. So which way a house faces is already written into the matter.

[OURS] The capture keeps the open space and the faces bordering it. The house fronts, the porch, the mailboxes, the fences and the hedges survive whole, because they stand at the edge of the open space. Behind them, the capture fades. That's why the film's houses are sliced off just behind their fronts, and

why the house in the blue box ends at its fence line, the boundary of its lot.

[OURS] Then Law 3 takes over. The open space's sky and distance couldn't be captured, so the Complex closes the space with what it has, yellow walls and panels for the street, a painted box for the house. That enclosure is built around the captured open space, not around the buildings. So the fronts face into the room every time, by construction.

[OURS] It also explains why people meet the house from the front. The only part of that room anyone can walk in is the captured front space. Behind the house there's only the wall of the box. Ravi couldn't have come at it from behind even if something had wanted him to. There was no behind.

Facades are the faces that bordered the open space

Copy	What survives	What's missing
House in the blue box	Front, porch, hedges, back fences	Everything past the fence line. The sky, painted on
The film's street	Garage fronts, mailboxes, picket fences	The houses behind their fronts. The sky, made into a ceiling
The playground set	"The shell of a building that's nothing but a front with windows"	The building behind its front
The farm corridor	The flat front of a house or barn, standing like stage scenery	The barn behind its front
The Red City	Tower faces whose windows look like glowing pictures rather than rooms	The rooms behind the faces

[OURS] So facades aren't a separate error. They're exactly the faces that stood at the edge of the captured open space, with nothing captured behind them.

[SCIENCE] The mathematics chapter gives a physical comparison. Light carries far through air and is absorbed within a short depth by a wall, following the Beer-Lambert law. A capture that behaved the same way, reaching far along open space and fading quickly once it met matter, would produce exactly these facades.

Indoors, the same law runs the other way

[FILM] [CANON] When a capture is centred on the inside of a building, the captured open space is the rooms. The faces that look into the rooms survive, and anything that looks out runs into the edge of the capture.

- The copy of Clark's store, whose glass front doors open onto a solid yellow wall.
- The classroom where Ravi lands, with a window that looks onto a brick wall.
- The roofless apartment, whose windows are bricked up.
- The house in the blue box, whose front door, according to the account of the footage, opens from the inside onto brick and concrete.

[OURS] The house in the blue box has a complete exterior and a near-perfect interior, yet its front door opens onto brick from inside. One way to read this is that the house is two captures joined together, the exterior with its yard and the interior with its rooms, and that the join between them falls at the front door. Seen from inside, the door is at the edge of the interior capture, so it opens onto the Complex's material. That would make the front door a seam, which is where Law 8 says seams should be.

The capture passes through glass

[FILM] [OURS] The opening into Clark's store was in its basement, inside the building, yet the Complex holds a copy of the store's outside, its front, sign and car park. The only way out from the sales floor to that car park is through the glass front doors. If the capture behaves like light, that's no puzzle. Glass is transparent, so the capture passes through it, into the car park, where the sky drains it, which is why that

copy is streamlined. The Red City is seen through the glass of a skywalk and an office for the same reason. Glass passes the capture. Walls don't.

Fronts that forget

[YOURS] You asked whether the red neighbourhood in Pitfalls breaks this law, since it seems to have whole houses rather than fronts.

[CANON] Canon shows less than it seems to. Only one house on the red street is ever entered, the one at the end of the street, standing square to the road. Inside is a blue room with upside-down traffic turn signs sticking out of the carpet at different heights, then a hallway, then a room where someone has been living, with rotting walls, a sleeping bag, a backpack and a heap of house numbers taken off the other houses. The fan wiki's summary, recorded in the nature chapter, is that the house "forgets" it's supposed to be a house as you walk through it.

[OURS] So it isn't a whole house. It's a house that dissolves the deeper you go, and that's exactly what this law predicts.

1. **The capture was centred on the street.** The house fronts border the street's open space, so they came through whole, with the trees, the street lamps and the tunnel.
2. **Behind each front, the capture thins with depth.** Near the door it's still a house, with a hallway and a room. Further in there's less and less of the original.
3. **What it lacked was filled from the nearest stock (Law 5).** The nearest stock was the street itself, so traffic signs ended up in the house, stuck in its carpet, and upside down because their orientation was lost (Law 2).

[OURS] "Forgets it's a house as you walk through it" is the fade of the capture, experienced from the inside. The heap of house numbers adds a small confirmation. Someone camping there could pull numbers off the other houses, so the fronts had been copied in full detail, numbers and all.

Why the house in the blue box is different

[CANON] The house in the blue box does have a near-perfect interior, with its whiskey bottle, mounted fish and shoe stuck in the floor. The difference is where the opening was. That house is the copy of the father's house, and the null zone was inside his living-room wall. The capture began inside, so the rooms were the open space at its centre, and they came through whole.

[OURS] That gives a clean rule. **A copied building has a convincing interior only if the opening was inside it.** Captured from the street, a building is a front that forgets itself as you go in. Captured from within, it's an interior whose outward doors and windows run into the Complex's walls. The houses on the red street that Marvin never entered should be like the one he did.

What would break it

- A copy showing the back of a building with its front hidden, when the back didn't face the open space in the original.
- A building captured from outside, with no opening inside it, whose interior stays fully convincing all the way through.
- An outdoor copy that continues behind its buildings as far as it does in front of them.
- An interior copy whose outward windows look onto a correctly copied outside.

How sure we are. Strong for the pattern, which holds in every case. The explanation of the blue-box house's front door as a seam is a reasonable guess, no more.

Law 5. Interpretation

> **Law 5**
> Whatever a copy lacks is filled from what the Complex already holds, matched by appearance and by role. There are three sources of gaps. Some things were never capturable, like the sky. Some were lost through repetition. Some were damaged. All three are filled the same way, from stock that came from real places.

[KANE] [FILM] This is Kane's own word, "interprets", and it's Clark's image of drawing a dog without ever having seen one. When you don't know what something looks like, you use what you do know.

[YOURS] Your version of this was a camera. The Complex looks at a scene and tries to match what it sees with the materials and things it has learnt, rather than creating something new. A black night sky with glowing dots becomes a black surface with light fittings. A sky behind a house becomes a painted sky. Two refinements made it stronger. The Complex can't be a camera, since it copies ductwork above ceilings and labels on the back of ballasts that no camera could see. And the reason the sky needs replacing isn't a lack of experience with outdoor places. It's Law 3. No amount of experience would let it capture a sky.

What canon shows

What was missing	What filled it	Where the filling came from
Foliage	Leaf-print wallpaper	Wallpaper, the most common surface in the Complex
The sky behind a house	Paint on the walls of a box	Painted surfaces
A daytime sky	Fluorescent panels and a drop ceiling	The default ceiling of the yellow rooms
Stars and a night sky	Light fittings and a dark surface	Lamps
The sun over an apartment	"A big light"	Lamps
A real leg, behind a prop	The chair leg that was strapped to it	The object physically touching it
The insides of a body	White stuffing, porridge-like	Possibly furniture filling, from a region that copied a furniture store
A demolished house's broken slab	The handprints, restored	The intact slab
A picture on a wall	An opening the same shape, through the wall	A rectangle on a wall became a rectangle in a wall
A connection between two worlds	A breaker switch, crooked and red	Clark's own breaker panel, the nearest source

[CANON] In Found Footage #3, behind a couch, "where a picture should hang", the wall opens into another room. Of all the fills in canon this one may be the most telling. A frame on a wall and a doorway in a wall are both rectangles at about head height, and the Complex has swapped one for the other.

[FILM] At the end of the film, the copy of Mary's childhood home is a heap of rubble with the handprints restored. Mary had kept a broken chunk of that slab with her own handprint in it, and smashed it to pieces on Pirate Clark's face. The copy has the slab whole. And the chunk itself went into the Complex with Mary and shattered there on Pirate Clark's face. Something from that house passed through an opening, which under Law 1 is how the house could have been taken in at all, and the whole slab may have been rebuilt from that one piece. Either the Complex took the slab at a moment before it was broken, or it filled the missing part with the intact version. Kane's commentary has Clark keeping Kat's head in the hope the Complex would remember her, a hope that only makes sense if it can rebuild a whole from part of one.

The playground, read two ways

[CANON] The playground set has a tiled path, green carpet standing in for grass, a street lamp, a slide, a building that's only a front, and lights that come on while Ravi is there. The room next to it, with the drum

kit, also has green carpet.

[OURS] There are two readings, and both fit the laws.

- **A faithful copy in the wrong place.** [REAL] Indoor play centres really are built like this. Mall play areas and soft-play halls often have building fronts as scenery, imitation street lamps, green carpet or artificial turf, and lights on sensors. The Codex already files the playground under "wrong context", which is exactly what an accurate copy of an indoor playground set down in the Complex would be. No substitution needed.
- **An outdoor playground, interpreted.** The grass was lost through repetition (Law 6), and was replaced by the most familiar flat green floor in the region, the green carpet that also covers the drum kit room next door.

[OURS] The first reading is simpler and needs fewer steps. The second fits the neighbouring room. Neither needs the Complex to find grass too difficult to make.

Three tests that keep this law honest

[OURS] A law like this could explain anything, if it were allowed to. Every strange thing could be called a substitute. So it has to pass three tests.

1. **Every substitute must come from somewhere real.** The chair leg was in the store. Carpet, wallpaper and fluorescent panels are everywhere in the Complex. Breaker switches exist in Clark's own basement. A substitute with no possible real source would count against the law.
2. **A substitute must match what it replaces, by look or by role.** Flat and green for grass. A point of light for a star. A rectangle at head height for a picture. A random object in place of something it doesn't resemble or serve would count against it.
3. **Substitution should grow with the number of rememberings.** Fresh copies should hold the fewest substitutes. Clark's store, the house in the blue box and Mary's yard fit this. A fresh copy full of substitutes would count against it.

Familiar, not cheap

[YOURS] You proposed that the Complex takes the cheapest, easiest options. That turned out to be right about what happens and wrong about why. The Complex spends lavishly on detail no one will ever see, serial numbers inside ballasts, insulation in the floor above, the chemistry of a tile. Nothing that saves effort would bother.

[OURS] What it reaches for isn't what's cheap but what's familiar, whatever it has copied most (Law 7). There's a sense in which familiar things are cheap, but it's the sense of information, not effort. Common things take the least information to describe. When information runs short, rare things are replaced by common ones. Green carpet stands in for grass not because grass is hard, but because the Complex has copied carpet a thousand times and grass a handful of times.

How sure we are. Strong. It's in canon in Kane's word and in Clark's dog, and every example passes all three tests. The stuffing as furniture filling is a reading, since the descriptions compare it to porridge, rice and stuffing alike.

Law 6. Every remembering is a worse copy

> **Law 6**
> Each copy is made from the copy before it, not from the original. Fine detail drains away first, then the shapes of things, then the layout, and the filling from Law 5 grows to take their place. A copy can never contain more of the original than the copy it was made from.

What canon shows

[FILM] Clark's line is the heart of it. The place remembers, and "the more times it remembers something, the less it does". His example is a man in a striped shirt who is out there in the real world and in here has been remembered slightly wrong.

[CREW] Danny Vermette, the film's production designer, described the design the same way. The deeper you sink, the less things are remembered and the further they drift from their original state.

[OFFICIAL] The teaser shows one sunlit basement passing through eight stages until it becomes the yellow office rooms. The clutter goes first, then the furniture melts into the floor, the window becomes a frame and vanishes, the room grows, the walls bend and yellow, an arch appears that wasn't there, and finally partitions and fluorescent panels take over. The full table is in the previous chapter.

Two kinds of loss at once

[OURS] The teaser shows two different processes happening together.

- **Blurring.** Detail is lost and nothing replaces it. Clutter disappears and edges soften. This is how analogue copying fails. Each dub of a tape is noisier and duller than the last.
- **Rebuilding toward the expected.** Missing things are replaced by typical things. The arch in stage 7 and the partitions in stage 8 weren't in the original at all. This is how human memory fails, as Bartlett showed in 1932, and it's Law 5 at work.

[FAN] A Real Sound essay on the film argues that 1990 was chosen partly because it was the last era when every copy physically degraded, when tapes lost quality each time they were dubbed. Whatever Kane's reasons, the period fits a place whose rule is that copies get worse.

[SCIENCE] The mathematics chapter sets out both processes. The data-processing inequality proves a copy can't contain more information than its source. Rate-distortion theory shows that small details are dropped first when information runs short. And the formula for filling gaps toward a prior shows how each remembering keeps only a fraction of what made something different from the average.

What follows from it

- **Freshness is about generations, not distance.** A copy made once, directly from its original, is accurate where it was enclosed, and streamlined where it faced the sky (Law 3). A copy of a copy of a copy isn't. That's why Clark's store is nearly perfect while the yellow rooms just past the Threshold are the most generic things in the series.
- **Real places sit like islands.** Fresh copies are set down among material that has been remembered countless times.
- **Remembering rebuilds as well as blurs.** See below.
- **"Deeper" means older.** Depth in the Complex is the number of rememberings, not metres from the door.
- **Old copies can't be repaired from themselves.** Once something is lost from a chain of copies, no later copy in that chain can get it back. Only a fresh capture from the original can.

How sure we are. Very strong. It's Clark's line, the teaser, Vermette's description and the three signs, and it's mathematically unavoidable for any copying that makes mistakes.

Remembering rebuilds, it doesn't only blur

[YOURS] You proposed that the Complex doesn't keep a copy's exact geometry at all after a while. It learns the place's materials, its rough shape and how its rooms connect, and then builds it again from the ground up in its own image, so that it fits with everything around it and loses whatever made the original incomprehensible.

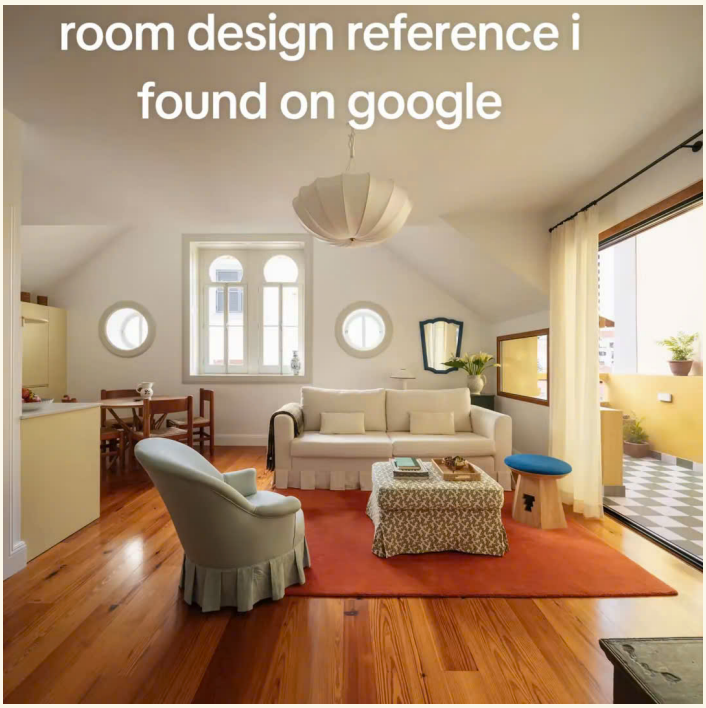
[FILM] **[CANON]** Canon shows exactly that. The third copy of Clark's store, the dark maze found in Everything Must Go, no longer has the store's layout at all. Its corridors are the Complex's own. But its walls, its steel trusses and its signs are the store's, and the signs repeat down the corridor. A place re-expressed in the Complex's image, keeping what it was made of and what was in it.



The dark maze copy of Clark's store, from Everything Must Go, supplied with this commission. The layout is gone. The wall design, the trusses and the signs remain, and the signs repeat.

[OURS] So remembering does two things. It blurs, dropping detail and pulling toward the typical, as the teaser shows. And it rebuilds, replacing a place's geometry with the Complex's own while keeping its materials, its notable objects and the way its rooms join. Rebuilding is how a place with absurd geometry still ends up as walkable rooms, recognisably that place, made by something that never understood it.

[FAN] A fan project made a good picture of both at once, shown here as an illustration of the laws, not as evidence. It takes a real room and shows it as a copy of a copy. The clutter is gone, the wood floor has become brown carpet, the pendant lamp has become a grid of recessed lights, the round windows are gone, the colours have washed out, and the window looks onto another room of the Complex instead of the outside, Law 4 exactly.



Fan work, not canon. The real room the fan project started from.



Fan work, not canon. The fan project's copy of a copy of that room.

Law 7. The snowball

> **Law 7**
>
> The Complex's default, the material it fills gaps with and drifts toward, is whatever it has repeated most. Because it copies its own copies, whatever is common becomes more common, so the earliest material it ever took in had a head start that snowballed. That's the yellow rooms.

Why "most repeated" isn't "most common in the world"

[OURS] If the default were simply whatever is most common in the world, the Complex would be full of open fields, ocean and forest. It isn't. And if it were whatever is most common near its openings, the default near a San Jose furniture store should look Californian. Instead the default is a yellow wallpaper whose design Kane says comes from Europe.

[SCIENCE] A process that copies its own output behaves like what mathematicians call a Pólya urn. Draw a ball from an urn, put it back with another of the same colour, and repeat. Whichever colours happen to be drawn first get more balls, so they're more likely to be drawn again. The proportions settle, but where they settle is decided mostly by the earliest draws. Biology has the same effect under another name. A population founded by a few individuals carries their traits far out of proportion for generations, which is called the founder effect. The mathematics chapter gives the formula.

[FAN] [OURS] That gives Wendigoon's theory, that the yellow wallpaper comes from Ivan Beck's past, a mechanism. If the Complex began with very little and one of the first things it took in was a room from Beck's European past, that room would have had a head start that snowballed into the most repeated material in the Complex. Beck was born in Karlovy Vary in 1931. The theory still can't be proved, but this law explains how it could be true.

Variety survives

[SCIENCE] Copying its own copies would eventually make everything identical if the copying were perfect. It isn't. The previous chapter's drift and mutation model shows that copying errors keep a steady level of variety alive. Most of what you see is the common type, and every so often there's a pool, a Christmas tree, a playground or a mirrored stop sign.

Why simple architecture dominates

[YOURS] You asked whether the Complex prefers the simplest, most consistent architecture, which would be why it favours buildings over caves even though both are enclosed.

[OURS] It does end up full of simple architecture, but not because it prefers it at capture. It's survival. Repetitive architecture survives repeated remembering because it's easy to keep. A wall, a floor and a ceiling cost almost nothing to describe, and a grid of pillars is one pillar repeated. A cave has no repeating parts, so it would drift into something else quickly. Over many generations, the simple things are what's left. The mathematics chapter calls this "simplicity survives".

Why interiors outnumber outdoors

[OURS] Three reasons stack, and none of them is a preference.

1. **Where openings form.** Natural null zones turn up in basements, garages and walls. The car on the highway is the one clear outdoor contact in canon, and what came through was the car.
2. **What an outdoor capture holds.** An outdoor scene is mostly air, sky and distance, none of which can be captured. It arrives sparse and gets boxed in.
3. **What survives.** Rare material is the first to disappear when things are remembered again and again, so outdoor scenes are absorbed into the default faster than new ones arrive.

What would break it

- The default shifting quickly toward recently captured material, so that the rooms near Clark's store started looking like Clark's store everywhere.
- Rare material surviving repeated remembering better than common material.

How sure we are. Good. The mathematics is solid and it explains the European wallpaper, which nothing else does. Whether the earliest material really was Beck's can't be checked.

Law 8. Continuation

> **Law 8**
> The Complex extends itself through openings. New material is attached where old material has a doorway, gap, hole, crawl space or chute. Pieces meet at natural seams where possible, are forced together where not, and the space between fresh copies is filled with the default rooms. Connection isn't something it aims for. It's what growing from your own openings produces.

What canon shows

[CANON] The parts of the Complex anyone has seen are connected. People walk, fall or climb from one area to the next through doors, gaps in walls, holes in floors, crawl spaces, chutes and ladders. Ravi walks from a classroom to a house to a furniture store to the Red City without ever leaving. Async's divisions are all reachable on foot from the Threshold.

[CANON] The Threshold opened straight into the yellow rooms, and real places sit inside the yellow like islands.

Why it connects

[YOURS] You asked why the Complex needs to connect places at all, if it isn't trying to make somewhere people can walk.

[OURS] It doesn't need to. Copies are made at openings and attached at openings, so they're connected by construction. It's the same reason a crystal is all one piece. It only ever grows from its own faces.

Why it's walkable, mostly

[OURS] What it copies is human space, which was already walkable, and its seams fall at doorways, where people walk. So walkability is inherited, not guaranteed, and canon shows its limits.

- Ravi can't climb back up the chute he slid down.
- A door opens onto a brick wall. A hallway climbs like a staircase with no steps.
- Pits drop people into regions they can't get back from.
- Many doorways in canon close behind whoever goes through.

Seams, grafts and punched openings

[SCIENCE] The microtile result from computer graphics, described in the mathematics chapter, says that any new shape that looks locally like a real example can only be joined along boundaries that occur in the example. For buildings, that means seams at doorways, corridor ends and junctions.

[CANON] Mostly that's where the Complex's seams are. Where they aren't, the damage shows.

- **Forced joins.** The crack running across a hallway floor in Found Footage #3, where two kinds of room meet. The Static Dead End, half wallpaper and half tile, its floor sagging and bulging, its wallpaper stretching while Async watched.
- **Grafts.** The three copies of Clark's store, a maze built from the store's own materials, an accurate copy, and an inside-out copy with both inside and outside, show pieces of one place being recombined.
- **Punched openings.** The wall that opens behind the couch where a picture should hang.

[YOURS] Your two proposals both find support. The Complex can open a hole using a shape it already knows, and it can cut and graft pieces together in what you called Frankenstein architecture. Both leave marks.

Pits are vertical seams

[CANON] [FILM] Square pits keep leading to very different places. The red street lies below the pits of Room 14D, reached by a winch. A huge pit lies under the copy of Clark's store, with a smaller one leading up into its basement. The film's chase passes through a vast room built around a pit with no visible bottom.

[OURS] A pit reads as a join between two pieces at different heights. Where a horizontal seam would be a doorway, a vertical one is a hole.

Why it doesn't overlap everywhere

[OURS] Solid can't share space with solid. Where two pieces would overlap, one sinks into the other, which is exactly what furniture sunk into floors looks like. That merging is the visible trace of overlap. Overlap in time does happen. Room 14C changed while nobody was watching, the floor plan "changed again" for Clark, and Kat saw Clark through a wall that was opaque from his side. The overlapping rooms section of the previous chapter covers the research on how little people notice this.

What would break it

- A fresh copy found floating with no opening into anything.
- Seams that consistently fall in the middle of rooms rather than at doorways and junctions.

How sure we are. Good for continuation and seams. The grafts and punched openings rest on only a few examples each.

Law 9. Structure before function

> **Law 9**
>
> The form of a thing comes through well. Its working insides and its behaviour come through only roughly. The freshest copies keep the most function.

What canon shows

[FILM] [CANON] Still Lifes have the outward shape of people and almost none of their insides. There are no bones or organs, only a white, porridge-like substance. They don't react to being stabbed. Their minds vary. The bearded one barely reacts to anything. The red-haired one shrieks and then goes still. ALS switches his lamp on when the lights go off, apparently understanding what Clark wants. The knocker in Found Footage #3 knocks politely, the way people knock, before smashing the door, as though it knows that people knock but not what a door is for.

[FILM] Pirate Clark is the exception. He's the only Still Life that bleeds like a person, he roars when hurt, and he hunts and holds a territory. But Async's gas, which drops Mary almost instantly, does nothing to him, presumably because there's no real biology inside for it to act on. Clark's mural line that "tables don't bleed" reads as Clark noticing exactly this mismatch, something made of furniture material that bleeds.

[OURS] Pirate Clark is also the freshest copy. He was made directly from the store, while it was joined to the Complex. Mary's copy, made at the very end, is described as less distorted than most. The two freshest Still Lifes keep the most. That's what this law predicts.

Function isn't impossible

[OURS] An earlier version of this idea said the Complex copies states but not processes. That's false in canon. The lights run, the ballasts hum at 120 Hz, Still Lifes walk and hunt, the wallpaper stretches, bacteria grow, and the Lifeform seems to grow in place like a plant. Processes plainly happen. What the law says is weaker and fits everything. Structure comes through well and function comes through roughly.

The name says it

[SCIENCE] In John Conway's Game of Life, the cellular automaton printed on Phil's shirt, a "still life" is a pattern that doesn't change from one step to the next. It has structure and no change. Whether or not Kane meant it, the term describes a copy that keeps a living thing's form and loses most of its living.

Plants as Still Lifes

[YOURS] You proposed that plants in the Complex are Still Lifes too, frozen as they were when captured, with the shape and composition of a plant but none of its life. Plants would be easier than people because they're simpler.

[OURS] This fits the law well, with one refinement. What matters isn't overall complexity so much as how much of a thing is behaviour rather than structure. A plant has almost no visible behaviour, so a plant Still Life would look exactly like a plant. The difference would only show over time. It would never grow, never wilt, never drop a leaf. A person is the opposite. Behaviour is most of what we see of someone, so a person's missing function shows at once, in the knocking, the swinging heads and the lamp switched on and off.

[SCIENCE] One real fact keeps the question open. Fluorescent tubes are grow lights. Plants can photosynthesise under them, and greenhouses use them. A real plant under endless fluorescent light could live for a while, though water would be its problem.

[OURS] So canon allows three kinds of plant in the Complex. Some are surely artificial, since a plastic plant copies as a plastic plant. Some may be plant Still Lifes, exact and unchanging. And living plants under endless fluorescent light can't be ruled out. The test is simple. If any plant in the Complex is ever shown to grow or wilt, it isn't a Still Life.

[FILM] The seagull in the film's cold open crashes to the floor, lies still and then flies off. It's the one animal shown coming through, and it came through working.

The faces fail worst

[FAN] TV Tropes offers a reason the faces of Still Lifes are where copying fails worst. A face packs more detail into less space than anything else on a body. [SCI] The mathematics chapter makes the same point with Kolmogorov complexity. Under any fixed budget, the things with the longest descriptions get mangled first.

What would break it

- A Still Life with fully working organs, or one that responds to the gas like a person.
- An old, much-remembered copy keeping more function than a fresh one.

How sure we are. Good. It fits every Still Life shown, and Pirate Clark's bleeding, which looks like the exception, turns out to support it.

Law 10. Reaching back

> **Law 10**
>
> Once the Complex is joined to a place, it starts to change our side of the join as well. What it puts there carries its signature, the right thing in the wrong placement.

What canon shows

[FILM] Before Clark ever goes in, his store starts losing power, upstairs one night and downstairs the next, and the bill climbs. In the breaker box the meter man finds a red switch set crooked, at an angle, connected to nothing, as if someone had just stuck it in, in a part of the circuit power can't even pass through. Later the red switches are the only breakers that do anything. When Clark switches them off, the

store goes dark, and he hears fluorescent lights humming behind a wall.

[CANON] Earlier releases had already shown the Complex altering our side, though less clearly. Ravi's basement had a hole broken through a cinder block wall with a passage behind it, and his sliding glass door was smashed from the inside, so something broke out rather than in. In Overflow, a green glow fills Ivan Beck's laboratory in 1972. The red switches are the first time the Complex leaves a recognisable made object in our world.

[FILM] At the end of the film Phil tells Mary that doors are opening everywhere, that nobody knows why or what connects them, and that they can't stop them.

What the switches are

[YOURS] You proposed that the red switches are the Complex reusing a model it had learnt, a breaker switch from some house or office it had copied. That fits Law 5. And the first test of Law 5 says the nearest real source is the most likely one. The nearest breaker switches are Clark's own.

[OURS] So the likeliest reading is that the Complex copied Clark's store, breaker panel included, and as the copy and the original were joined, the copy's switches began to turn up in the original's panel. Look at how they're described. Crooked, at an angle, connected to nothing. That's the Complex's signature from Law 2, the right object in the wrong placement, sitting in our world instead of the Complex.

[FAN] TV Tropes records a theory that the real world in the film is itself becoming a memory, with the crooked switch as the sign. This law is a milder version of the same idea.

Why the power drained

[YOURS] You asked why the Complex would drain power from Clark's store when it already seems to have endless power of its own, and whether it might draw energy from our world, or from the Sun, through null zones. You also saw the problem. Any field strong enough to carry that much energy would wreck Async's electronics and the people carrying them, and it doesn't.

[OURS] Your objection is decisive against a field filling the space. And inside the Complex, the Lighting and Tile Survey found the lights running with no supply anywhere, which Async put down to a continuous, perhaps self-sustaining source.

[OURS] Clark's store shows something more specific. The store's own circuits ended up running through switches the Complex made, and the outages moved from floor to floor night by night. That looks less like a Complex feeding on our grid and more like the store being taken over piece by piece, its wiring joined to its copies. The bill rises because the store is now feeding lights that include the copies, which is why fluorescent light hums behind the wall after the store goes dark.

[OURS] On this reading the Complex doesn't need Clark's energy at all. Two joined systems share a supply, the way two connected tanks level out. A source with no limit inside doesn't stop current flowing across a join.

Why red?

[OURS] Nobody knows. Red recurs in the red lamps of the Red City and the red street, and in the Outpost's alarm lights. That's not enough to build on.

What would break it

- The Complex changing our world far from any opening.
- A thing it puts in our world that is correctly placed and fully functional, with none of its usual signature.

How sure we are. Good for the pattern, moderate for the details. The reading of the power drain as a merge rather than a theft rests on two lines of dialogue, the alternating floors and the switches becoming

the only ones that work.

Why Kane's Complex is never huge

[OURS] Fan creations often make the Backrooms a generator of spectacle, with vast impossible megastructures. Kane's version is far more restrained. Every copy in canon is a single place, a store, a house, a yard, a street, a room. The largest-looking things in the series turn out to be one of three kinds, and none of them is one big copy.

- **Views.** The Red City is mostly the faces of distant towers whose windows look like glowing pictures rather than rooms. The near trees, the road and the faces came through. The city behind them didn't.
- **Repetition.** The Recording Studio's tower rises and falls out of sight, with the same painting of a smiling sun on every level. The film's enormous room around a bottomless pit is lined with open, showroom-like bays, one small piece repeated over and over.
- **The default.** The Main Chamber is about a hundred metres on each side, but it's one cross-shaped pillar repeated in a grid. It's the Complex's own material, not a copy of anything.

[CREW] Danny Vermette, the film's production designer, wanted the spaces vertical and awkward rather than flat and endless.

[CANON] Ravi walks for something like nine hours, but through dozens of small places, never one giant one.

[OURS] The laws explain this restraint without needing a separate rule. A capture is local and fades quickly once it meets matter (Laws 1 and 4), so no single copy can be large. A building is deep only where the opening was inside it. The Complex grows large through how many pieces it has and how often it repeats them (Laws 7 and 8), never through the size of any one copy. The limits aren't something imposed on the Complex from outside. They're what capture is.

The whole theory in one paragraph

The working theory

The Complex takes in the physical structure of whatever touches it, a whole scene at a moment, with its people caught up inside. It keeps what things are far better than where they belong. It can take in matter but not light, so it has no sky and lights itself with fittings, and the sky drains its copying, so what faced the sky comes through as a stage set and what was enclosed comes through faithful. A copy keeps the open space at its centre and the faces that border it, and the Complex closes that space with its own walls, so fronts always look inward. Whatever a copy lacks, whether never captured, lost through repetition, or broken, is filled from what the Complex already holds, matched by look and role. Each remembering is a copy of the last, so detail drains away and its most repeated material, which snowballed from its earliest contacts, takes over. It extends itself through openings, joining pieces at natural seams and filling the gaps with its default rooms. Its copies keep form better than function, and the freshest keep the most. And once it is joined to a place, it begins to change our side too.

What the theory leaves open

[OURS] Some things in canon lie outside these laws, and the theory doesn't pretend otherwise.

- **Whether it thinks.** Kane says he doesn't know. The laws work without a mind and can't rule one out.
- **What powers it.** The lights run with no supply. The laws say nothing about where the energy comes from.
- **What the green glow is.** It reliably appears where walls move, rooms grow and doors open on half-formed rooms. That fits capture and growth events, but what it physically is remains unknown.
- **Why people only go forward in time.** Things from many times appear inside, but people who fall in only ever come out later, never earlier.

- **Why some openings are stable.** Clark's doorway stayed open and two-way for weeks. Most openings close behind whoever falls through.
- **The Lifeform.** A colony organism that grows from human remains doesn't come out of copying at all. Kane has said it's completely separate from the Still Lifes.
- **The Sun.** The August 1972 storm, the largest of its era, falls exactly on Overflow's date, and Async's machine is magnetic. That's a striking match, and the time chapter sets it out. But the big October 1989 flare came two days after the sixth test, not before, and nothing in canon ties the Sun to the Complex's power. It stays a possible trigger, not a law.

How sure we are, law by law

Law	Confidence	What would break it
1. Capture	Strong	A fresh copy of a place that was never near an opening
2. Two fidelities	Very strong	A copy with the right layout and the wrong materials
3. Matter, not light, and the sky drains	Strong	A real sky or real sunlight inside, or a fresh outside as detailed and weathered as its inside
4. The open space is the centre	Strong	A copy showing a back that never faced the open space
5. Interpretation	Strong	A substitute with no real source, or one that matches nothing
6. Every remembering is a worse copy	Very strong	An old copy more accurate than a fresh one of the same thing
7. The snowball	Good	The default shifting quickly toward recent material
8. Continuation	Good	A fresh copy with no opening into anything
9. Structure before function	Good	A Still Life with working organs
10. Reaching back	Good	The Complex changing our world far from any opening

Testing the Theory

A theory of the Complex is only worth anything if it could have failed. This chapter shows the working. It lists the ideas that were proposed along the way and didn't survive, runs every relevant case in canon against the ten laws, looks closely at the frames that settled the hardest questions, and ends with the predictions that future episodes could use to break the theory.

How the testing was done

[OURS] Every hypothesis was put against every case in this book that could contradict it. If one clear case broke it, it was dropped or rewritten. If it needed an extra assumption to survive, the assumption had to be something canon already shows. And between two explanations of the same thing, the one with fewer steps was preferred.

[OURS] Three habits did most of the damage to weak ideas.

- **Look for the case that should be there if the idea is true.** If the Complex replaced hard things with cheap ones, there should be no real grass anywhere. There is.
- **Look for the case that should be missing.** If the Complex fitted copies to whoever entered them, no copy should ever face the wrong way. Clark's store faces a wall.
- **Check the quote.** Several ideas rested on things Kane supposedly said. Some of them he didn't say.

Ideas that didn't survive

"The Complex picks the cheapest, easiest option"

[YOURS] The proposal was that copying an outdoor playground accurately would be too taxing, so the Complex used the cheapest substitute and imposed its indoor materials.

[OURS] **Why it failed.** The Complex spends extravagantly on detail nobody will ever see, from the serial number inside a ballast to the insulation in the floor above a ceiling. Nothing economising would bother. And it reproduces real grass in the copy of Mary's yard, so grass can't be too hard.

[OURS] **What replaced it.** Familiar, not cheap (Law 7). Common things take the least information to describe, so when information runs short, rare things give way to common ones. That's "cheap" only in the sense of information, and it explains everything the cheapness idea was meant to.

"Red City happened because skyscrapers look like walls"

[YOURS] The proposal was that the Complex mistook a cluster of tall, flat-faced buildings for the walls of a room, copied a city as if it were an interior, then noticed the mistake and substituted what it had.

[OURS] **Why it failed.** The red street in Pitfalls has the same treatment, a dark overhead and red light from lamps, but it's a street of low houses and trees with nothing remotely wall-like. Whatever made the Red City what it is also made the red street, and it can't be the height of the buildings.

[OURS] **What replaced it.** The missing sun (Law 3). Every outdoor copy lacks a sky and is lit by fittings, whatever its buildings look like.

"The Complex copies states, not processes"

[OURS] **The proposal.** Copies are frozen snapshots of physical states, and the Complex can't reproduce anything that happens over time, which would explain Still Life interiors and plants that never wilt.

[OURS] **Why it failed.** Processes run all over the Complex. The lights run and hum at 120 Hz. Still Lifes walk, hunt and hold territory. The wallpaper in the Static Dead End stretches while people watch. Bacteria

grow, and the Lifeform seems to grow from human remains.

[OURS] **What replaced it.** Structure before function (Law 9). Form comes through well and working insides come through roughly. That explains the Still Lifes and leaves room for everything that plainly moves.

"The Complex works like a camera with a point of view"

[YOURS] The proposal was that the Complex takes something like a picture of a place and rebuilds what it sees.

[OURS] **Why it failed as stated.** No camera could see the ductwork above a ceiling, the insulation in the floor above, or the label on the back of a ballast. The Complex gets them anyway. And a point of view would make copies depend on where the camera stood, but the copies keep the original's own layout.

[OURS] **What survived.** The heart of the idea, rebuilding what's there from what the Complex already has, became Law 5. The reason the sky in particular gets replaced became Law 3.

"The Complex turns its copies to face whoever enters"

[OURS] **The proposal.** The house in the blue box faces the way Ravi came in, and the Red City is laid out for the skywalk, so the Complex arranges things for the viewer.

[OURS] **Why it failed.** The copy of Clark's store has its glass front doors facing a solid yellow wall. The classroom where Ravi lands has a window onto brick. These copies face the wrong way for anyone, and a Complex arranging things for visitors wouldn't do that.

[OURS] **What replaced it.** The open space is the centre (Law 4). Outdoors, the captured open space is the street or the yard, so fronts face into the room. Indoors, it's the rooms themselves, so outward faces end at walls. One rule covers both, and neither needs a viewer.

[OURS] **A correction along the way.** At one point we read the blue-box house's front door, which opens onto brick from the inside, as a sign that the house faced away from the room. The frame shows the opposite. The front of the house plainly faces the open floor. The door onto brick is something else, most likely a seam where the house's exterior and interior captures meet.

"The Sun powers the Complex"

[OURS] **The proposal.** The Complex draws its endless power from our world through null zones, and ultimately from the Sun.

[OURS] **Why it failed.** Nothing in canon connects the Sun to the Complex's power. The lights run with no supply at all, as Async found. And as you pointed out yourself, any field carrying that much energy across the boundary would wreck electronics and people, and nothing like that happens.

[OURS] **What survived.** The date of Overflow, which falls on the August 1972 solar storm, stays as a possible trigger for whatever happened in Beck's lab. It isn't a law.

"The Complex needed Clark's electricity"

[OURS] **The proposal.** The Complex drained Clark's store because it needed the energy.

[OURS] **Why it failed.** It doesn't need energy it already has. The lights inside run with no supply. "Draining" assumes hunger, and nothing in canon shows the Complex being short of anything.

[OURS] **What replaced it.** Reaching back (Law 10). The store's circuits were being joined to its copies, floor by floor, until they ran only through the Complex's switches. Two joined systems shared a supply.

"Fidelity falls with distance from the opening"

[OURS] **The proposal.** A capture is strongest at the opening and fades with distance, so near things are faithful and far things streamlined.

[OURS] **Why it failed.** The film's suburban street was the open space at the centre of its own capture, yet its fronts are toy-clean. And the inside of Clark's store, far from the basement opening, is accurate.

[OURS] **What replaced it.** Exposure to the sky (Law 3). Depth into matter still matters, which is why backs and insides behind fronts are lost, but the faithfulness of a surface depends on whether it faced the sky.

"A fresh copy is faithful everywhere"

[OURS] **The proposal.** A first-generation copy is a near-perfect replica, and errors only come with remembering.

[YOURS] **Why it failed.** You pointed out that Clark's store isn't perfectly copied either. Its outside is streamlined while its inside is accurate. The house in the blue box is the same.

[OURS] **What replaced it.** Faithful where enclosed, streamlined where exposed to the sky, from the very first copy.

"The Complex learns things and only sometimes builds them"

[OURS] **The proposal.** To explain why the Complex isn't crowded with billions of Still Lifes, suppose it takes in information about everything but only sometimes turns it into something physical, through a separate stage of selection.

[OURS] **Why it was dropped.** It isn't wrong, it's unnecessary. Law 1 already explains the rarity. Capture only happens near openings, openings are rare, and capture comes in events. An extra stage that nobody can see adds nothing.

Claims about Kane that don't hold

- **"Kane said the Complex is getting better at learning."** No such statement could be found. The nearest line in canon is someone in Everything Must Go saying the television "just keeps getting better and better".
- **"Kane said the Complex isn't sentient."** He said he doesn't know whether there's intelligence or intent behind it.
- **"The film is the very first time the Complex changes our world."** In release order, Found Footage #3 had already shown Ravi's basement wall broken through, with his glass door smashed from the inside, and Overflow had shown a green glow in Beck's laboratory. The red switches are the first recognisable object it leaves here.
- **"Async scanned Pirate Clark and found anatomy."** The brain scan in the film is Mary's. Pirate Clark is last seen on a table with the crown of its head cut away, where Async removed the hat that had grown into its scalp.
- **"The house in the blue box sits in a room covered in sky wallpaper."** The room is a box painted dark blue with clouds. The painted sky in a skylight belongs to a different room, the one with six chairs.

Every outdoor copy against the laws

Copy	Law 1, a capture	Law 3, no sky	Law 4, faces inward	Law 5, the fill
Mary's childhood home	A chunk of its slab went in with Mary and shattered there	Yellow walls and panels over it	The rubble and lamp sit in the room	The broken slab restored

Copy	Law 1, a capture	Law 3, no sky	Law 4, faces inward	Law 5, the fill
The red street	Reached down a pit from Room 14D	Dark overhead	House fronts line the road, and the one house entered forgets itself as you go in	Red floodlight, and the street's own traffic signs upside down inside the house
The Red City	Towers, trees, road	Lamps for stars, a dark surface	Tower faces only, windows like pictures	Coloured lamps for the red light
The playground set	A play area copied whole	Lit by its own lights, enclosed	A building that's only a front	Green carpet, or a faithful indoor play area
The house in the blue box	A copy of the father's house beside a null zone	A painted box	Front faces the open floor, back at the fence line	Painted clouds
The film's street	Houses on both sides of a road	Drop ceiling and panels	Fronts face the road, backs cut by the walls	Fluorescent "daylight"
The farm corridor	Wheelbarrows, sledgehammer, a barn front	Indoors	A front like stage scenery	Leaf-print wallpaper
The outside of Clark's store	The store's front, the sign and mascot, cars, trees, reached through glass doors	Plain unlit ceiling tiles	The front faces the car park, nothing behind	Cars sunk in the ground, the front reduced to a box
The six-chair room	Six chairs	A skylight	Chairs face each other in the room	A painted sky in the skylight
The roofless apartment	Sockets, radiator, kitchen	No ceiling	Windows bricked up	"A big light"

[OURS] Every outdoor copy in canon fits every relevant law. None has a real sky, none is lit by anything but fittings, and every building in them is a front facing its open space.

Three skies, three generations

[OURS] Set the ways of closing an outdoor copy side by side and an order appears.

Copy	How its sky is made	How much of a sky is left
The Red City	Coloured lamps, light fittings for stars, a dark surface, lit windows	A night sky, rich and detailed
The house in the blue box	Paint on a box, with clouds	A day sky, simplified
The film's street	A drop ceiling, fluorescent panels and fans	Nothing sky-like at all, only the default

[OURS] That's the same order as the teaser, where sunlight goes first and fluorescent panels take over at the end. It's possible that these three are the same process caught at three different generations, with the film's street the most remembered of them. It's only a pattern in three cases, but it would be a natural result of Laws 5 and 6 together.

[OURS] There's a small extra detail. The ceiling over the film's street is the commercial kind, with large warehouse fans of the sort found in big stores and warehouses. The region it sits in grew from a furniture warehouse. Under the first test of Law 5, that's a plausible nearby source for the ceiling, though it can't be shown.

[OURS] The outside of Clark's store weakens this pattern. It looks like a fresh copy, yet its sky is closed with plain, unlit tiles, the last rung, not the first. One reading is that it was captured weakly, through the glass doors, so its sky deficit was small and was closed with the commonest ceiling there was. Another is that

this ordering never held. With three cases it was always only a pattern.

Clark's store, three copies from one doorway

[FILM] [CANON] The film and Everything Must Go show three copies of Clark's store near each other. The opening that made them was in the store's basement, inside the building. Every one of them can be explained by the laws, and together they're the best single test of the theory.



The accurate interior copy, a frame from the film supplied with this commission. Signs, furniture, trusses and long fluorescent tubes, and Async's gas canisters and hoses on the floor.

Copy	What it shows	How the laws make it
The accurate interior	The sales floor with its signs, furniture and trusses, brightly lit. Its glass front doors open onto a solid yellow wall	The capture starts in the basement and fills the sales floor, which saw no sky, so it comes through faithful (Law 3). It was taken with its lights on, so it's lit (Law 2). Its front doors face away from the open space at its centre, so they run into the edge of the copy (Law 4)
The inside-out copy	The store's front, a plain box with a gable, the sign and mascot, cars half sunk in a car park, real trees, plain unlit ceiling tiles overhead, darkness	The capture passes through the glass front doors into the car park (Law 4). The car park saw the whole sky, so the sky drains it and everything there is streamlined (Law 3). The cars drifted and sank (Law 2). The trees are matter. It was taken at night, lights off
The dark maze	Corridors that no longer follow the store's layout, the store's wall design, trusses and signs, two "MUST GO" signs repeating down a corridor, no light	A copy of a night capture, rebuilt in the Complex's own layout while keeping the store's materials and signs (Law 6, remembering rebuilds). The signs repeat (Law 2). Its lights were off when taken

[OURS] All three sit near one another because captures from one opening gather at the same place, which is the Kelowna Branch, and copies of copies spread around the freshest ones.

Every Still Life against the laws

Still Life	Captured where	What was kept	What was lost or filled	What it shows
Pirate Clark	The store, on the day of the commercial	Costume colours, hat, sash, a shoe, the chair leg	Real lower leg, proportions, biology the gas acts on	Merging, interpretation, freshest keeps most function

Still Life	Captured where	What was kept	What was lost or filled	What it shows
Mary	Async's interview room, near the Threshold	Her tank top, her posture, her face mostly	Six fingers, a face split down the middle	Capture at a moment, a fresh copy less distorted
The redheaded woman	Unknown	A red business suit	Several angles of a face merged	Faces fail first
The bearded man	Unknown	His clothes	Six eyes, no reaction to anything	Little function left
ALS	Unknown, possibly long ago	Old clothes, a lamp, a wheelchair	Fused to the chair, legs attached haphazardly	Lost purpose, the chair kept as part of the body
The knocker in Found Footage #3	Unknown	A man's jacket and shirt	Proportions, half the face dark, runs on all fours	Behaviour copied as form, knocking without understanding doors
The grey figure with a phone	Unknown	The shape of a person on a call	Colour, material, half sunk in the floor	Perhaps unfinished, or a copy of a statue

Pirate Clark, frame by frame



Pirate Clark, image supplied with this commission. Teal sleeves, a yellow coat grown from the commercial's vest, the purple sash and belt, one grey shoe, and the chair leg as a real peg.

[FILM] Set the commercial frame from the first law's section beside this one.

- **The costume came through.** Teal sleeves, a pale yellow vest, a purple sash, a black belt, dark breeches and a tricorn hat. All of them are there on Pirate Clark. The colours match the store's teal and yellow mascot, so this frame can't tell whether the copy followed the mascot or the costume. They're the same outfit.
- **The vest became a long coat.** The body grew to over eight feet and became wire-thin. Proportions drifted everywhere, as Law 2 predicts.
- **Two white sneakers became one grey shoe.** In the commercial, both of Clark's feet are visible. On Pirate Clark there's one shoe and one peg.
- **The chair leg and the real leg were one bundle.** In the commercial the chair leg is strapped right alongside Clark's real lower leg, folded up tight against it. Wood and leg were pressed together at the

knee.

[OURS] What this shows is that the leg wasn't missed. The capture took in a man and a chair leg pressed into one bundle. The rule that sinks furniture into floors welds touching things together, which is why the hat grew into his head. The welded mass then had to be rebuilt as one form, and the form that won was the familiar one, a pirate whose leg is a peg, the shape of the store's own mascot. A real lower leg in the same place would have been solid inside solid, which the Complex resolves by keeping one. It kept the one that matched (Laws 2 and 5).

[OURS] And Pirate Clark isn't a scan in any case. His whole body has been rebuilt at the wrong proportions, with a stretched face, misaligned eyes and a mouth that isn't Clark's. The leg is one re-made relationship among many.

The time problem

[CANON] The time chapter found that almost every misplaced thing in the Complex comes from the future. Law 1 depends on openings scattered through time, so this needs checking.

Thing	Its date	Where it turns up	Does it look out of place?
The Heathrow courtyard	2018	A 1991 tape	Yes, it's from the future
The Arcadia flyer	2022	Ravi, 1995	Yes
MGMT's "Kids" and a 2015 interview	2008, 2015	Marvin's radio, 1990	Yes
The father's television advert	2007 to 2009	Ravi, 1995	Yes
The Universal ballast	1975	The ceiling, 1989	No, old fittings are normal in a building
The troffer	1973	The ceiling, 1989	No
ALS's clothes	nineteenth century	The film, 1990	Only because a person is wearing them
The cardboard caveman and the Mao portrait	older	Found Footage #3	No

[OURS] The old things are there. They just don't stand out, because old objects in a building are ordinary. Only things from after the date of the scene look wrong, so only those get noticed. Contacts can be spread across time in both directions, and the apparent lean toward the future is mostly a matter of what we can spot.

[OURS] People are a separate matter. Every person who has fallen in and come out came out later, never earlier. That's about how people move between our world and the Complex, not about what the Complex copies, and the theory leaves it open.

Does the film show intent?

[FAN] TV Tropes lists the film's signs that the Complex acts on purpose. Each one has an ordinary explanation.

Sign of intent	Ordinary explanation
Clark's voicemail says he "opened the window" right after Mary dreams of opening one	Mary's book is The Window Within, its pitch is about opening the window within, and her tape talks about a window that was never locked. Clark had been listening to it. The phrase is hers
The crack of light opens just as Clark reaches it	It opens right after he switches the red breakers off. His action came first
The store's lights flicker and lead him to the basement	The store's power was being rerouted. Flickering lights send anyone to the breaker box

Sign of intent	Ordinary explanation
The television shows Backrooms footage	Signals leak across thin places throughout canon, like Marvin's radio picking up future broadcasts
The playground's lights come on while Ravi is there	Real buildings have lights on motion sensors, and Async's Outpost has them too

[OURS] So the film doesn't require a mind. It doesn't rule one out either, and Kane says he doesn't know. The theory stays neutral, as he does.

Predictions that could break the theory

[OURS] A theory that can't be broken isn't worth much. These are the things any future episode could show that would break one or more of the laws.

1. **A real sky.** Sunlight, a real sky, or shadows cast by a sun anywhere inside. That breaks Law 3.
2. **A back without a front.** A copied building showing its rear to the open space when its rear didn't face open space in the original. That breaks Law 4.
3. **A substitute from nowhere.** A filling with no possible real source, or one that resembles and serves nothing. That breaks Law 5.
4. **A fresh copy full of substitutes,** or an old copy more accurate than a fresh one of the same thing. That breaks Law 6.
5. **The default shifting fast** toward something recently captured. That breaks Law 7.
6. **A plant that grows or wilts.** That doesn't break a law, but it would settle that some plants in the Complex are alive rather than Still Lifes.
7. **A Still Life with working organs,** or one the gas knocks out like a person. That breaks Law 9.
8. **The Complex changing our world far from any opening.** That breaks Law 10.
9. **A room changing dramatically in front of a group with no green glow.** That breaks your hypothesis from the previous chapter, that the Complex is steadier where people are.
10. **A fresh copy of a place that was never near an opening.** That breaks Law 1.
11. **A house captured from the street with a fully convincing interior,** all the way through, when no opening was inside it. That breaks Law 4.
12. **A single copy on the scale of a whole city,** complete rather than a view of faces, a repetition or the default. That breaks Laws 1 and 4 together.
13. **A fresh outdoor copy whose fronts are weathered, cluttered and detailed,** as detailed as the interiors beside them. That breaks the sky drain of Law 3.
14. **A dark copy whose lights come on by themselves,** or a lit one going dark by itself. That breaks Law 2's captured light state.
15. **Outdoor-looking places common among the old default rooms,** or beside a way in. That breaks the outdoor system of Law 3.
16. **A red copy lit evenly from above,** or with no stars, or with red street lamps of its own. That breaks the dusk theory.

Questions and Answers

This chapter takes every question about how the Complex works that came up while this book was being made, along with the ones a careful reader would ask next, and answers each from the working theory. Every answer says which law it rests on. Where canon gives no answer and the theory can't reach one, the answer says so.

The laws are numbered as in the working theory. 1 is Capture, 2 Two fidelities, 3 Matter not light, 4 The open space is the centre, 5 Interpretation, 6 Every remembering is a worse copy, 7 The snowball, 8 Continuation, 9 Structure before function, and 10 Reaching back.

The basics

What is the Complex, in one sentence?

[OURS] A place that takes in the physical structure of whatever touches it, keeps what things are far better than where they belong, rebuilds what it lacks from what it already holds, and grows by extending itself through its own openings. Kane's version is shorter. It "recognizes, interprets, and stores" the physical structure of our world.

Does it think?

[KANE] Kane says he doesn't know whether there's intelligence or intent behind it. He calls it a neutral technology and compares it to a force of nature.

[OURS] The theory works without a mind. Every sign of intent in the film has an ordinary explanation (see the previous chapter). But working without a mind isn't the same as proving there isn't one, and nobody can settle it from what's been shown. The honest answer is that it's open.

Does it care about people?

[KANE] Kane's words are that "sometimes, humans get caught up in that too". People are caught up in what it does, not targeted by it.

[OURS] Everything in the theory agrees. It copies places, and people are copied only when they happen to be inside a place at the moment it's taken (Law 1). The things that make it feel as though it cares, the views, the fronts facing you, the lights coming on, all have explanations that don't involve people at all (Laws 3 and 4).

Why does Kane keep it so vague?

[KANE] He has said that the audience's understanding of what the place is and how it works is as correct as the characters', that he doesn't want to define it or give it a "Backrooms spirit", and that he would never set up a mystery without knowing the answer himself. He also says exactly one fan has worked the whole thing out.

[OURS] So there is an answer, and it's in his private document. A working theory can't claim to be that answer. It can only explain what's on screen as well as possible.

How it copies

How does it know what's inside and what's outside?

[OURS] It doesn't need to know. Being inside is a physical fact, not an idea. A room is air walled off by matter. Copy the matter, and the walling off comes with it for free.

[OURS] Real architecture looks random and chaotic, but it's packed with hidden order. Gravity, weather, structure, the way people move, property lines, the buildings that were there before. All of that order is frozen into the matter of a building. A copy of the matter carries the order with it, without the Complex understanding any of it.

[OURS] And what lies outside a building is mostly sky and distance, which can't be copied (Law 3). So every copy ends at walls or at the edge of what was taken, and the Complex fills beyond that with its default rooms (Law 8).

How does it remember a place and rebuild it?

[KANE] Kane says it builds "a cache of physical spatial information" and "synthesizes such environments internally". It keeps a record and builds from it.

[FILM] [OURS] Each rebuild is made from the last one, not from the original, and each loses a little (Law 6). That's Clark's line, "the more times it remembers something, the less it does". What's lost is replaced from the Complex's stock (Law 5), so over many rememberings a place drifts toward the yellow rooms.

How does it take in a place at all?

[OURS] Canon never shows the mechanism, and Kane doesn't want to define it. What canon does show is what the mechanism must be able to do.

- **It gets what's hidden.** Ductwork above the ceiling, insulation on the floor above, the label on the back of a ballast. No line of sight is needed.
- **It works near openings.** Every copy with a known origin was made next to one, or of something that went through one (Law 1).
- **It takes whole volumes.** A house comes with its interior, its yard and its fences.

[SCIENCE] There's one real technology that sees inside solid things without line of sight, and the series puts it front and centre. Async started out making MRI machines, and its Threshold is a magnetic machine. Magnetic resonance imaging builds a three-dimensional picture of what's inside a body from how its atoms respond to a magnetic field and radio pulses. [OURS] That's a strong thematic lead, not a literal answer. An MRI scanner can't read the ink on a label. But a company that learned to image the inside of matter finding a place that copies the inside of matter is unlikely to be an accident.

How could it get surfaces, volumes, connections, orientation, materials, objects, markings and context all at once?

[OURS] All eight follow from a single ability, a point-by-point record of what matter is where inside a volume. Everything else can be read off that record.

1. **Surfaces** are where the matter changes.
2. **Volumes** are where matter is absent.
3. **Connections** are how the empty spaces join up.
4. **Orientation** is just the coordinates, kept as they were.
5. **Materials** are the composition at each point, which is why the chemistry of the tile is right.
6. **Objects** are continuous bodies of matter that differ from what surrounds them. No labels are needed, which is why the Complex can copy a sign perfectly without knowing what a sign is for.
7. **Markings** are matter too. Ink sits on a surface and a stamp is pressed into steel. A full record of matter includes printed text for free.
8. **Context** is the relationships between all of the above.

[OURS] The striking thing is that the eighth is the only one that's purely about relationships, and it's exactly the one that fails (Law 2). The same single ability also predicts what can never be captured, anything that

isn't matter, like light, sky and distance (Law 3).

Does it see like a camera?

[YOURS] The idea was that it takes something like a picture and rebuilds what it sees from materials it has learnt.

[OURS] Not a camera, because it copies things no camera could see. But the heart of the idea is right. It rebuilds what it lacks from what it already has (Law 5), and the reason it has to rebuild the sky every time is that the sky isn't matter (Law 3).

Where does its point of view come from?

[OURS] It has none. The hidden ductwork and the labels on the backs of things prove it isn't looking from anywhere. It takes the whole volume. So there's no question of copying "from the front" or "from the roof". The copy keeps the original's own up and down and its own layout. The front of a copied house is where the front of the real house was.

How can it know the inside of a building it only meets from outside?

[OURS] The inside is matter like everything else, so it comes along with the rest. The house in the blue box has a near-perfect interior, down to a whiskey bottle, a mounted fish and a shoe stuck in the floor, because the interior was in the volume that was taken. Where a copied house leads on into places that were never part of the house, that's the copy ending and the Complex continuing from its openings (Law 8).

How can serial numbers be perfect when the sizes are wrong?

[OURS] Because they're different kinds of information (Law 2). What a thing is, its chemistry and its printing, lives inside the thing. Where it belongs is a relationship between that thing and others, often across a distance. Any copying that makes small errors keeps the first far better than the second.

[CANON] The three closing-down signs prove it. One object, copied three times, with identical tiny flaws in proportional positions, each time smaller and sunk further into the floor. Perfect as a thing every time. Wrong in size and placement every time.

How far can it reach? Could it copy all of New York?

[OURS] It takes a scene around an opening. The largest copies in canon are the store, copied at least three times, a house with its yard, a street, and the Red City.

[CANON] Look closely at the Red City and the limit shows. Near things are whole. The far towers are faces only, their windows looking like glowing pictures rather than rooms.

[OURS] That's what a capture that fades with distance would give, whole objects near the opening, only faces further out, nothing beyond. So the limit is a fall-off, not a hard radius, and facades are its signature (Law 4). New York is impossible because an opening is local, and most of a city, seen from any one place, is distance and the faces of things.

Why doesn't it copy oceans, deserts, the arctic or caves?

[OURS] Three reasons, none of them a preference.

1. **Where openings are.** Natural null zones turn up in basements, garages and walls, inside solid structures. The car on the highway is the one clear outdoor contact in canon, and what came through was the car.
2. **What open nature is made of.** An ocean view, a desert or an ice field is mostly sky, open air and horizon, none of which can be copied (Law 3). Capture one and you get a little sand or water and a great deal of nothing.
3. **What survives.** Rare material is the first to vanish when things are remembered over and over (Laws 6 and 7). A cave, with no repeating parts, would drift into something else quickly.

[CANON] Where natural matter does sit near an opening, it comes through. Water is copied, in the pools. Grass is copied, in Mary's yard. Trees line the Red City.

Shouldn't it be full of patches of grass and handfuls of sand?

[OURS] It does contain them, which is a point in the theory's favour. The copy of Mary's yard is grass and broken paving inside yellow walls. The Static Dead End has a plastic lawn chair sitting on a hump of carpet. A house on the red street has upside-down traffic signs stuck in its carpet. They're rare for the reasons in the last answer, not absent.

Why are Kane's copies so small, when fan versions are so huge?

[OURS] Because a capture is local and fades quickly once it meets matter (Laws 1 and 4), so no single copy can be large. Every copy in canon is one place, a store, a house, a yard, a street. The biggest-looking things are views of faces (the Red City's towers), repetitions of one small piece (the sun-painting tower, the showroom bays around the film's bottomless pit), or the Complex's own default (the Main Chamber's grid of identical pillars). It gets big through numbers and repetition, never through the size of one copy. The working theory has a section on this.

Weren't the red street's houses copied whole?

[CANON] Only one was ever entered, the house at the end of the street. Inside were a blue room with upside-down traffic signs stuck in the carpet, a hallway, and a room someone had been camping in. The fan wiki says the house "forgets" it's supposed to be a house as you walk through it.

[OURS] That's the fade of a capture centred on the street (Law 4). The front came through whole. Behind it, less and less of the house survived, and the gaps were filled from the nearest stock, the street's own traffic signs, upside down (Laws 2 and 5). The houses nobody entered should be the same.

Then why does the house in the blue box have a near-perfect interior?

[OURS] Because its opening was inside it. It's the copy of the father's house, and the null zone was in his living-room wall, so the capture began among the rooms. The rule is that a copied building has a convincing interior only if the opening was inside it (Law 4).

Does it prefer simple architecture?

[YOURS] The question was whether it favours the simplest, most consistent buildings, which would be why it copies buildings more than caves even though both are enclosed.

[OURS] It ends up full of simple architecture, but not because it chooses it. Simple, repetitive architecture survives being remembered again and again, because it costs almost nothing to describe. A grid of pillars is one pillar repeated. A cave has nothing that repeats, so it drifts fast (Law 7). Over many generations, simple things are what's left.

Inside, outside and the sky

Why are you always enclosed? Why are you never outside?

[OURS] Because it has nothing to make an outside from. The sky isn't matter, so it can't be copied (Law 3). Every open-looking place has to be closed by something the Complex does have, a painted box, a dark ceiling, a drop ceiling of panels, a surface lit by lamps. Even the Red City's sky is fittings and a surface.

Why does it mostly copy interiors, and what makes it copy an outdoor area?

[OURS] There's no switch that flips it into copying outdoors. A capture takes the matter around an opening. If that matter is carpet and drywall, the result is an interior. If it's grass, paving and a street lamp, the result is an outdoor scene. Either way the sky is missing. It mostly copies interiors because openings mostly form inside buildings, and because the default it fills gaps with snowballed from early indoor

material (Law 7).

[OURS] No canon source gives a figure like 99 per cent, but "overwhelmingly" is fair.

Why are outdoor areas so rare?

[OURS] Four things multiply. Openings rarely form outdoors, since canon's are in basements, walls and garages, so a capture fills an interior first and only reaches outdoor air through a door, a window or a gap. Once it's outside, the sky drains it, so it gathers little (Law 3). Most of an outdoor view is sky and distance, which can't be copied at all. And rare material is absorbed into the default faster than new outdoor captures arrive (Laws 6 and 7). The working theory sets out the whole system under Law 3.

What is the Red City, really?

[CANON] A city at night seen through the windows of a skywalk and later of an office. Office towers with lit windows, trees, a road and a giant road sign standing on end, all under a starry sky and flooded with red light.

[OURS] Under the theory it's an outdoor capture like any other. The towers, trees, road and sign are matter and came through (Law 3). The sky couldn't, so it's a dark surface with light fittings for stars, as the fan wiki and the gazetteer both suspect. The towers are faces only, because the capture fades with distance (Law 4). The road sign standing on end is a thing in the wrong orientation (Law 2).

[YOURS] You proposed that the Complex mistook the clustered towers for the walls of a room. That idea failed one test. The red street in Pitfalls gets the same treatment and has no tall buildings at all. What the two share is the missing sun.

Why is the Red City red?

[OURS] Most likely because it was captured at dusk. The gazetteer's study of the frames found the red light comes from lamps, low and from one side, under a dark sky with stars, while the street lamps give white light and the office windows warm white. At dusk the sky overhead is already dark with the first stars, while the last red light of the set sun comes in low from one side. The sun isn't matter, so the Complex can't copy it. It replaces it with fittings that keep the colour and direction of the light it gave at that moment. The working theory sets this out under Law 3 as the dusk theory, and Kane's own track title "Red Sun in the Sky" sits well with it.

How does the Complex know what colour to make the lights of an outdoor copy?

[OURS] It doesn't choose. The colour and direction are those of the light falling on the scene at the moment of capture. Midday gives white light from above, so bright panels overhead. Dusk gives red light low from one side, so red floodlights low on one side. Deep night gives none, so only the scene's own lamps. The scene's own lamps are matter and keep their own colour whatever the time.

Why is the playground's grass green carpet?

[OURS] Size isn't the reason. The playground is small and the Complex can copy grass elsewhere. Two readings fit.

- **It's an accurate copy of an indoor playground.** [REAL] Indoor play centres often have building fronts as scenery, imitation street lamps, green carpet or artificial turf, and lights on sensors. The Codex files the playground under "wrong context", and a faithful copy of an indoor play area set down in the Complex is exactly that.
- **It's an outdoor playground after many rememberings,** with the grass replaced by the most familiar flat green floor nearby (Laws 5 and 6). The drum kit room right next to it has green carpet too.

[OURS] The first is simpler. Neither needs grass to be too hard.

Why is the house in the blue box under a painted sky?

[OURS] The house, its porch, hedges and fences are matter and came through. The sky behind it couldn't (Law 3). The Complex closed the captured space with a box and painted the sky on, using paint, which it does have (Law 5).

What is the whole system behind outdoor places, what, why, how, when and where?

[OURS] Canon has never explained it. The system that fits everything canon shows is set out under Law 3 in the working theory. In short, an outdoor copy is a capture whose centre was outdoor air. It's rare because openings form indoors and the sky drains the capture. It looks like a stage set under a ceiling, lit by lamps. It happens only when a capture's flood reaches outdoor air, and it's dark and red-lit when taken at night. And it's found only near the opening that made it, never among the old default rooms.

Why do outdoor copies look like dioramas or stage sets?

[YOURS] [OURS] Because whatever faced the sky was copied weakly. The sky drains the capture the way it swallows light that would otherwise bounce round a room, so a sky-facing surface keeps only its large shape and main colour. The house in the blue box has flat single-colour siding and box-shaped hedges, the film's street is toy-clean, the Red City's windows look like pictures. The incidental things that make a real outside look lived in, wear, stains, clutter, are the first to go, and without them a house looks like a model.

Why is the outside of Clark's store simplified when its inside is accurate?

[OURS] Because the opening was in the basement. The capture filled the store's inside, which saw no sky, so it came through faithfully. It reached the outside only through the glass front doors, into a car park open to the sky, where it was drained, so the front came through as a plain box with its sign, mascot, sunk cars and trees.

Why does the film's suburban street look so clean?

[OURS] The street was the open space at the centre of its capture, but every face along it saw the sky, so every face was streamlined. That's the case that shows the sky matters more than distance from the opening.

Does the capture bounce, like light?

[OURS] It behaves as if it does. Inside, it keeps circulating between surfaces and samples everything many times. Outside, the sky swallows it. The mathematics chapter works it through with the radiosity equation that describes light bouncing in a room. It's a model, not something canon states, but it explains the pattern better than anything else.

If the capture is like light, how did it copy the ballast inside a dark fitting?

[OURS] Because it isn't visible light, and darkness doesn't weaken it. Only the open sky drains it. A sealed ceiling cavity is the most enclosed place in a building, so it's copied best of all, which is exactly why Async found perfect ductwork, insulation and serial numbers above the tiles.

Wouldn't that make streamlined outdoor places appear everywhere?

[OURS] No. Streamlining decides how an outdoor part looks when there is one. What keeps them rare is separate. Openings form indoors, the sky drains the capture so outdoor reach is short, remembering removes the sky first, and so outdoor places stay near the openings that made them. Canon shows seven among dozens of places, every one far from any way in.

Why are there three copies of Clark's store, and why are two of them dark?

[OURS] One doorway, several capture events, and remembering. The accurate interior was taken with the lights on. The inside-out copy is the capture escaping through the glass front doors into the car park, taken at night. The maze is a copy of a night capture, rebuilt in the Complex's own layout but keeping the store's walls, trusses and signs. Lights keep the state they were captured in, on or off, so the night copies are dark. The testing chapter has the full analysis.

Does the capture pass through glass?

[OURS] It behaves as if it does, as light would. That's how a capture that began in the store's basement reached its car park, and how the Red City is seen through a skywalk's windows.

Does the Complex rebuild places rather than copy them?

[YOURS] [OURS] Both. A fresh copy keeps the place's geometry, faithful inside and streamlined outside. Copies of copies rebuild it in the Complex's own image, keeping its materials, its notable objects and how its rooms join. The maze copy of Clark's store is canon's example.

Fronts, views and connections

How does it know to keep the front of a house facing the room?

[OURS] It doesn't know anything about fronts. The room is built around the open space the front was facing (Law 4).

- In the real world, a house's front is the side that faces open space, its yard and street. Which way a house faces is written into the matter.
- A capture keeps the open space and the faces bordering it, and fades behind them. That's why the blue-box house ends at its fence line, and why the houses in the film's street are cut off just behind their fronts.
- The sky over that open space can't be copied (Law 3), so the Complex encloses the space with its own walls. The enclosure is wrapped around the open space, so the fronts face into it.
- The only part of that room anyone can walk in is the front space. Behind the house there's only wall. Nobody could come at it from behind.

[FILM] [CANON] Indoor captures show the same law the other way round. The copy of Clark's store has its glass front doors facing a yellow wall, and the classroom where Ravi lands has a window onto brick. There, the open space at the centre was the inside, so anything facing out runs into the edge of the capture.

Why does Ravi get a skywalk with a perfect view of the Red City? Is it showing off?

[OURS] Skywalks are real. They're enclosed walkways between buildings, with windows onto the street below. If the capture took a skywalk together with the street and towers around it as one scene, the view came with the matter (Law 1). The walkway and the city it overlooks were already neighbours, and short-range relationships like that survive well (Law 2). Ravi sees the city a second time from an office's tall windows, another place where real buildings look out over a street.

[OURS] There's also a simple selection effect. Found footage is edited, and fans suspect someone cut Ravi's tape together. We're watching the highlights, so the Complex looks like it's putting on a show. And Kane, as a filmmaker, chose to show the Red City. Inside the story, none of that needs the Complex to want anything.

How does it connect one place to another?

[OURS] By growing from its own openings (Law 8). New material is attached where old material has a doorway, gap, hole, crawl space or chute. Pieces meet at natural seams, doorways, corridor ends and junctions, wherever they can. The space between fresh copies is filled with the default rooms. Nothing ever checks the whole, only each join.

Why does it connect places at all?

[OURS] It doesn't need to, and it isn't trying to. Copies are made at openings and attached at openings, so they're connected by construction. A crystal is one piece for the same reason. It only ever grows from its own faces.

Why is it walkable? Why don't places overlap everywhere?

[OURS] It's walkable because it copies human places, which were already walkable, and its seams fall at doorways, where people walk. So walkability is inherited, not guaranteed. Ravi can't climb back up his chute, a door opens onto brick, a hallway climbs like a staircase with no steps, and pits drop people where they can't get back from.

[OURS] Places don't overlap everywhere because solid can't share space with solid. Where two pieces would overlap, one sinks into the other, which is exactly what furniture half sunk into a floor looks like. Overlap in time does happen. Room 14C changed while nobody was looking, Clark's floor plan "changed again", and Kat could see Clark through a wall that was opaque from his side.

Does it punch holes, or graft pieces together?

[YOURS] Both were proposed. Does it find an opening shape in its stock and punch it through a dead end? Or does it cut off a dead end and graft on a piece that has an opening, like Frankenstein architecture?

[CANON] [OURS] Canon has evidence for both.

- **Punching.** In Found Footage #3, behind a couch, where a picture should hang, the wall opens into another room. A rectangle on a wall has become a rectangle through a wall (Law 5).
- **Grafting.** The crack across a hallway floor where two kinds of room meet, and the Static Dead End, half wallpaper and half tile, look like pieces forced together with no natural join. The three copies of Clark's store, a maze of the store's own materials, an accurate copy and an inside-out copy, show one place cut and recombined.

Why does such a nonsensical walk still make sense?

[OURS] Because every single step is locally sensible. A doorway leads to a room. A corridor leads somewhere. The brain judges each transition on its own and rarely the whole route. Only when you ask how the classroom, the house, the furniture store and the Red City fit together does it fall apart. Real cities feel like this too, a little, and the Complex takes away the global order entirely while keeping the local kind.

Why it goes wrong

What causes the imperfections?

[OURS] It isn't trying to get things wrong. Three mechanisms produce almost every error in canon.

1. **Placement drift.** Things keep their form while their sizes and positions are remembered wrongly (Law 2). Wrongly sized or shifted pieces end up in each other's space.
2. **Forced joins.** Where two pieces have no clean seam between them, the join shows as a crack, a seam between two materials, or sagging (Law 8).
3. **Filling.** Gaps are filled with the typical, which adds things that were never there, like the arch that appears in the teaser (Law 5).

Why does furniture sink into floors?

[OURS] Because the furniture has kept its form while its position relative to the floor has drifted (Law 2). When a remembered chair and a remembered floor disagree about where the floor is, the chair ends up partly inside it. The same rule fused Pirate Clark's hat into his head, and sinks each closing-down sign a little deeper than the last.

Why do walls stretch and floors sag?

[CANON] In the Static Dead End, the wallpaper was physically stretching sideways, pulling taped squares into rectangles, and patches of floor sagged and bulged.

[OURS] That room is half wallpaper and half tile, a place where two pieces meet without a natural join (Law 8). The slow stretching looks like a join still being fitted, two remembered pieces with different proportions being forced into one space. A green door led into it, and green light tends to appear where the Complex is actively changing.

What are the pits?

[CANON] [FILM] Square pits keep leading to very different places. The red street lies below the pits of Room 14D. A huge pit lies under the copy of Clark's store. The film's chase passes a vast room built around a pit with no visible bottom.

[OURS] A pit is a seam between two pieces at different heights. A horizontal join is a doorway, and a vertical one is a hole (Law 8).

Why are things repeated, like the three signs and the sun painting?

[OURS] Repetition is a failure of how many there should be (Law 2), and it's also how the snowball works (Law 7). An object copied and then copied from its copies turns up again and again. The three signs are one object placed three times. The smiling sun is one painting on every level of a tower.

Why are signs mirrored?

[OURS] The sign is copied perfectly and its orientation isn't (Law 2). Every letter on the POTS stop sign is correct, only reversed.

Why are some copies dark, if the lights never go out?

[OURS] Because lights keep the state they were captured in. A lamp taken while on never goes out, which is canon's wording. A lamp taken while off never comes on. A place copied at night, lights off, stays dark. The inside-out and maze copies of Clark's store are dark for that reason (Law 2).

Why do things lose their purpose, like a door onto brick?

[OURS] Purpose is a relationship. A door is for passing from one space to another, a hood is for the cooker under it. The door and the hood are things and come through. What they're for is a relationship to other things and gets lost (Law 2). Doors that face away from a capture's open space end at the edge of the capture, which is why so many doors and windows in the Complex open onto brick or yellow walls (Law 4).

Why does it fall back to the yellow rooms? Why that wallpaper?

[OURS] The yellow rooms are what the Complex has repeated most. Because it copies its own copies, whatever is common gets more common, so its earliest material had a head start that snowballed (Law 7).

[KANE] [FAN] Kane says the yellow wallpaper design comes from Europe. Wendigoon suggests it comes from Ivan Beck's past. [OURS] The snowball makes that possible. If one of the first things the Complex ever took in was a room from Beck's European past, that room could have become its default, far from where most of its openings now are. Beck was born in Karlovy Vary in 1931.

Plants, water and bodies

If it fills gaps with substitutes, why are there real plants?

[OURS] Because plants are matter. Where they were present at capture, they come through (Law 3). The Red City's trees, the drum kit room's pot plant and the grass in Mary's yard are all copies of real plants that were there. Substitution only fills gaps, things that couldn't be captured, were lost, or were damaged. The biggest gap in any outdoor scene is always the sky, not the grass.

Are the plants alive? How would they survive without water or sun?

[OURS] Canon has never tested one. The tile survey proves the Complex copies composition, but not that it copies life. Three kinds of plant are possible.

- **Artificial plants.** Some must be, since a plastic plant copies as a plastic plant.
- **Plant Still Lifes,** exact in form and composition and never changing (see the next answer).
- **Living plants.** [SCI] Fluorescent tubes are grow lights. Plants can photosynthesise under them, and greenhouses use them. A plant under endless fluorescent light could live for a while. Water would be its real problem.

[OURS] Biology does run in the Complex. Bacteria grow there, the Lifeform seems to grow in place like a plant, and the young man found in February 1990 had his decay oddly halted in places. So living plants can't be ruled out.

Are the plants Still Lifes?

[YOURS] You proposed that they are, frozen as they were when captured, with the form and composition of a plant and none of its life, and easier to make than people because plants are simpler.

[OURS] It fits Law 9 well, with one refinement. What matters most isn't how complex a thing is, but how much of it is behaviour rather than structure. A plant has almost no visible behaviour, so a plant Still Life would look exactly like a plant. You'd only know over time. It would never grow, never wilt and never drop a leaf. A person is the opposite. Behaviour is most of what we see of someone, so a person's missing function shows at once.

[SCIENCE] In John Conway's Game of Life, printed on Phil's shirt in the film, a "still life" is a pattern that doesn't change from one step to the next. That's exactly what a plant Still Life would be.

[OURS] The test is simple. If any plant in the Complex is ever shown to grow or wilt, it isn't a Still Life.

How does it handle water and the pools?

[CANON] [FILM] Water is matter, and everything tested in the Complex is ordinary matter, so copied water behaves like water (Law 3). The film's pool rooms have running water. A pool is only a basin of tiles and the water in it, and both copy easily.

Why are Still Lifes full of white stuffing?

[FILM] Inside, they have no bones or organs, only a white substance like porridge, rice or furniture stuffing. Clark eats it.

[OURS] A body's insides are the densest, least exposed and most functional part of it, so they're what copies worst (Law 9) and what gets filled (Law 5). What fills them is telling. The Still Lifes in the film live in a region grown from a furniture store, Pirate Clark is made of the same cheap particleboard as the store's stock, and Clark himself says they "just exist, like furniture". If the filling is furniture filling, it's Law 5 at its clearest. A thing that has copied a furniture store and doesn't know what's inside a human fills the human with what it knows is inside a sofa. That stays a reading, since the descriptions compare the substance to porridge and rice as well.

Why does Pirate Clark bleed when the others don't? Does he feel pain?

[FILM] He's the only Still Life that bleeds like a person, and he roars and fights back when Mary hurts him. The others don't react even to being stabbed.

[OURS] He's also the freshest copy, taken directly from the store while it was joined to the Complex. The freshest copies keep the most function (Law 9). Mary's copy, made at the end, is the least distorted of the rest.

[OURS] Whether he feels pain is unknown. Reacting to damage shows a response, not a feeling. And his immunity to Async's gas shows his biology is still far from complete.

Why are faces the worst part?

[FAN] [SCIENCE] A face packs more detail into less space than anything else on a body. Under any limited budget, the things with the longest descriptions are mangled first. That's why Still Lifes have extra eyes, split faces and several angles of a face merged, while their clothes are fine.

Why doesn't the gas work on Pirate Clark?

[FILM] [OURS] Presumably because there's no real biology inside for it to act on, as TV Tropes suggests. Even the freshest Still Life has structure without the full workings (Law 9).

People and Still Lifes

How, when and why does it copy a place and the people in it?

[OURS] One scene, at one moment, near an opening, with the people in it as passengers (Law 1). It copies a place because the place was touching an opening. It copies a person because the person was standing in that place at that moment. It copies the moment it does because capture happens in events, not continuously.

Why Pirate Clark, and not Clark in bed? Why Mary at Async, and not in her office?

[FILM] [OURS] Because neither copy is about the person. Both are about the place.

- **Mary** was copied in Async's interview room, a few corridors from the KV31 Threshold, the largest opening there is. Her therapy office never touched an opening, however many years she spent there.
- **Clark** was copied on the day of the commercial. His store's power trouble begins right afterwards, so the store was very likely already being joined to the Complex, and the closing-down banners Async later found copied inside were hanging in the store during the shoot.

[KANE] It isn't about the most memorable or meaningful moment either. Kane has said the Complex isn't picking moments out of people's minds.

Why isn't it full of billions of Still Lifes?

[OURS] Because it only takes in what touches an opening, and openings are rare and local (Law 1). Most people never stand next to one.

[FILM] [OURS] Even near a stable opening, capture is occasional. Clark spent weeks going in and out of his doorway and sleeping a few metres from it, and the film shows exactly one copy of him. Kane's word is "sometimes". The best guess at what triggers a capture is the Complex extending itself, which canon often marks with green light. So a man going from his house to a mall, changing clothes on the way, is never copied at all unless an opening happens to be beside him at the moment the Complex grows.

Where did Pirate Clark's real leg go? Why doesn't he have a useless extra leg behind the peg?

[FILM] In the commercial, both of Clark's sneakers are visible. The chair leg is strapped alongside his real lower leg, which is folded up tight against it. Pirate Clark has one shoe and a real peg made of the chair leg, with no leg behind it.

[OURS] The leg wasn't missed. The capture took in a man and a chair leg pressed together into one bundle at the knee. Three laws then did their work.

- **Touching things merge (Law 2).** The rule that sinks furniture into floors welds things that touch. The hat, sitting on his scalp, grew into his head. The chair leg and the folded leg became one mass.
- **The mass had to become one form (Law 5).** It was rebuilt as the most familiar form available, a pirate whose leg is a peg, the shape of the store's own teal and yellow mascot, whose costume he was wearing.

- **Solid can't sit inside solid.** A real lower leg in the same place as the peg would have been two limbs in one space. The Complex keeps one, and it kept the one that matched the form.

[OURS] And Pirate Clark isn't a scan in the first place. He's over eight feet tall and wire-thin, with a stretched face and misaligned eyes. His whole body was rebuilt. The leg is one re-made relationship among many.

Why do Still Lifes behave so differently from each other?

[OURS] Because each keeps a different amount of function (Law 9). The bearded one keeps almost none. ALS keeps a single habit, his lamp. Pirate Clark keeps enough to hunt, patrol and bleed. How much survives seems to depend on how fresh the copy is.

Why do Still Lifes knock on doors?

[CANON] [FILM] The knocker in Found Footage #3 and Pirate Clark both knock politely before smashing a door in.

[OURS] Knocking is a behaviour attached to doors, and the behaviour came through without its purpose (Law 9). A Still Life knows that people knock, but not that a knock is a request to be let in.

Why does the song "Still Life" play in their dens?

[OURS] The theory has no answer. The speakers are copied objects, but a song playing on them is something happening, not something present, and canon doesn't explain where it comes from. It stays open.

Could the Complex really have brought Kat back from her head?

[KANE] Kane has explained that Clark kept the head hoping the Complex would remember her.

[OURS] Under the theory, Clark's hope was half right. The copy of Mary's home restored her broken slab, and the chunk she carried in was enough for something from that house to be taken in at all, so the Complex can rebuild a whole from a part (Law 5). But anything it rebuilt would be a copy, worse than the original, and probably without most of its function (Laws 6 and 9). The best Clark could have hoped for was a Still Life of Kat, not Kat.

Why is Bobby's shirt copied so big?

[FILM] [OURS] His "End Apartheid" shirt, which went through an opening with him, is copied at giant size in Pirate Clark's lair. The thing came through perfectly and its size didn't (Law 2), like the oversized copy of Clark's throne.

Is the Lifeform a copy too?

[KANE] No. Kane says the Lifeform and the Still Lifes are completely separate, and that the Lifeform isn't a transformed human, though its life cycle involves human remains. [OURS] It's bacterial and grows. The theory doesn't explain it and doesn't try to.

Power and reaching back

Where does the Complex's power come from?

[CANON] Nobody knows. Async tried to cut power to one light and couldn't find where it came from. The conduit stayed live with no supply anywhere, and every light in the area ran steadily. The report concluded there must be a continuous, perhaps self-sustaining source. The ballasts are built for 60 Hz American mains and hum at 120 Hz, so whatever supplies them supplies ordinary alternating current.

[OURS] The theory says nothing about where the energy comes from. It only says what the store shows, that the Complex's supply and ours can be joined (Law 10).

If it drew energy from our world, why didn't it fry Async's equipment and people?

[YOURS] You raised this objection yourself, and it's decisive. A field strong enough to carry that much energy across the boundary would wreck electronics and harm people, and nothing like that happens. So the power isn't something filling the space. Whatever the source is, it reaches the lights the way ordinary current reaches ordinary lights, through wires.

Why did it drain Clark's store if it already has endless power?

[OURS] It doesn't need Clark's energy. What the film shows is the store being joined to its copies (Law 10). The outages moved from floor to floor night by night, and in the end the store's own circuits ran only through switches the Complex had made. The bill climbed because the store was now feeding lights that included the copies, which is why fluorescent light hummed behind the wall after the store went dark. Two joined systems share a supply, the way connected tanks level out. A source with no limit inside doesn't stop current crossing a join.

Why did breaker switches appear, and why red?

[YOURS] You proposed that the Complex was reusing a breaker switch it had copied somewhere else. That fits Law 5, and the first test of Law 5 points to the nearest real source, Clark's own panel.

[FILM] [OURS] So the likeliest reading is that the Complex copied Clark's store, breaker panel included, and as copy and original were joined, the copy's switches showed up in the original's panel. They were crooked, at an angle, connected to nothing, "as if someone had just stuck it in there". That's the Complex's signature, the right thing in the wrong placement (Law 2), sitting in our world.

[OURS] Why red, nobody knows. Red recurs in the Red City's lamps, the red street and the Outpost's alarm, which isn't enough to build anything on.

Was Clark's store the first time it reached into our world?

[CANON] Not quite. In release order, Found Footage #3 had already shown Ravi's basement wall broken through, with his glass door smashed from the inside, and Overflow had shown a green glow in Beck's laboratory in 1972. [OURS] The red switches are the first recognisable made object the Complex leaves in our world, which makes them the clearest case.

Why are doors opening everywhere now?

[FILM] Phil tells Mary that doors are opening all over, that nobody knows why or what connects them, and that they can't stop them.

[OURS] The theory points to a feedback loop. Every opening lets the Complex take in more of our world (Law 1), and once joined to a place it starts to change our side too (Law 10). Clark's store shows how one opening can grow from strange power bills into a stable doorway. If each joined place becomes a site where new openings form, they would multiply, as Phil says they are. Whether that's the actual cause, the film doesn't show.

Time

Why do things from the future appear inside?

[OURS] Because openings are scattered through time as well as space, and we only notice the ones from the future (Law 1). Old things inside the Complex don't look out of place. A 1975 ballast or a 1973 troffer in a ceiling is perfectly normal, and an old cardboard cutout or portrait raises no eyebrows. Only things from after the date of a scene look wrong, like the Heathrow courtyard in 1991 or the 2022 flyer in 1995, so they're the ones that get noticed. The previous chapter sets this out in a table.

Why do people only jump forward?

[CANON] Tench came out 68 days later. Kane's camera came out more than five years later. No one has come out earlier than they went in.

[OURS] The theory can't explain it. It's about how people pass between our world and the Complex, not about what the Complex copies. It stays open.

What does Clark mean by "every place that ever was"?

[FILM] It's his answer when Mary asks where they are.

[OURS] He's a character guessing, as Kane points out about everyone in the film. But it fits the picture of a place built from contacts scattered through time. "Ever was" rather than "is" is a good description of a place made of copies of things as they were at the moment they were taken.

The Sun and the green glow

Is the Complex connected to the Sun?

[REAL WORLD] The coincidence is real. Overflow's document is dated 2 August 1972, the start of one of the most intense solar storm sequences of the century, which peaked on 4 August. Its coronal mass ejection reached Earth in about 14.6 hours, one of the fastest ever recorded. The aurora was bright enough to cast shadows on England's south coast and was seen as far south as Bilbao in Spain. A 2018 study links it to dozens of US Navy magnetic sea mines detonating off North Vietnam.

[OURS] Async's machine is a magnetic distortion system, and a magnetic storm falling exactly on Overflow's date is too neat to be chance. It's very likely deliberate on Kane's part. The October 1989 match is weaker, since the big flare came two days after the sixth test, not before.

[CANON] [OURS] The sun runs through the imagery. The setting sun over the Threshold in Informational Video, the long sunset over the sea in home_27647.mov, the smiling Sun in Splendour on every level of the tower, the suns of Out of Sync's artwork, and Kane's track "Red Sun in the Sky". Under Law 3 there's a reading that fits, offered as a reading only. The one thing the Complex can never copy is the Sun, and inside it the Sun exists only as paint, repeated.

[OURS] What there's no evidence for is the Sun powering the Complex. The 1972 storm stays as a possible trigger for whatever happened in Beck's laboratory.

Is the green glow an aurora?

[SCIENCE] Not literally. Aurora is light given off by oxygen and nitrogen high in the atmosphere when particles from the Sun strike them, and its strongest green is oxygen's emission at 557.7 nanometres. The green glow appears indoors, behind doors and through cracks in walls, where there's no upper atmosphere. "Aurora-like" works as a family resemblance, especially beside a storm that painted the sky green in 1972.

What is the green glow?

[OURS] Unknown. What's clear is where it appears. Where walls move, where a room is half formed, where a door opens onto stretching wallpaper, and in Beck's laboratory in 1972. Under the theory it's the visible mark of the Complex actively changing, capturing or growing. What it physically is, the theory can't say.

Origins and the future

Was the Complex once empty?

[YOURS] You proposed that it might have started as an empty space, and that contact with our world gave it what it needed to fill itself.

[FAN] [OURS] This is close to Wendigoon's theory that before 1972 it was a void. It can't be proved, but the snowball (Law 7) gives it a consequence. If it began with nothing, whatever it touched first became the seed of its default, so the yellow rooms would be the fossil of its first contacts. ALS's nineteenth-century

clothes suggest it took in things from long ago, which fits if its contacts reach across time. Kane's own word for what it does with what it takes in is "aggregates", which suits a place that becomes a place by collecting.

Does it learn? Is it getting better?

[OURS] No statement from Kane saying so could be found. But the laws imply a kind of learning anyway. Every capture adds to its stock (Law 1), and its stock is what it fills gaps with (Law 5). So the more it has taken in of something, the better it can rebuild things like it. What it can't do is recover what an old copy has lost (Law 6). It can get better at kinds of things while its old places keep drifting.

Could it eventually copy our whole world perfectly, inside and out?

[OURS] No. Three laws forbid it.

1. **It can never capture light or sky (Law 3),** so a real outside is impossible however long it runs.
2. **Every remembering loses (Law 6),** and nothing lost from a chain of copies comes back.
3. **It only takes in what touches it (Law 1).**

[OURS] The most it can reach is perfect islands, fresh copies as good as Clark's store, set in a sea of drifting yellow. Never a perfect world.

How big is it?

[CANON] Nobody knows. The Main Chamber is about a hundred metres on each side, and the space above the ceiling is "more than one floor". Figures like 600 million square miles come from fan writing, not canon. [OURS] Under Law 8 it grows whenever it extends itself, so its size isn't fixed. It's however big it has grown so far.

What happens to a copy taken out of the Complex?

[CANON] Async took a troffer and half a metre of conduit back to Standard and examined them. The fitting was outdated in design, fully working, and made of exactly what you'd expect. Nothing strange, the report says, which somehow makes it stranger.

[OURS] That fits the theory. A copy is ordinary matter (Law 2), so out in the world it's an ordinary object, only one that came from nowhere.

Is the Complex turning our world into the Complex?

[FAN] TV Tropes records a theory that the real world in the film is itself starting to be remembered, with Clark's crooked switch as the sign.

[OURS] Law 10 is a milder version. Where the Complex is joined to a place, it changes that place. The store's wiring became partly the Complex's. Whether that could spread far beyond an opening, nothing in canon shows. If it ever did, Law 10 as written would be broken.

The Mathematics and the Science

This chapter does the sums. Some sections test canon (the signs, the dates, the light fittings). Some give the real science behind things the series borrows (MRI, bacteria, solar storms, the earthquake). The rest set out the models behind the hypotheses in the previous chapter. All arithmetic here was worked out for this book and can be checked by hand.

The signs in Everything Must Go

[CANON] Async's measurements, from the footage.

	Width	Gap to next
Sign 1	1.44 m, hanging clear, lowest corner 0.3 m above the floor	3.47 m
Sign 2	1.13 m, partly sunk	3.26 m
Sign 3	0.66 m, a little under half buried	

[SCIENCE] The ratios of successive widths are 0.785 and 0.584, so it isn't a constant scale factor. The differences are 0.31 m and 0.47 m, so it isn't a constant step either. The signs are shrinking faster and faster. The gaps shrink much more gently, by a factor of 0.939. The areas of the visible faces are 2.07, 1.28 and 0.44 square metres.

[SCIENCE] Three numbers can't pin down a rule, but each reasonable rule makes its own prediction for a fourth sign.

Rule that fits the first three	Fourth sign width
The ratio itself shrinks by a constant factor (0.785, 0.584, then 0.435). Equivalent to the logarithm of the width falling along a parabola	about 0.29 m
The ratio falls by a constant amount (0.785, 0.584, then 0.383)	about 0.25 m
The width falls along a parabola (differences 0.31, 0.47, then 0.63)	about 0.03 m
The differences grow by a constant factor (0.31, 0.47, then 0.71)	below zero, so no fourth sign
A constant ratio, the average of the two (0.677), which doesn't really fit	about 0.45 m

[SCIENCE] For position, a constant gap ratio puts sign 4 about 3.06 m past sign 3, and a constant decrease puts it 3.05 m past. Either way, about three metres on.

[CANON] Ronald McCarthy predicted the fourth sign would be just inside or just beyond the back wall, and they found it there, "much smaller". The fourth rule, which says there should be no fourth sign, is ruled out. The first two, giving a sign a quarter to a third of a metre wide, fit "much smaller" best. A three centimetre sign would hardly be called a sign.

[CANON] Two details don't fit a simple sequence. The fourth sign was "barely clear of the carpet", not sunk deeper than the third. And past the wall there were more signs at about the same scale, perhaps slightly smaller. So the shrinking run seems to end at the wall, where a different copy, the store, begins.

[SCIENCE] **The instancing finding.** The narrator found the same tiny flaws on all three signs in proportional positions. That means each sign is the same object scaled uniformly, a geometric similarity, with every point moved toward a centre by the same factor. If the Complex had printed three signs from one design, the flaws would differ. If it had stretched them, the flaws would sit in the right places in one direction and the wrong places in the other. Uniform scaling of one object is exactly how computer graphics draws instances of a single model. A tree in a game forest is stored once and drawn many times, each with its own position, rotation and size.

The ceiling tile and the lights

[SCIENCE] The Complex's ceiling tile is 1.27 by 1.14 metres. That's 50.0 by 44.9 inches, almost exactly 50 by 45. Standard American tiles are 24 by 24 inches or 24 by 48 inches (0.61 by 0.61 or 0.61 by 1.22 metres). Against the long tile, the Complex's is 4 per cent longer and 87 per cent wider. Against the square tile it's 108 and 87 per cent bigger in the two directions. It isn't a uniform enlargement of any standard tile, which fits the general pattern of the Complex getting proportions wrong.

[SCIENCE] The bulbs, by contrast, are close to standard. An F40 T12 is nominally 48 inches long (1.22 metres) and 1.5 inches across (38.1 millimetres, since T12 means twelve eighths of an inch). The report gives 1.2 metres and 38.1 millimetres. The ballast is the part that's oversized. So within one light fitting, some parts are copied true and others aren't.

[SCIENCE] The 120 Hz hum is physics. Mains power in North America alternates at 60 Hz. The steel core of a magnetic ballast changes length slightly whenever it's magnetised, in either direction, so it stretches twice per cycle. That's magnetostriction, and it makes a 120 Hz hum with harmonics above it.

Dates and days of the week

[SCIENCE] Every in-universe date, with its day of the week.

Date	Day	Event
16 July 1931	Thursday	Ivan Beck born
2 August 1972	Wednesday	Overflow, per the document
4 August 1972	Friday	Overflow, per Wendigoon. The storm's peak
10 May 1982	Monday	Prototype
2 July 1988	Saturday	The Third Test
17 October 1989	Tuesday	First Contact and the earthquake
14 November 1989	Tuesday	Lighting and Tile Survey
3 February 1990	Saturday	The body is found
5 February 1990	Monday	The autopsy
1 March 1990	Thursday	Tench vanishes
5 March 1990	Monday	Motion cameras placed
6 May 1990	Sunday	Pitfalls and Report
8 May 1990	Tuesday	Presentation, Tench returns
22 May 1990	Tuesday	Tench escapes inside
25 May 1990	Friday	Reunion
26 May 1990	Saturday	Damage Control briefing
29 May 1990	Tuesday	Static Dead End
18 June 1990	Monday	The signs found
19 June 1990	Tuesday	The wall cut, Naren dies
29 June 1990	Friday	Clark falls in
3 July 1990	Tuesday	The expedition with Bobby and Kat
4 July 1991	Thursday	Kane falls in, on Independence Day
19 August 1995	Saturday	The garage
23 September 1996	Monday	Kane's camera found

[SCIENCE] A few things stand out. Async works weekends. Pitfalls and Report fall on a Sunday, and the briefing and the body's discovery on Saturdays. The Third Test was on a Saturday too. And the Lighting

and Tile researcher's "today is 14 November, a Tuesday" checks out.

Time jumps

[SCIENCE] The arithmetic for every jump in the series.

Case	Calculation	Result
Tench	12:25 pm 1 March to 5:30 pm 8 May 1990	68 days 5 h 5 min, or 98,225 minutes
Tench's rate	98,225 minutes over 30 to 180 minutes lived	about 550 to 3,300 times
Kane's camera	4 July 1991 to 23 September 1996	1,908 days, 5 years 2 months
Heathrow atrium seen in 1991	opened 2018	27 years ahead
Arcadia flyer seen in 1995	dated 2022	27 years ahead
Marvin's radio, 1990	MGMT 2008, ABC News 2015	18 and 25 years ahead
Simpsons tape	1991 broadcast, 2000 advert	about 9 years
The father's TV, if Ravi is 1995	2007 to 2009 advert	12 to 14 years

[OURS] The two visual anomalies in the found footage, the Heathrow atrium and the Arcadia flyer, are both exactly 27 years ahead of the tapes they appear on. The radio and TV leaks give 9, 12 to 14, 18 and 25 years, so there's no fixed offset in general. It may be coincidence, but it's the kind of coincidence Kane tends to plant, and worth watching for in any future found footage.

The fan time-jump curve

[SCIENCE] The fan curve jump = 189.4 $e^{1.027\,t}$ passes through (2.249 s, 1,908 days) and (3.849 s, 9,862 days) exactly, which is what any two-parameter curve does with two points. Solving it for Tench's 68 days gives t = ln(68 / 189.4) / 1.027 = −1.0 seconds, an impossible negative fall. For the garage fall of 1.76 seconds it predicts 1,154 days. The full discussion is in the null zones chapter.

How big is it?

[SCIENCE] A figure of 600 million square miles circulates in fan writing. That's about 1.55 billion square kilometres, or about three times the whole surface of the Earth (510 million square kilometres). Taylor Holmes reports the A-Space pitch claiming a trillion square miles [UNVERIFIED], which would be about 5,000 Earths. Neither figure appears in canon.

Lossy copying, in equations

[SCIENCE] **Copies can't gain information.** If Y is a copy of an original X, and Z is a copy of Y made without looking at X again, information theory's data-processing inequality says

$$I(X;Z) \le I(X;Y)$$

where I is mutual information, the amount one thing tells you about another. Each generation can at best stay level. In practice it loses.

[SCIENCE] **Fine detail goes first.** In rate-distortion theory, the cheapest way to describe a set of independent features within a budget is "reverse water-filling". Pick a level λ. Every feature whose variation is smaller than λ is dropped entirely, and every feature larger than λ is kept with error λ. The total cost in bits is

$$R = \Sigma \tfrac{1}{2} \log_2(\sigma_i^{\,2} / \lambda)$$

summed over the kept features only. In natural images and spaces, small-scale features vary much less than large-scale ones (their power falls roughly as 1 over the square of their frequency), so as the budget tightens, small things go first. Clutter, then furniture shape, then windows, then the walls last. That's the teaser.

[SCIENCE] **Gaps are filled with the typical.** If remembering is a noisy measurement of the previous version, and the system fills gaps with its prior expectation (mean μ, spread σ_p) when the noise (spread σ_n) is high, the best guess is

$$x' = \mu + k\,(y - \mu),\ k = \sigma_p{}^2 / (\sigma_p{}^2 + \sigma_n{}^2)$$

Here y is the noisy impression and x' the remembered result. Each remembering keeps only a fraction k of what made the thing different from typical. After n rememberings the difference left is about k^n of the original. That's Clark's line as a formula. The more times it remembers something, the less of it is left, and what replaces it is the average room.

Why weak copies look like dioramas

[SCIENCE] When a picture is compressed hard, it doesn't blur evenly. It breaks into flat patches of single colour with sharp edges between them, which is called posterisation. The reason is general. With only a few levels to spend, the description that loses least is to give each region its average value and spend the remaining information on the boundaries where values jump. Vector quantisation, the basis of many compression schemes, does the same thing, replacing many slightly different values with a few representative ones.

[OURS] Applied to a copied place, that means surfaces become their average material, objects become their bulk in their average material, small variations disappear, and sharp boundaries between very different materials, like a white window frame on a blue wall, survive longest. That's the diorama look of the house in the blue box, explained by nothing more than a capture with little information to spend.

Drift and mutation

[SCIENCE] If each copy is assembled from N pieces drawn from the copy before, in proportion to how common each piece is, then variety (the chance two pieces picked at random differ) falls as

$$H_n = H_0 \times (1 - 1/N)^n$$

This is the Wright-Fisher model of genetic drift for single-copy genes. Rare pieces die out first. Big places with many pieces drift slowly, small ones fast.

[SCIENCE] If each piece also has a small chance μ of coming out wrong, as a new variant, variety stops falling and settles at

$$H^* = \theta / (1 + \theta),\ \theta = 2N\mu$$

the mutation-drift balance. Not collapse to a single room, not endless novelty, but a steady state where most of what you see is the common type and now and then something odd. That's the deep yellow rooms with their occasional pools and Christmas trees.

The snowball, in equations

[SCIENCE] A process that copies its own output behaves like a Pólya urn. Start with an urn holding a_i balls of each colour i, A in all. Draw a ball at random, put it back, and add another ball of the same colour. After n draws, of which n_i were colour i, the chance that the next draw is colour i is

$$P(i) = (a_i + n_i) / (A + n)$$

[SCIENCE] Each draw makes its own colour more likely next time. The share of each colour settles down to a limit, but the limit is random, and it's decided mostly by the earliest draws. Start with one ball of each of two colours and the long-run share of the first is equally likely to be anything from 0 to 1. One draw at the start moves the outcome hugely. One draw after a thousand barely moves it at all. Biologists call the same thing the founder effect, where a population started by a few individuals carries their traits out of all proportion for generations.

[OURS] For the Complex this means the default isn't whatever is most common in the world, or even near its openings. It's whatever it took in earliest, multiplied by its own copying. That's how a wallpaper Kane says comes from Europe can dominate a Complex reached from California. The drift and mutation model above then explains why variety never quite dies out.

Why near things stay right and far things go wrong

[SCIENCE] Suppose each remembering keeps every object intact but moves each joint between pieces by a small random amount with spread σ. Two points inside one object move together, so their relationship never changes. Two points joined by a chain of k separate joints, after n rememberings, end up displaced from each other by an amount with spread

$$\sigma_{rel} = \sigma \sqrt{(k\, n)}$$

[SCIENCE] Take σ as one centimetre per joint per remembering and ten rememberings. Across a room, with one joint between the wall and the chair, the error is about 3 centimetres, which nobody would notice. Across a building, through a hundred joints, it's about 32 centimetres, enough for doors to stop lining up and furniture to sink into floors. Across a district, through ten thousand joints, it's about 3.2 metres, enough to scramble the map entirely. The numbers are only illustrative, but the shape is the point. What a thing is never drifts, nearby relationships drift a little, and distant ones drift a lot. That's the second law of the working theory.

A capture that fades with depth

[SCIENCE] Light passing into a material fades exponentially with depth. If it enters with intensity I_0, after a depth x it has

$$I(x) = I_0\, e^{-\mu x}$$

where μ measures how strongly the material absorbs. This is the Beer-Lambert law. In air μ is tiny and light carries for kilometres. In a wall it's huge and light is gone within millimetres.

[OURS] The Complex's copies behave as if capture worked the same way. It reaches far along open space, which is why the Red City's distant towers are there at all, and fades within a short depth once it meets matter, which is why those towers are faces only, why the film's suburban houses are cut off a few metres behind their fronts, and why the house in the blue box ends at its fence line. Nothing in canon says the capture is light or anything like it. The point is only that something which travels freely through open space and is quickly absorbed by matter would produce exactly the facades the Complex is full of. That's the fourth law of the working theory.

Bounces and the sky, in equations

[SCIENCE] The radiosity equation describes light bouncing round a space. The light leaving surface i is what it gives off itself plus what it reflects of the light arriving from every other surface j,

$$B_i = E_i + \rho_i \Sigma_j F_{ij} B_j$$

where ρ is how much the surface reflects and F_{ij} is the view factor, the share of what surface i sees that is surface j. In a closed room the view factors of each surface add up to 1, because everything it sees is another surface. A surface with a share f of its view taken up by open sky has view factors adding to only 1 − f, because the sky never sends anything back.

[SCIENCE] For a simple case where every surface is alike, the total that keeps circulating, compared with what was put in, is

$$N = 1 / (1 - \rho (1 - f))$$

With an ordinary reflectance of 0.7, a closed room gives N of about 3.3, a surface seeing half sky gives about 1.5, and a surface seeing nothing but sky gives exactly 1. Light in a room reaches each surface about three times over. Outside, once.

[OURS] If the Complex's copying behaves like this, N is how many times each surface is sampled. The formula for filling gaps with the typical, earlier in this chapter, then says how much of a surface's distinctiveness survives. Each sample is a noisy impression, and averaging N of them divides the noise by N, so

$$k = \sigma_p^2 / (\sigma_p^2 + \sigma_n^2 / N)$$

Taking the noise equal to the natural variation for a single look, a surface seeing only sky keeps k = 0.5 of what makes it different from typical. A surface half open keeps about 0.6. An enclosed surface keeps about 0.77. Streamlining isn't a separate effect. It's the pull toward the typical that remembering applies, made stronger wherever the copy was sampled less, which is wherever it faced the sky.

[OURS] The same picture says why darkness doesn't matter. N depends on the view factors, on how enclosed a surface is, not on how much light happened to be around. A sealed, black ceiling cavity has f of 0 and the highest N there is.

Simplicity survives

[SCIENCE] The Kolmogorov complexity of a thing is the length of the shortest description that reproduces it. A grid of identical pillars has a tiny description, "this pillar, repeated in a grid". A human face has an enormous one. Under any fixed budget, the low-complexity things come through exactly and the high-complexity things get mangled. That's why the Main Chamber is perfect and Still Life faces are the worst-copied thing in the series. TV Tropes puts it in plain words. A living being packs more detail into a smaller space.

Joins and microtiles

[SCIENCE] Kalojanov, Bokeloh, Wand and colleagues (2012) proved that any shape which looks exactly like an example within a radius r of every point can be broken into "microtiles" of that example, and that microtiles can only meet along boundaries that occur in the example. Applied to architecture, a new building that looks locally real everywhere has its seams only where real buildings have them. Seams elsewhere, like the crack across a hallway where two room types meet, or the half-tiled Static Dead End, are where that rule had to be broken.

[SCIENCE] Related methods for building large layouts from examples, model synthesis (Paul Merrell, from 2007) and the Wave Function Collapse algorithm (Maxim Gumin, 2016), do the same thing in practice, placing pieces so every neighbourhood matches something in the example. Their known failure is contradiction, when no piece fits a gap, and the Complex's half-sunk furniture looks a lot like what such a system would produce if it forced something in anyway.

Overlap and relocation

[SCIENCE] In Evan Suma and colleagues' "Impossible Spaces" experiments (2012), people walking in virtual reality didn't notice rooms overlapping by up to about 56 per cent in larger rooms. In Khrystyna Vasylevska and colleagues' "Flexible Spaces" (2013), corridors were regenerated behind people's backs and they didn't notice. A space that changes where nobody is looking and overlaps itself a little can feel perfectly solid to the people in it, which is the Complex as Async experiences it.

Can it all be connected?

[SCIENCE] If each wall between neighbouring cells in a square grid were open at random with probability p, there would be an endless connected maze only if p is above one half. That threshold is exact, proved by Harry Kesten in 1980 for bond percolation on the square lattice. Below it, every walkable region is finite. The Main Chamber is effectively fully open. If the rest of the Complex really were random, it would need to be more than half open to be one place. Since Async, Kane, Ravi and Clark all move across large distances, the Complex is either more open than that or not random.

Measuring a layout

[SCIENCE] Space syntax, developed by Bill Hillier and Julienne Hanson in the 1970s and 80s, measures buildings by how many steps each space is from every other (depth), how central it is (integration), and how many dead ends and loops there are. An isovist, from Michael Benedikt (1979), is everything visible from one point. A grid of pillars like the Main Chamber has huge isovists and very shallow depth, so everything is near and visible. The corridors of the first Found Footage have tiny isovists and deep, looping structure. These are the measures that would let anyone compare the Complex's layouts to real buildings with numbers rather than impressions.

The psychology of misremembered places

- [SCIENCE] **Bartlett, 1932.** People retelling an unfamiliar story ("The War of the Ghosts") changed it toward what their own culture expected, dropping strange details and filling gaps with familiar ones.
- [SCIENCE] **Reconsolidation.** Nader, Schafe and LeDoux (2000) showed that recalling a memory makes it changeable again before it's stored back. Each recall is a rewrite. That's the closest real parallel to "the more times it remembers something, the less it does".
- [SCIENCE] **Boundary extension.** Intraub and Richardson (1989) found people remember seeing more of a scene than they were shown, filling in its edges.
- [SCIENCE] **Change blindness.** In Simons and Levin's 1998 "door study", about half the people giving directions to a stranger didn't notice when the stranger was swapped for someone else while a door was carried between them.
- [SCIENCE] **The doorway effect.** Radvansky and colleagues (2011) found that walking through a doorway makes people forget what they were doing, because the brain treats it as an event boundary. In a place made of nothing but doorways, that has obvious consequences.
- [SCIENCE] **The uncanny valley.** Masahiro Mori (1970) proposed that things almost but not quite human are more disturbing than things obviously not human. Research reported in the Journal of Environmental Psychology suggests liminal spaces fall into an architectural version of the same valley.

- [SCIENCE] **Liminality.** Arnold van Gennep (1909) and Victor Turner (1960s) described the in-between stage of rites of passage. Marc Augé (1992) wrote about "non-places", the airports, motorways and chain hotels designed to be passed through rather than lived in. The Holiday Inn Express at Heathrow is about as pure a non-place as exists.

The real science in the series

- [SCIENCE] **MRI.** Magnetic resonance imaging uses a strong, very even magnetic field (typically 1.5 or 3 tesla) and radio pulses to image the body. Early work by Raymond Damadian, Paul Lauterbur and Peter Mansfield in the 1970s led to the first human scans in 1977. It was first called nuclear magnetic resonance imaging and the word "nuclear" was dropped, partly to avoid frightening patients. Lauterbur and Mansfield shared the 2003 Nobel Prize. A company that builds MRI magnets is a believable origin for a magnetic machine.
- [SCIENCE] **Tellurite glass.** Glasses containing tellurium oxide are real, with high refractive indices and dielectric constants, and their dielectric behaviour at microwave frequencies is studied for electronics. The 0.5 to 0.767 GHz band in Overflow's report corresponds to wavelengths of 60 to 39 centimetres. [OURS] It also falls inside the UHF television band used in the United States in 1972 (470 to 890 MHz). For a series full of television broadcasts leaking across time, that's a neat coincidence.
- [SCIENCE] **Hay bacillus.** Bacillus subtilis is a harmless soil and gut bacterium famous for spores that survive heat, drying and radiation, and for forming tough biofilms. It's used to make natto. Pseudomonas fluorescens, the examiner's first guess, is a soil bacterium that makes a yellow-green pigment glowing under ultraviolet light. [OURS] A yellow-green glow from a bacterium named in the series is another coincidence worth noting next to the green glow, without reading too much into it.
- [SCIENCE] **Loma Prieta.** A magnitude 6.9 earthquake at 5:04 pm Pacific time on 17 October 1989, centred in the Santa Cruz Mountains near Loma Prieta peak. It killed 63 people, collapsed the Cypress Street Viaduct in Oakland and a section of the Bay Bridge's upper deck, and struck as the World Series was about to start Game 3 at Candlestick Park, so it went out live on television. That's the footage in faultline.mov.
- [SCIENCE] **Solar storms.** Covered in the time chapter. August 1972 (the Navy mines), March 1989 (the Hydro-Québec blackout), October 1989 (a big flare on the 19th, two days after the sixth test).
- [SCIENCE] **The Voyager Golden Record.** Two copies flew on Voyager 1 and 2 in 1977, carrying greetings in 55 languages, music, sounds of Earth and images. The English greeting, "Hello from the children of planet Earth", was spoken by Carl Sagan's six-year-old son Nick.
- [SCIENCE] **Conway's Game of Life.** John Conway's 1970 cellular automaton, in which patterns that never change from one step to the next are called still lifes. Phil wears it on his shirt.

PART IX

Loose Ends and Reference

What nobody knows yet, where sources disagree, the words to know, and where everything came from.

Open Questions and Contradictions

[OURS] Many of the questions below get a proposed answer in the working theory and the questions and answers chapters of Part VIII. They're left here as questions because canon hasn't settled them.

Questions canon hasn't answered

About the Complex

- What powers the lights, and where does the current come from?
- Does it think, or does it only behave as if it did?
- Did Async create it, wake it, or only find it? Overflow (1972) and the ALS Still Life's clothes say it's older than the Threshold.
- Why the yellow rooms? Wendigoon's answer is Ivan Beck's past. Ours is that they're simply what it has copied most.
- Is it copying places, minds, or both? Kane says it isn't picking moments out of minds, but the drum kit in Found Footage #3 and Mary's house in the film make proximity to people matter.
- What is the green glow, and why does it appear where walls move?
- Why are almost all time anomalies from the future?
- Is there a sky anywhere, or is every outdoor area a box? Where does the Red City's red light come from? (See your floodlight hypothesis.)
- How big is it? Is it finite?
- Why do some openings, like Clark's, stay stable and two-way while most close behind whoever falls through?

About the creatures

- Is there one Lifeform or many? What's the tentacled thing in Motion Detected?
- Where does the Lifeform come from, if not from transformed people?
- Why are some Still Lifes violent and others harmless?
- Do Still Lifes change over time? The Found Footage #3 one is fast. The film's are slow.
- Who wrote "DON'T MOVE, STAY STILL" on the wall in the first Found Footage?
- Who was camping in the Pitfalls house Marvin explored?

About Async

- What does Ivan Beck want? Why does Kane call him both protagonist and antagonist?
- Was Async founded in 1983 as the fan wiki says, and if so, how did Beck's 1972 and 1982 work fit in?
- Is Peter Tench dead? Who is the man on the street camera at the end of Damage Control, and what was the syringe?
- What did Naren's duffel bag of Async data contain, and who was he going to give it to?
- What happens to Mary after Phil's interview?
- What happened to Async between July 1990 and 1991, when the found footage shows no trace of them?
- Who is Miller, and what was his theory about null zones?

About the people who fell in

- Who broke into Ravi's basement through the sliding door?
- What happened to the father and his boys?
- Who watched the woman's tape at the end of Found Footage #2, with wind chimes in the room?
- How did Kane's camera, and the other tapes, get out?

About the hidden videos

- How does home_27647.mov's family connect to the house in Found Footage #2, beyond the shared layout and painting?
- What does I Remember's whiteboard ("cell images clustering results in individual cell classification") refer to?
- Why does 9780415263573 point to The Yellow Wallpaper?
- Why does the Simpsons tape exist in-universe at all?

Where the sources contradict each other

Topic	One version	The other	Where it stands
Tench's disappearance date	"29 February 1990" (Informational Video's description)	1 March 1990 (Damage Control)	1990 had no 29 February. Later sources use 1 March
Length of Tench's jump	Two months (Damage Control, 68 days)	Three months (several fan sources)	Two months is right
How Tench ended up back inside	Async forced him back (Reunion's implication)	He escaped back in, paranoid (Damage Control)	Unresolved by design
Overflow's date	2 August 1972 (fan wiki, from the document)	4 August 1972 (Wendigoon)	2 August is better supported
Async's founding	1983 (fan wiki)	Beck's work from 1972 and the 1982 prototype	Unexplained
Third Test date	2 July 1988 (the episode)	1982 (some fan sources)	1988 is right
Everything Must Go Edition release	3 July 2026	4 July 2026 (TV Tropes)	3 July in most sources
Everything Must Go on YouTube	17 August 2026, Pacific time	18 August 2026 (Wikipedia)	Same moment, different time zones
Number of episodes	25 (Wikipedia, leaving out I Remember)	26 including it, or 19 main episodes (fan wiki)	Depends on counting
The red street's label	"14D + 228" (Static Dead End whiteboard)	Room 14D-22B (fan wiki)	Probably the same label read differently
Ravi's date	Late April 1995 (radio report), 19 April 1995 (fan infographic)	Undated (TV Tropes timeline)	April 1995 best supported
The 600 million square mile figure	fan writing	No canon figure	Unsupported
Clark's store sign	Red and black pirate with hook and two legs	Clark's teal and yellow peg-legged mascot	A real difference in the film. Possibly a bought business
Film set size	About 30,000 square feet built	About 100,000 in Kane's Blender map	Both true. The map was bigger than the build
The name Kelowna	Kelowna is in British Columbia, where the film was shot	No source links them	Coincidence or nod, unknown

Glossary

A-Space. Async's trademarked name for the Complex as a commercial product, pitched to the Department of Energy on 8 May 1990 as unlimited space for storage, housing, transport and commerce.

ALS Still Life. Archibald Leland Sutter, the Still Life fused to a wheelchair with a lamp. Named only in the credits.

Async. The Async Research Institute or Async Foundation, a San Jose company that made MRI machines and then opened the Threshold.

Async Rover. A tracked, camera-carrying robot driven from outside Division 14 (fan wiki).

Backrooms. The 2019 internet legend of endless yellow office rooms. In Kane's version, the place Async calls the Complex. Also the title of his web series and of the 2026 film, which has no "The".

Bacteria. A fan name for the Lifeform, after Kane's Ko-fi drawing.

Cap'n Clark's Ottoman Empire. Clark's failing furniture store at Capitol and McKee, San Jose, with a doorway into the Complex in its basement.

Capture. In the working theory, the Complex taking in the physical structure of a scene near one of its openings, at one moment, with any people in it.

Classic or Common Backrooms. Fan names for the yellow wallpaper, brown carpet, drop ceiling and fluorescent light that make up most of the Complex.

Complex, the. Async's name for the Backrooms.

Division. Async's term for each corridor off the Main Chamber. Lateral divisions run off the sides and numbered divisions off the front and back.

Division 14. The route into the deeper Complex, with Rooms 14A to 14D and the Static Dead End.

Doorway-type null zone. A stable natural opening, like the one in Clark's basement (fan wiki).

Fill. In the working theory, whatever the Complex puts in place of something a copy lacks, taken from its existing stock and matched by look or role, like paint for a sky or a light fitting for a star.

Found Footage. The episodes filmed by ordinary people who fell in, in 1991 and 1995.

Glitch. The fan wiki's word for an unstable, short-lived null zone.

Green glow. A green light seen where the Complex changes or opens.

Kelowna Branch (KLWNA). The region joined to Clark's basement, holding at least three copies of his store.

KLWNA Outpost. Also the Secluded Outpost. An Async base deep in the Kelowna Branch.

KV31. Project KV31, Async's programme to open the Complex. Usually read as Karlovy Vary 1931, Beck's birthplace and year. Also the number of a tomb in the Valley of the Kings.

Lateral division A. The row of cells next to the Threshold, where the motion cameras were placed.

Lifeform, the. Kane's name for the tall, wiry creature that mimics human voices and seems to grow from bacteria and human remains.

LPMDS. The Low-Proximity Magnetic Distortion System, Async's room-sized machine with the Threshold at its centre.

Main Chamber. The roughly hundred-metre-square pillared hall just past the Threshold.

Marvin's Friend. The researchers' joke name for the Lifeform in Reunion.

Noclip. Video game slang for passing through walls. From the 4chan caption. Async never uses it.

Not Kane Pixels. Kane's music channel.

Null zone. A place where a real surface stops being solid and things fall through into the Complex. The fan wiki also calls them null kx fields.

Open space, captured. In the working theory, the open volume at the centre of a copy, a street, a yard or a set of rooms. The faces bordering it survive and the Complex encloses it, which is why fronts face inward.

Out of Sync. A playlist of Kane's music, read by fans as a portrait of Ivan Beck.

Pirate Clark. The Still Life of Clark in his commercial costume. Also called Cap'n Clark or Captain Clark.

Re-expression. In the working theory, the way copies of copies are rebuilt in the Complex's own layout while keeping a place's materials, notable objects and connections, as in the maze copy of Clark's store.

Red City. The red-lit night city Ravi sees through skywalk windows in Found Footage #3, part of what the fan wiki calls the Red Outdoors.

Red street. The red-lit neighbourhood Marvin finds below Room 14D, labelled "14D + 228" on a whiteboard and Room 14D-22B by the fan wiki.

Room 14C. The room where Tench ambushed Team B, and which changed between visits.

Room 14D. The room of square pits, five by seven.

Sky drain. In the working theory, the way the open sky weakens the Complex's copying, so whatever faced the sky is streamlined and whatever was enclosed is faithful.

Snowball, the. In the working theory, the way the Complex's earliest material came to dominate, because it copies its own copies and whatever is common becomes more common.

Standard. What Async's staff call their own building when speaking from inside the Complex.

Static Dead End. The half-formed room past Room 14D's door, with furniture sunk into the floor.

Still Life. A copy of a person made by the Complex, distorted, filled with a white stuffing, and edible. Named after the art form, and in the film's world after the stable patterns in Conway's Game of Life.

Streamlining. What happens to sky-facing parts of a copy, one flat colour per surface, simple shapes, no clutter and no wear, like a stage set.

Ten laws, the. The working theory of the Complex set out in Part VIII. Capture, two fidelities, matter not light, the open space at the centre, interpretation, worse copies, the snowball, continuation, structure before function, and reaching back.

Threshold. The doorway at the centre of the LPMDS, and Async's only reliable way in and out.

Threshold Outpost. Async's first building inside, also called the Observation Room.

Tiled Pool Area. Kane's version of the Poolrooms, seen in Found Footage #2 and the film.

Voyager greetings. The 55-language greetings from the 1977 Golden Record, played by Async's cardboard cutouts in the film.

Sources

Every source drawn on in this book, grouped by kind. Episode links are given in the episode tables in Part III.

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